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In the Eye of the Beholder:

Quantificational, pragmatic and aspectual features

of the *bi-√ verbal prefix in Sumerian

A dissertation submitted in partial satisfaction of

the requirements for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy

in Near Eastern Languages and Cultures

by

Justin Cale Johnson

2004

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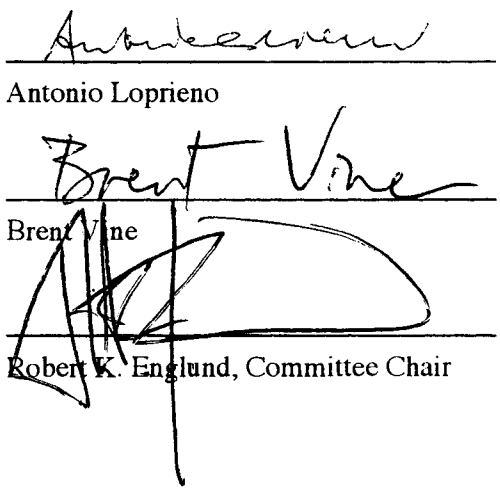
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Antonio Loprieno

Brent Vine

Robert K. Englund, Committee Chair

University of California, Los Angeles

2004

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To Grace

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

> Each dance and its music belong to a time and place. It can be borrowed elsewhere, or later in time, but it will never be in its moment again.
> When these little cultural blooms are past, they become ethnic or nostalgic, but never quite fully present—manifesting the web of their original connections and meanings—again
>
> — Gary Snyder

There are many people who have helped me in one way or another over the years. I cannot mention them all here, but I would like to thank a few people who made particularly lasting impressions on me at each stage of the journey.

At UC Davis, where I did my undergraduate degree, two of my teachers were particularly influential: my undergraduate advisor, Naomi Janowitz, introduced me to the History of Religions, instilled in me the critical eye that is so often missing from work in the humanities, sent me to Cairo for a year to cure me of my parochialism and tried to get me to think twice about going to the Divinity School at the University of Chicago; Aram Yengoyan let me into the graduate courses that he taught when I was eighteen years old and had no right to be there, and my decision to go to graduate school was largely a product of the impression that those classes left on me. Kendall House, a graduate student

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education in anthropological linguistics, pragmatics and semiotics where Silverstein had left off and was always generous with his time and his optimism.

In my third year at UCLA, I discovered Sumerian in the classes of Bob Englund and have spent the vast majority of my time here at UCLA ever since preoccupied by the languages, culture and history of Mesopotamia. Bob has done everything in his power to make me into a good Assyriologist. In the meantime, he has gone to a great deal of trouble to ensure that I was well fed, had a roof over my head and was able to ignore the daily rush and concentrate on learning to read cuneiform. Over the years, he has listened with some amusement I imagine to my theories, all the while insisting that I master, to the best of my ability, the philological and historical disciplines that constitute Assyriology as a field of study. For all of these things, I am eternally grateful. Thanks to Klaudia as well for always making me feel welcome when I was out visiting the boss. It is telling that Englund thought it important that I spent some time studying with at least one other leading Assyriologist so as to broaden my exposure to the different methods and the best practices of other leaders in the field. When I applied for and received a two-year fellowship to study with Professor Maekawa at Kyoto University, Englund supported it even through the territory was unfamiliar and my departure left him with no graduate students to help out with the preliminary stages of the Cuneiform Digital Library Initiative.

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PUBLICATIONS AND PRESENTATIONS

Johnson, Cale. December 4, 1999. Global case-marking in Sumerian: /mu-/, /ba-/, /i-/. Paper presented at the 6th West Asian Linguistics Meeting, Kyoto, Japan.

———. December 23, 1999. Evidence of antipassivization in Sumerian. Paper presented at the 40th Sumerology Workshop, Tokyo, Japan.

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———. August 31, 2000. The verbal infix /-ni-/ in the Sumerian of the Old Babylonian Period: Mediopassivization and pragmatic constraints on its interpretation. Paper presented at the 41st Sumerology Workshop, Kyoto, Japan.

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———. July 2, 2002. Complex graphemes in the proto-cuneiform corpus and the problem of phonological reconstruction. Paper presented at the 48e Rencontre Assyriologique Internationale, Leiden, The Netherlands.

———. October 21, 2002. The invention of writing in Mesopotamia. Public lecture at Andrews University, Berrien Springs, Michigan.

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———. March 13, 2004. Decomposing lexical aspect in Sumerian: BNBV(inalienable) lexical class, particle-verbs and telicity. Paper presented at the American Oriental Society, San Diego, California.

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ABSTRACT OF THE DISSERTATION

In the Eye of the Beholder:

Quantificational, pragmatic and aspectual features

of the *bi-√ verbal prefix in Sumerian

by

Justin Cale Johnson

Doctor of Philosophy in Near Eastern Languages and Cultures

University of California, Los Angeles, 2004

Professor Robert K. Englund, Chair

Traditional models of Sumerian grammar suggest that the primary function of the *bi-√ verbal prefix is as a marker of locative agreement of one kind or another, but these models have, as a rule, described the *bi-√ prefix in purely morphological terms and failed to elucidate syntactic relations that hold between the *bi-√ prefix and other elements of the clauses in which it occurs. One of the consequences of the traditional avoidance of syntactic questions in the study of Sumerian is that almost nothing is known about several grammatical phenomena that appear to be coded through syntactic means such as definiteness, existential quantification, and the pragmatic opposition between

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topic and focus. This dissertation investigates the *bi-√ prefix as part of a larger effort to identify some of these basic morphosyntactic oppositions in the text-artifactual record of the Sumerian materials that originate from Old Babylonian Period (ca. 2000-1600 BCE) in Mesopotamia. I argue that the occurrence of a bare inalienable noun immediately to the left of a *bi-√ prefix-verb forms a distinctive morphosyntactic construction which can be identified on the basis of both morphosyntactic and semantic critieria as a low source applicative construction.

The identification of this subset of the occurrences of the *bi-√ prefix as a low source applicative construction has broad implications for other parts of Sumerian grammar, in particular, the development of ergativity in the language. The low source applicative construction is limited to a group of verbs that includes verbs of perception and adversity and can be juxtaposed to a type of causative construction in which a bare *alienable* noun occurs immediately to the left of the *bi-√ prefix. This opposition stems from the fact that, in the low source applicative construction, the ergative noun phrase is the possessor of the inalienable noun rather than the agent of the clause. In order to elucidate several possible correlations between the clausal possessive constructions underlying the use of the low source applicative and the development of ergativity, several other issues are also dealt with in considerable detail in the balance of the dissertation: the use of possessive pronominal suffixes to code definiteness and topicalization as well as the role of indefiniteness and the definiteness effect in verbs of perception, head-internal relative clauses and contrastive focus constructions.

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Abbreviations and Translations

Assyriological abbreviations follow the list made available on the internet by CDLI at the following address: (http://cdli.ucla.edu/Tools/abbrev.html). All other non-Assyriological abbreviations are listed below:

Abs	Absolutive case
Acc	Accusative case
Agr	Agreement
Alla	Allative
Anim	Animate
AP	Adjective Phrase
Appl	Applicative
Asp	Aspect
BNBV	Bare Noun Bi-Verb construction
$BNBV_{inal}$	Inalienable Bare Noun Bi-Verb construction
Cause	Causative
Cop	Copula
Dat	Dative case
Decl	Declarative mood
Def	Definite
Dir	Directive case
DistAdv	Distal Adverb
DP	Determiner Phrase
Dur	Durative grammatical aspect
Erg	Ergative case

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FocusP	Focus Phrase
ForceP	(Illocutionary) Force Phrase
Gen	Genitive case
GN	Geographical Name
HIRC	Head-Internal Relative Clause
Imprf	Imperfective grammatical aspect
Inan	Inanimate
Indef	Indefinite
Intrans	Intransitive
IO	Indirect Object
LoAp	Low Applicative
Loc	Locative case
LocTerm	Locative-Terminative case
Masc	Masculine
Neg	Negative
Nmz	Nominalizer
Nom	Nominative case
NP	Noun Phrase
Obl	Oblique case
OO	Oblique Object
Perf	Perfective grammatical aspect
PerfPrt	Perfective Participle
Pl(ur)	Plural
PN	Personal Name
Poss	Possessive
Pres	Present tense
ProAnim	Animate Pronominal agreement marker
ProInan	Inanimate Pronominal agreement marker
PP	Prepositional/Postpositional Phrase

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Prt	Participle
Redup	Reduplication
Rel	Relative marker
Sg	Singular
Spec	Specifier
Subord	Subordinate marker
Top	Topic
TopicP	Topic Phrase
TP	Tense Phrase
Trans	Transitive
Vent	Ventive
VP	Verb Phrase
XP	Phrase of unspecified type

As a rule, the translations of Sumerian were initially taken from ETCSL or a published edition of the passage in question; it should probably noted that ETCSL translations are also, as a rule, taken from past editions of the text in more or less anonymous fashion. Once these translations entered the manuscript they began a process of transformation so that, as they stand, they are curious hybrids of the conventional wisdom of previous generations of Assyriologists and my own insights and misunderstandings. The translation of a passage from Streck 1999 on pages 129 and 130 is my own except for one phrase that Prof. Streck kindly offered me a translation of. In the examples, one asterisk indicates that the example is hypothetical or that the segment in question is a bound morpheme and would not ordinarily occur alone; two asterisks indicate the example in question is ungrammatical.

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Preface

Before turning to the first chapter I would like to spend a few moments discussing the role of linguistic theory and the absence of tree diagrams and other kinds of linguistic formalism in this dissertation as well as providing a restatement of the hypothesis to be investigated.

Theoretical preliminaries

One of the most surprising aspects of the linguistic investigation of archaeologically recovered languages is the particular type of linguistic theory that is most often used in such investigations, primarily "broad" or "inclusive" typology of the Greenbergian variety and "psychological" and/or "extreme" functionalism (cf. Nichols 1984, 100-101, 103) with few if any formal or distributional criteria whatsoever. These theories are not, for the most part, predictive, but, on the contrary, merely act to confirm the plausibility of a reconstruction that is based on either philological investigation or analogies based on the set of languages familiar to the analyst. The actual method of investigation often boils down to a rather selective reading of recent typological descriptions followed by an attempt to match a particular construction in the dead language with the linguistic type that most closely resembles it. The "identification" is rarely tested and distributional criteria that might link the construction in question to other morphosyntactic distributional patterns are usually omitted. I have attempted, wherever possible, to avoid

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such "typological/psychological" functionalism, but I have not always succeeded. But even after theories that do not make use of formal diagnostics are set aside, many competing theories remain to choose from.

There are worlds of difference between the two main camps in syntactic research, formalists and functionalists, or so it seems at times, particularly in their respective treatment of pragmatic phenomena such as topic and focus, but recent developments in formalism such as Rizzi's work on the fine structure of the left periphery (Rizzi 1997) have introduced large numbers of essentially "pragmatic" syntactic positions or landing sites within the left periphery and attempted to capture pragmatic phenomena in their syntactic trees. Recent work on the formation of verbal complexes (Koopman and Szabolcsi 2000, Julien 2002) now regularly moves the entire clause into the left periphery with various pieces of phrase structure moving from traditional syntactic positions such as verb phrase (VP) and tense phrase (TP) into the left periphery and ending up in places like (illocutionary) force phrase (ForceP), topic position (TopicP) and focus position (FocusP). In recent formalist work, one is left with the impression that pragmatic categories are an essential part of syntactic structure. But the view that pragmatic phenomena affect syntactic categorization is, in fact, not new at all: functionalists have long maintained just such a point of view and the inclusion of such "pragmatic" syntactic positions in recent formalist work amounts to an admission that the functionalists were, in certain respects, right all along. This paradigm shift in formalist work, which can be attributed, above all, to Kayne's work on binary branching and antisymmetry (Kayne

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1994), has produced a degree of compatibility with certain schools of functionalism such as Role and Reference Grammar (Van Valin 1993).

The fact that the text-artifactual record of any particular archaeologically recovered language is necessarily quite limited and of inconsistent quality would seem to require that highly predictive linguistic theories take the lead role. The two theories that have most influenced the hypotheses and argumentation in this dissertation are (i) Role and Reference Grammar and in particular work on case-marking and clause-linkage by Silverstein (1976; 1993a) and Agha (1993) and (ii) recent formalist work carried out on the basis of Kayne's antisymmetry (1994) and, in particular, the generative literature on so-called "double object" constructions, culminating—at least for the time being—in Pylkkänen's recent dissertation (2002) on low applicative constructions. My own theoretical orientation remains structural-functionalist and those functionalist theories that continue to make use of formal diagnostics for distributional classes are, in my view, the most trustworthy. But the vast majority of recent research on the several topics that this dissertation is about have been carried out almost entirely within generative linguistics, notably investigators working within Distributed Morphology (see Marantz 1998 for orientation) and those investigating the right periphery—the region below, for example, [31]*AspSingCompletive1* in Cinque's cartography (Cinque 1999)—and its association with lexical aspect and quantization (Tenny 2000; Filip 2000). Although Pylkkänen's work and theoretical works by a few others are discussed from time to time in this dissertation, the formal representations that have taken on such importance in syntactic investigation in the past few decades have been eschewed.

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There are several reasons for not using tree diagrams or other methods of representing detailed hierarchical phrase structure in this dissertation. The most important reason is that the kind of relatively subtle and contrastive semantic and pragmatic differences that would—under normal circumstances—provide the basis for choosing one tree diagram over another (types of syntactic binding, quantifier scope, etc.) are simply unavailable. Given the empirical constraints on an archaeologically recovered language, we can never be sure of the precise semantic or pragmatic features of any sentence—all the glosses and translations in this and all other investigations of Sumerian morphosyntax are only approximations. There is no way of producing additional examples, introducing measured variation in form and testing for grammaticality through elicitation with a native speaker. Thus, in a special sense, any tree diagram or other formal representation is deceptive in that it suggests that we know more about Sumerian syntax than we actually do. Although generic formal representations would, at least in certain places along the way, have made the argumentation more precise, they would also have remained entirely meaningless to the vast majority of those who investigate the Sumerian text-artifactual record.

Instead of attempting to import a huge amount of linguistic theory and its associated terminology and formalism into the Assyriological discussion, I have chosen to follow a rather different method in presenting my findings. Since the most important component of any investigation of Sumerian morphosyntax is the identification of formal criteria that differentiate distributional classes *in Sumerian* (rather than the scholarly metalanguage of translations and glosses that are applied to the Sumerian forms), the description of each

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grammatical phenomenon begins with a purely formal criterion on the basis of which a set of examples can be identified without recourse to the meaning of the examples. Once the formal criterion and the examples that meet the criterion have been isolated, I attempt to characterize the set of examples on the basis of both traditional philological practice (including the use of analogous constructions in English and other well-known and typologically similar languages such as Korean and Japanese) as well as the most recent theoretical discussion of the relevant phenomenon in disciplinary linguistics. The theoretical discussions often include predictions about special restrictions on certain distributional classes and postulate associations with related phenomena and I have used such predicted behaviors to form hypotheses about related distributional classes in Sumerian. Much of the theoretical argumentation is, however, abbreviated or sometimes omitted entirely where I felt that the Sumerian materials provided sufficient justification for the meanings that I hypothesize. Ultimately, the only real justification for positing a morphosyntactic category (whether lexical classification, for example, or derivational morpheme) in Sumerian is the degree to which the hypothesized meaning of a particular linguistic form makes better and more detailed sense of the particular contexts in which it occurs; any linguistic theorizing or typological conformity merely provides a set of predictions which constrain the formation of hypotheses, but have no real effect on their validity in the Sumerian text-artifactual record.

One of the more troubling aspects of recent work on Sumerian morphosyntax is that it has remained persistently morphological in orientation and avoided, wherever possible, syntactic argumentation or investigation. Although the best traditions of Americanist

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descriptivism and structural-functionalism in Europe have always treated morphology and syntax as, essentially, two varieties of marking within the same distributional system, the tradition in Sumerology grows out of the philological practices of the late nineteenth century and tends to value only morphological oppositions. At present, as noted above, certain varieties of functionalism such as Role and Reference Grammar [RRG] and certain varieties of formalism such as Distributed Morphology [DM] are actually in agreement to a great degree and differ primarily in terms of the geometric model that each adopts for the formal representation of syntactic phenomena: RRG adopts multiple, partially independent formalisms for distinct phenomena such as surface syntactic constituency, argument and focus structure, and case-marking whereas DM linearizes each of these phenomena into a single syntactic tree and invokes massive leftward movement to ensure that constituents travel through the nodes in the tree that code information such as focus structure and the like. The point is that the differences between these theories is relatively minor (at least from the perspective of the current state of Sumerian grammar), whereas they share the central assumption that there is no separate morphological subsystem in the grammar and that the entire morphosyntactic system is really just a syntactic system in which some distributional classes are coded by segmental morphology, while others are coded through configuration. The import of such an observation is that those interested in detailed morphosyntactic description of Sumerian would do well to attempt investigation of Sumerian on the basis of syntactic distribution as understood within either RRG or DM rather than the traditional reliance on inherited

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morphological oppositions that are based, above all, on the lexical and grammatical observations of Old Babylonian literati who were not native speakers of the language.

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The hypothesis

Two unresolved problems with present-day reconstructions of Sumerian grammar have troubled me since I first came into contact with the language: (i) the correlation or lack thereof between topic/focus marking and (in)definiteness and (ii) questions of subordination and pragmatic backgrounding in a written tradition in which each line is typically a clause and the verb is regularly final, yielding few hints as to the syntactic relations that hold between clauses. With the important exception of Yoshikawa's work (assembled in Yoshikawa 1993), few investigations of Sumerian have paid much attention to how topic and focus are coded or differentiated in Sumerian.[1] But comparative and typological studies have repeatedly demonstrated that the articulation of topic and focus in a language tell us almost as much about the syntax of the language as word-order and morphological patterns. At the same time, the articulation of topic and focus in a particular language often interacts in a highly rule-governed fashion with (in)definiteness. Take the two sentences in (1) and (2) for example (here and in the rest of the dissertation, topics appear in italics with indices such as "i" in (1) marking constituents that refer to the same entity; constituents in focus appear in capital letters).

(1) *As for Mary*$_i$, I don't know what she$_i$ wants.

(2) It's THE CAR that needs to be fixed, (not the motor scooter).

[1] Rubio suggests that "the choice of [conjugation] prefix seems governed by focus" (Rubio forthcoming, 29) on the basis of Gragg's suggestions to the same effect (Gragg 1973b, 93-94; Woods 2001, 394) and Vanstiphout's discourse analytical study of the *i- prefix (Vanstiphout 1985; Woods 2001, 394-395). Gragg's rather general statement could serve as a rather distant antecedent to my own views, translated into one of the contemporary theoretical programs, but the more specific articulation of Vanstiphout on the basis of ± person and ± locus is really a codification conventional Sumerological interpretations of the conjugation prefixes and should not serve as the basis for future investigations of focus in Sumerian.

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The topic-marked noun in (1), *Mary*, is resumed by the pronoun, *she*, later on in the sentence, whereas the focus construction in (2) makes use of a cleft-sentence in which a dummy pronoun followed by the copula in combination with a distinct intonation of the word *car* indicates that it is emphasized within the sentence, possibly in contrast to some other referent. Needless to say, topic and focus patterns often reconfigure the grammatical structures in a language quite dramatically.

Once the articulation of topic and focus have been delineated within a language, it soon becomes apparent that clauses that include an explicit topicalization tend to occur in a rather different set of textual environments than clauses involving a focalization. Clearly, a clause that introduces a new topic will often be followed by a number of subsequent clauses in which the topic plays an important role, even if it is rather quickly replaced by another referent as topic. Clauses involving focalization are quite different in that they often occur at points of culmination or transition within, for example, an unfolding narrative.[2] The problem with attempting to use topic and focus to understand the tectonics of clause structure in Sumerian is that there are no hard and fast rules: each literary tradition adopts a limited number of what we might call rhetorical devices, which are built up out of both syntactic phenomena such as contrastive focus as well as textual conventions that have no direct syntactic correlation such as rules of elementary composition, viz. "the first sentence in a paragraph should be the 'topic sentence' and summarize the content of the entire paragraph." Clearly, as soon as an entirely typographic phenomenon such as the paragraph is invoked, we are no longer dealing with

[2] The expression "points of culmination and transition" can be thought of as analogous to Vanstiphout's foregrounding function (see Vanstiphout 1985, 12-13).

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matters of morphosyntax—we have entered, at that point, the realm of text-artifactual convention. Just as familiarity with present-day Indo-European languages (what Whorf famously called Standard Average European) often blinds us to the types of linguistic structure used in languages that bear a greater similarity to Sumerian than, say, English, likewise, our own conventions for the organization of clauses into paragraphs tends to outweigh the different ways in which other text-artifactual traditions organize textual material. Whether we think of the at times radically periodic textual structure of formal Japanese, in which what a speaker of English might call a topic sentence regularly occurs at the end of a paragraph if at all, or the sometimes curious set of textual devices such as *Wiederaufnahme*, i.e., "repetitive resumption," and Seidel's Law that organize the redaction of the Hebrew Bible (see Levinson 1997, 17-20, for an overview), the lesson is clear: the particular morphosyntactic phenomena and the way in which they are used in specific rhetorical devices is often highly constrained within a particular text-artifactual tradition. Even once the morphosyntactic phenomena are isolated and identified, the recognition of the rhetorical devices in which they occur and the overall textual pattern of such devices can only be identified through extensive contextual analysis of particular morphosyntactic forms. This dissertation is a case-study of one such morphosyntactic form in context: the *bi-√ verbal prefix.

Having identified a number of reasonably coherent properties associated with a construction in which a bare inalienable noun immediately precedes a perfective verb bearing the *bi-√ prefix (hereafter Bare Noun Bi-√ Verb [$BNBV_{inal}$]), the next step is to figure out what the *bi-√ prefix is and where it comes from. Given the array of

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descriptive characterizations applicable to the construction in question, this amounts to a relatively straightforward typological question. Is there some grammatical category or phenomenon that shows a similar set of properties, distributional and semantic? The answer came in the form of a recently completed MIT dissertation (Pylkkänen 2002). Pylkkänen, working within the Distributed Morphology branch of the generative tradition (see Marantz 1998 for orientation and bibliography), proposed a number of subdivisions within the group of phenomena known as applicative constructions, constructions in which an adpositional phrase of one kind or another loses its adpositional morphology and becomes directly involved in the syntactic processes of the verbal predicate. One particular type of applicative in the typology of applicative constructions proposed by Pylkkänen, the *low source applicative*, corresponds particularly well with the Sumerian phenomenon dealt with herein and I argue that the *bi-√ prefix in a $BNBV_{inal}$ construction should be classified as a low source applicative. The low source applicative hypothesis not only makes sense of the particular syntactic and semantic phenomena associated with inalienable nouns that immediately precede *bi-√ prefix verbs, but it also conforms to Zólyomi's description of certain rather specific features of what is known as the directive case hypothesis (see Zólyomi 1999 for orientation). But the low source applicative hypothesis also predicts a number of previously unrecognized semantic phenomena that are associated with the subset of *bi-√ prefix compound verbs that include a bare inalienable noun, including the use of the ergative case to code an experiencer argument and an association of the locative-terminative or non-human dative argument with a perceived or adversely affected argument. Hence I argue that the "ergative" postposition,

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*-e, also marks (raised) inalienable possessors and that, where the nominal component of a BNBV compound verb is inalienable, the ergative case-marked noun is not the agent of the clause, but merely the possessor of the inalienable theme. Such a possessive construction forms an absolutive/oblique case-marking system in which the inalienable possessor and the bare inalienable noun form a single unit in the zero-marked, absolutive case, whereas the locative-terminative or locative argument functions as the oblique argument. This type of pattern is, in cross-linguistic terms, quite common with verbs of perception and experience.

Bearing in mind the series of interdependent hypotheses proposed in the first chapter (the *bi-√ prefix in the BNBV construction as a low source applicative, the ergative postposition, *-e, as inalienable possessor rather than agent in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions, and consequently the formation of absolutive/oblique predicates in which the "ergative" case-marked noun is an experiencer of an event rather than the cause), the second chapter investigates what effects, if any, the curious case-marking system of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates has on lexical and grammatical aspect in Sumerian. Why, for example, does the introduction of an inalienable noun in a compound verbal construction regularly form a telic predicate? Telicity in more familiar languages such as English is usually coded through the use of particles indicating directions as in *hammer out*, *tie up*, *shoot down*, and so forth, but Sumerian seems to be using inalienable nouns to achieve the same function. Ultimately there are good reasons for suspecting that the use of particles to control telicity in English and other similar languages and the use of inalienable nouns in the position immediately before the verb in Sumerian are equivalent in a number of

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respects and differ only with respect to a single parameter: the head-initial sequence of languages like English as opposed to the strictly head-final order in Sumerian. Whether viewed in terms of dependency theory (Nichols 1986; Van Valin 2001, 86-107) or one of several XP-movement hypotheses currently under discussion (Koopman and Szabolcsi 2000, Julien 2002), the most reasonable way of coding telicity in Sumerian would appear to be through the introduction of a noun immediately to the left of the finite verb that, due to its inalienability, is not highly referential. At the same time, the inherently relational nature of body-part nouns, taking the human body as its default compass, means that the directional quality of English particles such as "up," "down," "out" and "in," can likewise be coded using inalienable nouns like **gu**$_2$ "neck," **giri**$_3$ "foot," **a**$_2$ "arm," and **ša**$_3$ "stomach."

Whereas chapters 1 and 2 attempt to elucidate two perspectives on the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction (case and thematic role in chapter 1 and lexical aspect (telicity) in chapter 2), chapters 3 and 4 identify two morphosyntactic environments in which *bi-√ prefix verbs such as $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates (but not limited to them exclusively) regularly occur. These two environments correspond to topicalizing and a particular kind of focalizing contexts of occurrence: the topicalized *bi-√ prefix construction is dealt with in chapter 3, the focalized in chapter 4. Topics regularly presuppose that the referent of the topical phrase is known to both speaker and addressee, so topical phrases are often definite (even when indefinite, they tend to be highly specific). As I argue below, there are three primary ways of indicating that a nominal phrase is a topic in Sumerian: the two familiar methods are the use of the ergative postposition or an independent pronoun, but I would

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argue that there is a third mechanism, namely, *the use of nouns modified by possessive pronouns in clause-initial position.* In chapter 3, I argue that *bi-√ prefix verbs can also be topicalized through this third method. In particular, I suggest that verbs of the form *mini-√ derive from *bi-√ prefix verbs that have been modified by the third person animate possessive pronoun, *-ni.[3] This use of *bi-√ prefix verbs as the basis for a construction that, at least prototypically, is limited to nouns raises the possibility that *bi-√ prefix verbs are, in fact, a species of relative clause, in particular, the type of head-internal relative clauses [HIRC] frequently found in verb-final languages. I go on to argue that *bi-√ prefix verbs are indefinite HIRCs, whereas *mini-√ prefix verbs are the corresponding definite HIRCs, making use of the same system of possessive pronouns to code definiteness and topicality.

To a certain degree, topic-marking in Sumerian is well understood, even if it has hardly ever been studied in detail. Clause-initial noun phrases in the ergative case and independent personal pronouns can be identified as topics due to the combination of clause-initial position and/or ergative case-marking,[4] but that is usually where the discussion ends. Although a somewhat more detailed discussion of topic-marking patterns appears in section 1.7 below, I would like to suggest that the missing piece in theories of Sumerian topic-marking is the possessive pronoun construction. Besides the

[3] The form that is typically given as third person animate possessive suffix is *-ani, but it seems fairly clear that, if the animate, *-ni, and inanimate, *-bi, possessive pronouns derive from the proximal, *-ne, and distal, *-be, demonstratives, the original form of the third person animate possessive pronoun must have been *-ni rather than *-ani. Although I do not develop the argument here, I believe that there is good reason to suspect that *-ni itself is an inalienable possessive pronoun and that the corresponding alienable possessive pronoun consists of a linking morpheme, *-a-, and the inalienable possessive pronoun, *-ni.

[4] The {e} that appears at the end of independent pronouns is identical to the ergative postposition in orthography and phonological form, but independent pronouns in Sumerian seem to exhibit nominal/accusative rection (Woods 2001, 272). In terms of orthography, however, the defining criteria for topicalization can be stated as (i) clause-initial position and (ii), at least in orthographic terms, the "ergative" postposition.

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ergative case-marked lexical noun phrase such as **lugal.e** and the pronouns such as **za.e**, I propose that the third way of topic-marking in Sumerian is through the use of otherwise facultative possessive pronoun constructions such as **lugal.ĝu$_{10}$** 'my king'. Since Sumerian lacks determiners like those found in English and similar languages and over time the use of full demonstratives seems to have attenuated somewhat (cf. Woods 2001, 25-184), I hypothesize that Sumerian might be using possessive constructions as a means of coding definiteness and that since topics are regularly definite, in its written incarnation, Sumerian might well have used a somewhat artificial convention such as possessive pronoun constructions to indicate that a particular noun phrase was topical. I have not attempted to defend this view in itself, but if the derivation of *mini-√ from *bi-√ can be taken as evidence, then it lends some support to my suggestion.

If it is in fact the case that Sumerian codes definiteness through the addition of a possessive pronoun, does this imply that bare, unmodified nouns in Sumerian are indefinite? For the most part, bare nouns in Sumerian are simply unmarked for definiteness. But in one particular environment, bare nouns in Sumerian do seem to display what is known as a definiteness effect: a restriction in a particular morphosyntactic environment that allows only indefinite nouns to occur in that environment. Only when affected by focus as in the answer to a wh-question or in contrast with an alternative, do environments that display a definiteness effect allow a definite noun to occur. The classic example of this kind of alternation is the existential sentence in English with expletive *there* as in the following examples.

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(5) There is a rat in my soup.

(6) *There is the rat in my soup.

(7) A: What's in your soup?

%B: There's the rat, the tomatoes and the creamed corn.

Under ordinary discursive expectations (in which existential sentences are only used to introduce a new topic), the definite noun phrase in (6) is blocked, whereas the indefinite one in (5) is fine. The definite noun phrase is only permitted when it is focused as in answer to the question in (7A), and then it is limited to a distinct pair-list reading, in which the referent of the definite noun phrase is interpreted as one of a number of possible answers to the question (see sections 3.4 and 3.5 for further elaboration).

Chapter 4 identifies and investigates one example of a focus-affected definiteness effect environment: the *XP nam bi-√ construction, a construction that I interpret as a negative contrastive focus construction. In the non-progressive/perfective aspect, the configuration of body-part noun followed by *bi-√ prefix has all the properties typically associated with an existentially-quantified, indefinite noun such as boundedness and homogeneity, but in the progressive/imperfective aspect, which is the usual form of the verb in *XP nam bi-√ environments, the predicate no longer refers to a bounded entity and can no longer be interpreted as equivalent to an indefinite noun. The unbounded version only seems to be permitted in an environment that also includes contrastive, indeed, negative contrastive focus of the form "it is not A, (but rather B) that ...." Therefore, in the midst of a number of broader arguments as to the nature of topic and

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focus, clause-linkage and rhetorical devices of one kind or another, much of the inner workings of the dissertation deal with a pair of relatively circumscribed issues: (i) definiteness in relation to topic and focus and (ii) the role of possessive constructions in the development of the animacy opposition and ergativity in Sumerian.

Chapter 5 introduces several theories that others have proposed to explain the development of ergativity in Sumerian and the differentiation of the two postpositions that share the form *-e: namely, the locative-terminative postposition and the ergative postposition. I argue that several distinct stages led to the development of ergativity in Sumerian and that the correct analysis of the Sumerian phenomena is similar to both Garrett's description of the development of ergativity in Hittite (1990) and Zólyomi's description of the history of four-participant verbs in Sumerian (1999).

At a somewhat more mundane level, the organization of chapters 1 through 5 can be thought of as a series of related distributional classes held together by the hypothesis outlined above.

Chapter	**Distributional class**	**Interpretation**
1	$BNBV_{inal}$	Absolutive/oblique case-marking
2	*bi-√	Achievement lexical aspectual class
3	*mini-√	Topic and definiteness
4	*XP nam bi-√	Focus and indefiniteness
5	*-e (LocTerm and Erg)	Possession and the rise of ergativity

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Therefore, it should be apparent that, in terms of methodology, I follow a rather straightforward procedure: chapter 1 identifies a small and, hopefully, well-defined syntactic class ($BNBV_{inal}$), chapter 2 looks at the contexts in which members of the class occur so as to identify some of the its semantic features, chapters 3 and 4 look at the occurrence of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class in two distinct morphosyntactic environments, *mini-√ and *XP nam bi-√ respectively, in the hope that some form of semantic compositionality can be identified in these environments, and chapter 5 formulates a diachronic hypothesis as to how ergativity arises in Sumerian, resulting in the differentiation of locative-terminative and ergative cases, both of which share the form *-e.

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1

The $BNBV_{inal}$ distributional class

Sumerian frequently makes use of a syntactic construction in which a noun phrase occurs immediately before the verb and seems to form a lexical or idiomatic unit with the verbal root. These noun/verb pairs are known as compound verbs and are often treated as distinct lexemes in lexicographical work such as the example in (1).

(1) Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta, l. 554[5]

en aratta^{ki}.ke$_4$ gig.e igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$

en	aratta-k-e	gig-e	igi	$[b]_5$-$[i]_{10}$-$[n]_{11}$-√du
lord	GN-Gen-Erg	wheat-LocTerm	eye	Inan-Dir-ProAnim-close.up

The lord of Aratta saw the wheat

[5] Transcriptions of languages written in cuneiform and, in particular, transcriptions of Sumerian make use of a plethora of conventions, only a few of which will be outlined here: (a) graphemes are separated by periods if they belong to the same word or appear in superscript if they are purely semantic elements and lack phonological representation, (b) the numbers in subscript following some graphemes code correspondences between certain orthographies and phonological forms, but in themselves they do not represent any phonological diacritic. Elsewhere in this thesis, where necessary, the subdivisions in the verbal prefix signaled by the use of square brackets such as -$[b]_5$- are based on the segmentation and numbering in use at the Pennsylvania Sumerian Dictionary (Karahashi, personal communication), but for the sake of exposition the segmentation implicit in the work of Krecher, Jagersma, and Zólyomi (Zólyomi 1999) is used in this section. See the section on conventions and abbreviations in the front matter for the abbreviations in the glosses.

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In recent years the investigation of their syntax has become one of the most interesting areas of Sumerian grammatical research, primarily due to the postulation of a distinct case-marking pattern in which a directive case agreement morpheme [Dir] appears in the verbal prefix and is thought to agree with either a dative or a locative case-marking postposition following the corresponding noun phrase. The noun phrase that bears the dative or locative case in these constructions is often now described as the oblique object [OO] of the verb.

In (1), under the OO hypothesis, **igi** is the syntactic object of the verb √**du**$_8$ and is in the zero-marked absolutive case, but since it is a compound verb, the logical object is coded in an oblique case such as the locative-terminative case, *-e [LocTerm], that follows **gig** "wheat" in the phrase **gig-e**.

(2) Enki's Journey to Nippur [1.1.4], l. 93 (Al-Fouadi 1969; Karahashi 2000: 29)

^{d}en.ki.ke$_4$ gu$_4$ im.ma.ab.gaz.e

enkik-e gud-Ø [i]$_2$-[b]$_5$-[a]$_7$-[b]$_{11}$-√gaz-e

PN-Erg ox-Abs Vent-NH-Dat-ProNH-√kill-Dur

Enki was slaughtering oxen

In (2), however, as one might expect in an ergative language, the agent appears in the ergative case, ^{d}**en.ki.ke**$_4$, while the patient appears in the absolutive case, **gu**$_4$. The morphosyntactic pattern in (1) is thought to be limited to transitive verbs of low

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transitivity as opposed to the pattern in (2), which exhibits high transitivity (Zólyomi 1999: 216-217 n. 2).

In section 1.1, the OO hypothesis and its roots in work carried out, above all, by Krecher, is briefly examined and the rather heterogeneous and complex character of the "system" of verbal prefixes emphasized. In section 1.2, a proper subset of the many lexemes that are generally described as compound verbs is isolated on the basis of a simple diagnostic: the occurrence of a bare, unmodified nominal component of a compound verb that immediately precedes the verbal component with the verbal prefix [bi-√] (termed the *Bare Noun* + **Bi-√ Verb* [BNBV] class) as in (1). The set of lexemes defined by the BNBV diagnostic, particularly if it is further restricted to *inalienable* nouns (hence the mnemonic [$BNBV_{inal}$]), is interesting in that it corresponds to what are known as *low source applicative* constructions in other languages (Pylkkänen 2002) and their association with privative semantics (including verbs of perception which form the core of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class). Low source applicatives and their semantic peculiarities are described and compared to the contextual meaning of the subset of compound verbs defined as $BNBV_{inal}$ in section 1.3. The three following sections look at three types of $BNBV_{inal}$ verb in more detail: section 1.4 deals with *verbs of perception*, section 1.5 with what, for the time being, I term *verbs of adversity* and section 1.6 with the remaining examples.

In section 1.7, a number of possible motivations for and/or correlations with the $BNBV_{inal}$ class are sketched out and two distinct phenomena are isolated as likely factors in the semantic effects displayed by the $BNBV_{inal}$ class: indefiniteness and transfer of

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possession. I propose that the *bi-√ prefix is the unmarked member of the rather elaborate set of dimensional infixes, that it is regularly used with an indefinite bare noun, and that, for the most part, we can use a transfer of possession model in which $BNBV_{inal}$ verbs code the transfer of the referent of an indefinite noun from a source to a goal (both indicated, for the most part, by an *-e postposition): the particular semantics of each subset within the $BNBV_{inal}$ group resulting in a somewhat different interpretation of source and goal. In section 1.8, I offer an alternative interpretation of the significance of the ergative postposition in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions as inalienable possessor rather than ergator and draw a comparison to nominative/dative or absolutive/oblique case-marking subsystems that are used in a variety of languages to code the thematic relations in verbs of perception and experience.

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1.1 Directive case and the oblique object hypothesis

Sumerian morphosyntax has traditionally been thought of in terms of *agreement* between nominal case-endings or postpositions and elements of the verbal prefix with relatively little consideration of any kind of external evidence or motivation for such agreement besides the phonological form of the agreeing elements themselves. The paradigms generated by this traditional practice have been subjected to increasingly sophisticated elucidation and testing in recent years, but the basic premise remains unchanged. In particular, models in which *subcategorization* of the verb replaces verbal *agreement* as in the head-marking, head-final type have not, as a rule, been investigated in any detail. Therefore I use the word *agreement* in the following account in a pretheoretical sense to mean simply regular co-occurrence without taking any position as to whether it is true agreement or subcategorization of the verb with a corresponding nominal. Regardless of theoretical presuppositions, an interesting contrast can be drawn between the two case-marking subsystems that involve agreement with dative and locative case-marked nouns: the indirect object [IO] subsystem as opposed to the oblique object [OO] subsystem. In the following account I attempt to follow the model of directive case-marking and OO proposed by Zólyomi (1999) without attempting to take into consideration differences between Zólyomi's work and that of Jagersma, which is largely unpublished. The views adhered to by Zólyomi and Jagersma both reflect a line of thought that begins with work by Krecher (1985). I would also like to emphasize that the morphological segmentations in this section attempt to represent the hypothesis advanced in recent years by Zólyomi and Jagersma—they do not represent my own understanding of Sumerian morphological

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segmentation. Readers who find the directive case hypothesis unconvincing would do well to skip this section entirely—it is not a critical component of my own proposal.

Like many languages, the primary opposition in the nominal system of Sumerian is between animate nouns that are capable of being an agent and those that are inanimate and only capable of filling an agentive thematic role in unusual circumstances; this corresponds to a basic division at or near ± human on a hierarchy of inherent lexical content or other measure of relative animacy (Silverstein 1976; 1993a; see Duranti 1997: 181-192 for background; Lee 1997 for broader implications). The animacy opposition is realized in, for example, the dative case-marking postposition: the animate form is *-ra, the inanimate form is *-e (the dative and locative-terminative postpositions respectively; see Zólyomi 1999: 251-253 for justification). The ergative postposition, *-e, is identical in morphological form to the locative-terminative postposition, *-e, but since the ergative postposition usually only occurs with animate nouns and the two postpositions often differ in their placement within the clause (the ergative typically in initial position in the absence of focus, the locative-terminative not similarly constrained), we can be fairly sure of the opposition. The opposition is illustrated in the two following examples, where the salient postposition appears in bold:

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(3) Ean. 11 2:9-3:4 (Jagersma forthcoming, 7/22)

^{d}nin.gir$_2$.su.ra gir$_2$.su^{ki} mu.na.du$_3$

ningirsuk-**ra**	girsu	[mu]$_4$-[n]$_{5/6}$-[a]$_7$-√du
PN-**Dat**	GN	Vent-Anim-Dat-build

He built Girsu for Ningirsu

(4) Gudea Cyl. A 18: 8-9 (Zólyomi 1999: 252)

e$_2$.e im.ma.g̃en

e-**e**	[i]$_2$-[b]$_{5/6}$-[a]$_7$-√g̃en
house-**Dat**	Vent-Inan-Dat-go

He went to the temple

Note in particular the agreement between the nominal postposition in each example and the corresponding segment of the verbal prefix: (3) NP-ra = [n]$_{5/6}$-[a]$_7$ and (4) NP-e = [b]$_{5/6}$-[a]$_7$, where [n]$_{5/6}$ and [b]$_{5/6}$ are animate and inanimate respectively.[6] The paradigm of (singular) dative elements in the verbal prefix are as follows:[7]

[6] The animate and inanimate elements in the verbal prefix are often assigned to distinct slots, [ ]$_6$ and [ ]$_5$ respectively in the verbal prefix in order to solve several incongruities having to do with the verb, but in the constructions involving the type of verb that concerns us here, there is no reason to maintain the opposition. There is a great deal of disagreement about the number, segmentation and ordering of the verbal slots and the numbering used here is purely conventional, hence the notation [ ]$_{5/6}$.

[7] The form of the second person dative alternates between *mura-√ and *mara-√ but the latter is simply a case of assimilation and should not be confused with the first person dative prefix or necessarily associated with the second person dative affix itself.

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*-'a-	first person singular
*-ra-	second person singular
*-na-	third person animate singular
*-ba-	third person inanimate singular

In opposition to the IO subsystem outlined above, another paradigm has been identified within the verbal prefix that is for the most part identical to the IO paradigm except for the vowel: the directive case agreement morphemes, *-bi-, *-ni-, *-ri-, which form part of the OO subsystem. These elements likewise occur in the verbal prefix, but they are not in complementary distribution with the dative agreement morphology and their pattern of agreement and interpretation remain controversial as illustrated in the following examples:

(5) Nanna-Suen's Journey to Nippur [1.5.1], l. 271 (Zólyomi 1999: 218, ex. 3)

$ud_5.de_3$ $ni\tilde{g}_2.ar_3.ra$ $bi_2.ib_2.gu_7.en$

ud-**e**	niğara	$[\mathbf{b}]_{5/6}$-$[\mathbf{i}]_{10}$-$[b]_{11}$-√gu-$[en]_{13}$
goat-**Dat**	groats	**Inan-Dir**-ProInan-eat-1/2Sg

I will make the goats eat groats

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(6) Ean. 1 9:2-3 (Zólyomi 1999: 218)

e_2.an.na.tum_2.ra lu_2 ti mu.ni.ra

eanatum-ra	lu	ti	$[mu]_4$-**[n]**$_{5/6}$-**[i]**$_{10}$-√ra
PN-Dat	man	arrow	Vent-**Anim-Dir**-hit

Somebody struck Eannatum with an arrow,

(7) Cyl. A 15: 19-21 (Zólyomi 1999: 242, ex. 61)

kur ^{giš}eren.na lu_2 nu.ku_4.ku_4.da gu_3.de_2.a en ^{d}nin.ĝir_2.su.ke_4 ĝiri_3 mu.na.ni.ĝar

kur	eren-ak	lu	nu-ku.ku-ed-a	gudea-r
mountain	cedar-Gen	man	Neg-enter.Redup-ED-Loc	PN-Dat

en	ningirsuk-e	ĝiri	$[mu]_4$-**[n]**$_{5/6}$-$[a]_7$-**[ni]**$_{10}$-√ĝar
lord	PN-Erg	foot	Vent-Anim-Dat-Dir-place

Ningirsu has made Gudea make his way into the Cedar Mountain where nobody is to enter

All three examples are causative constructions that exploit a compound verb, and since causativization of low transitivity verbs seems to be one of the basic features of alienable BNBV constructions (as already noted by Zólyomi [1999, 238-242]), any future work on the alienable BNBV class will have to investigate causativization in detail. The alienable class is not, however, dealt with in substantial fashion herein.

But, at this point in the discussion, the most important thing to notice is the relative incoherence and analytical complexity of the verbal prefixes in (5), (6) and (7): examples (5) and (6) are roughly parallel, differing only in the animacy of the directive argument:

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$[b]_{5/6}$ is inanimate in (5), whereas $[n]_{5/6}$ is animate in (6). In (7), however, the directive case shows allophonic variation and appears in the form $[ni]_{10}$ which is formally equivalent to $[n]_{5/6}$-$[i]_{10}$ (Anim-Dir). Zólyomi analyzes the $[ni]_{10}$ in (7) as a locative morpheme that agrees with the locative postposition at the end of the phrase **kur ^{ĝeš}eren.na lu$_2$ nu.ku$_4$.ku$_4$.da** rather than as the directive infix. But here Zólyomi seems to run into trouble, since one of the original motivations of the directive case hypothesis was the differentiation of the benefactive use of the animate dative postposition, *-ra, and its use to mark a causee. Zólyomi's Table 5 (1999, 229) identifies the co-occurrence of the animate dative postposition, *-ra, with the "/n/ + /a/" verbal infix as the dative case (to be associated, primarily, with benefactive use), whereas the co-occurrence of the same postposition with the "/n/ + /i/" verbal infix is identified as the directive case. Since the interpretation of **gu$_3$.de$_2$.a(r)** as causee rather than benefactive (in accord with Zólyomi's translation) would require associating **gu$_3$.de$_2$.a(r)** with $[ni]_{10}$ rather than $[n]_{5/6}$-$[a]_7$, under the directive case hypothesis, **gu$_3$.de$_2$.a(r)** is either dative, in which case, the clause is benefactive rather than causative and $[ni]_{10}$ can be interpreted as locative, or directive, in which case, (a) the clause is causative, but (b) $[ni]_{10}$ must be reinterpreted as the directive case infix rather than the locative infix, (c) the dative infix no longer has a argument in the clause to agree with, and (d) $[ni]_{10}$ has to be treated as an allophonic variant of $[i]_{10}$ so as to preserve Krecher's Rule (see Zólyomi 1999, 221, table 1, slot II).

The interpretation of $[ni]_{10}$ as an allophonic variant of the directive case infix, however, is clearly a loophole in the directive case hypothesis and Krecher's Rule. The morphological segmentation of the verb in (7), at least in Zólyomi's analysis, favors

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interpreting $[ni]_{10}$ as locative, whereas the contextual meaning of the clause clearly calls for a causative interpretation. None of the theories that have been applied to examples like (7) can be considered descriptively adequate, but the line of argument exemplified by the OO hypothesis, in particular, the fact that benefactive arguments seem to be differentiated from causee arguments (where the nominal phrases themselves are both followed by the animate dative postposition, *-ra) by the alternation between the dative infix (prototypically *-na-) and the directive infix (prototypically *-ni-) is presumably a valid characterization in empirical terms at some level of description. Any new proposals must make sense of these descriptive facts in the long run, but I have chosen to narrow the scope of this study to a proper subset of the verbs bearing the *bi-√ prefix, leaving the more elaborate alternatives involving animate causees and benefactives for future study. My point, however, is that the directive case hypothesis is overly complex in morphological terms and makes extensive use of homophonous segments such as /ni/ that are analyzed in distinctive ways (locative $[ni]_{10}$ as opposed to animate directive $[n]_{5/6}$-$[i]_{10}$) so as to resolve inconsistencies within the directive case hypothesis itself. In the following section, I propose an alternative solution to one subset of the morphosyntactic facts addressed by the directive case hypothesis. Where the directive case hypothesis postulates increasingly complex and empirically fragile morphological segmentations, my proposal juxtaposes lexical classes of several types to morphosyntactically defined components of the verbal prefix (such as "applicative" or "causative") to yield meanings that are equivalent, or in some cases, even more precise than the values proposed in the directive case hypothesis.

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1.2 The bare noun + *bi-√ verb [BNBV] diagnostic

The set of compound verbs in Sumerian is extensive, no doubt due in large part to the rather small set of verbal roots in Sumerian (approximately 200 verbal roots are identified by Thomsen ([1984] 2001, 295-323; Karahashi 2000, 16). But the compound verbs co-occur with a wide variety of verbal prefixes and cannot be easily characterized in semantic terms, so it is reasonable to assume that there are a number of distinct lexically-defined subsets and that *compound verb* is at most a relatively uninformative cover term. The only syntactic feature shared by the entire set is that atelic verbs of ongoing action (Activity verbs in the Vendlerian typology [Vendler 1967]) do not form compound verbs (this does not trivially follow from the fact that Activity verbs are generally intransitive, particularly given phenomena such as unaccusativity).[8] If, however, certain formal diagnostics are applied to the entire set of compound verbs, various subsets do seem to emerge: one of the clearest of these subsets is the one defined by the co-occurrence of a bare noun that is immediately followed by a verb that begins with the *bi-√ verbal prefix (the bare noun + *bi-√ verb [BNBV] diagnostic). In the subset of compound verbs defined by the BNBV diagnostic, certain verbs (**g̃iš-√tuk** "to hear," **igi-√du$_8$** "to see," **zu$_2$-√gub** "to taste") which indicate the achievement of a perception are included by the diagnostic as opposed to, say, an activity such as looking at or for something without perceiving it. In the following section (2.3), a particular syntactic description of the

[8] Unaccusative predicates take a single argument that is analogous, in semantic terms, to a patient or "direct object," but that occurs in the same syntactic position as an agent or "subject." Thus, in a nominative/accusative language like English, the syntactic form of an unaccusative is a simple intransitive sentence with subject preceding the verb, in semantic terms, however, the subject of an unaccusative is interpreted as if it were accusative and followed the verb. The generative tradition has long interpreted such forms by having the "subject" following the verb in underlying form.

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BNBV class will be proposed, but in this section the diagnostic test is specified and the set of lexemes defined by the diagnostic characterized.

Before attempting to explain why the BNBV diagnostic is a useful distributional class and forms a relatively coherent, semantically-defined group, I would first of all like to contrast the syntactic behavior of the BNBV class with several other types of verbal construction in Sumerian. In each of the following two pairs, examples (8) and (9) as well as examples (10) and (11), the first example is a member of the BNBV class, while the second is not, even though the verbs mean very nearly the same thing.

(8) Gilgamesh and the Netherworld [1.8.1.4], l. 302 (Karahashi 2000, 121, ex. 25)[9]

lu_2 izi.la_2 igi bi_2.du_8.am_3 igi nu.mu.ni.du_8

lu	izi-√la-r	igi	$[b]_{5/6}$-$[i]_{10}$-√du-am
person	fire-hang-Dat	eye	Inan-Dir-hold-Cop

igi	$[nu]_1$-$[mu]_2$-$[n]_{5/6}$-$[i]_{10}$-√du
eye	Neg-Vent-Anim-Dir-hold

A: Did you see a man who had burned (to death)?

B: I didn't see such a man.

[9] Shaffer also records a slightly different verbal prefix in one variant: **nu mu.de_3.du_8.am_3**.

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(9) Lament over Sumer and Ur [2.2.3], l. 23 (Karahashi 2000: 124)

^{d}en.lil$_2$.le igi.ni ki kur$_2$.ra ba.ab.ĝar.ra.a.ba

enlil-e	igi-ni	ki	kur-a
PN-Erg	eye-3Poss	place	oppose-Loc

[b]$_{5/6}$-[a]$_7$-[b]$_{11}$-√ĝar-a-bi-a

Inan-Dat-Inan-place-Nmz-DistAdv-Loc

After Enlil had looked at the enemy land ...

(10) The Young Scribe and his Father, l. 117 (Sjöberg 1973, 112, 117-118, 128, 147; Karahashi 2000, 87)

a.ra$_2$ na.me.ka ka.tar.ra.a.du$_{11}$.du$_{11}$ ĝiš li.bi$_2$.tuku.am$_3$

ara	name-k-a	katara-du-du	ĝiš	li	[b]$_{5/6}$-[i]$_{10}$-tuku-am
time	any-Gen-Loc	praise-say-Redup	"wood"	Neg	Inan-Dir-"have"-Cop

I have never heard such praise.

(11) Lugalbanda II [1.8.2.2], l. 160 (PSD A/3: 85)

mušen.e ĝeštu$_2$ mu.un.ši.in.ak (*var.* mu.un.ši.in.ĝa$_2$.ar)

mušen-e	ĝeštu	[mu]$_2$-[n]$_{5/6}$-[ši]$_9$-[n]$_{11}$-√ak/ĝar
bird-Erg	ear	Vent-Anim-Alla-Anim-do/place

The bird listened to him

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Examples (8) and (9) obviously differ according the basic BNBV criteria, so in (9) the nominal component of the compound verb bears a possessive pronoun and does not immediately precede the verb. Both (8) and (9) are compound verbs in the general sense, however, and they take the perceived object in an oblique case (the apparent absence of oblique case on **lu$_2$ izi.la$_2$** is only apparent, since both phonological and orthographic principles often result in the non-appearance of certain postpositions in the writing system, and it has been reconstructed in the gloss). With a handful of exceptions, the nominal component of any particular BNBV compound verb *never* bears a possessive pronoun or demonstrative clitic *even in those cases where the verbal prefix is not the *bi-√ prefix.*

Example (11) differs from example (10) in that an allative [Alla] directional element [ši]$_9$ occurs in the verbal prefix even though an allative postpositional phrase does not appear in the clause. Although older theories expected that dimensional infixes such as [ši]$_9$ would "agree" with postpositional phrases formed from an etymologically related postposition, Gragg's work has overturned this assumption (see section 1.3). I assume in the following that, in the majority of cases, the dimensional infixes can be thought of as the pronominal equivalent of the etymologically corresponding postpositional phrase. As a rule, the *bi-√ prefix excludes such directional/pronominal elements—this is in fact the intuition behind the most widely accepted reconstruction of the verbal prefix under the OO hypothesis: namely, that the *bi-√ prefix is made up of [b]$_{5/6}$-[i]$_{10}$, excluding the directional/pronominal elements (otherwise known as the dimensional infixes) in slots

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$[\ ]_7$, $[\ ]_8$ and $[\ ]_9$. In other words, the occurrence of the *bi-√ prefix in the BNBV diagnostic necessarily excludes the other dimensional infixes which I would argue are associated with pronominalization of postpositional phrases and, as a result, the definiteness of the noun phrase that bears the postposition (see Gragg 1973a). All in all, the BNBV diagnostic systematically excludes from the BNBV set the most obvious cases of definite nouns that immediately precede the verb: namely, independent nominal phrases bearing possessive or demonstrative suffixes as well as the dimensional infixes. The reason for these restrictions on the definiteness of a phrase that appears immediately before the verb is that one of the primary goals of this investigation is to isolate constructions that include indefinite nouns and to track the morphosyntactic consequences of their indefiniteness.

If one turns to the corpora being assembled by CDLI, several preliminary distributional questions should probably be addressed before looking at the semantic class defined by the diagnostic: (a) what kinds of constituent can occur immediately before *bi-√ verbs in general (what, in other words, is the BNBV class a subset of), (b) what kinds of constituents occur immediately before the nominal component of a BNBV compound verb in which the bare noun is alienable, and (c) what kinds of constituents occur immediately before the nominal component of a BNBV construction in which the bare nominal is inalienable. The following table presupposes a number of interpretative principles that need to be made clear: *type* refers to a distinct lexemic set of exemplars (which due to the extremely formulaic character of most early documents represents a single exemplar in certain respects, e.g., **šu.a bi_2.gi_4** with 142 tokens of the type, nearly

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all identical in syntax), XP_1 refers to the syntactic phrase that immediately precedes the *bi-√ prefix verb, and XP_2 refers to the phrase that immediately precedes XP_1, schematically: *XP_2 XP_1 bi-√. It should be emphasized that this is not an attempt to delineate the overall correlations between particular *bi-√ prefix verbs and any co-occurring syntactic phrase, but rather an attempt to locate any patterns involving locality with respect to the *bi-√ prefix itself. Where there is apparent alternation between the category of the preceding XP with respect to a particular verb and the alternation is between a postpositional phrase and a bare DP that ends in a vowel, all other things being equal, I have assumed that the bare DP is in fact a postpositional phrase of the corresponding type.

Period	XP_2	XP_1	Lexemes	Types/tokens
ED IIIb	$PP_{Loc/Erg}$	DP_{Bare}	i_3-√ak, gin_2-√bar, ki-gar-√du_{11}, nu-$banda_3$-√gar, giš-√ra, na-√ri/ru_2, a-√ru, al-√du_3, si-√sa_2, giš/GIN_2.$ŠE_3$-√se_3, igi-√sag_5, za_3-√$šu_4$, giš-√tag, za_3-√us_2	14/143
ED IIIb	$XP_{zero/DP/Erg/Loc}$	DP_{Loc}	za_3-√ak, √du_8, √gar, šu-√gi_4, √gu_7, √mu_7, √du_3	7/126

Several important observations can be made about the overall distribution of *bi-√ prefixes in the different corpora: there is clear opposition in the ED IIIb materials

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between (i) a construction in which a bare noun phrase occurs immediately to the left of the verb and a locative or ergative postpositional phrase occurs immediately to the left of the bare nominal *$PP_{Loc/Erg}$ NP_{Bare} bi-√, and (ii) a construction in which a locative postpositional phrase appears immediately to the left of the verb and the category of the constituent to the left of the locative postpositional phrase is entirely unconstrained *XP PP_{Loc} bi-√.[10] Although the number of tokens of BNBV constructions in the ED IIIb corpus are roughly equivalent for the two distributional classes, I would like to focus on the distribution that shows greater formal complexity, the $DP_{Loc/Erg}$ DP_{Bare} *bi-√ class, if for no other reason than the fact that the Old Babylonian materials that show the same distribution of preceding elements form a relatively coherent semantic class. Thus, anticipating my results somewhat, I would like to limit my attention to BNBV predicates of the form *$DP_{Loc/Erg}$ DP_{Bare} *bi-√ in which the nominal component of the compound verb is an inalienable body-part noun.

The *$DP_{Loc/Erg}$ DP_{Bare} *bi-√ distributional class is very poorly represented in the Old Akkadian materials, if present at all, and the predominant feature of the OAkk exemplars of *bi-√ prefix verbs is that co-occurring NPs tend to lack any overt case morphology whatsoever. I take this as an underspecification perhaps under the influence of the emergent, non-native Sargonic scribal elites, but do not pursue the matter further here.

The Ur III materials are also quite limited in that administrative and legal genres dominate the attested materials. There are a few examples of predicates that meet one of

[10] Note that the highly attenuated nature of verbal prefixes in the ED IIIb period may call into question some of these identifications, but the juxtaposition of the two syntactic patterns, [NP-e NP-Ø bi-√] vs. [XP NP-a bi-√], seems to represent a rather clear pattern.

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the two criteria mentioned above, namely an inalienable body-part noun that immediately precedes the *bi-√ prefix: **igi bi$_2$.ib.sa$_6$** (ASJ 7,125, 27); **šu bi$_2$.bar.ra.še$_3$** (BM 18078 = ASJ 9, 329, rev. i 2), **šu bi$_2$.ba** (BM 23871 = ASJ 10, 88, 2; ITT 2/1: 924 = NG 213; MVN 2, 2), **šu bi$_2$.in.ba** (SANTAG 6, 154); **a$_2$ bi$_2$.dar** (Nik 447), **a$_2$ bi$_2$.in.dar** (ITT 3:6572 = NG 145; BM 106157 = SNAT 535; AO 6047 = NG 214); **šu bi$_2$.in.us$_2$** (Jean SA 42). But in no case is the bare inalienable noun itself preceded by a noun followed by the locative-terminative postposition. If one assumes that **šu-√ba** and **šu-√bar** represent the same verbal root, there are 11 tokens of four types. Of these lexemes, most show the distributional pattern $DP_{Loc/Erg}$ DP_{Bare} *bi-√ just as the ED IIIb materials do, but one, **a$_2$-√dar**, shows the same distributional pattern as the Old Babylonian examples that form one of the primary sets of data for this chapter: *$DP_{LocTerm}$ DP_{Bare} bi-√. This last distributional pattern is the most robust and coherent subset within the class defined by the BNBV diagnostic in Old Babylonian materials from Nippur: those BNBV constructions in which the bare nominal is an (inalienable) part of the body and the nominal that precedes the bare nominal bears the locative-terminative postposition. This particular distributional category is, however, limited to a handful of questionable examples in the third millennium corpora such as **igi-√sag$_5$** (ED IIIb) or **igi-√sa$_6$(g)** (Ur III): the only lexeme that fully conforms to the Old Babylonian pattern that is the centerpiece of this chapter is **a$_2$-√dar**, which is included in the appropriate section below in spite of its anachronism. One possible member of the BNBV class that seems to have been lexicalized is **umbisag**, "scribe," which presumably derives from **um bi$_2$.sag$_x$**, "one who strikes (= √sag$_3$) the DUB$_a$/UM"—leaving open the question of the proper

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interpretation of UM, which like MA is a member of the set of graphemes in Sumerian without any clear lexical meaning and presumably derives from whatever language underlies the proto-cuneiform materials (see Englund 1998, 77, fn. 158, 79-81). In chapter 3, I argue that one function of the *bi-√ prefix is to form what are known as head-internal relative clauses and it appears that **umbisag** may represent just such a head-internal relative clause.

If we now turn to the class defined by the BNBV diagnostic in the Old Babylonian materials from Nippur, in the materials studied by Karahashi (2000), which are limited to compound verbs in which the nominal component of the compound is a body-part, nearly a dozen and a half compound verbs belong to this narrowly defined subset of the BNBV class.

Table of $BNBV_{inal}$ lexemes (excluding those involving šu 'hand')

Noun	Verb	Meaning	Type
a_2	√dar	to seize illegally; to confiscate	Adversity
a_2	√g̃ar	to lose	Adversity
a_2	√su_3	to spread out; to sail away; to run off	?
du_{10}	√g̃al_2	to fight	Adversity
dur_2	√g̃ar	to sit; to seat	?
g̃iš	√tuk	to hear	Perception
gu_2	√du_3	to neglect; to despise	Adversity
gu_2	√e_3	to wear; to cover; to be clad in	?
gu_2	√gur	to bend downwards; to lodge; to spy	Perception
igi	√du_8	to see	Perception
igi	√kar_2	to examine	Perception
ka	√$keš_2$	to put together; to tie up; to bind	Adversity
$ša_3$	√dab_5	to feel hurt; to be angry; to be worried	Adversity
umbin	√la_2	to scratch	Adversity
za_3	√tag	to push away; to overthrow; to reject	Adversity
zu_2	√gub	to taste	Perception

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Note that two lexemes, **saĝ-√il$_2$** "to lift the head" and **saĝ-√se$_3$** "to entrust; to take care of" are not included although the bare nominal, **saĝ**, "head," is generally thought of as part of the body. This is due to the fact that **saĝ** "head" presumably stands in opposition to **saĝ.ki** "forehead" in that **saĝ** is probably relational like **an** "sky; above" or **ki** "earth, below," whereas **saĝ.ki** is limited in meaning to a part of the body. There also seem to be some telling grammatical differences such the fact that compound verbs headed by **saĝ** occurs in the *nam.mi-√ construction, whereas the other alienable nouns occur in the *nam bi-√ construction, an opposition that seems to depend on the inalienability of the head noun; I explore it detail in chapter 4. Note that in the most famous case of disembodied head in Sumerian literature, namely when Gilgamesh and Enkidu dump Huwawa's head out in front of Enlil (*Gilgamesh and Huwawa*, version A, line 183), the possessive pronoun refers to the original owner, but the form is **saĝ.du.ni** rather than **saĝ.ĝa.ni**. This leads me to suspect that **saĝ** itself does not directly refer to the head.

kas$_4$-√kar "to sprint" is also excluded even though Karahashi included it in her study of compound verbs that involve a part of the body. Karahashi herself notes that "kas$_4$ normally means 'runner, courier' but may have originally designated a part of the leg/foot which became obsolete during later times..." (Karahashi 2000, 129).

The reason that few if any of these lexemes occur in texts earlier than the Old Babylonian period is, in my view, that the kinds of generic contexts in which verbs of perception, adversity and possession that constitute the vast majority of the members of the class simply did not exist in the written medium. In other words, the genres in which the particular semantics that I argue are associated with this distributional class are not

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attested in significant numbers prior to the Old Babylonian period. Only once these genres surface in text-artifactual form, does the distributional category that I investigate in this chapter appear in clear and robust fashion. But even if the lexemes that occur in the class defined by the BNBV diagnostic differ in some respects, the form of the syntactic constituents that seem to occur in BNBV constructions in the OB period can be derived in a fairly transparent way from the form seen in the ED IIIb period. Whereas the ED IIIb materials seem to suggest a syntactic structure such as [[... $PP_{Loc/Erg}$ [(NP_{Bare}) bi]-√], the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction seems to suggest a syntactic ground plan such as the following: [... $PP_{Loc/Erg}$ [$PP_{LocTerm}$ NP_{Bare}] bi]-√ with the inclusion of the an additional $PP_{LocTerm}$ argument of the verb (the oblique object in the terminology of Zólyomi [1999]).

Even given this relatively sketchy set of distributional facts, a preliminary distributional template can be proposed:

(12) $[_{XP}$ ... $[[_{Direct\ speech}$ Ø Ø $bi_2]$-$du_{11}]]$

(13) $[_{XP}$ ... $[[PP_{Loc}$ Ø Ø $bi_2]$-√]]

(14) $[_{XP}$ ... $[PP_{Loc/Erg}$ Ø $[NP_{Bare}]$ $bi_2]$-√]

(15) $[_{XP}$ ... $[PP_{Loc/Erg}$ $[PP_{LocTerm}$ $[NP_{Bare}]]$ $bi_2]$-√]

Although the series of phrase diagrams running from (12) through (15) is a fiction in that they do not represent any single synchronic phase of the language, they are at least partially representative of the overall syntactic pattern that I am attempting to justify in

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this chapter. And, it is, after all, a syntactic pattern familiar from the center-embedding genitive construction in Sumerian.

Example	Syntactic form	Genitive parallel
13	$[PP_{Loc}\ bi_2]$-√	[NP-Loc]
14	$[PP_{Loc/Erg}\ NP_{Bare}\ bi_2]$-√	[NP NP-Gen]
15	$[PP_{Loc/Erg}\ [PP_{LocTerm}\ NP_{Bare}\ (bi_2)]\ bi_2]$-√	[NP [NP NP-Gen]-Gen]

As I will argue in explicit terms later on, a number of factors indicate that the *bi-√ prefix is quite similar to the expletive *there* in English existential sentences such as "there is a dog in the parlor." This obviously corresponds in certain respects to the traditional notion that the *bi-√ prefix "agrees" with a locative argument, but I would like to emphasize two fundamental distinctions before moving on to the next section. If the *bi-√ prefix is similar to the expletive *there* in English existential sentences, then one might expect it to regularly occur with locative arguments. But it needs to be remembered that *there* does not agree with the locative it occurs with, it simply occurs in certain *syntactic* configurations that also typically include locative arguments. In other words, it is a matter of syntax rather than a morphologically-driven agreement relation that holds between a morpheme on the verb and a locative phrase in the clause. The other difference between the traditional agreement-based interpretation and my suggestion that the bi-√ prefix is analogous to expletive "there" is that the use of expletive "there" in English has far reaching syntactic implications for case-marking, quantification and focus constructions.

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In the following section, I argue that the *bi- prefix is best understood from a syntactic point of view rather than the conventional, "morphological" interpretation of it as an agreement marker. Bearing these considerations in mind, let us turn to the first part of my redescription of the *bi-√ prefix.

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1.3 $BNBV_{inal}$ as a low source applicative

Not only does the BNBV diagnostic, when its use is limited to compound verbs in which the bare noun is an inalienable part of the body ($BNBV_{inal}$), identify a distinct syntactic class, but it also identifies a semantic field that includes verbs of perception as well as verbs that signify privation or loss with respect to an argument that represents the object of perception or the participant who is adversely affected. The natural counterpart of an argument that represents the source from which something is taken, an entity that receives or benefits from the privation of the source, is an experiencer argument. Recent work (Pylkkänen 2002) has identified a syntactic phenomenon known as a low source applicative[11] that exhibits the same set of semantic features as the $BNBV_{inal}$ class: this section offers an overview of low applicativity based on Pylkkänen's dissertation that supports a redescription of the *bi-√ prefix in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions as a low source applicative morpheme.

In general terms, an applicative morpheme allows a noun phrase that would otherwise have appeared in an adpositional phrase to appear in a zero/unmarked case and to participate more directly in the syntactic behavior of a verbal predicate. This phenomenon exists, for example, in English in so-called double object constructions as exemplified in the following examples:

[11] Pylkkänen's low source applicative hypothesis represents only the most recent and innovative phase of the investigation of so-called double object constructions. Previous milestones in the investigation of the double object are Larson 1988 and Pesetsky 1995, see Harley 2003 for the current state of double object construction analyses in generative terms, including a review of previous literature.

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(18) Sue bought a cake for Lou.

(19) Sue bought Lou a cake.

Although there is no distinct segmental morphology in English, nonetheless it is fairly clear that the dative case-marked argument in (18), *for Lou*, can drop its preposition and shift to a position immediately after the verb and before the patient as in (19). Building on previous work by, among others, Pesetsky (1995), Pylkkänen (2002) differentiates a number of different kinds of applicative on the basis of different syntactic criteria. The most basic opposition drawn by Pylkkänen is between high applicatives and low applicatives. The classic examples of applicatives from slightly older works are, as a rule, high applicatives such as the following:

(20) Chichewa (Pylkkänen 2002, 18; Baker 1988, 354)

Maruto	a-na-umb-ir-a	inpeni	mtsuko
PN	Sp-Past-mold-Appl-Asp	knife	waterpot

Maruto molded the waterpot with a knife

Note that the instrumental adjunct, *inpeni*, "knife," in (20) is a bare noun, whereas its English translation, *with a knife*, is a prepositional phrase. Comparison with other examples that lack the instrumental adjunct show the *-ir- morpheme indicates that the knife is an instrument instead of, say, the patient. Pylkkänen then differentiates between high applicatives such as (20) and two types of low applicative: low goal applicatives as

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in the English double object construction in (19) and low source applicatives as in the following example from Korean (Pylkkänen 2002: 21, example [21] in contrast with example [22]).

(21) totwuk-i Mary-**hanthey** panci-lul humchi-ess-ta
thief-Nom Mary-**Dat** ring-Acc steal-Past-Plain
The thief stole a ring from Mary (and it was in her possession when he stole it)

(22) totwuk-i Mary-**ui** panci-lul humchi-ess-ta
thief-Nom Mary-**Gen** ring-Acc steal-Past-Plain
The thief stole Mary's ring (with no implication as to the presence of Mary at the theft)

The basic criterion for differentiating a high applicative such as (20) from a low applicative such as (21) is whether or not there is necessarily a possessive relation between the direct object and the applied argument: high applicatives do not presuppose any kind of possessive relation between direct object and the oblique argument, whereas low applicatives require such a possessive relation. In (20), there is no reason to suspect the existence of any kind of possessive relation between the knife and the waterpot, but in (21) as well as the English example in (19), the oblique argument, *Mary-Dat* and *Lou* respectively, must either start out (21) or end up (19) as the possessor of the direct object. Although Pylkkänen does not make the connection explicit, readers familiar with either

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Zólyomi's description of possessor raising in Sumerian (1999, 231-237) or the use of clausal possessive constructions for certain kinds of inalienable noun (see Nichols 1988 for orientation) should recognize that the low source applicative is also a kind of possessor raising construction. In other words, the low source applicative takes a possessive construction involving a head noun, such as *panci-lul* in (22), and a possessor in the genitive case, such as *Mary-ui* in (22)—where only *panci-lul*, the direct object, has a syntactic relation to the main verb—and changes it into a raised possessor construction in which *both the head noun, panci-lul in (21), and the raised possessor, Mary-hanthey in (21), are arguments of the verb.* It is only because of the fact that *Mary-ui* is not an argument of the verb, whereas *Mary-hanthey* is, that we can speak of the construction in (21) as a low source *applicative* construction, since one defining feature of an applicative construction is that it takes a phrase that is not an argument of the verb and converts it into a phrase that is an argument of the verb.

The parallel with the other types of applicative should, therefore, be fairly clear: the high applicative in (20) removes the instrumental case-marking from an instrument, *inpeni*, and indicates that it a core argument of the verb by adding a morpheme, *-ir-, to the verb; the low goal applicative in (19) changes a benefactive prepositional phrase, *for Lou*, into a bare noun, *Lou*, and incorporates the bare noun into the verb; likewise, the low source applicative in (21) changes a genitive possessive construction into a clausal possessive construction with a raised possessor and, in the process, makes the raised possessor an argument of the verb (for further discussion of possessor raising and its relation to the rise of ergative case-marking in Sumerian, see chapter 5).

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Various theoretical considerations that I will not go into here lead Pylkkänen (2002, 21-23) to postulate that the low applicative is best understood as a higher order predicate that takes three arguments: the direct object, the oblique argument and the lexical verb. But more importantly from a descriptive point of view, Pylkkänen also offers a number of diagnostics for differentiating high and low applicatives, two of which I repeat here in full (Pylkkänen 2002, 23):

> DIAGNOSTIC 1: TRANSITIVITY RESTRICTIONS
>
> Only high applicative heads should be able to combine with unergatives [agentive, intransitive verbs, CJ]. Since a low applicative head denotes a relation between the direct and indirect object, it cannot appear in a structure that lacks a direct object.
>
> DIAGNOSTIC 2: VERB SEMANTICS
>
> Since low applicatives imply a transfer of possession, they make no sense with verbs that are completely static: for example, an event of holding a bag does not plausibly result in the bag ending up in someone's possession. High applicatives, on the other hand, should have no problem combining with verbs such as *hold*: it is perfectly plausible that somebody would benefit from a bag-holding event.

It should be fairly clear that the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction meets both of these criteria: given the close association between compound verbs and the OO constructions in an environment defined by the occurrence of a *bi-√ prefix verb, it is reasonable to assume

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that *bi-√ prefix verbs are generally transitive and involve both a direct object and an indirect object. Likewise, the fact that all of the members of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class involve a change of state indicates that Pylkkänen's second diagnostic is satisfied as well.

One the most well-known semantic effects of the constructions such as (12) and the corresponding form in Japanese (gapped adversity passives) is that the event described by the predicate affects the dative possessor in a negative way: this clearly results from the source argument implicit in low applicative constructions and is apparent in examples of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class (Pylkkänen 2002, 23; on Japanese gapped adversity passives and their similarity to (12), see Kubo 1992 and Pylkkänen 2002, 59-68). One the best examples of the role of privation in low source applicatives is the meaning that Landau has attributed to possessor dative constructions in Hebrew (1999) and Pylkkänen critical response to Landau's initial proposal (Pylkkänen 2002, 43-49).

Landau begins with a discussion of a raised possessor construction in Modern Hebrew in which the possessor is preceded by a dative preposition, while the possessed noun is unmarked except for case as in the following example (Borer and Grodzinsky, 1986, ex. 12a; Landau 1999, 3, ex. 3).

(23)	ha-yalda	kilkela	le-Dan	et	ha-radio
	the-girl	spoiled	to-Dan	Acc	the-radio
	The girl broke Dan's radio				

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But Landau then draws a comparison with a construction in which the dative prepositional phrase is not the actual possessor, but rather a person who is negatively affected by the event described in the clause.

(24) Gil šavar le-Rina et ha-miškafayim šel Sigal
PN broke to-Rina Acc the-glasses of PN_2
Gil broke Sigal's glasses on Rina, i.e. Rina was negatively affected by event

Here in (24), the possessor of the glasses is indicated by *šel Sigal* "of Sigal," whereas the phrase that includes the dative preposition refers to Rina as the person negatively affected by the breaking of the glasses. The negative affect attributed to the referent of a noun in the dative case or a prepositional phrase should be familiar as one of the hallmarks of the low source applicative described above. The problem arises with a seemingly arbitrary restriction that would seem to contradict a low source applicative interpretation of verbs of direct perception. Landau notes that the possessor dative construction does not felicitously occur with verbs of perception such as *ra'a* "to see." Landau offers the following example of an ungrammatical sentence in which the verb is *ra'a* "to see" in contrast with a similar clause in (26) where the verb means "to look at" (Landau 1999, 25-26, ex. 49a and 49b).

(25) *Gil ra'a le-Rina et ha-bayit
PN saw to-Rina Acc the-house
Gil saw Rina's house

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(26)	Gil	histakel	le-Rina	al	ha-bayit
	PN	looked.at	to-Rina	on	the-house

Gil looked at Rina's house

Various hypotheses, taking examples like (24) as exemplary, have argued that the crucial matter is affectedness: in (23) and (24), the dative possessor is affected by the event, whereas in (25), it is not, hence the ungrammaticality of (25). Landau himself argued otherwise, attributing the ungrammaticality to the fact that the perceiver in (25) is non-agentive, whereas in (26), it is agentive. Landau does comment, in a footnote, that there is a small class of "to see" verbs which are grammatical such as the following (Landau 1999, 26, fn. 14; Pylkkänen 2002, 48).

(27)	Gil	ra'a	le-Rina	et	ha-pupik
	PN	saw	to-Rina	Acc	the-belly.button

Gil saw Rina's belly button

Landau attributes the grammaticality of (27) to the fact that *ha-pupik* "the belly button" is a part of the body and, in Landau's view, inalienable; this follows from a fairly common analysis among generativists, namely that inalienable possessors are generated at [Spec, NP], whereas alienable possessors are generated at [Spec, DP]; the import of such a structural description has long been recognized in functionalist circles at least since the

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work of Nichols who describes the diachronic origin of inalienability as follows (Nichols 1988, 579):

> A single diachronic process appears to motivate all of the attested patterns involving '[in]alienability': tighter bonding of possessive affixes, fusion of possessive affixes to nouns, and earlier lexicalization of possession, take place with those nouns which are most often possessed—kin terms, body parts, and (in languages where they are lexicalized as nouns) inherently relational notions such as parts of wholes.

Landau's argument ultimately boils down to a purely structural argument about the location of inalienable as apposed to alienable nouns in certain positions within syntactic trees and he explains the grammaticality of (27) on the basis of the idiomatic character of inalienable nouns and the fact that inalienable possessors are more tightly bound to an inalienable noun than is the case with alienable nouns. But it turns out that Landau's hypothesis is wrong: as noted by Pylkkänen (2002, 48), there are cases in which an alienable noun can occur as the perceived object with the verb *ra'a* "to see" and the criterion appears to have nothing to do with inalienability and everything to do with the privative semantics associated with low source applicatives; Pylkkänen describes the criterion as follows (Pylkkänen 2002, 48):

> Landau notes that the acceptability of the construction increases with intimate body parts and decreases with neutral ones. In other words, the semantic restrictions parallel the Finnish [low source applicative] ones precisely: the possessor dative is only acceptable with 'see' when the seeing-event makes something public that was private before. And, contrary to Landau's generalization, the object that becomes

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public does not need to be inalienably possessed; it simply needs to be "secret", in some way.

Pylkkänen cites as evidence the following example in which the perceived object is decidedly alienable.

(28)	Gil	ra'a	le-Rina	et	ha-mismaxim
	PN	saw	to-Rina	Acc	the-documents

Gil saw the documents that Rina had

The requirement for non-public objects of direct perception follows directly from the fact that "source applicatives . . . always involve an implication of loss, but this loss does not need to be concrete" (Pylkkänen 2002, 48). It should be relatively clear that the model that underlies low source applicatives is a transfer of possession model: an object of possession starts out in the possession of one entity and moves into the possession of another. Although acts of direct perception are quite abstract, Pylkkänen seems to be arguing that the perception of an entity initially "belongs" to that entity and the act of perception transfers the perception from the perceived object to its perceiver as if it were the referent of a concrete noun. At this point, it may be useful to turn to the first collection of exemplars from Sumerian, since they can be divided two primary groups, verbs of perception and affect, as well as third group of exceptions (those involving **šu** "hand" are dealt with in chapter 2).

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1.4 $BNBV_{inal}$ verbs of perception

Bearing in mind the sometimes quite complicated distributional pattern of low source applicatives, especially those involving perception and (usually negative) affect, I turn initially to $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates that are verbs of direct perception.

(29) Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta [1.8.2.3], ll. 551-554

(Karahashi 2000, 119; Vanstiphout 2003, 88-89)

551. gig ni_2.bi mu_2.a $guru_7$	*The wheat grown by itself . . . granary . . .,*
[x (x)] ka	
552. en $aratta^{ki}$.ra	*As for that which was brought to the lord of*
mu.na.ni.in.⌈ku_4⌉.[ku_4]	*Aratta,*
553. kisal $aratta^{ki}$.a.ka igi.ni.$še_3$	*It was piled up in front of him in the court of*
i.im.dub[?]	*Aratta,*
554. **en $aratta^{ki}$.ke_4 gig.e**	*The lord of Aratta saw the wheat,*
igi bi_2.in.du_8	

The example of a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate in line 554 is the one that appears at the beginning of the chapter as a prototypical example of a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate. For a hint as to the reasoning behind my translation of line 552 as a topicalized relative clause, see the discussion of *mini-√ in chapter 3.

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(30) Lugalbanda II [1.8.2.2], ll. 207-208 (Wilcke 1969a; Karahashi 2000, 119)

207. **[mušen.e an].ta igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$**	*As for the bird, who was looking from*
erin$_2$.e igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru	*above, she saw the troops,*
208. **[lugal].⌜ban$_3$⌝.da ki.ta**	*As for Lugalbanda, who was looking from*
igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$ saḫar erin$_2$.e	*below, he saw the troops enveloped in*
du$_8$.a igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru	*dust,*

The lack of a direct object with the first of the two perception verbs in each line provides some evidence in favor interpreting **igi-√du$_8$** as "to see" (achieved perception) as opposed to **igi-√il$_2$** "to look at" (attempted perception). As in the previous example, some justification for the translation of **igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$** as a relative clause is offered in chapter 4 in an extended discussion of the *mini-√ prefix; my interpretation of **igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$** as a relative clause also provides some justification for the progressive form of the verb in the English translation: since the relative clause in *mini-√ provide background information, they must be translated into English in the progressive aspect even through the Sumerian verbal form is *ḫamṭu* and would, typically, be translated with a past or perfect verb. The fact that **√du$_8$** is followed by the plural suffix /eš/ with the orthographic form **du$_8$.ru** indicates that the perceived object is **erin$_2$.e** "the troops" rather than a cloud of dust. Partial justification for interpreting **du$_8$.ru** as the verbal root followed by the plural suffix rather than, for example, the *marû* marker, *-e, is offered in chapter 2. For additional examples of **igi-√du$_8$** in BNBV$_{inal}$ configurations, see Karahashi (2000, 118-122).

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(31) Eduba Regulations [PBS 1/2, 98 = PBS 12, 30; UET 6, 168; UET 6, *240; ISET 1, 72 (Ni 4103); CBS 11786], the following based on PBS 12, 30, rev. 1-5 (unpublished) Falkenstein 1947, 183-184; Karahashi 2000, 127)

1. tur e_2.dub.ba.a ⌜šub⌝.šub.⌜ba⌝ x šu [...] igi dub.ba na.du_{11}.am_3 gu_2 [...]	*The little ones left at left . . .,*
2. ad.da e_2.dub.ba.a $giri_{17}$.zal da.bi i_3.tuku x	*The father has . . . his mouth at school,*
3. šeš.gal.e u_3 ba.dab$_5$ dub.be$_2$ igi bi$_2$.ib$_2$.kar$_2$.kar$_2$	*The older student, once he has taken them, should inspect the tablets,*
4. ki gu sar SI nu.ub.kar_2 a ⌜$ğa_2$⌝.e an.na.ab.sa_2.e	*Where he does not find . . ., he should correct it . . . ,*
5. tukum.bi tur e_2.dub.ba.a tur.re	*If a student at school . . . a student . . .,*

This composition is unpublished and difficult to make sense of. Since only line 3 makes much sense and the continuity of the passage remains unclear, it should be treated with caution.

(32) The Young Scribe and his Father, ll. 114-117

(Sjöberg 1973, 112, 117-118, 128, 147; Karahashi 2000, 87)

114. ^{ĝiš}gid$_2$.da ad.da.$ğa_2$.$še_3$ geštu$_2$ ga.ğar nu.ub.be_2.en	*You do not say, "I want to listen to the ... of my father,"*

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115. nam ^{d}en.lil$_2$.le lu$_2$.u$_{18}$.lu.a	*That the fate of humanity is determined by*
nam.bi tar.ra	*Enlil,*
116. dumu kig̃$_2$.gi$_4$.a ad.da.na.ka	*That a son should follow in the occupation*
i$_3$.ib$_2$.us$_2$	*of his father,*
117. **a.ra$_2$ na.me.ka ka.tar.ra.a**	*Haven't you heard these precious statements*
du$_{11}$.du$_{11}$ g̃iš li bi$_2$.tuku.am$_3$	*made innumerable times?*

This composition is better known as *Der Vater und sein missratener Sohn* after the edition of Sjöberg (1973). The meaning of the passage is still quite uncertain and I have taken the absence of an explicit agreement marker before the verbal root in combination with the copula following the verb as an indication that line 117 is a question (for a similar construction, see the series of **igi bi$_2$.du$_8$.am$_3$** ["did you see . . . ?"] predicates at the end of *Gilgamesh and the Netherworld*). The final verb in line 115 also shows a great deal of formal variation: **nam.bi tar.ra** (K and EE), **nam bi$_2$.ib.tar.re** (Z), **nam.bi in.tar.re** (AA), **nam.bi in.tar.ra.am$_3$** (FF), **nam.bi tar.re** (II), **nam bi$_2$ [...]** (JJ). It seems fairly clear that the variation revolves around the sequence /nam bi tar/ and one interpretation, **nam bi$_2$.ib.tar.re** (Z), belongs to a grammatical class dealt with in chapter 4, namely the *XP nam bi-√ distributional class.

(33) UM 29-15-367 I 5-6 (Civil 1964, 9, Karahashi 2000, 180)

munus.e u$_2$.lal$_3$.am$_3$ zu$_2$ bi$_2$.in.gub ša$_3$.gal ba.ni.in.g̃ar

It was the clover that the woman tasted, and it became her meal,

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The special characteristic of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates involving perception is that in many of the examples both the perceiver and the perceived object are followed by the *-e postposition. This is, in my view, the prototypical and most archaic form of the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction; the other groups of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates, though hewing to the semantic characterization of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates, diverge from the perception verb group in that the adversely affected participant usually appears in the locative case.

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1.5 $BNBV_{inal}$ verbs of adversity

The earliest attestation of a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate, **a_2-√dar**, dates to the Ur III period and is adversarial. The four exemplars of **a_2-√dar** are included at the beginning of this section, but it should be noted that **a_2-√dar** does not occur in $BNBV_{inal}$ in the Old Babylonian materials; the rest of the examples in this section are from the Old Babylonian period.

(34) Nik 2, 447, ll. 11-13 (Karahashi 2000, 75)

10. $niĝ_2$.gur_{11} ur.TAR.LUH.ka	*As for the property of UrTARLUH,*
11. ur.ab.zu u_3 dam ur.ab.zu.ka.ke_4	*Ur'abzu and his wife*
12. **a_2 bi_2.dar** ba.an.de_6	*illegally seized it and took it away,*

(35) NG 145 (ITT 3, 6572), obv. 2 (Karahashi 2000, 75)

1. ⌜še⌝ [x x x]	
2. še lu_2.⌜nin.$ĝa_2$.ka⌝ na.⌜gu⌝	*Nagu illegally appropriated Lunina's grain,*
a_2 bi_2.in.⌜dar⌝	
3. na.gu lu_2.sukkal.⌜ke_4⌝ ma.an.bala	*Nagu said, "one of the sukkal's servants*
bi_2.in.du_{11}	*exchanged it with me,"*

(36) SNAT 535 (BM 106157)

7. 1(diš) ma.na 1(u) 5(diš) gin_2	*Lugal'ushur gave 1 mana 15 gin*
lugal.$ušur_4$.e	
8. ur.^{d}ḫal.mu.DU.ra in.na.an.$šum_2$	*to Ur-halmuDU,*

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9. 1/3(diš) ma.na 5(diš) gin_2 in.da.an.tuku	*He still was owed 1/3 mana 5 gin*
10. dab_5.bi.$še_3$ ĝen.na.ni	*When he came in order to seize it,*
11. e_2.ĝa_2 a_2 bi_2.in.dar	*He illegally seized my house,*
12. $kišib_3$ šu.ga_2 ba.an.de_6	*He took away the seal in my hand,*

(37) NG 214 (AO 6047), i 10 – ii 2

i

10. šu.^{d}nin.mug.ga ugula	*(As for) Shuninmuga, the overseer,*
11. u_3 a.PU_3.ŠA.a.a $šar_2$.ra.ab.du	*and Apuzraya, the sharabdu,*
12. a.$ša_3$ dam a.ne.a.ti.ka 1(bur_3) GAN_2.am_3	*"Lugalmelam illegally seized*

ii

1. lugal.me.lam_2.[e a_2] bi_2.in.dar	*the field of the wife of Ane'ati, measuring 1 bur,"*
2. bi_2.in.eš	*they said.*

These four examples are from legal texts from the Ur III period, but they do not exhibit the most common distributional pattern found in the Old Babylonian materials, namely the combination of ergative and locative-terminative (or, in the case of adversity predicates, locative) postpositional phrases. Turning now to examples from the Old Babylonian period, one of the clearest examples of a $BNBV_{inal}$ verb of adversity is **a_2-√ĝar**, "to overcome."

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(38) Enmerkar and Ensuḫgirana [1.8.2.4], ll. 120-125 (Karahashi 2000, 77)

120. a.na ga.an.na.ab.be$_2$ a.na	*"What shall I say to him? What shall I say*
ga.an.na.ab.be$_2$	*to him?*
121. en unug^{ki}.ga en kul.aba$_4^{ki}$.ra	*What shall I say to the lord of Uruk, the lord*
a.na ga.an.na.ab.be$_2$	*of Kulaba?*
122. [gu$_4$].da.ni gu$_4$.g̃u$_{10}$.da ⌜lirum?⌝	*As for his bull, it stood up to fight my bull,*
im.da.ab.zi	
123. gu$_4$ unug^{ki}.ga.ke$_4$ a$_2$ bi$_2$.ib.g̃ar	*The bull of Uruk overcame him,*
124. lu$_2$.ni lu$_2$.g̃u$_{10}$.da usu im.da.ab.ra$_2$	*As for his man, he wrestled with my man,*
125. lu$_2$ unug^{ki}.ga.ke$_4$ a$_2$ bi$_2$.ib.g̃ar	*The man of Uruk overcame him,"*

(39) Lament over Sumer and Ur [2.2.3], l. 386-388 (Karahashi 2000, 77)

386. na$_4$ gal.gal.e ni$_2$.bi.a pu.ud.pa.ad	*Large stones on themselves fell with*
im.mi.ni.ib.za	*great thuds.*
386a. u$_4$ šu$_2$.uš iri^{ki}.ta im.ḫul.e	*Daily the evil wind came back into the city,*
mu.un.da.an.gi$_4$.gi$_4$	
387. uri$_5^{ki}$ ne$_3$.bi.ta nir.g̃al$_2$ gab$_2$.gaz.e	*Ur, confident in its own strength, stood*
ba.gub	*ready for the murderers,*
388. **ug̃$_3$.bi lu$_2$.erim$_2$.e a$_2$ bi$_2$.ib$_2$.g̃ar**	*As for its people, the enemy overcame them,*
$^{g̃iš}$tukul.e la ba.su$_8$.ge.eš	*they could not withstand their weapons,*

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(40) Inanna and Ebih [1.3.2], ll. 83-86

83. kur.kur.ra muš ki.in.dar.ra.gin$_7$	*May he destroy the lands as a snake in a*
šu ḫu.mu.da.dub$_2$.be$_2$.eš	*crevice,*
84. muš.sağ.kal kur.bi.ta e$_{11}$.da.gin$_7$	*May he make them slither around like a*
da.ga ḫu.mu.da.an.du	*sankal snake coming down from a mountain.*
85. kur.ra a$_2$ he$_2$ bi$_2$.in.ğar igi	*May he overcome the mountain, examine it,*
ḫe$_2$.ni.in.bar gid$_2$.da.bi ḫa.ba.zu	*and know its length,*
86. ḫar.ra.an ku$_3$ an.na.ka.še$_3$	*May he go out on the holy campaign of An*
ḫe$_2$.ni.e$_3$ buru$_3$.da.bi ḫa.ba.zu	*and know its depth,*

In the four examples in (38), (39) and (40), a noun phrase in the ergative case is positively affected by the event, whereas the negatively affected participant either does not appear explicitly or appears followed by the locative postposition.

(41) Lament for Sumer and Ur [2.2.3], ll. 400-402

400. ša$_3$.bi.a niğ$_2$ ša$_3$.ğar.ra.ka	*On the inside, we are being finished off by*
i.im.til.le.de$_3$.en.de$_3$.en	*famine,*
401. bar.bi.a ^{giš}tukul elam^{ki}.ma.ka	*On the outside, won't we be finished off by*
ga nam ba.[e.til].le.en.de$_3$.en	*Elamite weapons,*
402. uri$_5^{\text{ki}}$.ma lu$_2$.erim$_2$.e a$_2$ bi$_2$.ib.ğar	*Won't we be finished off by the enemy that*
ga nam ba.til.e.de$_3$.<en>.de$_3$.en	*has overcome Ur?*

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(42) Ur Lament [2.2.2], ll. 396-398

396. ĝalga niĝ$_2$ aratta^{ki}.ka šu pe.el.la$_2$	*Which defiled the weighty counsel,*
im.mi.ib.du$_{11}$.ga.re	
397. u$_4$ kalam.ma niĝ$_2$ du$_{10}$	*The storm which cut off all that is good from*
im.mi.ib.ku$_5$.da.re	*the Land,*
398. u$_4$ saĝ ĝi$_6$.ga a$_2$ bi$_2$.ib.la$_2$.a.re	*The storm which pinioned the arms of the*
	black-headed people,

This is only a brief passage from a long litany of descriptive characterizations or appellations that are applied to the raging storm in the Ur Lament. For an extensive discussion of this passage, see below in sections 4.4 and 4.5.

(43) A praise poem of Enlil-bani (Enlil-bani A), ll. 92-100 (Kapp 1955, 76-87)

92. šagina.zu	*Your governors*
93. saĝ šul.a.lum la ba.ak	*suffer no injuries,*
94. erin$_2$.zu erin$_2$ kur$_2$.ra	*As for your troops,*
95. a$_2$ bi$_2$.ib$_2$.ĝar	*they overcome hostile troops,*
96. ^{ĝiš}tukul.zu	*As for your weapons,*
97. ^{ĝiš}tukul gaba.ri nu.tuku.am$_3$	*they have no rival weapons,*
98. tuš.a.zu.ne	*When you take your seat,*
99. kur.kur	*all the foreign lands*
100. gam.e.en	*bow down to you,*

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(44) Sumerian Proverbs, Collection [6.1.01], no. 25

(Alster 1997, 11; Civil 1985, 78; sources A and B only, elsewhere e.gar)

da.ga nam.ku$_3$.zu ^{d}lamma a$_2$ bi$_2$.ib.g̃ar

Organization and wisdom overcome good fortune

(45) Lugalbanda in the Wilderness [1.8.2.1], ll. 42-46 (Karahashi 2000, 80; Vanstiphout 2003, 106-107)

42. zi.du ša$_3$ kuš$_2$.u$_3$ ^{d}en.lil$_2$.la$_2$.ke$_4$	*When the righteous one who takes counsel with Enlil (i.e. Enmerkar),*
43. kul.aba$_4^{ki}$ niğin$_2$.na.bi im.ma.an.kar.eš.ba	*took away the whole of Kulaba (on expedition),*
44. [x] ⌜kur⌝.ra.ke$_4$ u$_8^{?}$.gin$_7$ ba.an.gur.ru.uš (√gur-eš)	*They wended their way through the . . . of the mountains like ewes,*
45. [x x] ⌜zi.ga?⌝ gaba ḫur.sağ.ğa$_2$.ke$_4$ am.gin$_7$ du$_{10}$ bi$_2$.in.ğal$_2$.⌜le⌝ (√ğal-eš)	*They* (-eš) *ran over the high . . . of the foothills like wild bulls,*
46. [x x] za$_3$.še$_3$ i$_3$.kiğ$_2$.e ḫar.ra.an i$_3$.zu.ne	*Each (?) . . . was looking for a passage, and they found a road,*

In (45), note that the plural suffix, *-eš, occurs in both lines 44 and 45, although the orthographic form is quite different in each case: **ba.an.gur.ru.uš** as opposed to **du$_{10}$ bi$_2$.in.ğal$_2$.le**. The alternative would be to analyze **bi$_2$.in.ğal$_2$.le** as a verb with the *marû*

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verbal suffix, *-e, but such an interpretation would make this verb nearly unique in the entire set of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates, which do not, as a rule, occur in the *marû*.

(46) Enlil Hymn A [4.05.1], l. 40 (Falkenstein 1959, 44; Karahashi 2000, 82)

37. $bara_2$ nam.ḫe$_2$ e_2.kur e_2 za.gin_3	*He made the dais of abundance, the Ekur,*
saḫar.ta ša ba.ra.an.il_2	*the shining temple, rise from the soil,*
38. ḫur.saĝ il_2.la.gin_7 ki sikil.la	*He has made it grow in the pure place like*
bi_2.in.mu_2	*a mountain lifted up,*
39. nun.bi kur gal a.a ^{d}en.lil_2	*As for its prince, the Great Mountain, father*
	Enlil,
40. e_2.kur $eš_3$ maḫ.a $bara_2$.ba dur_2	*He has taken his seat on the dais of the*
bi_2.in.ĝar	*Ekur, the lofty shrine,*
41. e_2.a me.bi diĝir sag_2 nu.di	*As for the rituals of the temple, no deity*
	scatters them,
42. šu.luḫ sikil.bi ki.gin_7 nu.silig.ge	*As for its hand-washing rites, they are*
	everlasting like the earth,

(47) Collection of Temple Hymns [4.80.1], l. 466 (Sjöberg and Bergmann 1969, 136; Karahashi 2000, 82; cf. Michalowski 1993, 154)

463. nun.zu ^{d}gir_3.ra lugal	*As for your prince, Gira, the*
$meš_3$.lam.ma	*lord of Meshlam,*
464. diĝir ḫuš ki.a lugal u_4.$šu_2$.[uš]	*The fierce god of the underworld, the*
	lord of Udshush,

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465. ^{d}nergal ^{d}meš$_3$.lam.ta.e$_3$.[a]	*Nergal, Meshlamta'eda,*
466. muš$_3$.za e$_2$ bi$_2$.in.gub	*He has erected a house in your precinct,*
bara$_2$.za dur$_2$ bi$_2$.in.ĝar	*and taken his seat upon your dais,*
467. 10 e$_2$ ^{d}nergal gu$_2$.du$_8$.a^{ki}	*10 lines: the house of Nergal in Gudua,*

(48) The Marriage of Sud [1.2.2], ll. 72-76 (Civil 1983, 54, 59, 62; Karahashi 2000, 83)

72. [lugal.zu.ur$_2$ ki.ur$_3$ maḫ].a.ni ur$_5$.gin$_7$ du$_{11}$.mu.na.ab	*Inform your lord thus in his august Ki'ur,*
73. [^{d}en.lil$_2$.ra itima ku$_3$ si.ga].⌜na⌝ u$_3$.ga.na.de$_3$.taḫ	*and repeat this to Enlil in the privacy of his holy bedchamber,*
74. [...] ra a$_2$ mu.da.an.ag̃$_2$.⌜ta⌝	*After . . . had instructed,*
75. [...] ⌜DU⌝ ^{d}nuska dur$_2$ bi$_2$.in.ĝar	*and Nuska took his seat on it,*

Karahashi transliterates line 75 as follows: $^{[ĝiš]}$**gu.za šu.niĝin.na mu.un.na.gub ^{d}nuska dur$_2$ bi$_2$.in.ĝar**, "She set out the chair of honor for him and seated Nuska on it," but since neither ETCSL, nor Karahashi provide information on sources, it is difficult to decide between them—here I adopt ETCSL's transliteration.

(49) Schooldays 42 (Karahashi 2000, 95)

41. um.mi.a.ĝu$_{10}$ šu.zu nu.sag$_5$.sag$_5$.e.še in.tud$_2$.de$_3$.en	*As for my professor, he said, "your (scribal) hand is not good," and he caned me,*
42. **nam.dub.sar.ra gu$_2$ bi$_2$.du$_3$** nam.dub.sar.[ra im.šub bi$_2$.ak]	*You have neglected the scribal art, you have let the scribal art drop,*

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43. um.mi.a.ĝu$_{10}$ ka.ni
nu mu.e.da.an [...]

As for my professor, he was not able . . . his mouth,

(50) Schooldays 70 (Karahashi 2000, 95)

68. tug$_2$ mu.ni.mu$_4$ niĝ$_2$ mu.na.an.ba
ḫar šu.na bi$_2$.in.du$_3$

He dressed him in a (new) garment, gave him a gift, and put a bracelet on his hand,

69. um.mi.a ša$_3$ ḫul$_2$.la.ni.ta eme
mu.na.DU

The professor with joyful heart gave him a speech,

70. **lu$_2$ tur inim.ĝu$_{10}$.še$_3$ gu$_2$ li bi$_2$.du$_3$.a** im.šub li bi$_2$.in.ak

Young man, because you did not neglect my word, did not forsake it,

71. nam.dub.sar.ra sag̃.bi us$_2$.sa
za$_3$.bi.še$_3$ til.la

Reach the pinnacle of the scribal art,
Finish it in its entirety,

72. niĝ$_2$.na.me la ba.gi$_{16}$.ba.na.za.am$_3$
šu.ĝu$_{10}$.še$_3$ mu.e.šum$_2$.ma

It is something that cannot be obstructed that you have put into my hand,

(51) Bird and Fish [5.3.5], ll. 13-15 (Karahashi 2000, 129)

13. **[a.a ^{d}]$^{[}$en$^{]}$.ki.ke$_4$**
ambar.ambar.ra ka bi$_2$.in.keš$_2$
gi sumun gi ḫenbur$_2$ bi$_2$.in.mu$_2$

Father Enki knit together the marshlands, making young and old reeds grow there,

14. [x] x pu$_2$ umaḫ^{maḫ} ku$_6$ mušen
mi.ni.lu.ug

As for the birds and fish made to live in . . . pools and lagoons,

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15. [x x] ki niğ$_2$ zi pa.an.pa.ne.ne gu$_7$ nağ.bi.še$_3$ ba.an.šum$_2$ — *He gave them . . . all kinds of living creatures as their sustenance,*

(52) Inninshagura, manuscript D, ll. 104-108 (Sjöberg 1975, 188-189; Karahashi 2000, 134)

104. ^{d}a.nun.na giri$_{17}$.bi gam.e.eš giri$_{17}$ ba.e.dur$_2$.ru.ne.eš — *As for the noses of the Anuna, they have prostrated themselves noses bent (to the ground),*

105. ur gal.gal imin.bi ba.e.u$_5$ an.na ba.e.e$_3$.de$_3$ — *You ride on seven great dogs, you come out from heaven,*

106. an gal.e muš$_3$.za ni$_2$ bi$_2$.te ki.tuš.zu im.mi.ḫu.luḫ — *The great An feared your . . ., he was frightened of your dwelling-place,*

107. ki.tuš an.gal.la.ke$_4$ dur$_2$ ⌜ba$^{?}$.e$^{?}$⌝.ğar su nu mu.e.da.zi.zi — *He let you take your seat in the dwelling-place of the great An (and then) he did not fear your any more,*

(53) Gilgamesh and Huwawa, version A [1.8.1.5], ll. 183-187 (Edzard 1991, 229; Karahashi 2000, 145)

183. ^{tug2}a.⌜ğa$_2$⌝.la$_2$ bi$_2$.in.šub sağ.du.ni bi$_2$.in.e$_3$.de$_3$ — *They threw down the leather bag and made his head come out (of the bag),*

184. igi ^{d}en.lil$_2$.la$_2$.še$_3$! im.ma.ni.in.ğar.re.eš — *As for that which they had placed in front of Enlil,*

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185. ^{d}en.lil$_2$.le saĝ.du ^{d}hu.wa.wa
igi ba.ni.in.du$_8$.a
As for Enlil, when he spotted Huwawa's head,

186. inim ^{d}bil$_4$.ga.mes
ša$_3$ bi$_2$.in.⌈dab$_5$⌉
What Gilgamesh had done angered him,

187. a.na.aš.am$_3$ ur$_5$.gin$_7$
i$_3$.ak.en.ze$_2$.en
"Why did you (pl.) act in this way?"

(54) Heron and Turtle [5.9.2], l. 102-106 (Karahashi 2000, 174)

102. gud$_3$ us$_2$.sa.a.ĝu$_{10}$
ba.ni.in.suḫ$_3$.suḫ$_3$
As for my nest, it was turned upside down,

103. dumu.ĝu$_{10}$ a.e ba.ni.in.ra.ra
As for my young, they were knocked into the water,

104. mušen me.en lu$_2$
igi ku$_{10}$.ku$_{10}$.ga.ke$_4$
It is me, the dark-eyed bird,

105. niĝ.bun$_2$.na saĝ.ki.ĝu$_{10}$
umbin bi$_2$.in.la$_2$
The turtle scratched my forehead,

106. uš$_2$.ĝu$_{10}$ gaba.ĝa$_2$
im.mi.in.šu$_2$.šu$_2$
As for my blood, it covered my chest,

(55) Lament over Sumer and Ur [2.2.3], ll. 21-26 (Karahashi 2000, 176)

22. u$_4$ an.ne$_2$ kur.kur.ra saĝ.ki
ba.da.an.gid$_2$.da.ba
After An had frowned upon all the lands,

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23. ^{d}en.lil$_2$.le igi.ni ki kur$_2$.ra	*After Enlil had countenanced an enemy*
ba.an.ĝar.ra.a.ba	*land,*
24. ^{d}nin.tu.re niĝ$_2$.dim$_2$.dim$_2$.ma.ni	*After Nintu had scattered the creatures that*
za$_3$ bi$_2$.in.tag.ga.a.ba	*she had created,*
25. ^{d}en.ki.ke$_4$ ^{i7}idigna ^{i7}buranun.na	*After Enki had altered the course of the*
aš$_2$ bi$_2$.in.bala.a.ba	*Tigris and Euphrates,*
26. ^{d}utu ḫar.ra.an kaskal.e nam	*After Utu had cast his curse on the*
ba.an.ku$_5$.da.a.ba	*highways,*

(56) Nippur Lament [2.2.4], ll. 89-93 (Karahashi 2000, 176)

89. aĝ$_2$.gig ur$_5$.ra.a. a.še.er.ra	*Among dejection and lamentation, he has*
mu.un.du$_3$	*made it a sacrilege,*
90. ta.še eĝer na.aĝ$_2$.bi i.bi$_2$.ni.a	*After its fate, how long till his face would be*
la ba.an.barag$_2$	*streaked with teardrops?*
91. aĝ$_2$ sikil du$_3$.a.gin$_7$ ur$_5$.re	*He rejected it as though it were a*
za$_3$ bi$_2$.in.tag	*blasphemy!*
92. sig$_4$.bi ḫul$_2$.e a.na.aš ib$_2$.ta.an.e$_3$	*Why has joy left its brickwork?*
93. ĝi$_6$ an.bar$_7$.ba ša$_3$.ba er$_2$ bi$_2$.in.si	*At midnight and midday, tears filled his*
	heart,

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(57) Sargon Legend, 3 N-T 296, ll. 23-27 (Cooper and Heimpel 1983, 75, 77; Karahashi 2000, 181)

24. [i_7] ⌜maḫ i_7 mud⌝.$še_3$ $ĝa_2$.ra	*For me, she drowned you in a great [river],*
mu.un.⌜gir_5⌝.re.de_3.en	*a river of blood,*
25. [x] ⌜x⌝ [d]⌜ur⌝.[^{d}za].ba_4.ba_4	*... Urzababa chewed his lips, became*
nundum zu_2 bi_2.in.⌜gu_7⌝	*seriously afraid,*
26. [x x] x na ⌜AN⌝ [x] sukkal.a.ni	*He spoke to ... his chancellor,*
⌜gu_3⌝ mu.na.de_2.e	
27. [...] ⌜nin_9.e⌝.$ĝu_{10}$ ku_3 ^{d}inanna.ke_4	*"... my royal sister, Inanna,"*

(58) SP, UM 55-21-278 = 3 N-T 179 (Karahashi 2000, 181)

ka_5.a zu_2 bi_2.in.sud_2.sud_2

A fox bites.

The extensive set of examples in this section show a regular case-marking pattern (adversely affected argument in the locative, *-a, while the positively affected argument occurs in the ergative, *-e) that differs from the case-marking pattern in the previous section in one detail: whereas the perceived object in $BNBV_{inal}$ verbs of perception regularly occurs in the locative-terminative case, *-e, the negatively affected argument in $BNBV_{inal}$ verbs of adversity regularly occur in the locative, *-a. I suspect that in the older phases of the language, the negatively affected argument in $BNBV_{inal}$ verbs of adversity was also followed by the locative-terminative, but that, unlike verbs of perception, the *bi-√ prefix in verbs of adversity caused the case-marking on the negatively affected

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argument to be changed to locative in those cases in which an explicit postposition is written; in some of the cases, however, the negatively affected argument is modified by a possessive pronoun or is entirely bare. I would interpret this variation as a sign of the uncertainty many scribes faced in assigning a case to these examples.

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1.6 Other $BNBV_{inal}$ verbs

The following examples involve verbs that are neither experiential, nor adversarial. Some of these predicates probably do not, properly speaking, belong to the $BNBV_{inal}$ class.

(59) The Exploits of Ninurta [1.6.2], ll. 348-352 (Karahashi 2000, 78)

348. ^{d}nin.urta dumu ^{d}en.lil$_2$.la$_2$.ke$_4$	*Ninurta, the son of Enlil, wanted to do*
gal.bi i$_3$.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$	*something big,*
349. gu.ru.um na$_4$ kur.ra mi.ni.in.ak	*As for the pile of stones that had been*
	accumulated in the mountains,
350. dungu diri.ga.gin$_7$	*Since it (pile of stones) stretched across*
a$_2$ bi$_2$.in.su$_3$.su$_3$.ud	*them (mountains) like floating clouds,*
351. bad$_3$ maḫ.gin$_7$ kalam.ma igi.ba	*Blocking the view of the land like a huge*
bi$_2$.in.tab.⌜ba⌝	*wall,*
352. $^{g̃iš}$bal ki.šar$_2$.ra mu.ni.in.g̃ar	*He installed a spigot (?) at the horizon,*

This passage appears several times in the course of the dissertation and the form of the verb in line 350 is cited in recent secondary literature in two forms: **bi$_2$.in.su$_3$.su$_3$.ud** and **bi$_2$.in.su$_3$.su$_3$.e**: ETCSL offers the former, Karahashi the latter (for further discussion of the form of the verb in the text-artifactual record, see example [49] in section 2.3 below).

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(60) A praise poem of Shulgi (Shulgi B) [2.4.2.02], ll. 52-55 = 77-80

52. $ni\tilde{g}_2$ ak.a.$\tilde{g}a_2$ ni_2.bi ga.$bulu\tilde{g}_5$	*As for what I myself have done, let me boast,*
53. kal.ga.$\tilde{g}a_2$ mu.bi a_2 bi_2.su_3.ud	*As for the fame of my power, it has spread far and wide,*
54. $\tilde{g}e\check{s}tu_2$.$\tilde{g}u_{10}$ $ni\tilde{g}_2$ galam.ma su_3.ga.am_3	*As for my wisdom, it is full of subtlety,*
55. a.na.$\tilde{g}u_{10}$ $ni\tilde{g}_2$ ka.ge dib.ba nu	*As for my achievements, do they not surpass all qualifications?*

(61) Tree and Reed [5.3.4], ll. 2-6 (Karahashi 2000, 96)

2. [ki] da$\tilde{g}$al.e ku_3 ^{na4}za.gin_3.bi bar.bi am_3.mi.ib.si	*Precious metals and gems were inlaid on the outer wall of the vast place,*
3. ^{na4}esi ^{na4}nir_2 ^{na4}gug sud.ra_2.a$\tilde{g}_2$.$\tilde{g}a_2$ šu tag ba.ni.in.du_{11}	*Diorite, chalcedony, cornaline—all the shining ones were applied,*
4. **[ki] u_2.šim.e ḫi.li gu_2 bi_2.e_3** nam.nun.ba mu.un.gub	*The grassy ground is covered in luxury and stands in its princeliness,*
5. ki ku_3 ki sikil.la an.ku_3.ra ni_2.ba mu.na.sig_7	*The holy place, the pure place—for holy An it is by itself beautiful,*
6. an diĝir maḫ.e ki da$\tilde{g}$al.la du_{10} im.ma.ni.ib.nir	*An, the lofty god, made the good place sweet,*

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differs from manuscript A in a number of places: in line 2, **bar.ba** instead of **bar.bi**; in line 4, **$bi_2.ib_2.e_3$** instead of **$bi_2.e_3$** and **nam.nun** instead of **nam.nun.ba**; and in line 5, **ni_2.bi** instead of **ni_2.ba**.

(62) Shulgi and Ninlil's Barge (Shulgi R), manuscript A [2.4.2.18], ll. 90-92 (Klein 1990a, 108-109; Karahashi 2000, 96)

92. lugal me.lam_2 huš gu_2 $bi_2.e_3$	*The king is clad in a terrifying luminosity,*

Line 92 is a catchline meant to indicate the incipit of a following tablet; the first half of line 92 also occur in line 21 of the Ur III catalog at Yale [0.1.2]. In light of the fact that the line occurs without the benefit of context, there is probably not much this example can tell us.

(63) Winter and Summer [5.3.3], ll. 195-199 (Karahashi 2000, 99)

195. šar.ra.ab.du_8 ni_2 $bur_2.bur_2$.ra $ša_3$ a.$ša_3$.ga nu.zu	*The bragging sharabdu who does not know the extent of the field,*
196. e_2.me.eš šeš.gu_{10} $a_2.kuš_2$.a.gu_{10}.a ni_2 bulug u_3 mu.ni.e_3	*Summer, my brother, after you have gone out boasting about my toil,*
197. za_3 mu.ka še e_2.a u_3.mu.ni.in.ku_4 $guru_7$ gu_2 bi_2.in.gur.gur	*When at the turn of the year grain is brought into the houses in order to fill the granaries,*
198. diri u_3.me.de_6 ^{tug2}bar.dul_5 ^{tug2}nig$_2$.lam_2.zu bal.a.kam	*When you bring surplus, your bardul and niglam garments are . . .,*

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199. ^{uruda}ḫa.zi.in 2(diš) ma.na lu_2	*When someone gives a two mana axe to you,*
u_3.mu.ra.an.$šum_2$ edin.zu.$še_3$	*you go off to your steppe,*
ba.du.un	

(64) Winter and Summer [5.3.3], ll. 288-291 (Karahashi 2000, 99)

288. en.te.en.e inim.ma gu_4 maḫ.gin_7	*Like a great bull Winter raised his head*
saĝ $im.il_2.il_2$.e	*to speak:*
289. a.a ^{d}en.lil_2 nam.ku_5.$ĝal_2$	*"Father Enlil, you gave irrigation-control*
mu.e.$šum_2$ a he_2.$ĝal_2$.la mu.e.de_6	*and brought abundant waters,*
290. a.gar_3.a.gar_3.ra za_3 ba.ni.tag.tag	*The plantations were set up, lit., adjoined,*
$guru_7$ gu_2 bi_2.gur.gur	*in order to fill the granaries,*
291. še ab.sin_2.na gu_2 ba.ni.in.peš	*The grain grew thick in the furrows,*
292. ^{d}ezina$_2$.e ki.sikil sa_6.ga.gin_7	*And Ezina came forth in splendor like*
ni_2 pa e_3 bi_2.ak	*a beautiful maiden,*

ETCSL translates the line in question as "I made one meadow adjacent to another and heaped high the granaries," whereas Karahashi translates: "I will remove (the floor water) from the cultivated fields and pile up silos" (Karahashi 2000, 99). **a.gar_3** presumably refers to what is known in German as *der Flur*, meaning a collection of farmlands; the use of **a.gar_3.a.gar_3** here would seem, therefore, to refer to the entire expanse of collected farmland in a community. I have translated it as "plantations" for lack of a better term. This example is dealt with further in section 2.3, example (34).

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Although the three semantic classes into which I have divided up the $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates show some variation in the form of the postposition following the perceived or negatively affected argument, the single most important criterion of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class is manifest throughout: as a rule, the constructions lack the causative semantics typically found in other *bi-√ prefix constructions and the ergative case-marked noun is an experiencer of the event rather than an agent responsible for bringing it about.

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1.7 Possible motivations for the $BNBV_{inal}$ distributional class

Given the correlation between a formal test (bare nominal immediately before a *bi-√ prefix verb), a typological parallel (low source applicative constructions) and a relatively coherent semantics (verbs of perception and privation, which form a single coherent semantic class under the constraints of a low source applicative hypothesis), one might reasonably ask why these formal properties in particular are used to code this semantic category in Sumerian. I argue in the balance of this study that the two crucial factors determining the formal properties of the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction in Sumerian are indefiniteness (or its referential equivalent coded through other means) and transfer of possession from a source to a goal as indicated by *the absence* of resumptive pronominalization on the nominal component of a $BNBV_{inal}$ construction: any kind of possessive pronoun functioning resumptively would have to choose between resuming either the source argument or the goal argument, when the crucial factor in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction is the transfer rather than the possession itself.

Indefiniteness has not been investigated in Sumerian in any detail and Sumerian nouns are not explicitly identified as either definite or indefinite by distinctive morphology. Certain kinds of nouns and nominal constructions such as possessive constructions are often translated into European languages using definite nouns, but this may be misleading in that there is no necessary correlation between occurrence in a possessive construction and definiteness (Lyons 1999, 22-26). Nonetheless, if one assumes for the sake of argument that possessive pronouns in Sumerian are indicators of definiteness, certain phenomena fall into place: the use of nouns bearing possessive

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pronouns to form topic constructions can be explained rather straightforwardly if the addition of a possessive pronoun makes the noun definite, since discourse topics are regularly definite cross-linguistically. As emphasized by Woods, many of these supposedly possessive pronouns could be reinterpreted as demonstrative pronouns (Woods 2001, 87-94), but the same topic-marking function also occurs with first and second person possessive pronouns (which are, of course, deictic, but not demonstrative in the ordinary sense of the term). Compare, for example, (65), (66) and (67), setting aside for the moment questions of resumptivity in the anticipatory genitive in example (67):

(65) Eršemma 88: 18-19 (Cohen 1981, 84; Woods 2001, 92)

er$_2$ im.me [$_{\text{Topic}}$ er$_2$.bi] gig.ga.kam šir$_3$ im.me [$_{\text{Topic}}$ šir$_3$.bi] gig.ga.kam

I weep. *As for the tears,* they are bitter. I sing. *As for the song*, it is bitter.

(66) Gudea, Cyl. A 9:25-26 [ETCSL 2.1.7] (Zólyomi 1993, 133)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ igi ḫuš.a.g̃u$_{10}$] kur.re nu.um.il$_2$

As for my terrible look, no country can bear it.

(67) Gudea, Cyl. A 5:4 [ETCSL 2.1.7] (Zólyomi 1993, 35)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ e$_2$.a g̃iš.ḫur.bi] im.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$

As for the plan of the temple, he was setting it out.

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Note that I differ from Zólyomi in taking the entire anticipatory genitive in (67) as the topic—Zólyomi only includes **e_2.a** in the topic and sees the **-bi** of **ĝiš.ḫur.bi** as a resumptive pronoun. In examples (65), (66) and (67), the possessive pronoun demarcates a topic to the left from the rest of the sentence to the right: in (65), **er_2 im.me** constitutes a distinct clause and does not violate the generalization. It could be argued that in (65) and (67) the possessive pronoun is demonstrative in some fashion, but this is clearly not the case in example (66). Note that—in principle at least—every noun in the absolutive/nominative (zero-marked) case has available to it one of two possible "possessive" constructions: where the possessor is a lexical noun phrase (as opposed to a pronominal), the anticipatory genitive is regularly available for coding topicality through a possessive pronoun-final construction, whereas in the absence of a lexical noun phrase, the possessor can be coded more-or-less vacuously (since the possessive relation is presupposed and the addressee is presumably already aware of the possessive relation anyways) through the use of the ordinary possessive pronoun.

Although I do not attempt to establish the truth of such a *possessive pronoun theory of topic-marking* any further herein, I think it does suggest the plausibility of associating possessive constructions in Sumerian with definiteness. This is also in conformity with typological expectations in that in languages in which determiners (a somewhat general category subsuming demonstratives) and possessives occupy the same structural position as in Sumerian, the occurrence of a noun within a possessive construction generally indicates that the noun is definite (similar languages include English and Irish, known as "determiner-genitive" languages in opposition to "adjectival-genitive" languages such as

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Italian and Greek, see Lyons 1999, 22-25 with references). Bare nouns in Sumerian, therefore, have at least the possibility of being indefinite.

The other piece of, admittedly, indirect evidence in favor of linking the $BNBV_{inal}$ distributional class with indefiniteness has to do with the location of the so-called dimensional infixes (a class of directional morphemes that appear in the verbal prefix) within the Sumerian verb: in purely formal terms, the *bi-√ prefix excludes the entire set of dimensional infixes. In the system of numbered morphosyntactic slots proposed by Jagersma/Zólyomi, the dimensional infixes occupy slots [ ]$_7$ through [ ]$_9$, whereas the *bi-√ prefix, segmented into /b/ and /i/ fills slots [ ]$_{5/6}$ and [ ]$_{10}$. In the slightly different system in use at the Pennsylvania Sumerian Dictionary, the dimensional infixes fill slots [ ]$_4$, [ ]$_6$, and [ ]$_8$, while the *bi-√ prefix is split into slots [ ]$_3$ and [ ]$_9$. The point that is recognized by both systems is, as plainly stated by Gragg, "[t]he dimensional infixes, as a rule, do not occur with bí-, im.mi-, or al-" (Gragg 1973a, 15). But more importantly, Gragg's seminal work on the dimensional infixes makes clear that there is no regular "agreement" between postpositions and dimensional infixes:

> In these literary texts there are approximately 700 occurrences of the postposition - š è . But the infix - š i - occurs only 142 times. ... of these 142 occurrences of the infix, only 35 give the infix and the postposition together. While these statistics do not disprove the view just outlined [that the infixes arise through "agreement" with co-occurring postpositions], they do make it seem less likely; in fact, given these statistics one might well hypothesize that the infix and the postposition tend to be mutually exclusive rather than interdependent" (Gragg 1973a, 16)

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Gragg's statistics, based on a corpus of Old Babylonian materials from Nippur is equally convincing (note that some of Gragg's numbers are approximate).

	Postposition	Infix	Co-occurrences
-še$_3$ / -ši-	700	142	35
-ta / -ta-	380	100	29
-da / -da-	170	430	26

Gragg emphasizes that, with the exception of clauses that include a verb of motion, the postposition and its etymologically corresponding infix almost never occur in the same clause.

Although further research into the distribution of postpositions and their etymologically related infixes is needed, I would guess that, excluding verbs of motion, the postposition regularly occurs with definite lexical noun phrases, the infix when the lexical noun is pronominalized and the *bi-√ prefix when the relevant adverbial argument is indefinite. This would make the *bi-√ prefix the unmarked term in the system of dimensional infixes, a system that is organized on the basis of oppositions of source (**-ta**) and goal (**-še$_3$**), which coincides with the semantic field that I would associate with the *bi-√ prefix. The plausibility of *bi-√ as the unmarked dimensional infix follows quite naturally from its role as a low source applicative when it is immediately preceded by an inalienable noun. We can presumably juxtapose the importance of the source argument in the Sumerian low source applicative in BNBV$_{inal}$ across a number of distinct lexical classes: (i) verbs of perception include an indefinite noun in a raised possessor construction (with the experienced object as the raised possessor of an inalienable noun

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that refers to the medium through which the perception was achieved) as the source of the perception, (ii) verbs of adversity in which the negatively affected entity is the source in juxtaposition to the positively affected entity as the goal, and (iii) *verba dicendi* in which the object transferred from a possessor at the source to a possessor at the goal is simply the word that the speaker utters. In each case, the *bi-√ prefix indicates that there has been a transfer of possession from a source to a goal, where the object being transferred, at least in grammatical terms, is indefinite.

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1.8 Ergative possessors and the transfer of possession model

The model underlying Pylkkänen's low source applicative hypothesis is a transfer of possession model, but rather than attempting to describe the model in abstract terms, I would like to return to the Korean example (21) dealt with above, repeated below as (68).

(68)	totwuk-i	Mary-**hanthey**	panci-lul	humchi-ess-ta
	thief-Nom	Mary-**Dat**	ring-Acc	steal-Past-Plain

The thief stole a ring from Mary (and it was in her possession when he stole it)

In a transfer of possession model, the direct object of the verb starts out in a raised possessor construction, in which the source or the starting point of the transfer is the raised possessor, *Mary-hanthey* in (68), and the goal, recipient or endpoint of the transfer is the subject of the sentence, *totwuk-i* in (68). The possessive relation at the beginning of the event is coded through the use of a raised possessor construction, whereas the possessive relation at the end of the event is part of the lexical meaning, "to steal," of the main verb: there are, therefore, in a rather special sense of the term, two predicates at work in any particular low source applicative construction, both of which encode a possessive relation of some kind. The Korean example, however, differs from the foregoing Sumerian examples in that the lexical meaning of the vast majority of the verbal roots used to form $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in Sumerian encode, at most, existence in a location ($\tilde{g}al_2$, $\tilde{g}ar$, gub) or attachment (du_3, $ke\check{s}_2$, te, dab_5, la_2, tag), if even that (dar, gar_3, su_3, *tuk [derived from /ĝeštug/ "ear," not tuku "to possess"], du_3, $\tilde{g}ar$, du_8, kar_2). Where

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then is the resultant possessive relation between the direct object and the recipient coded? The answer lies, I believe, in a little known phenomenon that occurs with the possessor of an inalienable noun in languages that make use of ergative case-marking.

In West Greenlandic Inuit, the possessor of an inalienable noun that has been incorporated into the verbal complex regularly occurs in the ergative case, as in the following examples (Geenhoven 1998, 18, fn. 4; cf. Sadock 1991, 96-97; Rischel 1971, 234).

(69) kunngi-p panik-passna-qar-p-u-q
king-Erg daughter-many-have-Indic-Intrans-3Sg
There are many king's daughters, i.e., princesses

(70) hansi-p qimmi-p ame-qar-tip-p-a-a
Hans-Erg dog-Erg skin-have-Cause-Indic-Trans-3Sg-3Sg
Hans let him have a dog's skin

(71) sisimiut sissa-p naalaga-qar-p-u-q
Sisimut shore-Erg chief-have-Indic-Intrans-3Sg
Sisimut had a chief of the shore

In these examples, it is clear that the ergative case-marked noun in (69) and (71) and the ergative nominal that is closest to the verb in (70) are not, in any sense, agents in the

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sentences in which they occur, but rather that the particular means of coding an inalienable possessor in West Greenlandic Inuit is through the use of the ergative case.

The importance of the analogy is not simply that the resultant possessive relation in the transfer of possession in $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates is coded by the ergative case-marking on the ultimate possessor, it also makes sense of the fact that the ergative case-marked nominal in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions is an experiencer, whereas the ergative case-marked nominal in other BNBV constructions that do not involve an inalienable noun are causers, prototypical agents. The primary function, therefore, of the ergative case-marking in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions is to indicate the possessive relationship between the inalienable noun and its possessor rather than to mark the nominal argument which brings about the event in question: there are consequently two raised possessors in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions and the bare noun is transferred from the possession of one to the possession of the other without the intervention of an agent of any kind.

Source ⇨ Goal

Locative-terminative ⇨ Ergative inalienable possessor

Note, however, that even though both possessors occur in raised possessor constructions, the resultant possessive relationship is coded by an element of the nominal syntax, whereas the initial possessive relationship is coded through the use of a clause-level raised possessor construction such as "there is a $DP_{possessed}$ at (the location of) $DP_{possessor}$" or "$DP_{possessed}$ belongs to $DP_{possessor}$." At the same time, both of the raised possessor

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constructions that occur in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction are prototypical environments for indefinite nouns that exhibit what is known as the definiteness effect (a syntactic phenomenon that restricts the noun in certain syntactic positions to an indefinite noun, see chapter 3 for details).

Within a wide variety of different types of case-marking systems, one often finds a distinctive case-marking subsystem that uses the unmarked or default case (nominative or absolutive) in opposition to a dative or other oblique case so as to code verbs of perception and/or volition. The main characteristic of such predicates is the presence of two arguments, typically described as "theme" and "experiencer" and the association of these two arguments with a nominative/dative or absolutive/oblique case-marking system. Givón, for example, speaks of "verbs of **cognition**, **sensation** or **volition**, whose object registers—logically—no discernable impact or change. In fact, it is the experiencer-subject which registers some internal/cognitive change. Common verbs in this class are 'see', 'hear', 'know', 'understand', 'think of', 'want', 'feel', and most commonly they are semantically *states* rather than actions" (Givón 1984, 100). Givón notes that many such verbs of cognition, sensation and volition occur in English in a construction that makes use of an expletive 'it' and a dative experiencer such as the following examples (Givón 1984, 101, ex. 39).

(72) a. It seems to me that ... (cf. I see/think that ...)

b. It appears to me that ... (cf. I find it apparent that ...)

c. It is necessary that ... (cf. I insist that ...)

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In the examples in (72), a dummy pronoun appears in the subject position, while the experiencer appears in a dative prepositional phrase immediately before that which has been perceived, i.e., the theme. Predicates of this type also bear a strong resemblance to existential verb constructions such as, for example, "there is a rat in the soup" (see below, section 3.4, for further explication). In both types of construction, we find three crucial components: (i) a dummy pronoun or expletive in the subject position before the verb, (ii) a theme or perceived object/situation that follows the verb in some cases but cannot be characterized as a logical object or semantic patient, and (iii) an oblique argument that refers to either the location in which the object/situation occurs (as in the existential sentence) or the person to whom the object/situation is apparent as in (72). Given the use of the ergative postposition to refer to an inalienable possessor as outlined above, one way of thinking about the case-marking relations that hold between the different nominal phrases in a $BNBV_{inal}$ clause is that the locative-terminative source argument represents an oblique case and that the combination of the bare inalienable noun and its raised inalienable possessor act as a single nominative/absolutive case-marked argument.

In my view there are two important corollaries that follow from the case-marking relations that hold between the zero-marked nominative/absolutive experiencer + inalienable noun and the oblique case-marked perceived object: (i) the non-agentive character of the perceiver in combination with the stative and/or resultative semantics of the predicate and (ii) the fact that surface form of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates resembles the surface form or an ordinary transitive clause with ergative agent, *-e, and zero-marked absolutive patient (where the perceived object in the locative-terminative case is

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analogous to the ergative agent of a transitive clause and the bare inalienable noun + inalienable possessor is analogous to the zero-marked absolutive patient), but that the thematic roles of the participants are theme and experiencer rather than agent and patient. The first of these two corollaries is dealt with in the following chapter, where the non-agentivity of the experiencer and the stative/resultative nature of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class are dealt with at length; the second corollary is taken up in detail at the end of the dissertation (see chapter 5 for details).

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2

Decomposing lexical aspect:

Telicity, the particle-verb construction and secondary predication

Having outlined a rather involved set of case-marking relations in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction at the end of chapter 1—the transfer of possession from a raised locative-terminative source to a goal in the ergative case—this chapter seeks to clarify several nagging issues that have to do with lexical aspect and whether or not aspectual properties interact with this curious case-marking regime in any palpable way. I argue that, in fact, the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction provides a useful diagnostic class for resolving a number of outstanding problems in previous explanations of the lexical aspectual system in Sumerian, notably Yoshikawa's proposal that the introduction of **šu** "hand" into an otherwise atelic predicate (forming, in many cases, a $BNBV_{inal}$ construction) converts it into a telic predicate. But prior to turning to Yoshikawa's proposal, several preliminary steps are necessary: in section 2.1, a number of basic theoretical tools such as the opposition between lexical and grammatical aspect, the Vendlerian classification of lexical aspectual categories and the opposition between depictive and resultative secondary predication are introduced; in section 2.2, an analogy is drawn between

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depictive and secondary predicates in English and what Yoshikawa termed Gtn-stem and D-stem reduplications in Sumerian (based on co-occurring Akkadian verbs in bilingual texts); and in section 2.3, the classification of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in terms of secondary predication is investigated with largely negative results.

The fact that $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates do not fit into Yoshikawa's Gtn-stem/D-stem opposition implies, for a number of reasons, that the $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates are *achievements* in the typology of lexical aspectual classes formulated by Vendler (1967) and subsequently extended in a number of ways by Dowty (1979). The classification of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates as *achievements* (which can be characterized as a telic event in which the change between the initial state and the final state is instantaneous) fits quite nicely with the particular semantics of the members of the class, particularly when the class is defined in somewhat narrower terms using the additional criteria identified at the end of section 2.3. But a formal diagnostic of some kind is still needed if only so as to prevent circular argumentation since there is no independent source for semantic evaluations other than the attestations of the particular verbs in context, that is to say, there is—in a strict sense—no independent source for semantic evaluations whatsoever. There are only two substantial tests for diagnosing an achievement predicate: achievements do not normally appear in the progressive aspect (Rothstein 2004, 36-58), and when they do appear in the progressive aspect, it is because they have been converted into a derived *accomplishment* (Rothstein 2004, 123-147). Although "progressive aspect" (the term used by Rothstein) is not necessarily equivalent to the "imperfective (*marû*) aspect" familiar to most Assyriologists, in the following I use the term "progressive/imperfective

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aspect" as a rough equivalent to "progressive aspect" and "non-progressive/perfective aspect" as its opposite. Derived accomplishments, in turn, come in at least two varieties in English, progressive/imperfective achievements ("Dafna is finding her shoes" [Rothstein 2004, 36, ex. 2b]) and light verb constructions ("John gave the floor a clean sweep" derived from the resultative "John swept the floor clean") and derived accomplishments in Sumerian seem to exhibit some properties of both these constructions. In section 2.4, the type of derived accomplishment constructions that are criterial for the identification of achievement predicates are introduced on the basis of English data and the non-agentive character of achievements is elaborated, whereas in section 2.5, the distributional facts associated with derived accomplishments in Sumerian are presented in some detail and lead, in turn, to a redescription of the function of **šu** in certain $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions.

The penultimate section of the chapter differs from the earlier ones in that it correlates three of the phenomena associated with $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions earlier in the dissertation (transfer of possession, inalienability and telicity) with a particular, typologically common syntactic pattern known as a particle-verb construction. Particle-verb constructions, which are extremely common in English, are one of the regular means of controlling telicity in SVO and VSO languages: the isolation of an adposition in the vicinity of the verb that lacks a nominal complement is used to transform atelic predicates into telic ones as in the frequent use of directional particles in English ("pour" as opposed to "pour out," "fill" as opposed to "fill in" and so forth). Whereas the raised ergative possessor of an inalienable noun in a $BNBV_{inal}$ construction is not presumably involved in

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the particle-verb features of the construction (since the ergative case is a "core" or "structural" case analogous to the nominative or accusative cases and the combination of inalienable noun and its possessor seems to form a single unit in terms of reference and thematic role), the raised possessor in the locative-terminative case, however, seems to form an existential construction in conjunction with the low source application morpheme *bi-√ and, in this section, I propose that the combination of the raised locative-terminative possessor, the inherently relational bare noun and the low source applicative morpheme act as a unit in SOV languages like Sumerian to introduce telicity to otherwise atelic predicates in the same way that stranded adpositions do in SVO or VSO languages. On the basis of Szabolcsi's proposal that weak quantifiers—such as the bare noun in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions—can act as a kind of catalyst for the formation of verbal complexes in verb-final languages, I apply the model of complex verb formation described by Koopman and Szabolcsi (2000) to the formation of verbal complexes in Sumerian, yielding a relatively coherent description of a particle-verb construction in an SOV language. The interesting corollary of this proposal is that the particular semantics of the set of indefinite body-part nouns that form the nominal component of $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions, particularly in terms of their inherently relational and orientational features, correspond quite closely to the relational and orientational features of the directional adpositions typically found in particle-verb constructions in other languages.

In the last section, I make a first attempt at incorporating the telicity of the BNBV construction—in particular, the similarity between particle-verb constructions and

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resultative secondary predicates—into Trask's model for the development of Type B ergativity. It looks like word-order (at least with respect to the order of lexical verb and verbal prefix) acts as a fairly good indicator of the scope of the existential quantification introduced by the *bi-√ verbal prefix. If so, I argue that the shift from ROOT-*bi to *bi-ROOT order, which corresponds to the shift from underlying, "imperative" word-order to the word-order found in finite verbs,[12] corresponds to a narrowing of the scope of the *bi-√ prefix and that this change is a direct result of the grammaticalization of *-e as an ergative postposition. In other words, the change in word/morpheme-order resulted from the development of ergativity and can be explained as a way of indicating a corresponding change in the hierarchical relation (and hence scope relations) between verbal prefix and lexical verb.

[12] Michalowski describes the process that forms the imperative construction in Sumerian as "[c]opying the root to the front of the verbal form" (Michalowski 2004, 43). But even if Michalowski is correct, the diachronic structure of the language need not mirror its synchronic structure.

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2.1 Three aspects of predication: Grammatical, lexical and secondary

As a way of introducing the often subtle interactions between *grammatical aspect* such as the progressive in English (be + -ing as in "Beth **is** read**ing** a book") and *lexical aspect* such as, for example, the difference between "to bite" and "to gnaw" in English (the opposition is sometimes also labeled using the German term *Aktionsart*, lit., "type of action"), I would like to turn initially to a few examples from English, where the two phenomena and their interaction have been studied in considerable detail. To simplify greatly, grammatical aspect draws a basic opposition between a perfective event, which is represented as a single point in time with no duration, and an imperfective event, which is represented as ongoing, extending in time. This opposition need not correspond to our own tense-tainted collective imagination: an activity such as "to run" (without a durational object or goal) can appear in either the progressive/imperfective or the non-progressive/perfective aspect, representing—or so the story goes—two different perspectives on the event, internal and external respectively.

(1)		Past perfective	Past imperfective
	a.	Sam ran.	Sam was running.
	b.	Sam drove the car.	Sam was driving the car.
	c.	Sam died.	Sam was dying.
	d.	Sam built the house.	Sam was building the house.

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In (1), factoring out tense as much as possible (which is necessary in English since present tense perfectives and imperfectives interact in complex ways with the origo of the deixis ["now"]),[13] the same predicate can appear in either the unmarked perfective or the imperfective.

What is known as lexical aspect has to do with types of predicates (where "predicate" is used as a cover term to refer to both bare verbs as well as verb + direct object combinations) classified on the basis of a number of seemingly unrelated questions:

(a) Does the event that the predicate refers to have a natural endpoint?

(b) Does the predicate refer to an event that requires a certain span of time in which it takes places?

(c) Can the event referred to by the predicate be broken down into distinct stages that differ in the degree to which the event is completed in each stage?

(d) Does the event referred to by the predicate take place because of the activity of the subject of the sentence?

Based on a lengthy tradition of study that, at least in its modern phase, begins with Vendler (1967) and passes through a crucial transformation in Dowty's redescription (1979), Agha (1993, 127-153) has proposed that these differences between predicates can

[13] An "origo of deixis" is a point with respect to which deictics of one kind or another are evaluated: given two acts of deictic reference oriented with respect to the same origo of deixis, the choice of which is a "near" deictic, "this," and which is a "far" deictic, "that," is determined by spatiotemporal proximity to the origo of deixis.

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be delimited on the basis of four features corresponding to the four questions above: (a) ± punctate, (b) ± durative, (c) ± segmental change of state, and (d) ± agentive. If the examples in (2) are recast in tabular format and classified on the basis of these features, a rough idea of the lexical aspectual classes commonly in use can be elucidated in short order.

Predicate	± punctate	± durative	± seg. change state	± agentive
(1a) run	–	+	–	+
(1b) drive a car	–	+	–	+
(1c) die	+	–	–	–
(1d) build a house	+	+	+	+

The set of features attributed to these four examples can be described in a plethora of ways, but certain classifications and their associated terminology are relatively standard and will be used throughout the discussion. Vendler defined four categories based on the first three features above: "states" lack all three features ([– punctate, – durative, – segmentable change of state]), "activities" such as (1a) and (1b) are ongoing events with no inherent endpoint ([– punctate, + durative, – segmentable change of state]), "achievements" are events which have both a duration and a telos but are not cumulative ([+ punctate, + durative, – segmentable change of state]), whereas "accomplishments" can be characterized as having all three features ([+ punctate, + durative, + segmentable change of state]). The fourth feature, agentivity, is often incorrectly characterized

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separately on the basis of whether or not the single nominal argument of an intransitive predicate is analogous to the agent of a transitive predicate as in (1a) or patient as in (1c): agentive [+ agentive] predicates are often termed "unergative" on the basis of parallels with the distinctive case-marking that is used to mark agents in ergative languages, whereas patientive [– agentive] predicates are known as "unaccusatives" since their single nominal argument is analogous to the distinctive case-marking used to indicate the patient of a transitive predicate in accusative languages. In terms of lexical aspect, unaccusatives are often quite similar to telic transitive predicates, while unergatives often pattern along the lines of transitive predicates that lack telicity.

Rothstein, whose most recent work (2004) seems to represent a high point in recent studies of lexical aspect describes these aspectual oppositions (excluding the ± agentive feature) in terms of just two properties in the following table (after Rothstein 2004, 192, ex. 1).

	[± stages] = occurs in progressive	[± telic] = naturally heads telic VP
States	–	–
Activities	+	–
Achievements	–	+
Accomplishments	+	+

On the one hand, therefore, *activities* and *accomplishments* have internal duration and extend in time, whereas *states* and *achievements* do not, while on the other hand, *achievements* and *accomplishments* have a natural endpoint, whereas *states* and *activities* do not.

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In the past few years, investigations of lexical aspect, particularly in formal semantics, have also uncovered a third domain of aspectual categorization that, as it turns out, is particularly relevant to investigations of Sumerian: the primary examples of this phenomenon in the linguistics literature—dominated, as it is, by English morphosyntax—are resultative and depictive secondary predication in English. Older investigations of secondary predication can be associated quite clearly with what are known as *small clauses* such as "John leave" in "Mary saw [$_{SC}$ John leave]" (Stowell 1981; 1983; cf. Stowell 1995 and references therein), but the importance of secondary predication as a lexical aspectual phenomenon has only been clearly identified and dealt with in the past few years, so I would like to take a moment to introduce it before moving on to the specifically Sumerian questions that occupy the rest of the chapter. If we apply one of the standard tests for telicity (co-occurrence with bound ["in three hours"] and unbound ["for three hours"] temporal adverbials) to a series of increasingly complicated English predicates, an interesting pattern emerges (although the following example has become the standard one used in the secondary literature, its proximate source is Rothstein 2004).

(2) a. He hammered it for three hours / **in three hours. ("atelic")

b. He hammered it out for three hours / in three hours. ("telic")

c. He hammered it flat **for three hours / in three hours. ("resultative")

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In the three examples in (2), contrasting temporal adverbials are used to differentiate the lexical aspectual properties of the complex predicates "to hammer," "to hammer out" and "to hammer flat." In (2a), the bare verb can only occur with the unbounded temporal adverbial "for three hours," whereas the bounded temporal adverbial is ungrammatical: this indicates that the bare verb "to hammer" is *atelic*. In (2b), the introduction of a particle in a particle-verb construction allows the complex verb "to hammer out" to appear with either of the two temporal adverbials, indicating that there is an available *telic* endpoint in the semantics of the verb, but that it need not have been reached. The example in (2c), however, is inherently telic or better "resultative" and excludes the unbounded temporal adverbial. Note therefore that, even in English, so-called lexical aspect is in fact a grammatical phenomenon: particle-verbs as in (2b) show one type of telicity, while resultative secondary predicates (see below for definition) as in (2c) show another more restricted type of telicity.

There are in fact a number of different types of what has come to be called *secondary predication*, some of which are illustrated in (3) below (the following examples correspond to Rothstein 2004, 60, examples 2a, 2b, and 3).

(3) a. John$_i$ drove the car **drunk**$_i$.

b. Mary drank the coffee$_i$ **hot**$_i$.

c. John painted the house$_i$ **red**$_i$.

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In each of these examples, the secondary predicate is in bold and occurs in sentence final position in English—the subscripted indices indicate which words are coreferential. Examples (3a) and (3b) are "depictive" secondary predicates in that they qualify a particular nominal argument throughout the entire duration of the event denoted by the main predicate: the implication is that John is drunk throughout the period of time in which he drove and that the coffee, likewise, is hot throughout the time it took to drink it. The "resultative" secondary predicate in (3c), unlike the depictive ones in (3a) and (3b), is only true upon completion of the event denoted by the main predicate, so the house is red in its entirety only at the completion of John's act of painting and, in somewhat informal terms, the degree to which the direct object has the property attributed to it by the adjective that acts as the secondary predicate corresponds to the degree to which the event referred to by the main predicate is complete (see Rothstein 2004 for detailed criticism of the view that the direct object can serve as a true index of the relative completion of the event, cf. Krifka 1989). The literature on secondary predication is still somewhat inchoate and difficult to follow, but Rothstein notes several important points: (a) whereas resultative secondary predicates are limited in application to adjectival modifiers of direct objects, depictive secondary predicates can modify either subject or object of a transitive verb, (b) where the primary verb is intransitive, it can be transitivized so as to make available a direct object for secondary predication either through the use of a "fake-reflexive" (*John laughed himself$_i$ sick$_i$* [Rothstein 2004, 60, ex. 4c]) or a "non-thematic object" (*John sang the baby$_i$ asleep$_i$* [Rothstein 2004, 60, ex. 4d]), and (c) the use of adjectives as the basis for secondary predication means that the

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nominal modified by the secondary predicate is necessarily a non-agentive theme argument with respect to the secondary predicate.[14]

In the Sumerological tradition, telicity is nothing new: much of Yoshikawa's work centers on telicity (Yoshikawa 1988 [1993, 72-94]). It is clear from his collected works that his use of the two terms, "telicity" and "momentariness," represents his attempt to make sense of, on the one hand, the fact that certain verbs have natural end points ("telicity") such as "to build a house," while others such as "to run" do not, and, on the other hand, the fact that certain verbs lack any inherent duration ("momentariness") such as "to snap" or "to pop." The difficulty that one faces in attempting to assimilate Yoshikawa's aspectual metalanguage of telicity and momentariness to ongoing work in the study of aspect is substantial, but I have attempted in the following to take the lexical classes of *ḫamṭu* reduplication identified by Yoshikawa and redescribe them in terms of secondary predication and the aspectual terminology in present-day use. I should emphasize, however, that Yoshikawa's typology of *ḫamṭu* reduplication relies above all on semantic criteria that are dependent on the reliability of Old Babylonian scribal traditions maintained by non-native speakers.

[14] This follows from much of the discussion about internal as opposed to external arguments in the generative tradition: since telicity is typically associated with the VP, it makes some sense that it is only nominal arguments that occur within the VP that can be modified by a secondary predicate. This would also explain why unaccusatives tolerate resultative secondary predicates, whereas unergatives do not.

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2.2 D-stem/Gtn-stem reduplication in Sumerian

In the wake of Yoshikawa's revolutionary description of grammatical aspect in Sumerian (see Yoshikawa 1968a, 1968b, 1974, 1989, 1993; written in dialogue with, at least to some degree, Edzard's several iterations of a competing theory [1967, 1971, 1972], cf. Krecher 1995), the debate devolved to a class of reduplicated verbal roots that came to be called "*ḫamṭu* reduplications" due to the fact that they did not seem to belong to Yoshikawa's *marû* reduplication class; Edzard termed these examples of reduplication *freie Reduplikation*, identifiable in formal terms by, prototypically, full CVC reduplication in opposition to the reduced CV reduplication of Yoshikawa's *marû* reduplication class and the use of the same pattern of pronominal agreement as non-reduplicated *ḫamṭu* roots. Much of Yoshikawa's subsequent work, therefore, focused on questions of lexical aspect (primarily Yoshikawa 1979 [1993, 287-308] and 1981 [1993, 309-322], cf. 1988 [1993, 72-94]). Yoshikawa argues that two distinct classes of *freie Reduplikation* forms can be distinguished (besides *marû* reduplications, which would constitute a third non-*freie Reduplikation* class [Yoshikawa (1979, 119 [1993, 308])]) on the basis of the form of the corresponding Akkadian verb in bilingual contexts: punctate verbs (including, prototypically, what are often now termed semelfactives in the literature, cf. Rothstein 2004, 28-29) such as "to hit," "to break," and "to snap," which generally take Akkadian translations in the D-stem, can be juxtaposed to atelic verbs of, for the most part, repetitive motion such as "to crawl," which are usually translated by Akkadian verbs in the Gtn-stem. Yoshikawa further notes that the opposition between these two classes corresponds to the transitivity of their respective predicates: those

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translated by Akkadian D-stem verbs are generally transitive, whereas those translated by Akkadian Gtn-stem verb are generally intransitive (Yoshikawa 1979, 119 [1993, 308]).

The D-stem reduplications (subsuming the several semantically-defined types proposed by Yoshikawa) are best thought of as transitive and resultative, referring to the resulting state of the direct object: they correspond in a number of ways to the English resultative noted above (3c) such as "he hammered it flat" in that the two major subgroups within the D-stem reduplication set happen to correspond to the two components of an English resultative secondary predicate. In a resultative such as "he hammered it flat," two components are necessary: a direct object, "it" (often resulting in reflexive or so-called fake objects with intransitive verbs), and an adjective, "flat," that modifies the direct object and refers to the end state of the referent of the direct object after all telic points have been reached. In those cases in which the original meaning of the verbal root is transitive: the "it" of "hammered it flat" is already present, but the resulting state of "(something) flat" is introduced through the use of the reduplication.

(4) An-ta-gal, E, iv 10'-11' (Cavigneaux et al. 1985 [MSL 17], 212; Yoshikawa 1993, 291)

10'. sa.a	*ma-ša$_2$-du*	to full (cloth)
11'. sa.sa	*muš-šu-du*	to full (cloth)

This lexically-attested use of √**sa** is nowhere to be found in third millennium and Old Babylonian sources, but its semantics do correspond to a resultative predicate in that the

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reduplicated Sumerian verbal form corresponding to the D-stem does not indicate the plurality of the direct object, but rather that the direct object is beaten to a point of completion: fulled cloth being cloth that has been beaten until it reaches a point at which it is fully cleansed and thickened. Thus the reduplication in this case contributes the adjectival values of "to be clean" and "to be thick."

(5) Nabnîtum J 331-342 (Finkel 1982 [MSL 16], 165; Yoshikawa 1993, 293; Molina and Such-Gutiérrez 2004, 4)

331. ze_2	*ba-qa-mu*	to pluck
332. $ze_2.ze_2$	(*ba-qa-mu*)	
...		
342. $ze_2.ze_2$	*bu-uq-qu-mu*	to pluck clean

Here likewise, the reduplication of the verbal root does not seem to indicate plurality of the direct object, but rather a resultative which includes the adjectival meaning "to be clean," yielding something like "(a sheep) plucked clean" as its resultative meaning. But as should be apparent from the distance between lines 331 and 342, the simple opposition envisioned by Yoshikawa is not so simple: while it is true that basic and reduplicated stems follow directly in lines 331 and 332, the blank space in the translation column of line 332 presumably indicates that it is to be translated with a G-stem Akkadian verb just like the non-reduplicated form in line 331; the D-stem reduplication occurs ten lines later and is not preceded by a non-reduplicated form. This seems to indicate that reduplicated

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forms are, in some cases at least, radically ambiguous: the G-stem form in line 332 would seem to correspond to the common use of verbal reduplication to code the plurality of an absolutive argument, whereas the later reduplication in line 342 corresponds to the D-stem reduplication identified by Yoshikawa.

The other type of D-stem reduplication is complementary in that, rather than taking a verb with a direct object and introducing an adjectival component, what Yoshikawa calls "denominative reduplication" takes an adjectival root and introduces a direct object, resulting in a kind of causative, or to be more precise, resultative construction. Yoshikawa notes that "[m]ost of the verbs assignable to this group seem to derive themselves from adjectives, in particular, those denoting colour terms, luminosity, [and] cleanliness" (Yoshikawa 1993, 305).

(6) Groups III, E (Yoshikawa 1993, 305)

82. tam.ma	*eb-bu-um*	bright, shiny
83. tam.tam.ma	*ub-bu-bu-um*	to make bright, shiny
84. dag_2.ga	*el-lum*	pure
85. dag_2.dag_2.ga	*ul-lu-lum*	to purify

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Whereas D-stem reduplication introduced an adjectival component to the transitive verbs above, with respect to adjectival roots, which are necessarily intransitive, the D-stem reduplication introduces a direct object through causativization.[15]

(7) OBGT XI (MSL IV; Yoshikawa 1993, 305)

11. [gun_3].[gun_3].na.ab	*bu-⌈ri-im⌉*	make colored!
12. [sig_7].sig_7.ga.ab	*bu-ri-⌈iq⌉*	make green!

Likewise in example (7), the reduplication of the verbal root yields a resultative form and in the case of adjectival roots results in a causative semantics. Note, then, that in purely formal terms, the examples of originally transitive predicates in (4) and (5) form a resultative secondary predicate through simple reduplication of the root, whereas the adjectival examples in (6) and (7) start out as a verbal root followed by the nominalizing/resultative suffix, *-a, and form the resultative secondary predicate by verbal reduplication that preserves the nominalizing/resultative suffix in final position.

The fact that the resultative D-stem construction of both the transitive and the adjectival roots yields a semantic complex that includes both a direct object and an adjectival predicate that modifies the direct object should probably be taken as evidence that it is a resultative secondary predication (see Rothstein 2004, 59-90 and references therein). Yoshikawa drew a fundamental contrast between the D-stem *ḫamṭu* reduplications dealt with above and the Gtn-stem *ḫamṭu* reduplications that I turn to now

[15] Whether the causativization of the predicate follows from reduplication alone or is related in one way or another to the *-b- morpheme remains an open question: this is the generalization that best fits the grammatical texts (Kowaki 1982), but it probably needs to be investigated more thoroughly in non-lexical environments.

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(Yoshikawa 1993, 308). Whereas D-stem reduplications share a number of important properties with resultative secondary predicates, Gtn-stem reduplications bear a number of similarities to depictive secondary predicates in English. Yoshikawa refers to a number of examples from Late Old Babylonian lexical lists such as the following.

(8) Izi, E (Yoshikawa 1993, 297)

329. u_2 ki tag	*pa-ša-lum*	to crawl
330. u_2 ki tag.tag	*pi-ta-šu-lum*	to crawl continually

(9) Izi, F (Yoshikawa 1993, 297)

119. gu_2 gid_2	*ša-da-hu*	to walk
120. gu_2 gid_2.gid_2	*ši-⌈ta⌋-[du-du]*	to walk continually

(10) Izi, G (Yoshikawa 1993, 298)

249. gu_4.ud	*ša!-ḫa-⌈ṭu⌋*	to jump
250. gu_4.ud.gu_4.ud	*ši-taḫ-ḫu-⌈ṭu⌋*	to jump continually

In each case, the verb is intransitive and agentive and the reduplication of the Sumerian verbal root is translated by an Akkadian verb in the Gtn-stem, indicating repetitive action. The meaning of such repetitive Gtn-stem reduplications corresponds to the depictive secondary predicates described above in that the period of time referred to by the Gtn-stem reduplication is the entire period of time in the relevant domain, likewise depictive

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secondary predicates like (3a) and (3b) above (repeated below) indicate that the content of the secondary predicate is true throughout the period of time within which the main predicate takes place.

(11) John$_i$ drove the car **drunk**$_i$.

(12) Mary drank the coffee$_i$ **hot**$_i$.

In (12), for example, the depictive secondary predicate "hot" is true throughout the entire period of time during which Mary was drinking the coffee, not only at the end of the event as was the case with the resultative secondary predicates. Likewise, in example (11), John was presumably drunk throughout the period in which he drove the car, although the implication is somewhat less clear than in (12) due to the fact that "to drive a car" is atelic: secondary predicates that modify the subject of transitive atelic predicates are fine, but secondary predicates that modify the subject of a transitive, telic predicate are somewhat problematic, presumably because the occurrence of a direct object interferes with a secondary predicate that is meant to modify the subject of the clause.

(13) Mary$_i$ drank the coffee $^{\%}$drunk$_i$/$^{\%}$sober.

In (13), "drunk" and "sober" seem somewhat odd, but not entirely ungrammatical; they do, however, seem to imply that the drinking of coffee might have resulted in "sober"

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coffee—only the inanimacy of coffee blocks the resultative interpretation and forces a construal with Mary as depictively modified.

The import of these parallels between D-stem/Gtn-stem reduplications and secondary predication are difficult to clarify, but two points are worthy of mention: (a) secondary predicates tend to be associated with the nominal that corresponds to a natural end point or *telos* for the verb and (b) the D-stem and Gtn-stem reduplications both refer to the non-dynamic period of time after any and all telic points have been reached: where the verb is telic, such a non-dynamic period of time corresponds to the resultant state (analogous to resultative secondary predication), but when the verb is atelic, the non-dynamic period of time refers to the entire event (analogous to depictive secondary predication). As Rothstein reiterates: "... we see that when an AP [adjective phrase] is used as a secondary predicate, then the property it expresses must hold of the denotation of its subject for the whole time that the matrix [main] event is going on (for depictives) or for the whole time that the culmination of the matrix [main] event is going on (for resultatives)" (Rothstein 2004, 63). In other words, a secondary predicate in English picks out the nominal that serves as a natural end point for the verb and acts as an adjectival modifier, qualifying the nominal accordingly.

What is the formal mechanism in Sumerian that allows reduplication of a verbal root to correspond in semantic terms to the introduction of a distinct, secondary adjectival form in the English examples? It just so happens that several types of adjective in Sumerian seem to be formed through the reduplication of a verbal root. The group of

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adjectival roots that form Yoshikawa's "denominative reduplication" subset is one such group (Yoshikawa 1993, 305), repeated in (14).

(14)

a.	$bar_6.bar_6$	/babbar/	"to be white"
b.	$sig_7.sig_7$	/sissig/	"to be green"
c.	$dag_2.dag_2$	/daddag/	"to be clean"
d.	$gun_3.gun_3$	/guggun/	"to be speckled"

Note as well that the regular form of **$bar_6.bar_6$** is **babbar**, that of **$dag_2.dag_2$**, **dadag** and that these two forms always occur in reduplicated form.

Mandarin uses reduplication to code two distinct, but in my view, related morphosyntactic phenomena that may illuminate a distinct class of adjectives in Sumerian that is also formed through reduplication: what Li and Thompson term "the delimitative aspect" and certain forms of diminutive adjectives. Li and Thompson characterize the meaning of the delimitative aspect as "doing the action 'a little bit,' or for a short period of time" (Li and Thompson 1981, 232).

(15) Mandarin Chinese (Li and Thompson 1981, 233, ex. 195)

ni3	shi4	(yi)	shi4	kan4
you	try	one	try	see

Try it a little and see!

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(16) wo3 wen4 (yi) wen4 zai4 jue2-ding

I ask one ask then decide

I'll decide after I inquire a little.

Although Li and Thompson do not make the connection, the form in English that seems to correspond to the delimitative aspect construction in Mandarin is a light verb construction in which a higher ditransitive predicate is introduced into the construction and the original main verb is changed into an indefinite noun—examples (15) and (16) are repeated below with English light verb constructions in the glosses.

(17) ni3 shi4 (yi) shi4 kan4

you try one try see

Give it a try and see!

(18) wo3 wen4 (yi) wen4 zai4 jue2-ding

I ask one ask then decide

I'll decide after I make some inquires, lit., an inquiry.

While the light verb construction in (18) involves a verb of creation, "make," typically associated with verbs of speaking, the light verb construction in the gloss to (17) makes use of a low goal applicative construction. Light verbs that resemble a low source applicative such as "take a look at" also occur in English and bear a number of important

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similarities to the members of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class dealt with above, but the two should not be equated due to the highly restricted semantics of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates. Pylkkänen states at one point that "light verb constructions are not syntactically low applicatives" (2002, 38), based on the fact that, in her view, low applied arguments (*Mary* in "Lou gave Mary a cake") cannot be modified by depictive secondary predicates, but I find her argumentation at this point forced and I suspect that the restriction is due to the incorporation of the applied argument into the predicate (i.e., in the middle of verb and direct object) in English. Although it is, as Pylkkänen notes, "an open research question," I see no reason to exclude light verb constructions from a low applicative analysis (on the connection between light verb constructions, secondary predication and adjectival roots, see section 2.5 below).

Turning back to reduplicated adjectives in Mandarin, here the idea of "doing something a little bit" is carried over into the adjectival part of the lexicon where it exhibits the well-known grammatical category of diminutive. "The diminutive form . . . expresses the speaker's feeling that the referent is small, or subtle; that it endears the speaker—in short, a speaker evaluation of undersize, restricted and affectively positive," whereas "the augmentative form . . . expresses the speaker's feeling that the referent of some lexical item is large for what it is, or to excess, if an activity; that it is repulsive to the speaker—in short, a speaker evaluative of oversize, overmuch, and affectively negative" (Silverstein 1981, 8). In most languages, diminutives and augmentatives are formed through sometimes quite massive phonological deformation; in Mandarin Chinese, however, the diminutive is indicated by reduplication of the adjectival root.

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(19) ta1 de lian3 hen3 bai2

she Poss face very white

Her face is pale.

(20) ta2 de lian3 bai2-bai2 de

she Poss face white-Redup Nmz

He face is beautifully white.

In (19), the single adjectival root is neutral, but it presumably takes on a negative connotation in opposition to the reduplicated forms in (20). The reduplicated form in (20) does not indicate plurality or intensive meanings as we might expect on the basis of Sumerian or Akkadian comparisons, but rather that the referent of the adjective is, in an affective way, viewed as small, delicate or pretty. The contrast is highlighted when the adjective is question is something like "fat" as in (21) and (22).

(21) na4 ge (hen3) pang4 de xian1-sheng

that person very fat Nmz adult.male

That fat man ...

(22) na4 ge pang4-pang4 de hai2-zi

that person fat-Redup Nmz child

That chubby (and cute) child ...

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In terms of stereotypical usage, (21) would typically be used in reference to an adult and would tend to be a negative statement, whereas (22) would normally be used for a chubby baby or, perhaps, as a term of endearment for a girlfriend who has gained a little weight.

Although it is unclear whether or not "reduplication as diminutive" is productive in the Sumerian preserved in the text-artifactual record, it does appear in two highly lexicalized adjectival expressions.

(23) Diminutive-related CVC reduplication

$di_4.di_4.la$ "small"	/diddil-a/	cf. tur "small," gal "big," maḫ "huge"
$ku_7.ku_7.da$ "sweet"	/kukkud-a/	cf. dug_3 "sweet," sis "tart," mun_4 "bitter"

In (23), the contrast is two-fold: on the one hand, reduplicated diminutives contrast with ordinary adjectives that have the same basic meaning but lack the diminutive connotation (**tur** and **dug_3** respectively), on the other hand, diminutives contrast with adjectives having the polar opposite meaning such as **gal** and **maḫ**, or **sis** and **mun_4**.[16] It should be emphasized that adjectives that signify "positive" qualities such as **sa_6** "fine, good," **zid** "just," **kalag** "strong" would not normally be found in the diminutive since they lack the "cuteness" factor that is central to diminutive semantics. Note as well the close formal similarity between the adjectival roots in resultative secondary forms such as (6) and (7) and the diminutives in (23): in all four cases, the adjectival root is reduplicated and the

[16] Note that the two terms for "big" (**gal** and **maḫ**) and the two for "bitter" (**sis** and **mun_4**) may well represent corresponding augmentative contrasts coded through phonological deformation, but without a clearer understanding of Sumerian phonology and a detailed investigation of the contexts in which the different forms occur, we cannot be sure of such an interpretation.

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reduplicated stem is followed by the nominalizing/resultative suffix, *-a. There are many open research questions pertaining to the history of the Sumerian adjective that I will not attempt to address here, but it seems fairly clear that reduplication in the examples in this section does not indicate plurality of individuals as is typically assumed for *ḫamṭu* reduplication.[17]

The types of verbal/adjectival reduplication dealt with in this section, therefore, stand in opposition to the use of verbal reduplication to indicate plurality, certain types of pluractionality, or (in the case of "reduced" reduplication) progressive/imperfective aspect. The simplest explanation for the opposition between the reduplicated forms dealt with in this section as opposed to the more familiar plural/pluractional forms is that the forms dealt with in this section are limited to secondary predicational, adverbial or backgrounding functions, whereas the plural and pluractional uses of reduplication can be associated with primary predication, verbal or foregrounding discursive functions. In terms of secondary predication in Sumerian (if that is in fact the proper explanation for the reduplicated forms dealt with in this section), we should bear in mind that other studies of reduplication have shown that the particular grammatical phenomena indicated by reduplication are often determined by the lexical aspectual class of the reduplicated verbal root in conjunction with the particular morphology of the reduplication or the morphosyntactic environment in which the reduplicated form occurs (see Edzard 1971; 1972; 1976; Yoshikawa 1993, passim; Krecher 1995 for the morphological forms

[17] The use of reduplicated attributive adjectives such as **gal.gal** in **diĝir gal.gal.e.ne** "the greatest gods" is probably related to diminuative/delimitative reduplication in that superlatives regularly pick out a limited number of referents (see Thomsen 2001 [1984], 65; for a brief overview of verbal reduplication in Mandarin and its similarities to the attenuative prefix /po-/ in Russian, see J. Kim 2003).

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involved in Sumerian verbal reduplication; cf. Newman 1990, 53-130; 2000, 508-521 for an interesting set of materials for comparison). In a study of verbal reduplication in Niuean, Haji-Abdolhosseini, Massam and Oda have demonstrated that considerations of the morphological form of reduplication as well as the lexical aspectual class of the reduplicated verb regularly predict the meaning or grammatical function of reduplication in each case (Haji-Abdolhosseini et al. 2002, 488-489); similarly, the contrast in English between "he painted the *red* house" and "he painted the house *red*" demonstrates the difference a morphosyntactic environment makes: the adjective in the first of the two examples is an attributive adjective in a run-of-the-mill noun phrase, but the adjective in the second sentence is a resultative secondary predicate.

In the following section, I look at the relatively small number of examples in which the verbal root of a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate is reduplicated. I argue that reduplication of the verbal root in these cases is an indication of the fact that they are secondary and/or adverbial rather than an indication of plurality. This in turn raises the issue of which lexical aspectual class reduplicated $BNBV_{inal}$ roots belong to. I think that there are good reasons for assigning $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in which the root is reduplicated—at least to the degree that they are secondary predicates—to a third lexical aspectual alongside the accomplishments that form the resultative (D-stem) class and the activities that form the depictive (Gtn-stem) class. Although the particular secondary or adverbial nuance remains unclear, I suggest that one possibility is that it forms an adverbial clause of cause or result and corresponds to a particular use of the *iptaras* form in Akkadian.

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2.3 $BNBV_{inal}$ reduplication: Depictive, resultative or *tertium quid*?

In light of the opposition between D-stem, resultative reduplications and Gtn-stem, depictive reduplications, the aspectual properties of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates do not seem to conform to the expectations of either of these two classes. This section presents the relatively few examples of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in which the verbal root is reduplicated and formulates one possible solution to their meaning and morphosyntactic function. The conventional interpretation of these forms is that they indicate plurality of a noun in the nominative/absolutive case. Although the interpretation of them as plural does explain some of the following examples, others do not seem to involve plurality. Since there is no independent evidence of plurality in these cases (other than the reduplication itself), I tentatively propose an alternative analysis of "reduplicated" BNBVinal predicates as a form of secondary or adverbial predication. If $BNBV_{inal}$ "reduplication" is secondary or adverbial, the simplest hypothesis would be that it belongs to either the resultative (D-stem) reduplication class or the depictive (Gtn-stem) reduplication class, but neither form of reduplication seems to correspond to the following examples of $BNBV_{inal}$ "reduplication."

In Yoshikawa's paper "Verbal Reduplication in Sumerian" (Yoshikawa 1979 [1993, 287-308]), in which he breaks down the various *ḫamṭu* reduplications noted by Edzard (1971; 1972) into groups on the basis of the form of parallel, Akkadian verbs in bilinguals (largely lexical lists), the lone example of a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate in Yoshikawa's typology stands out as an exception and remains unclassified: **ĝiš-√tuk** (Yoshikawa 1993,

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290). Yoshikawa presents the rather sketchy material without further comment as follows:

(24) Kagal, tablet E, IV (Yoshikawa 1993, 290)[18]

79. ĝiš tuk	*še-mu-ú*	to hear
80. ĝiš TUK.TUK	*še-me-e a-ú*	to hear twice

The English translation of the Akkadian gloss in line 80 is Yoshikawa's—I have been unable to make sense of either the Akkadian gloss or Yoshikawa's translation into English. Since Yoshikawa's interpretation and its implications remain unclear to me, I have treated the form TUK.TUK, which could be read as either **tuk.tuk** or **du_{12}.du_{12}**, as a simple case of full verbal reduplication, namely **ĝiš tuk.tuk**.

The verbal form **ĝiš-√tuk.tuk** occurs two times in the Old Babylonian materials made available through the ETCSL project: in the Sargon Legend, segment B, line 16 and Shulgi C, segment B, line 50, neither of which elucidate its meaning in any great detail.

(25) The Sargon Legend [2.1.4], segment B, line ll. 14-18

14. ku_3 ^{d}inanna.ke_4 ma.mu_2 i_7 mud.$še_3$	*In the dream, holy Inanna drowned him*
mu.un.gir_5.gir_5	*(= Ur-Zababa) in a river of blood,*
15. ^{m}šar.ru.um.ki.in dum.dam.ma.na	*The sleeping Sargon gnawed the ground,*
zu_2 ki.⌜$še_3$⌝ ba.da.ab.ra.⌜aḫ⌝	*groaning,*

[18] No edition in MSL XIII; Civil notes that, "these texts will be published with corrections and additions in HAR-ra VII" (Civil 1971, 252).

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16. dum.dum.bi lugal ^{d}ur.^{d}za.ba$_4$.ba$_4$ — *As for these cries, because king Ur-Zababa*

ĝiš tuk.tuk.da.ni — *heard them,*

17. lugal.ra ki ku$_3$.ga.ni.še$_3$ — *He had them bring him into the*

im.ma.da.an.⌈sun$_5$⌉.ne.eš — *king's holy presence,*

18. ^{m}šar.ru.um.ki.in ki — *He had them bring Sargon into the presence*

^{d}ur.^{d}za.ba$_4$.ba$_4$.še$_3$ — *of Ur-Zababa,*

im.ma.da.an.sun$_5$.ne

Whatever is happening in line 14 and whatever its connection to the overall sequence of the passage, the cries (dum.dum.bi) of Sargon clearly provide the reason that the king has Sargon brought before him, hence the introduction of "because" in the translation of line 16.

(26) Shulgi C, segment B, line 50

48. x gi$_4$ x.ta ḫa.ma.ta.ḫu.ḫu.luḫ.eš$_2$ — *... may they be terrified,*

49. erin$_2$.ne$_2$ ni$_2$ ḫa.ba.ab.te — *and may his troops be frightened,*

50. [x] x x x x — *... because they heard ...,*

ĝiš? ḫa.ma.ab.tuk.tuk

51. x lugal kalam us$_2$.sa se$_3$.se$_3$ — *Since I am a king who puts the homeland*

in.ga.me.na.ta — *on track,*

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The example in line 50 is quite badly broken and adds nothing of substance (and my partial translation of the line is pure supposition on the basis the preceding example), but it should be noted that, like the previous example, the temporal relation between the lines is unclear and deserves further investigation.

In fact, the number of examples of *ḫamṭu* reduplication of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates can be counted on precisely one hand (five exemplars) and some members of the group are quite anomalous: **a_2-√su_3** "to sail; to spread" and the two occurrences of **gu_2-√gud** "to pile up" do not seem to fit into the semantic field of the other $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates presumably because the nominal component of these examples is alienable rather than inalienable despite the existence of an homophonous inalienable noun in each case. Only two examples show reduplication of predicates that seem, at least upon initial inspection, to be $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates: **zu_2-√sud_2** "to bite, to gnaw" and **igi-√kar_2** "to examine."

(27) The Exploits of Ninurta [1.6.2], ll. 348-352 (Karahashi 2000, 78)

348. ^{d}nin.urta dumu ^{d}en.lil_2.la_2.ke_4	*Ninurta, the son of Enlil, wanted to do*
gal.bi i_3.$\tilde{g}a_2$.$\tilde{g}a_2$	*something big,*
349. gu.ru.um na_4 kur.ra mi.ni.in.ak	*As for the pile of stones that had been accumulated in the mountains,*
350. dungu diri.ga.gin_7	*Because they were spread all over like*
a_2 bi_2.in.su_3.su_3.ud	*drifting clouds,*
351. bad_3 maḫ.gin_7 kalam.ma igi.ba	*Blocking the view of the land as if they*
bi_2.in.tab.⌈ba⌉	*were a huge wall,*

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352. ^{ĝiš}bal ki.šar$_2$.ra mu.ni.in.ĝar *He installed a spigot (?) on the horizon,*

(28) Winter and Summer [5.3.3], ll. 196-199 (Karahashi 2000, 99)

196. e$_2$.me.eš šeš.ĝu$_{10}$ a$_2$.kuš$_2$.a.ĝu$_{10}$.a ni$_2$ buluĝ$_5$ u$_3$ mu.ni.e$_3$ *Summer, my brother, after you have gone out boasting about my toil,*

197. za$_3$.mu.ka še e$_2$.a u$_3$.mu.ni.in.ku$_4$ guru$_7$ **gu$_2$ bi$_2$.in.gur.gur** *Because, at new year, having brought grain into the house, the silos are full,*

198. diri u$_3$.me.de$_6$ ^{tug2}bar.dul$_5$ ^{tug2}niĝ$_2$.lam$_2$.zu bal.a.kam *When you have brought in the surplus, your bardul and niglam garments are ...*

199. ^{uruda}ḫa.zi.in 2(diš) ma.na lu$_2$ u$_3$ mu.ra.an.šum$_2$ edin.zu.še$_3$ ba.du.un *When someone has given you a two-mana axe, you go off to your steppe,*

Although the meaning of line 198 is somewhat unclear, the surplus presumably results from the abundance of food in the granary. In the following example (29), Winter makes an appeal to Enlil, the judge in Winter's dispute with Summer.

(29) Winter and Summer [5.3.3], ll. 288-291 (Karahashi 2000, 99)

289. a.a ^{d}en.lil$_2$ nam.ku$_5$.ĝal$_2$ mu.e.šum$_2$ a he$_2$.ĝal$_2$.la mu.e.de$_6$ *"Father Enlil, you gave irrigation-control and brought abundant waters,*

290. a.gar$_3$.a.gar$_3$.ra za$_3$ ba.ni.tag.tag guru$_7$ **gu$_2$ bi$_2$.gur.gur** *The plantations were set up in order to fill the granaries,*

291. še ab.sin$_2$.na gu$_2$ ba.ni.in.peš *The grain grew thick in the furrows,*

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292. ^{d}ezina$_2$.e ki.sikil sa$_6$.ga.gin$_7$	*And Ezina came forth in splendour like*
ni$_2$ pa e$_3$ bi$_2$.ak	*a beautiful maiden,*

This example also occurs above in chapter 1, where I provide some justification for my interpretation of **a.gar$_3$.a.gar$_3$.ra** as "plantations." Here, in the midst of a pair of ba.ni-√ verbs, the reduplicated BNBV$_{inal}$ construction seems to form a purpose clause rather than a causal one. The only difference, however, between a causal relation and a purpose relation is between past and future tense, so the causal predicate in 290 simply seems to be occurring in a future context rather than a past one.

(30) Sumerian Proverbs, UM 55-21-278 = 3 N-T 179 [6.2.1]

(Alster 1997, 305; Karahashi 2000, 181)

ka$_5$.a zu$_2$ bi$_2$.in.sud$_2$.sud$_2$	*Because a fox bites,*
saĝ nam.mi.bul.bul	*you should pay attention to it (to avoid being bitten)*

In general terms, the inherently decontextualized nature of proverbs makes any definitive interpretation of them quite difficult, but the basic lexical meaning of both verbs is quite obscure as well: von Soden cites a few texts in which BUL is associated with *našû* and later in the same entry **saĝ bu.bu** is juxtaposed to the Akkadian *nu-uš qaq-qa-di* (V R 16, 47 cd; ZA 43, 243, 268; AHw 762); CAD identifies *rēš našû* as an idiom meaning "to

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check on quality or quantity of fields, materials, staples, animals," and I have interpreted the second line of the proverb as an extended sense of this meaning.

(31) Eduba Regulations, HT C3 (Karahashi 2000, 127)

šeš.gal.e u_3 ba.dab$_5$ **dub.be$_2$**	*The big brother, after taking the tablet in*
igi bi$_2$.ib$_2$.kar$_2$.kar$_2$	*order to examine it,*

Although there is little if any direct evidence for the interpretation of reduplicated $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates as cause or result clauses (primarily due to the fact that there are very few cases and the contextual meaning is unclear in almost every case). If in future additional evidence can be educed in favor of such an analysis, it would result in a rather elegant system of adjectival/adverbial reduplication: atelic predicates would form the equivalent of depictive secondary predicates (Gtn-stem reduplication), accomplishments would form the equivalent of resultative secondary predicates (D-stem reduplication), and achievements would form cause or result clauses with respect to the main predicate, another form of secondary predication in a certain sense (for some orientation on the topic of causal and purpose adverbial clauses, see Larson 2004, 10-12; Sawada and Larson 2004).

Why this might be the case can be clarified to some degree by looking at the behavior of achievement predicates in the unmarked or "present" tense in English: due to the fact that achievements lack duration of any kind, ambiguous forms in English are regularly interpreted so as to refer to either past or future events.

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(32) a. Becky won the poker game in half an hour.

b. %Becky wins the poker game in half a hour.

c. Becky will win the poker game in half an hour.

(33) a. Susan noticed the suitcase in 5 minutes.

b. %Susan notices the suitcase in 5 minutes.

c. Susan will notice the suitcase in 5 minutes.

In both (32) and (33), each of the three English tenses are exemplified, but the present tense form in each example, (32b) and (33b) respectively, is not particularly felicitous in pragmatic terms, yielding either a curious historical present or a kind of apodictic promise about future events. These two—otherwise quite anomalous—readings correspond quite precisely, in my view, to the type of cause and purpose adverbial meanings associated with reduplicated $BNBV_{inal}$ forms mentioned earlier in this section. As secondary/adverbial predicates go, this makes a certain amount of sense: (a) activity predicates which are inherently durational but lack an endpoint correspond to depictive secondary predicates that hold throughout the duration of the main predicate, (b) accomplishments, which have both duration and an endpoint, correspond to resultative secondary predicates in that the durative part of the accomplishment limits the temporal span of the secondary predicate to the same span as the main predicate, while the endpoint further limits the duration of the secondary predicate to the final state of the main predicate, but (c) achievement predicates lack the cumulative duration of the

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accomplishment, so as secondary predicates they can refer to events that occur outside the temporal constraints of the main predicate, but still relate to the final state of the main predicate.

(34) a. Joan washed the car drunk.

b. Joan washed the car clean.

c. (The car was really dirty.) Joan washed the car therefore

= "Joan washed the car, because it was dirty.

The first two examples in (34) are examples of depictive (34a) and resultative (34b) secondary predicates, whereas in (34c), the sentence-final form "therefore" corresponds in certain aspects to the interpretation of achievement secondary predicates that I propose above in that "therefore" occupies the same position that depictive and resultative secondary predicates occupy (although it can of course occur elsewhere), but refers to a prior sentence in the discourse and identifies it as the cause of the clause in which "therefore" occurs.

I would expect that the Akkadian parallel to these kinds of secondary/adverbial achievement predicates would be forms in either the Gt-stem or G-stem perfects, which often occur in the apodoses of legal texts, for example, and thanks to Streck (2003, 98), we have a good list of cases in which a Gt-stem in Akkadian parallels a reduplicated verbal form in Sumerian, so I turn initially to Gt-stems and afterward to G-stem perfects. Streck identifies sixteen cases of Akkadian Gt-stems that correspond to reduplicated

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forms in Sumerian (the forms in parentheses are the corresponding reduplicated Sumerian forms cited in either the standard dictionaries or Streck 2003; the number in brackets that follows each lexeme refers to the number assigned to the lexeme in Streck 2003): *itkupu* (a.gi$_6$ mu.un.du$_7$.du$_7$) [5], *mitḫuṣu* [8], *mitguru* (še.še.ga) [20], *atkulu* (cf. participle su.bi in.gu$_7$.gu$_7$!) [26], *ritkubu* (šed$_3$.šed$_3$) [37], *šitruṣu* (šu sa$_2$.sa$_2$) [40 (mistakenly listed as *itruṣu* on page 98)], *tiṣbutu* (sa ḫir.ḫir^{ir}) [41], *atwû* (du.ud.du // du$_{12}$.du$_{12}$, di.di, bala.bala) [43], *mitluku* (ad ba.ni.ib.gi$_4$.gi$_4$, cf. Gtn-stem mu.un.da.ab.sig$_3$.sig$_3$) [44], *ritḫuṣu* (giri$_3$ te.te) [62], *ḫitbuṣu* (si.suḫ.bi ma.az.ma.az) [114], *ḫitmuṭu* (ul$_4$ sa$_2$.sa$_2$) [116], *šitpû* (perhaps šu du$_7$.du$_7$ although not attested, cf. Gtn-stem e.da.an.gub.gub.ba) [129], *itḫusu* (ir$_2$.ra im.mi.in.še$_8$.še$_8$ // *ibakki it-ḫu-sa*) [134], *etpušu* (perhaps ka du$_3$.du$_3$, but again not attested) [142], and *k/ḫitruṣu* (kid$_x$.kid$_x$ [NUN.NUN], kid$_6$.kid$_6$ [KAD$_5$.KAD$_5$]) [175].

Streck characterizes the Gt-stem verbs that parallel Sumerian reduplications, in particular, as "intensive" without much further in the way of interpretation (Streck 2003, 98-99, cf. 110), but many of semantic fields identified by Streck in relation to Gt-stems in Akkadian correspond in a very general way to the semantic field of the BNBV$_{inal}$ class. But it should be noted that (a) no members of the BNBV$_{inal}$ class appear in parallel with Gt-stem verbs in Akkadian, (b) the Gt-stem reduplications identified by Streck never occur with the *bi-√ prefix, and (c) the semantics of the examples cited by Streck is by and large depictive or resultative. It is possible, of course, that adverbial clauses of cause or purpose are hiding in Streck's "intensive" category, but if so I have not been able to identify sufficient context for the Gt-stem reduplications to characterize them as such. My suspicion is that reduplicated BNBV$_{inal}$ predicates (and perhaps reduplicated verbs

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bearing the *bi-√ prefix generally) do correspond to certain discursive functions of G-stem perfect verbs in Akkadian. Streck identifies three primary functions of *iptaras*, the Akkadian perfect: (a) "it designates anteriority in the future in main clauses, subordinate clauses and conditional clauses," (b) it is used "to express the temporal progress in main clauses, subordinate clauses and conditional clauses," and (c) to refer to "the isolated past in main clauses of direct speech" (a usage that Streck limits the letters of Hammurapi [Streck 1998, 190; cf. 1999, 103]). Streck draws a parallel between the first of these uses and the Sumerian prospective, illustrating the usage (also found in Codex Ur-Namma §§13f and Codex Lipit-Ištar §§11, 14, 20b, 30, 32a) with Codex Lipit-Ištar §14.

(35) Codex Lipit-Ištar §14

tukum.bi ir_{11} lu_2.ke_4 lugal.a.ni.ir nam.ir_{11}.da.ni ba.an.da.gur lugal.a.ni.ir nam.ir_{11}.da.ni a.ra_2 2(diš).am_3 **un.ge.en** ir_{11}.bi al.bur_2.e

If a man's slave has contested his slave status against his master, and ***it has been proven*** *that his master has been compensated for his slavery two-fold, that slave shall be free.*

which Streck compares to §196 from Codex Hammurapi (Streck 1998, 190):

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(36) Codex Hammurapi §196

šumma awīlum īn mār awīlim uḫtappid īnšu uḫappadū

If a man (will have blinded =) has blinded the eye of another man, they shall blind his eye.

The third type mentioned by Streck only occurs in the letters of Hammurapi and need not concern us here (see Streck 1999, 113-115, where a number of examples are presented).

The second type of Akkadian perfect, however, what Streck describes as "*zeitlicher Progreß der Vorzeitigkeit*" or "temporal progress,"[19] bears a strong resemblance to my proposal that the reduplication of a Sumerian achievement verb in *bi-√ yields an adverbial clause of cause or result. In characterizing a corpus of "temporal progress" examples drawn from the letters of Hammurapi, Streck writes as follows:

> Temporal progress of anteriority (= *zeitlicher Progreß der Vorzeitigkeit*) is characterized by the sequence *iprus* + discourse particle + *iptaras*, whereby the number of *iprus*-elements as well as the number of *iptaras*-elements varies. The situations represented by *iprus* and *iptaras* are separated from one another temporally: in temporal terms, *iptaras* follows *iprus* and is thereby posterior to it. The progress is linked to neither a specific tense, nor a clause-level syntactic construction type: present and future tense examples are attested. In terms of clause-level syntactic construction type, only occurrences in main clauses are to be found in the following corpus, but attestations from outside the corpus show that the *iptaras*

[19] This may be equivalent to the traditional notion of *consecutio temporum* but I have not attempted to ascertain whether Streck equates the terms in his writings.

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denoting progress also occurs in subordinate clauses and in conditional sentences that begin with *šumma*. The particle *-ma* functions as the discourse particle marking temporal progress in 20 cases, *u* in one case and *inanna* in three cases. We translate *-ma* and *u* with "(and) then," "and (after that)," and with a contrastive nuance as "(since) however," "then, however," "but later." We translate *inanna* with "now" (Streck 1999, 108).

As examples of Streck's *temporal progress*, I offer here the following two examples (equivalent to Streck 1999, 109, ex. 53 and 55):

(37) AbB 4, 94: 12-14

eqlam ... aḫḫī abīja imkusū-ma ⌜ŠE⌝*-am itbalū*

My uncles have gathered up (the taxes on) the field, and then taken the grain for themselves.

(38) AbB 4, 16: 8-11

Š eqel bīt abīja īkamanni-ma ana rēdîm ittadin

Š. has taken a field that belongs to the household of my father away from me, and then given it to a soldier.

The glosses in (37) and (38) are rough translations of Streck's own, but if I had my preference, I would rather translate many of Streck's examples of "temporal progress" as result clauses as in (39) and (40), which repeat (37) and (38).

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(39) AbB 4, 94: 12-14

eqlam ... aḫḫī abīja imkusū-ma ⌜ŠE⌝*-am itbalū*

My uncles have gathered up (the taxes on) the field, so that they can take it for themselves.

(40) AbB 4, 16: 8-11

Š eqel bīt abīja īkamanni-ma ana rēdîm ittadin

Š. has taken a field that belongs to the household of my father away from me, so that he can give it to a soldier.

Akkadian *iptaras* forms, therefore, seem to function along the lines of injunctives elsewhere in Akkadian (as well as other relatively old Semitic languages). Injunction sequences expressing result or purpose, likewise, make use of the particle *-ma*, yielding sequences such as the following (after Huehnergard 2000, 147).

(41) *kaspam šuāti piqdam-ma ekallam lūpul-ma bītī lā iṣabbatū*

Provide me with the aforementioned silver, so that I can pay the palace, so that they do not seize my estate.

As Huehnergard describes the phenomenon:

In a sequence of two or more clauses in which the first verb is an injunctive form, i.e., an Imperative, a Precative, a Prohibitive, or a Vetitive, and the following verb or

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verbs are also injunctive forms, and the verbs are connected either by -ma or, less often, asyndetically . . ., the second and following clauses are often to be translated as purpose clauses (i.e., 'so that', 'in order that', 'that'). (Huehnergard 2000, 147)

But I would differentiate purpose clauses, which are regularly indicated in Akkadian by the preposition *ana* + infinitive, from causal and result clauses. The traditional description of linked non-indicative clauses, as rehearsed by Huehnergard above, does use terms such as "purpose clause," but it would be far better to characterize the relation as a causal one: "A causes B" or "B results from A" without any imposition of intentionality (or the deontic modality associated with it). Clearly the causal relation between a series of events ("A, so B, so C") is independent of the deontic modality coded by what are traditionally called moods such as "precative" or "imperative." I would argue that the indicative form of a causal sequence in Akkadian (the unmarked term within the system of deontic modality) is represented by *iptaras*, the Akkadian "perfect," in sequential forms.[20]

Bearing this correlation in mind, I would like to propose that the Akkadian form that should correspond to reduplicated achievement predicates in Sumerian is the *iptaras* form in its cause or result functions. Such a correspondence would yield a rather elegant system of secondary or adverbial reduplication in Sumerian: (a) reduplicated activity predicates (Gtn-stem reduplications) would be similar to depictive secondary predicates, (b) reduplicated achievement predicates (*iptaras* reduplications) would correspond to

[20] The form corresponding to iptaras + ma in other older Semitic languages is clearly the use of wa- in both Eblaite and Northwest Semitic; whether /ma/ and /wa/ are to be equated remains unclear to me, but it is certainly a possibility that deserves further investigation. Particularly interesting in this regard is the apparent variation in Eblaite texts between the use of WA and U_3 as clause-initial connectors.

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either causal or result clauses depending on the aspectual contexts in which they occur, and (c) reduplicated accomplishments (D-stem reduplication) would be analogous to resultative secondary predicates. Since both activities and accomplishments are thought to include a [+ stages] feature (in Rothstein's decomposition, see section 2.1 above), which allows them to freely occur in the progressive/imperfective aspect, when used as a secondary or adverbial predicate (perhaps better termed a backgrounding function), activities and accomplishments provide a durational extension within which the event referred to by the main predicate can take place. But achievements lack the [+ stages] feature and provide no such durational extension within which the main predication can take place. The resultative semantics, however, which originate from the telic point in the secondary predicate, remain in force even through the secondary predicate fails to provide a durational extension for the main predicate, yielding a resultative that, in temporal terms, either precedes the main predicate or follows it: preceding *iptaras*-reduplication resultatives could then be translated with "since" or "because" whereas following *iptaras*-reduplication resultatives would be translated as result or even, somewhat loosely, as purpose clauses such as "so that" or "in order to."

Other than the relatively few examples cited above from monolingual sources, I have not attempted to test the *iptaras*-reduplication hypothesis further. Bilingual examples are non-existent in *The Return of Ninurta to Nippur* (Cooper 1978), but there are a couple achievement reduplications bearing the *bi-√ prefix and paralleled by Akkadian *iptaras* verbs to be found in *The Exploits of Ninurta.*

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(42) The Exploits of Ninurta [1.6.2], l. 184 (van Dijk 1983, vol. 2, 78)

A_1 ^{d}a.nun.na.ke$_4$.ne e$_2$.gar$_8$.e ba.ab.ḫa.ḫa.za

B_2 [...] nun.na.ke$_4$.ne e$_2$.⌜gar$_8$⌝ [...]

K_4 ^{d}a.nun.na.ke$_4$ e$_2$.gar$_8$.e ⌜ba⌝ [...]

w **[...] ra bi$_2$.in.ḫa.ḫa.za**

[... *i-ga-ra*]-*ti i-taḫ-zu*

x **^{d}a.nun.na.ke$_4$.e.ne e$_2$.gar$_8$.ra bi$_2$.ib.ḫa.ḫa.za**

^{d}*a-nun-na-ki i-ga-ra-a-ti i-taḫ-za*

n_2 ^{d}a.[nun].na.ke$_4$.e.ne e$_2$ [...]

^{d}*a-nun-*[*na*]-⌜*ki*⌝ *i-ga-ra-a-*⌜*ti*⌝ [...]

In (42), although the Old Babylonian sources that preserve the relevant part of the line (A_1 and K_4) both have a *ba-√ prefix verb, the two first millennium sources (w and x) use the *bi-√ prefix and translate the verb with an *iptaras* form. The reason for the first millennium innovation is apparent from the context of line 184.

(43) The Exploits of Ninurta [1.6.2], ll. 182-186

182. an ib$_2$.dub$_2$ ba.tuš ša$_3$	*An was overwhelmed, crouched, pounded*
šu ba.ši.ib.ri	*his hands against his stomach,*
183. ^{d}en.lil$_2$ ib$_2$.ur$_4$.ur$_4$ da.še$_3$	*Enlil groaned and threw himself in a corner,*
im.ši.ib.ri	
184. ^{d}a.nun.na.ke$_4$.ne e$_2$.g̃ar$_8$.e	*The Anuna flattened themselves against*
ba.ab.ḫa.ḫa.za	*walls,*

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185. tu^{mušen}.gin$_7$ e$_2$ ni$_2$.te.ta gu$_3$ im.ma.ni.ib$_2$.be$_2$ — *The house was full of fearful sighing as of pigeons,*

186. kur gal ^{d}en.lil$_2$.le ^{d}nin.lil$_2$.ra gu$_3$ mu.na.de$_2$.e — *The great mountain Enlil was crying to Ninlil,*

Whereas the Old Babylonian form of line 184 simply portrays it as one among a number of events in lines 182-185 that were not sequential, the first millennium redactor posits a causal relation between Enlil's groaning in line 183 and the disappearance of the Anuna in line 184. Because line 184 has been reinterpreted as a result clause, its prefix seems to have been "corrected" to the *bi-√ prefix. If we were to privilege the first millennium version, an appropriate translation might be something like "Enlil groaned and hid himself, and because of this, the Anuna flattened themselves against the walls."

(44) The Exploits of Ninurta (1.6.2), line 350 (van Dijk 1983, vol. 2, 101)

H dungu diri.ga [...] a$_2$ bi$_2$.in [...]

F$_1$ dungu diri.ga.gin$_7$ a$_2$ bi$_2$.⌈in.su$_3$⌉.su$_3$.ud

H$_1$ dungu diri.ga.gin$_7$ a$_2$ bi$_2$.in.su$_3$.su$_3$.ud$^{!}$(E)

I$_1$ dungu diri.ga.gin$_7$ a$_2^{!}$ bi$_2$.⌈in⌉ [...]

J$_1$ dungu diri.ga.⌈gin$_7$⌉ [...]

K$_1$ ⌈dungu⌉ diri.ga.gin$_7$ a$_2$ ⌈bi$_2$⌉.in.su$_3$.⌈su$_3$⌉ [...]

L$_1$ dungu [...]

b$_1$ [dungu diri].ga.gin$_7$ ni$_2$.bi mu.un.su$_3$

⌈*ki*⌉-*ma* ⌈*er-pe*⌉-*e-ti muq-qal-pi-ti ina ram-ni-šu$_2$ i-šad-di-ḫu*

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The example in (44) was presented in abbreviated form above. As noted earlier, the sources that preserve the full form of the verb (F_1 and H_1) are evenly split in a sense: F_1 preserves the form **a_2 bi_2.in.su_3.su_3.ud** (the variant used by ETCSL), while H_1 preserves the form **a_2 bi_2.in.su_3.su_3.e** (the variant used in Karahashi 2000, 78). Although the Akkadian translation of this line translates a different Sumerian predicate, **ni_2.bi mu.un.su_3**, and is not, therefore, of probative value in analyzing the *bi-√ prefix verb in question, the previous example can be taken as a model in favor of reduplication and the form in H_1 emended to **a_2 bi_2.in.su_3.su_3.ud**(E).

(45) The Exploits of Ninurta [1.6.2], ll. 348-352

348. ^{d}nin.urta dumu ^{d}en.lil_2.la_2.ke_4	*Ninurta, the son of Enlil, wanted to do*
gal.bi i_3.ĝa_2.ĝa_2	*something big,*
349. gu.ru.um na_4 kur.ra mi.ni.in.ak	*As for the pile of stones that he accumulated*
	in the mountains,
350. dungu diri.ga.gin_7	*Because they were spread all over like*
a_2 bi_2.in.su_3.su_3.ud	*drifting clouds,*
351. bad_3 maḫ.gin_7 kalam.ma	*They blocked the view of the land like a*
igi.ba bi_2.in.tab.⌜ba⌝	*huge wall,*
352. ^{giš}bala ki.šar_2.ra mu.ni.in.ĝar	*He installed a spigot (?) on the horizon,*

The reduplicated *bi-√ prefix verb in line 350 takes **gu.ru.um na_4** "a pile of stones" as its subject and describes the result of Ninurta's activities, perhaps best translated using a

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result clause: "He made a pile of stones in the mountains, so that/with the result that it stretched across the mountains like floating clouds, like a huge wall . . . ."

Overall, therefore, the best candidate for the *tertium quid* mentioned at the beginning of the section is an interpretation of reduplicated $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates as adverbial clauses of cause or result. The evidence is quite slim, but what little evidence does exist seems to point in that direction. Other possibilities certainly exist, however: I suspect that future work on quantification and/or the mass/count noun opposition in Sumerian may ultimately yield a more conclusive result. Of the four lexical aspectual types identified at the beginning of the chapter, three seem to determine the interpretation of the adjectival/adverbial constructions found in *ḫamṭu* reduplication: activities (Gtn-stem depictive secondary predicates), achievements (*iptaras*-stem causal secondary predicates) and accomplishments (D-stem resultative secondary predicates). In the previous section, I argued that certain subsets of adjectival roots were formed through verbal reduplication in earlier historical phases of the language and, furthermore, that in the period represented by the text-artifactual record or just before, the formation of adjectival roots through reduplication yielded a number of distinct semantic classes, but primarily a diminutive semantics as also seen in Mandarin Chinese. Whether the diminutive/delimitative lexical aspectual class as evidenced in Mandarin exists in Sumerian, remains an open question. But it seems fairly clear that *ḫamṭu* reduplication can be associated with adjectival/adverbial formation at all levels of the grammar; the particular grammatical effects of such adjectival/adverbial formations remain, however, to be worked out in future studies.

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The last area of lexical aspectual concern is the ± agentive feature. Recently, Rothstein has argued that achievement predicates in the progressive/imperfective aspect exhibit a number of special characteristics, notably the absence of an agentive thematic role. The following section investigates whether or not this is the case in Sumerian.

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2.4 The curious morphosyntax of progressive achievements

Although lexical and grammatical aspect show various kinds of interaction, one of the more dramatic is actually negative in form: achievement predicates such as the members of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class do not usually occur in the progressive/imperfective aspect. As already noted above, what is generally termed the "progressive" aspect in disciplinary semantics is presumably equivalent to the "imperfective" (*marû*) aspect in Sumerian and in the following sections, as above, "progressive/imperfective" should be considered a cover term for "progressive" and "imperfective."[21] Rothstein identifies the basic incompatibility of achievements and progressive/imperfective aspect as follows:

> Since achievement verbs denote eventuality types which are near instantaneous and which are over as soon as they have begun, they ought to be incompatible with the progressive mode which asserts that an event is 'in progress,' and which we expect to be restricted to activities and accomplishments. (Rothstein 2004, 36)

But the curious thing about achievement predicates is that they do at times occur in the imperfective (Rothstein 2004, 23-24). This section presents the $BNBV_{inal}$ class as prototypical exemplars of the achievement lexical aspectual class, argues that they do not regularly occur in the progressive/imperfective (*marû*) aspect, and ends with a few suggestions as to further possible evidence having to do with the case-marking and non-agentivity of their subjects.

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[21] Strictly speaking, the marked category in the Sumerian grammatical aspectual system is the imperfective (*marû*) and in accord with convention should be described with a positive descriptor such as "progressive" or "continuative" (I prefer the latter). Since markedness is privative and not equipollent (Agha 1993, 132-133), the unmarked term in the system (*ḫamṭu*) would then be described as non-progressive or non-continuative. But I worry that changing established terminology on the basis of non-Assyriological convention (which is not consistently followed even in disciplinary linguistics) would only multiply terms and confuse matters, so I have retained the traditional terminology in part.

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As an example of the restriction on progressive/imperfective aspect, I turn initially to the following two examples (after Rothstein 2004, 36, ex. 1a and 1b).

(46) a. Jane reached the summit of the mountain.

b. Jane is reaching the summit of the mountain.

(47) a. Mary spotted her friend at the party.

b. Mary is spotting her friend at the party.

In each pair of examples, the first sentence, (46a) and (47a) respectively, is a perfective achievement predicate in the past tense, whereas the second sentence in each pair, (46b) and (47b) respectively, is a progressive/imperfective achievement in the present tense. The sentences in (46b) and (47b) are much less "natural" and force the rather curious impression that one is watching a film of Jane or Mary with a running narration (Rothstein 2004, 56-57). Rothstein notes that "[t]hese are what have been called 'slow-motion' or 'film-strip' readings, first noticed by Sandro Zucchi, where a normally instantaneous event is perceived as being 'stretched' over time" (Rothstein 2004, 37, presumably referring to Zucchi 1999). Much of the peculiar semantics of these kinds of examples follows from the rather unusual relation that exists between spectator and narrated events (Lee 1997, 344). While so-called explicit primary performatives also (a) resist occurring in the progressive/imperfective aspect, (b) yield a spectator effect, and (c) regularly occur with the *bi-√ prefix due to its use with direct speech, although *verba*

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dicendi do not appear to belong to the $BNBV_{inal}$ class. To my knowledge, this kind of slow-motion interpretation of progressive/imperfective achievements (the only interpretation available for prototypical achievements like "notice" and "spot") does not exist in the Sumerian text-artifactual record.

On the basis of both the rather indirect and weak evidence of causal and result clauses in the previous section and the general semantic cast of the members of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class, I would hypothesize that the remaining members of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class are prototypical achievements and that they should not occur in the progressive/imperfective (*marû*) aspect except under rather unusual circumstances. Somewhat less prototypical achievement such as "to die" and "to find," regularly occur in the progressive/imperfective without the "film commentary" interpretation as in the following examples (after Rothstein 2004, 36, ex. 2b and 2d).

(48) a. The cat is dying.

b. Dafna is finding her shoes.

But non-prototypical achievements such as (48a) and (48b) do not occur in the $BNBV_{inal}$ class, although some of them do occur with the *bi-√ prefix. On the whole, $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates do not in fact seem to occur in the progressive/imperfective aspect at all: (a) the one $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate with a suppletive *marû* root (zu_2-√gub) never suppletes, (b) all $BNBV_{inal}$ reduplications can be interpreted as *ḫamṭu* reduplications, and (c) I demonstrate in the following section that the relatively few $BNBV_{inal}$ roots which are occasionally

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followed by *-e (which could be an indication of progressive/imperfective aspect) are all to be interpreted as examples of the ergative or locative-terminative postposition following an indefinite relative construction. Although this is essentially negative evidence, the absence of progressive/imperfective achievements (or at least their restriction to highly exceptional contexts) is probably the best evidence available for the classification of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates as achievements.

Given the frequent use of metaphors that draw on imagery from the natural world (see Black 1998 for background, cf. Heimpel 1968) both in Sumerian literature in general as well as in the epic tale *Gilgamesh and Huwawa* in particular, the assertion in line 103 from Gilgamesh and Huwawa, version A, that Huwawa's brow devours reed-beds (according to the ETCSL translation) is surely a little bit odd. In the following, I break with my own convention and repeat the ETCSL translation verbatim.

(49) Gilgamesh and Huwawa, version A [1.8.1.5], ll. 100-104 (Edzard 1991, 200-201 [equivalent to lines 99-103 in Edzard's edition])

100. ur.saĝ ka.ka.ni ka ušumgal.la.kam	*His pugnacious mouth is a dragon's maw,*
101. igi.ni igi pirig̃.g̃a$_2$.kam	*His face is a lion's grimace,*
102. G̃IŠ.GABA.a.ni a.g̃i$_6$ du$_7$.du$_7$.dam	*His chest is like a raging flood,*

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103. **saĝ.ki.ni ĝiš.gi bi$_2$.gu$_7$.a** lu$_2$	*No one dare approach his brow, which*
nu.mu.da.te.ĝe$_{26}$.e.dam	*devours the reed-beds,*
(var. nu.mu.un.da.kar.re.de$_3$)[22]	
104. lugal.ĝu$_{10}$ za.e kur.še$_3$ u$_5$.a ĝa$_2$.e	*Travel on, my master, up into the*
iri^{ki}.še$_3$ ga.u$_5$	*mountains!—but I shall travel back to*
	the city,

The fact that **ĝiš.gi** "reed-bed" is in the absolutive case has led previous translators to interpret it as the patient of the verb √**gu$_7$** "to eat." Why, however, the brow of a forest guardian would be expected to devour reed-beds and why such an image would strike fear into the heart of a listener (as it was clearly intended to do) is beyond me: I would rather propose that the particular syntactic configuration of a bare noun followed by the *bi-√ prefix, where no pronominal agreement morpheme such as *-n- or *-b- occurs before the verbal root, be seen as an indefinite relative construction. In this case, the construction is particularly clear in that the head of the indefinite relative is set apart from the topic of the line through the use of the possessive pronoun topic-marking construction and the indefinite relative offers an elaboration as to "why no man dares to approach it." At the discursive level, this particular configuration of topic-marked phase followed by a parenthetical comment in apposition to the topical noun, forms a tripartite rhetorical structure as in (50) that will reappear in a slightly altered guise in chapter 4.

[22] The variant probably arises from the fact that **te.ĝe$_{26}$**, the *marû* form of the root √te(ĝ), is written TE.ĜA$_2$ and if it was misunderstood as a nominalized verbal root such as **te.ĝa$_2$**, it might, at some point in its transmission, have been written **te.a**. TE.A could have then been misunderstood as a *diri* writing for the verbal root √kar followed, as in the original, by the *-ed suffix, yielding **kar.re.de$_3$**. Since version B, in example (56) below, has a non-finite verbal form, **te.ĝe$_{26}$.dam**, the misinterpretation could easily have arisen on the basis of the several possible interpretations of TE ĜA$_2$ DAM.

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(50) [$_{\text{Topic}}$ *saĝ.ki.ni* [$_{\text{Apposition}}$ **ĝiš.gi bi$_2$.gu$_7$.a**]] [$_{\text{Comment}}$ lu$_2$ nu mu.da.te.ĝe$_{26}$.e.dam]

As for his brow, a devouring reed-bed, no ones dares to approach it,

But how does my suggestion that **ĝiš.gi bi$_2$.gu$_7$.a** forms an indefinite relative clause speak to the broader question of whether or not BNBV$_{\text{inal}}$ predicates occur in the progressive/imperfective aspect? First of all, although homophonous with the relative marker, the *-a suffix that follows **bi$_2$.gu$_7$** (the predicate inside the indefinite relative construction) is probably *not* a relative marker, but rather the locative postposition that so often can be found following an inanimate noun. This is demonstrated—or at least suggested—by the fact that the same line in version B of the same composition shows the locative-terminative postposition rather than the locative.

(51) Gilgamesh and Huwawa, version B [1.8.1.5.1], l. 93

saĝ.ki.ni ĝiš.gi bi$_2$.gu$_7$.e lu$_2$ nu te.ĝe$_{26}$.dam

As for his brow, a devouring reed-bed, no one approaches it,

The alternation between locative and locative-terminative postposition is indicative of an ambiguity inherent in the metaphor introduced by the indefinite relative: since the conservatism of Old Babylonian redactors would never have allowed the removal of **mu.da** if the trajectory were from **mu.da.√te.ĝe$_{26}$.e.dam** to **te.ĝe$_{26}$.dam**, what we must take as the original form of the line in (51) preserves the locative-terminative postposition following **bi$_2$.gu$_7$**. We might expect a locative-terminative in such a construction with a

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discrete, bounded entity such as the brow of Huwawa, whereas the locative in version A would be more appropriate to a relatively unbounded entity such as a bed of reeds: ultimately the shift in verbal form from **te.g̃e$_{26}$.dam** to **mu.da.te.g̃e$_{26}$.e.dam** may well have resulted from the shift in nominal postposition from locative-terminative to locative. Since the change in nominal postposition results from the ambiguity inherent in the metaphor, namely "his brow is a reed-bed," both **sag̃.ki.ni** and **g̃iš.gi** presumably refer to the same entity. More importantly, the alternation between locative and locative-terminative shows that the /-a/ in version A is not a relative marker (it would be surprising if *indefinite* relative clauses made use of an explicit relative marker, cf. Old Babylonian indefinite relatives in *warad iḫliqu* "an escaped slave" (Huehnergard 2000, 188, cf. Kienast 2001, 447) and the non-specific "indefinite" Middle Egyptian relative in *gmj.n=j ḫf3w pw jw=f m jj.t* "I found that it was a serpent which was coming" (Sh.S 61-62; Loprieno 1995, 158). Since the marker, whether locative or locative-terminative, is simply a nominal postposition, the form **bi$_2$.gu$_7$.e** cannot be a progressive/imperfective (*marû*) verbal form.

Further examples of the indefinite relative are somewhat more difficult to identify but they are regularly found in a rhetorical device in which an indefinite relative is followed by a definite noun having the same referent as in the following two examples.

(52) A tigi to Enki for Ur-Ninurta (Ur-Ninurta B) [2.5.6.2], ll. 25-28

25. en maḫ an ki.a za$_3$ bi$_2$.dib mu.zu	*August lord, you excel in heaven and earth,*
pa bi$_2$.e$_3$	*your name shines forth,*

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26. ^{d}en.ki me a.na ĝal$_2$.la mu.u$_8$.ur$_4$.ur$_4$	*Enki, you gathered up all the divine powers,*
abzu.še$_3$ mu.u$_8$.ĝar	*lit., whatever (of them) existed, and stored them in the abzu,*
27. **ki.tuš ku$_3$ ša$_3$.ge bi$_2$.pa$_3$.da.zu**	*Your holy dwelling, chosen by heart,*
abzu eš$_3$ maḫ-a x x	*the abzu, the august shrine ...,*
28. me.bi me.a diri ĝiš.ḫur.bi a.re.eš	*As for the plans of these Me, which exceed*
gub.ba me.en	*all others, you have made them praiseworthy,*

Although the interpretation of *-a as either a genitive or locative remains somewhat unclear in this example, its translation is fairly clear: "of/with regard to a holy place favored by you." In the following example, the role of the nominal postposition is somewhat clearer.

(53) A balbale to Inanna and Dumuzi [2.08.a]

30. **lugal ša$_3$.ge bi$_2$.pa$_3$.da.zu**	*For your king, chosen by heart,*
31. ^{d}dumu.zi dumu $^{d\lceil}$en.lil$_2^{\rceil}$.ra	*Dumuzi, the son of Enlil,*
32. e$_2$.tur$_3$.e i$_3$ ga ḫe$_2$.en.da.ab.be$_2$	*May the cattle-pen produce ghee and cheese,*

Here the familiar pattern of an indefinite descriptor followed by a personal name is repeated. The English translation is somewhat misleading and a more literal if somewhat stilted translation might be as follows: "a king, your favorite one, (namely) Dumuzi, the

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son of Enlil, for him, ...," where the gradually increasing referential specificity and the application of the benefactive postposition to the most referentially specific phrase **^{d}dumu.zi dumu ^{d}en.lil$_2$** is much more felicitous in pragmatic terms than the translation offered in (53). The indefinite relative also serves as a basis for the relative/ circumstantial construction (for further details, see below, section 3.3).

If we broaden, for a moment, the area of investigation to include achievements in general (not limited to $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates), other somewhat less prototypical achievement predicates do allow the formation of the progressive/imperfective and I turn to these examples at this point so as to illustrate some directions for future research. The classic example of a progressive/imperfective achievement is its use with an intransitive verb of motion to provide background information for some other event as in the following example.

(54) Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta [1.8.2.3], ll. 163-167

(Cohen 1973, 71, 98, 120, 175-177; Vanstiphout 2003)

163. inim gal ^{d}inanna gi zu_2.lum.ma	*Where will he carry such an important*
DU me.a mu.na.ab.tum_3	*sharply-intoned message from Inanna?*
164. ḫur.sağ zubi.še_3 bi$_2$.in.e$_{11}$.de$_3$	*As he was bringing it up the Zubi*
	Mountains,
165. ḫur.sağ zubi.ta	*As he was bringing it down from the Zubi*
im.ma.da.ra.ab.e$_{11}$.de$_3$	*Mountains,*
166. susin^{ki}.e kur an.ša_4.an^{ki}.a.še_3	*From Susa to the land of Anshan,*

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167. $peš_2$ tur.$ginˌ_7$ $kiri_3$	*Everyone prostrated themselves before*
šu mu.na.ab.$ğal_2$	*it/him like tiny mice,*

This is the last of three examples involving the verb $√e_{11}$**(d)** "to go up/down," here in a causative *bi-√ verb construction with **inim gal** as causee: lines 164 and 165 provide background information for the main assertion that "from Susa to Anshan, everyone prostrated themselves (before it/him) ...." The three repetitions in Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta differ in certain ways, but crucially not in the form of the verb **bi_2.in.e_{11}.de_3**.

(55) Enmerkar and the Lord of Arattta [1.8.2.3], ll. 73 // 108 // 164

73.	ḫur.sağ	zubi.$še_3$	ḫe_2 bi$_2$.in.e_{11}.de_3	3° precative
108.	ḫur.sağ	zubi.ka	ḫe_2 bi$_2$.in.e_{11}.de_3.en	2° precative
164.	ḫur.sağ	zubi.$še_3$	Ø bi$_2$.in.e_{11}.de_3	3° indicative

(56) Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta [1.8.2.3], ll. 74 // 109 // 165

74.	ḫur.sağ	zubi.ta	ḫe_2 im.ma.da.ra.e_{11}.de_3	3° precative
109.	ḫur.sağ	zubi.ta	ḫe_2 ⌜im⌝.ma.da.ra.an.e_{11}.de_3.en	2° precative
165.	ḫur.sağ	zubi.ta	Ø im.ma.da.ra.ab.e_{11}.de_3	3° indicative

There are two types of variation in the three occurrences of each of these two lines: (a) the relatively minor alternation between **zubi.$še_3$** and **zubi.ka** in line 108 and (b) a fascinating opposition between the pronominal agreement marker immediately before the verbal root, which remains consistently *-n- in the progressive/imperfective

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achievements in lines 73, 108, and 164, but changes in each occurrence of the progressive/imperfective activity predicates in lines 74, 109, and 165. Since all six lines provide background information in each of the three passages, it makes good sense that they all remain consistently in the progressive/imperfective (*marû*) aspect in each case. With the exception of the second person singular copula in line 108, "let it be you who ...," the precative/future forms of **bi$_2$.in.e$_{11}$.de$_3$** differ from the indicative form only in the addition of the modal **he$_2$**. This is in stark contrast to the quite systematic variation in the pronominal agreement marker (*-Ø-, *-n-, *-b-) in each of the three examples of the progressive/imperfective *activity*: **ḫe$_2$.em.ma.da.ra.e$_{11}$.de$_3$**, **ḫe$_2$.em.ma.da.ra.an.e$_{11}$.de$_3$**, and **im.ma.da.ra.ab.e$_{11}$.de$_3$** in lines 74, 109, and 165 respectively.

However we choose to interpret the pronominal agreement morphology that immediately precedes the verbal root in these examples (for the standard theory, see Michalowski 1980a; cf. Woods 2001, 263-285), one conclusion is unavoidable: whereas the agreement in the *activity* predicates in lines 74, 109, and 165 is clearly affected by person (second in 109, third in 74 and 165) and modality (precative in 74 and 109, indicative in 165), the agreement morphology of the progressive/imperfective *achievements* remains completely unaffected by these changes in person and modality. This indifference to modality and person results, in my view, from the fact that the progressive/imperfective achievements in lines 73, 108 and 164 are non-agentive and, since they are non-agentive, the expected alternation between ergative animate *-n- in the perfective and accusative inanimate *-b- in the progressive/imperfective (at least in the

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context available in these three passages) is not available.[23] Since the standard models of agreement do not work particularly well when it comes to *bi-√ prefix predicates, I will not hazard a guess (at least at this point) as to what phenomenon underlies the pervasive use of *-n- in these constructions. Nonetheless, the invariance of *-n- in the achievements does conforms quite well to Rothstein's characterization of achievements as non-agentive (Rothstein 2004, 138, ex. 38), since one might expect an agentive verbal form to vary in pronominal agreement according to grammatical aspect, as is regularly postulated for Sumerian agreement patterns in general.

(57) a. Mary reached the summit of the mountain unconscious and on a stretcher.

b. The supplies reached the summit of the mountain by helicopter.

As these two examples makes clear, the theme of an achievement need not show any agentivity whatsoever. This fits well with the fact that $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates are achievements in that the theme of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates is the nominal component of the compound verb, while the ergative case-marked nominal is its inalienable possessor, rather than its ergative agent. As I argued at the end of chapter 1, the ergative case-marking in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions indicates that the ergative case-marked nominal is the inalienable possessor of the body-part noun that forms the nominal component of the

[23] There is also a slim possibility that the constructions in question are intransitive and do not take **inim gal ^{d}inanna** as an argument, even though the typically causative semantics of *bi-√ prefix verbs would generally suggest the transitive interpretation. If, for whatever reason, the construction is intransitive, the opposition between "an ergative, animate *-n- in the perfective and accusative, inanimate *-b- in the imperfective" would no longer be valid as stated, but the contrast between invariant *-n- in the achievements as opposed to the variation in the corresponding activity predicates supports a transitive, indeed causative, interpretation of the constructions in question.

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$BNBV_{inal}$ predicate: it is, in other words, non-agentive. This yields a zero-marked, absolutive/nominative experiencer such as **lugal.e igi** "the king's eye" in opposition to an oblique, typically locative-terminative case-marked experienced object such as **gig.e** "wheat" at the end of the event in conformity the expectation that the theme of an achievement such **lugal.e igi** "the king's eye/perception" is non-agentive.

The last point I would like to bring up in this section has to do with the relative agentivity and affectedness of the theme or subject in a progressive achievement. Achievements have a curious way of taking as a direct object a noun the referent of which is not affected by the verb in any way at all: in "Mary reached the summit" (cf. Rothstein 2004, 138), the summit is not affected by Mary's action at all, likewise in "Paul spotted the train," nothing has happened to the train and it is Paul who has been affected by the event. Rothstein starts out, in a rather involved discussion of the issue with the following sentence (Rothstein 2004, 138, ex. 36).

(58) Mary is reaching the summit.

Rothstein points out that since progressive achievements bear a number of similarities to accomplishments in that the progressive/imperfective aspect adds an activity predicate meaning "she is going" to an otherwise momentary achievement "she reached the summit." Because of this, (58) can be thought of as either an activity or an achievement: as an activity, Mary would be the single, non-agentive argument of an intransitive predicate, but the agentivity or affectedness of Mary in an achievement predicate is much

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less clear. Achievements are quite regularly transitive in a certain sense, but since the direct object is not affected by the predicate, it is hard to imagine that in an ergative language like Sumerian, the logical subject of an achievement would appear in the ergative case or the direct object in an absolutive case.

If we turn from $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates to BNBV predicates in which the nominal component is alienable, or even *bi-√ prefix verbs that are not preceded by a bare noun, a few examples seem to provide some justification for interpreting *bi-√ prefix verbs as achievements more generally. The primary difference between $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates and other lexical classes is that—in terms of case-marking—the absolutive noun (in conjunction with its raised possessor in the ergative case) is an experiencer rather than a patient; where the absolutive noun is not inalienable, and, consequently, the ergative noun cannot be a possessor, we should expect that the ergative noun is an agent of some kind and the absolutive noun is a patient. Given such a combination of achievement semantics and an absolutive case-marked patient, there is the possibility that the logical object of an achievement predicate might undergo dethematization (demotion of an absolutive case-marked nominal to an adpositional case), resulting in a semantic "patient" appearing in an oblique case; there appear to be a couple of examples in which such a dethematization seems to have taken place.

(59) Nippur Lament [2.2.4] (Tinney 1996, 110-111, 163)

193. si.ga.bi mu.un.du_3.un.na.gin_7 — *Just as he silenced you, when he made*

ḫul$_2$ u_4 mi.ni.in.ku_4.ra — *joy enter again,*

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194. za.pa.ag̃$_2$ kurun$_2$ lal$_3$ diri.še$_3$ bala.bala.e **na.ag̃$_2$.še$_3$ bi$_2$.ib.tar.re**

The sound of choice beer and syrup poured to overflow he decreed as your fate,

195. ib$_2$.si u$_4$ en$_3$.še$_3$ er$_2$ gul.la e.ne e.ra.an.du$_{11}$.ga

"Enough!, lit. it is full!, It is time to stifle the lament," he said to you himself,

(60) Nippur Lament [2.2.4] (Tinney 1996, 118-119)

279. ĝarza suḫ$_3$.a bir.a.bi si bi$_2$.in.sa$_2$

As for its disordered and scattered rites, he put them in order,

280. ku$_3$.ku$_3$.ga šub.ba šu pel$_2$.la$_2$.a.ke$_4$ ki.bi.še$_3$ in.ĝar.ra

He restored the most sacred things, neglected and defiled,

281. šuku u$_4$ šub.ba eša zi$_3$ dub.dub.bu **na.ag̃$_2$.še$_3$ bi$_2$.ib.tar.re**

He ordains the offering of daily rations and the grinding of fine meal and flour,

282. ^{ĝiš}banšur ninda lu ninda šar$_2$.re.da ša$_3$.ga.ni im.de$_6$.a

He decided to make bread plentiful at table, to make loaves numerous!

These two cases are largely parallel and in both of them the direct object in a compound verb construction, **nam-√tar** "to decide someone's fate; to decree" is followed by the allative postposition, even though there is no motion toward **nam** "fate." Two other examples (from a single passage) seem to show the same syntactic pattern: the occurrence of the direct object of compound verb in the allative case instead of its usual absolutive form in conjunction with a progressive/imperfective verb with the *bi-√ prefix.

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(61) A hymn to Haya for Rim-Sin (Rim-Sin B) [2.6.9.2]

39. en ĝi$_6$.par$_3$.e mu.ni.ib.huĝ.en	*You appoint the high priest for the gipar and*
saĝ.se$_3$ mu.ni.ib.ĝar.re.en	*install him there as its caretaker,*
40. sipa kalam.ma.ra ĝidru maḫ	*You make the shepherd of the Land hold the*
u$_4$ sud.ra$_2$ **šu.ni.še$_3$**	*august sceptre until distant days,*
bi$_2$.ib.dab$_5$.e.en	
41. ^{d}ḫa.ia$_3$ diĝir kalam.ma a.ra.zu	*Haia, you are the god of the land who*
uĝ$_3$ šar$_2$.ra ĝiš tuku me.en	*listens to the prayers of all people,*
42. za.e diĝir gal.gal.e.ne	*You make him (= the king) hold the*
uĝ$_3$ dagal.la **šu.ni.še$_3$**	*widespread people for the great gods,*
bi$_2$.ib.dab$_5$.e.en	

I should note, as this point, that dethematization does not seem to be limited to *bi-√ prefix verbs, the following example, likewise, exhibits dethematization of the nominal component of a compound verb but with mu.e.da-√ as prefix rather than bi-√.

(62) Dialogue between Enkihegal and Enkitalu 194 (Dialogue 2; unpublished, cf. Karahashi 2000, 74)

eš$_2$.gar$_3$ ḫe$_2$ bi$_2$.šid niĝin ḫe$_2$ bi$_2$.gi.ne a$_2$.še$_3$ mu.e.da.aĝ$_2$

You ordered me to have the task computed and the grand totals corrected,

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All the texts in which dethematization (**-še$_3$** immediately preceding *bi-√ prefix verbs) occurs date to the Isin-Larsa period: The Nippur Lament examples dating to perhaps a century before the Rim-Sin B examples (for other exceptional uses of the terminative postposition in the Isin-Larsa period, see Brisch 2003, 138-139; Thomsen 2001 [1984], 103). If they can be corroborated by earlier examples, they may provide evidence of the demotion of the underlying theme (dethematization) so as to allow for underlying subject to appear in the absolutive/nominative case in progressive/imperfective achievements. The appearance of the "agent" in the nominative case in the progressive/imperfective (*marû*) aspect is to be expected regardless of lexical aspectual class, so the only real evidence for dethematization is the demotion of the patient from absolutive to allative case with a progressive/imperfective achievement verb.

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2.5 Introducing telicity, **šu**, and inalienable possession under nominalization

Among the many morphosyntactic proposals that originate from Yoshikawa's work, one of the most surprising is that otherwise atelic predicates can, under certain circumstances, be made telic through the introduction of **šu** "hand" in a compound verb construction of some kind (Yoshikawa 1993, 82-84). The clearest source of derived telicity, in my view however, is the use of the *bi-√ prefix. This leads to a rather interesting aporia in that, as argued above, the $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates are the prototypical examples of achievements and they include (by definition) a *bi-√ prefix verb as well as an inalienable noun such as **šu**: the obvious question is which of these two elements is responsible for the telicity of these predicates. The plausibility of Yoshikawa's proposal has been obscured up to now by my artificial exclusion of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in which **šu** functions as the nominal component from my initial survey in chapter 1, but these examples will be presented at the conclusion of this section.

At the beginning of the chapter, I spoke of D-stem reduplication in Sumerian as analogous to resultative secondary predication, but at the time I was hesitant to classify D-stem reduplications as resultative secondary predicates in the strict sense. One of the reasons for my hesitation was that the D-stem reduplications differ from ordinary resultatives in a number of little ways, but the main reason for my hesitation was that there is an extremely small group of constructions in Sumerian which resemble English-style secondary predicates even more and that may also provide some insight into which of the two elements, *bi-√ or **šu**, codes telicity: the two examples of this phenomenon that I am aware of follow in (63) and (64).

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(63) Enki and Ninmah [1.1.2], ll. 53-55

53. ^{d}nin.maḫ.e ^{d}en.ki.ra gu_3	*Ninmah calls to Enki:*
mu.na.de_2.e	
54. me.dim_2 na.a$\tilde{g}_2$.lu_2.ulu_3.ta sa_6.ge	*"Man's body can be either good or*
ḫul ma.al.la.a.kam	*bad,*
55. ki $ša_3$ gi_4.a.$\tilde{g}u_{10}$ na.a$\tilde{g}_2$.tar	*Whether I make a fate good or bad*
bi_2.ib.se_3.ge **bi_2.ib.ḫul.e**	*depends on my will,"*

(64) Ninurta and the Turtle, segment B [1.6.3], ll. 49-51

49. $\tilde{g}a_2$.ra sa$\tilde{g}$.$\tilde{g}iš^{?}$.ra.$\tilde{g}u_{10}$.uš igi.zu	*You who have decided to kill me,*
mu.e.$\tilde{g}$ar.ra.$\lceil am_3 \rceil$	
50. x bil_2.ga gal.gal di $\tilde{g}a_2$.e	*. . . who makes big claims: "I put things in*
bi_2.$\lceil ib_2 \rceil$.$\tilde{g}a_2$.$\tilde{g}a_2$ $\tilde{g}a_2$.e **bi_2.ib_2.zi.de_3**	*place, I make things right,"*
51. za.e $\tilde{g}a_2$.ra a.gin_7 igi.zu	*From you who set your sights on me*
mu.$\tilde{g}$ar.ra	*like this,*

At first glance these two examples do not seem to resemble the resultative secondary predicates that were under discussion earlier in the chapter ("Julie painted the house red"), but this is largely due to the fact that Sumerian is a verb-final language. In other verb-final languages, it is the resultative secondary predicate (typically based on an adjectival root) that occurs in final position in the sentence and bears the inflectional morphology typically associated with a "main verb." Thus the sequence of lexical verb

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followed by resultative seems to be invariant, which is quite surprising given the inverse ordering of constituents in SOV languages under Kaynean antisymmetry.

(65) Japanese *-te shimau* construction (Kaiser et al. 2001, 518)

nantoka	shinai	to	gōsuto	taun-ni	nat-**te**	**shima-u**
something	do-Neg	Comp	ghost	town-Loc	become-Inf	end.up-Indic

Unless we do something, it'll **end up** becoming a ghost town.

(66) Korean poryo-ta construction

ceolsoo-ga	ne	ca-rul	pa-**ra**	**boryot-ta**
PN-Sub	1Poss	car-Acc	sold-Inf	end.up-Indic

Chelsu **ended up** selling my car (negative meaning)

The only way that I know of to identify the particular morphological element that introduces telicity would be to identify an adjectival root that has undergone two derivational phases: the first involving the shift from state (adjective) to derived achievement and the second from achievement to derived accomplishment. If one assumes, as I will for the sake of the argument, that each of these two derivations can be tied to some kind of morphological element or syntactic configuration, the derived achievement and the derived accomplishment should share at least one morphosyntactic feature that is not found in the simple adjective, while the accomplishment should bear at least one morphosyntactic feature that neither the state (adjective), nor the achievement

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exemplify. Rather than speaking in generalities, I would like to introduce an example from English which may serve as an informal model of the phenomenon I have in mind. English is capable, for example, of converting a predicate of uncertain telicity into a resultative through the introduction of an adjective as a secondary predicate that modifies the direct object and describes the resultant state in some fashion ("he swept the floor" > "he swept the floor clean"). A derived achievement such as "he swept the floor clean" can then be transformed into an accomplishment through the formation of a light verb construction: in one kind of English light verb construction, the main verb is changed into an indefinite noun that is modified by an attributive adjective that corresponds to the adjective used to form the resultative secondary predicate; the indefinite noun derived from the underlying main verb becomes the direct object of a higher, ditransitive verb which is introduced as the new main verb, while the original or underlying direct object becomes either the recipient or the source in a low applicative construction ("he swept the floor clean" > "he gave the floor a clean sweep"). Note that in the following parallel the lexical meaning of the English and Sumerian forms is completely unrelated (clean ≠ ḫul, ḫul = "bad, rotten, false")—they are only parallel in morphosyntactic form, if that, see below for further discussion.

(67)	a.	The floor is clean	ḫul
	b.	He swept the floor clean	šu bi_2.ḫul
	c.	He gave the floor a clean sweep	šu ḫul bi_2.du_{11}

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In (67), I present the two-part derivation ("state > achievement" followed by "achievement > accomplishment") as exemplified by three English sentences alongside what Yoshikawa's theory of **šu** as the telicizing component might predict: **šu ḫul** and **šu ḫul bi$_2$.du$_{11}$** both include **šu** as the telicizing component, while the derived accomplishment in (67c) also includes a plausible light verb, namely **bi$_2$.du$_{11}$**.

The problem is that no such sequence seems to exist in the text-artifactual record. The contrast that is represented exists between achievements such as (63) and (64) above and nominalized structures such as the following examples (example [63] repeated below as [68a]).

(68) a. Enki and Ninmah [1.1.2], l. 55

ki ša$_3$ gi$_4$.a.g̃u$_{10}$ na.ag̃$_2$.tar — *Whether I make a fate good or bad*

bi$_2$.ib.se$_3$.ge **bi$_2$.ib.ḫul.e** — *depends on my will,*

b. Nippur Lament [2.2.4], l. 263 (Attinger 1993, 707)

u$_4$ ki.en.gi ki.uri lu$_2$.erim$_2$.e — *The enemy, having done Sumer and Akkad*

šu ḫul bi$_2$.in.du$_{11}$.ga — *a terrible deed,*

An additional example of the **šu ḫul bi$_2$.in.du$_{11}$.ga** pattern occurs in line 299 of the Nippur Lament [2.2.4]. Since √**ḫul** is not a BNBV$_{inal}$ predicate, it shows causative semantics as expected: "to make (a fate) bad." Whereas (68a) is equivalent in some respects to a resultative like "he swept the floor clean," the **šu ḫul bi$_2$.in.du$_{11}$.ga**

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construction is (68b) bears a number of similarities to a light verb construction such as "he gave the floor a clean sweep": the adjectival root in (68a), **√ḫul**, is nominalized as an indefinite noun, **šu ḫul**, that serves as the patient of a newly introduced ditransitive verbal root, namely **√du$_{11}$**. The environment in which **√ḫul** occurs in (68b), *šu . . . bi-√, indicates that the nominal phrase formed by **√ḫul** in combination with the inalienable noun **šu** is indefinite, but I suspect that the use of **šu** also allows for the inclusion of an agentive adjunct such as **lu$_2$.erim$_2$.e** in a clause that would, otherwise, exclude agentive arguments of any kind.

(69) a. Ninurta and the Turtle, segment B [1.6.3], l. 50

x bil$_2$.ga gal.gal di g̃a$_2$.e bi$_2$.⌈ib$_2$⌉.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$ g̃a$_2$.e bi$_2$.ib$_2$.zi.de$_3$

. . . who makes big claims: I put things in place, I make things right,

b. Bird and Fish [5.3.5], l. 88

maḫ gu$_7$.gu$_7$ sag̃ šu zi bi$_2$.ib$_2$.du$_{11}$.ga kisal.e še$_{10}$ si.si

Gluttonous, malformed, filling the courtyard with droppings,

In (69a), there are two expressions in parallel: **g̃a$_2$.e bi$_2$.ib$_2$.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$** "I myself am one who puts (things) in place," and **g̃a$_2$.e bi$_2$.ib$_2$.zi.de$_3$** "I myself am one who makes (things) right." Although I translate the two expressions as equational sentences, the *bi-√ prefix verbs are actually independent expressions in apposition to the first person singular pronoun (see below, chapter 3, for a discussion of the appositional character of head-

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internal relative clauses such as these). Since, again, the *bi-√ prefix predicates are not $BNBV_{inal}$, their meaning is causative: "put (things) in place = cause (things) to be in place," and "make (things) right/straight" respectively. In the light verb construction in (69b), however, the meaning of the expression is somewhat more difficult. The ETCSL translation of the expression **saĝ šu ZI bi_2.ib_2.du_{11}.ga** is simply "malformed." But this translation follows almost entirely from the fact that the series of epithets are all negative characterizations of Bird's appearance and the word **saĝ**, "head," appears in this particular epithet. The ETCSL transliteration offers some insight into the particular way that ETCSL editors imagined the head in question to be malformed: ETCSL transliterates ZI as **zig_3**, meaning "to rise up" and forming a syntagm **saĝ √zi(g)** that has generally positive connotations in Sumerian literature if not elsewhere (cf. the story of the cupbearer and the baker in Genesis 40). The parallel that I have drawn in (69), however, would necessarily interpret ZI as the verbal root **√zi(d)**, "to be straight; to be just," and I would interpret the epithet to mean that Bird's head (including its beak) is straightened and angular as opposed to the gracefully curving head of Fish. My interpretation would seem to be in line with Fish's generally negative attitude toward the angular body-parts of Bird, if the ETCSL translation of line 86, **ka ur_2 gu_2 $guru_5$ $giri_3$ su.ul.su.ul ka ḫa.la eme sal.sal** as "[c]hopped-off beak and legs, deformed feet, cleft mouth, thin tongue!" has any merit.

Although the number of cases in which the same adjectival root appears in both the **bi_2.in.ḫul_2.le** construction and the **šu ADJECTIVE bi_2.in/ib.du_{11}.ga** construction is

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limited to two pairs of exemplars,[24] the details so precisely correspond to the two-step derivation discussed above (state [adjective] > achievement > accomplishment) that some consideration of the forms must be allowed. Again, using the three example sentences in English as scaffolding, the derivational correspondences can be understood as follows:

(70) a. The floor is clean. ḫul

b. He swept the floor clean. bi_2.in.ḫul

c. He gave the floor a clean sweep. šu ḫul bi_2.in.du_{11}.ga

The presence of the *bi-√ prefix in (70b) and (70c), the achievement and the accomplishment respectively, would seem to indicate that it is the *bi-√ prefix that codes telicity, while the addition of **šu** under nominalization seems to derive the accomplishment (70c) from the achievement in (70b). In formal terms, there are a number of intriguing similarities between the English and the Sumerian constructions in (70c) such as nominalization (*-a), the demotion of the original verbal root to a nominal argument position (ḫul) and its replacement by a newly introduced ditransitive verb (du_{11}), but one of the primary differences, which I would like to associate with the introduction of **šu** in (70c), is that unlike (70b) the English sentence in (70c) is agentive. The contrast can be seen more clearly if the subject of the English sentences in (70b) and (70c) is changed to an inanimate noun. Thus a (resultative) achievement such as "the wind swept the floor clean" is fine with a non-agentive subject like "wind," but "the wind

[24] Although not brought into discussion here, the larger set of examples of the form **šu suḫ$_3$.a ba.ab.du$_{11}$** (Lament over Sumer and Ur 67) presumably offer a minimal contrast with complexes of the form **šu ḫul bi$_2$.in.du$_{11}$.ga**.

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gave the floor a clean sweep" only works if the wind is personified a great deal. This seems, therefore, to conform to Rothstein's expectation that the subject of achievements is non-agentive, while the subject off accomplishments is necessarily agentive.

Thinking back to my earlier discussion of non-agentivity in achievements and the role of ergative possessor and inalienable body-part noun as a single constituent in the absolutive case, the reason for the use of the **šu** may be elucidated somewhat: since **šu** is the most agentive of the possible body-part nouns in a $BNBV_{inal}$ construction and the derived accomplishment in (70c) must use some means of reintroducing an agent into a previously non-agentive achievement predicate, **šu** is the natural choice. The crucial factor, however, in differentiating such agent-introducing **šu** constructions from ordinary $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions in which the nominal component happens to be **šu** seems to be nominalization. The $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates can appear without any form of nominalization, whereas pseudo-agentive **šu** in derived accomplishments only seems to occur under some form of nominalization. But, given the paucity of sources and the difficulty of differentiating them within such a relatively unstructured corpus, it has been difficult to identify this opposition in the text-artifactual records. Beyond the examples of the **šu ḫul bi_2.in.du_{11}.ga** construction above, I have been able to locate only a few other examples of **šu**, where it introduces an agent rather than provides some specific semantic content to the predicate.

(71) Ur Lament [2.2.2], l. 258 (Karahashi 2000, 149)

256. $egir_3$.re $eš_3$ uri_2^{ki} ḫul.a.na	*Over her devastated shrine Urim, the*
gig.ga.bi im.me	*princess bitterly declares:*

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257. an.ne$_2$ uru$_2$.ĝu$_{10}$ na.aĝ$_2$ ha.ba.da.an.ku$_5$ uru$_2$.ĝu$_{10}$ ḫu.mu.da.gul

"An has indeed cursed my city, my city has been destroyed before me,

258. ^{d}mu.ul.lil$_2$.le e$_2$.ĝu$_{10}$ **šu ḫe$_2$ bi$_2$.in.bala** ^{ĝiš}al.e ḫa.ba.ra

Mullil has indeed transformed my house, it has been smitten by pickaxes.

259. sig.ta di.ĝa$_2$ izi ḫa.ba.ni.in.šub a uru$_2$.ĝu$_{10}$ ḫu.mu.da.gul

On my ones coming from the south he hurled fire. Alas, my city has been destroyed before me,

(72) Lament over Sumer and Ur [2.2.3] (Michalowski 1989, 113; Karahashi 2000, 149)

23. ^{d}en.lil$_2$.le igi.ni ki kur$_2$.ra ba.an.ĝar.ra.a.ba

After Enlil had looked favourably on an enemy land,

24. ^{d}nin.tu.re niĝ$_2$.dim$_2$.dim$_2$.ma.ni za$_3$ bi$_2$.in.tag.ga.a.ba

After Nintu had scattered the creatures that she had created,

25. ^{d}en.ki.ke$_4$ ^{i7}idigna ^{i7}buranun.na šu bi$_2$.in.bala.a.ba

After Enki had altered the course of the Tigris and Euphrates,

26. ^{d}utu ḫar.ra.an kaskal.e nam ba.an.ku$_5$.da.a.ba

After Utu had cast his curse on the roads and highways,

(73) Gilgamesh, Enkidu and the Netherworld [1.8.1.4], ll. 247-251 (Karahashi 2000, 167)

247. tukum.bi a$_2$ aĝ$_2$.ĝa$_2$ kur.ra mu.ra.ab.[be$_2$.en]

(Enkidu:) If I tell you the order of the nether world,

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248. [za].e tuš.a er_2 $ĝa_2$.e ga.tuš ga.⌜er_2⌝	*You, sit down and weep! (Gilgamesh:) I shall sit down and weep!*
249. **[x] šu bi_2.in.tag.⌜ga⌝** $ša_3$.zu ba.e.$ḫul_2$	*..., which your heart rejoiced to touch,*
250. [...] ⌜$ši^?$⌝.du.un bi_2.in.du_{11}	*is ...,*
251. [... tug_2 sumun].⌜a⌝.gin_7 uḫ bi_2.in.⌜tag⌝	*Worms infest it like an old garment (?),*

Karahashi reconstructs the line as **su.mu šu bi_2.in.tag.ga $ša_3$.zu ba.e.hul_2**, "*When you touched my flesh, you felt happy,*" but the line is broken and passage is difficult. Nonetheless, if we can assume that the meaning of the verb **šu bi_2.in.tag.ga** is "to touch," then it is clear that the **šu** does not contribute to the lexical meaning of the verb since the verbal root √tag alone also means the same thing. But since **šu** would serve as a natural semantic component of a verb meaning "to touch," the precise lexical meaning of the verbal root √tag is probably in need of further investigation.

One example is exceptional in that it is clear that the **šu** does not play any particular role in the semantics of the predicate, but the predicate appears with **šu** even though it contributes no lexical meaning to the predicate.

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(74) Bird and Fish [5.3.5], ll. 7-11 (Karahashi 2000, 164)

7. ^{i7}⌈idigna⌉ ^{i7}buranun.na za_3.ga	*He laid out side by side the Tigris and the*
ba.an.la_2 a kur.kur.ra	*Euphrates, and caused them to bring*
mi.ni.in.tum_3.uš	*water from the mountains,*
8. i_7 tur.⌈tur⌉.ra šu luḫ ba.an.ak	*He scoured out the smaller streams, and*
sur_3.sur_3 mi.ni.g̃ar.g̃ar	*positioned the other watercourses,*
9. **[a.a ^{d}]⌈en⌉.ki.ke_4 tur_3 amaš**	*Father Enki made the sheepfolds and cattle-*
šu bi_2.in.dag̃al sipa unu_3	*pens teem, and provided them with*
bi_2.in.tuku	*shepherds and herdsmen,*
10. ⌈iri⌉ ki a_2.dam ki.a	*He founded cities and settlements*
bi_2.in.g̃ar.g̃ar sag̃ gi_6	*throughout the earth, and made the*
mi.ni.in.lu	*black-headed multiply,*
11. lugal.e nam.sipa.bi.$še_3$	*He provided them with a king as shepherd,*
mu.un.tuku nam.nun.bi.$še_3$	*elevating him to sovereignty over them,*
mu.un.il_2	

Karahashi transliterates the verb in question as **šu bi_2.in.nig̃in**, whereas ETCSL has **šu bi_2.in.dag̃al**. The copy in PBS 10, 2, 21 is quite difficult to read and collation may yield NIG̃IN, but the copy in UET 6/1, 38 is clearly AMA, hence **dag̃al**. I believe that this is an example of the use of **šu** to introduce an agent into an achievement predicate; the reason for the absence of a nominalizing/resultative postposition is that the verbal root, **√dag̃al**, is adjectival and it is a good examples of a derived achievement as discussed above.

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Since it is an achievement predicate, we might expect that there would be no ergative case-marked agent, but the introduction of **šu** allows the agent to appear in the clause as the inalienable possessor of **šu** in the ergative case. Thus the contrast between pseudo-agentive **šu** compound verbs and true $BNBV_{inal}$ compound verbs in **šu** on the basis of whether or not the main verb bears the nominalizing/resultative suffix, *-a, only seems to apply to non-adjectival verbs. Of course, it is not particularly surprising that fientive verbs bearing the nominalizing/resultative suffix and adjectival roots are more or less interchangeable.

(75) Lament over Sumer and Ur [2.2.3], ll. 407-410 (Karahashi 2000, 153)

407. lu_2.kar.ra.bi dub_3 nu.um.zil.e	*As for its refugees, they were unable to flee,*
bad_3 za_3.ga bi_2.in.dab_5.be_2.eš	*they were trapped inside the walls,*
408. ^{uruda}alan $uzug_x$(AN.ZAG).ge	*The statues that were in the treasury were*
si.a.bi gu_2.$guru_5$ ba.an.ne.eš	*cut down,*
409. ^{d}nin.i_3.$gara_2$ ağrig maḫ.e	*The great stewardess Ninigara abandoned*
$erim_3$.ma šu bi_2.in.dag	*the storehouse,*
410. ^{giš}gu.za.bi igi.bi.ta ba.e.$šu_2$	*As for its throne, it was cast down before*
saḫar.ra ba.da.an.tuš	*them, (and) she threw herself down into*
	the dust,

Other examples of the **šu bi_2.in.dag** construction include Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta [1.8.2.3], lines 558-562, Eridu Lament [2.2.6], line 6/7, and Nippur Lament [2.2.4], line 88 (Karahashi 2000, 153-154).

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(76) Lament over Sumer and Ur [2.2.3], l. 445 (Michalowski 1989, 64-65; Karahashi 2000, 155)

443. ^{ĝiš}na$_2$ gi$_4$.rin.na nu.um.gub u$_2$ za.gin$_3$ nu.mu.un.bara$_3$	*The divine bed was not set up, it was not spread with lapis-colored grass,*
444. alan AN.ZAG.ge$_4$ si.a.ba gu$_2$.gur$_5$ ba.an.ne.eš	*The statues that were in the treasury were cut down,*
445. engiz ensi kišib$_3$ ĝal$_2$.bi eš.da šu li bi$_2$.in.du$_7$.uš	*The temple cook, dream interpreter, and seal-keeper didn't prepare the rite,*
446. gu$_2$ ki.še$_3$ ĝal$_2$.la.bi ba.e.su$_8$.su$_8$.ge.eš kur$_2$.re ba.ab.laḫ$_5$.e.eš	*They stood in submission and were carried off by the foreigners,*
447. uz.ga ku$_3$ šu.luḫ dadag.ga ša$_3$.gada.la$_2$.bi.e.ne	*The holy uzga-priests of the sacred lustrations, the linen-clad priests,*

(77) Lament over Eridu [2.2.6], section B, ll. 7-11 (Green 1975, 338, 346 [ll. 5/3-5/7 in Green's edition]; Karahashi 2000, 157)

7. nin.bi ab$_2$.zi arḫuš.a ku$_3$ ^{d}dam.gal.nun.na	*As for its lady, the faithful cow, the compassionate one, the pure one, Damgalnuna,*
8. gaba.ni ⌜i$_3$.ḫar.re igi⌝.ni i$_3$.ḫar.re gu$_3$ mir.ra im.me	*She claws at her breast; she claws at her eyes; she utters a frenzied cry,*
9. **šu 2(diš).a.na ⌜ĝir$_2$⌝ ba.da.ra šu bi$_2$.in.du$_8$** teš$_2$.bi i$_3$.gu$_7$.e	*She held dagger and sword in her two hands; they consume each other,*

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10. siki.ni ^{u2}numun$_2$.bur.gin$_7$ i$_3$.ze$_2$.e	*She tears out her hair like rushes, uttering a*
i.lu gig ĝa$_2$.ĝa$_2$	*bitter lament,*
11. uru$_2$ munus.zu mu.⌜til⌝.[la	*"My city, your woman does not reside (in*
a].⌜la⌝.zu nu.gi$_4$.a.ĝu$_{10}$ me.a	*you); your lilting song does not*
er$_2$.zu ba.gig	*resound. Where is a lament uttered*
	bitterly for you?"

(78) Kesh Temple Hymn 109 (Karahashi 2000, 157, Gragg in Sjöberg and Bergmann 1969, 174)

107. e$_2$.e lugal.bur.ra am$_3$.mi.gub	*The* lugalburra*-priest stepped up to the*
	temple,
108. en du$_{10}$ ša$_3$ eš$_2$.la$_2$ am$_3$.mi.in.la$_2$	*The good* en*-priest . . . held the lead-rope*
	suspended,
109. a.tu.e šibir šu bi$_2$.in.du$_8$	*The* atu*-priest held the staff,*
110. tu.e a.ur$_4$.a am$_3$.mi.tum$_2$	*The . . . brought the gathered waters,*
111. lal$_3$.e ki ku$_3$.ga am$_3$.mi.in.tuš	*The . . . took his seat in the holy place,*

(79) Inanna's Descent 290-292 (Karahashi 2000, 157)

290. ^{d}inanna kur.ta ba.e$_{11}$.de$_3$	*So Inanna left the netherworld,*
291. lu$_2$ igi.na sukkal nu.me.a	*The one in front of her, though not a sukkal,*
^{ĝiš}gidru šu bi$_2$.in.du$_8$	*held a scepter,*
292. bar.ra.na ra.gaba nu.me.a	*The one behind her, though not an escort,*
^{ĝiš}tukul ur$_2$.ra bi$_2$.in.la$_2$	*carried a mace at his hip,*

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(80) Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta [1.8.2.3], ll. 501-504

(Vanstiphout 2003, 84-85; Karahashi 2000, 165)

501. kig̃$_2$.gi$_4$.a ka.ni dugud	*As for the messenger's mouth, it was heavy,*
šu nu mu.un.da.an.gi$_4$.gi$_4$	*so he could not repeat it (the message),*
502. bar kig̃$_2$.gi$_4$.a ka.ni dugud	*Since the messenger's mouth was heavy and*
šu nu mu.un.da.an.gi$_4$.gi$_4$.da.ka	*he couldn't repeat it (the message),*
503. **en kul.aba$_4$^{ki}.a.ke$_4$ im.e**	*The lord of Kulab patted some clay and put*
šu bi$_2$.in.ra inim dub.gin$_7$	*the words on the tablet instead* (-gin$_7$),
⌜bi$_2$.in⌝.gub	*(of saying them to the messenger)*
504. u$_4$.bi.ta inim im.ma gub.bu	*Before that time, no one had ever put words*
nu.ub.ta.g̃al$_2$.la	*on clay,*

Lines 501 and 502 actually illustrate quite nicely the contrast between two forms of cause or result clause: in line 501, the heaviness of the messenger's mouth results in his inability to repeat the message ("his mouth was heavy, so . . .") where the reduplication of √**gi$_4$** presumably indicates that it is an adverbial/subordinate clause, but in line 502, the entire content of line 501 is taken as a cause (rather than a result) of the creation of writing ("Since . . ., the lord of Kulab . . . ."). The causal subordination is marked with the familiar **bar . . . /ak/** construction.

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(81) Enmerkar and Ensuḫgirana [1.8.2.4], ll. 75-79 (Karahashi 2000, 165)

77. **[im].gin$_7$ šu bi$_2$.in.ra** im.gin$_7$	*He patted it into (the form of) a tablet and*
igi i.ni.in.bar	*looked at it like a tablet,*
78. [e.ne] ^{d}inanna.da e$_2$.za.gin$_3$	*He may dwell with Inanna in the Ezagin of*
aratta.ka ḫu.mu.da.an.ti	*Aratta,*
79. ĝa$_2$.e [x] ⌜an⌝.ta ki.a gub.ba.ni	*But I dwell with her . . . as her earthly*
ḫu.mu.da.an.ti.en	*companion,*

(82) The Marriage of Sud [1.2.2] ll. 83-87 (Karahashi 2000, 171)

83. [šu] ⌜ki⌝.ta.ni sukkal	*The minister opened his left hand and gave*
mu.un.ši.in.bar gi$_{16}$.sa	*her the jewellery,*
mu.na.an.šum$_2$	
84. [...] x.ka.ni niĝ$_2$.nam ĝar.ĝar	*. . . everything . . . and set it before her,*
igi.[ni].še$_3$ mu.na.an.gub	
85. [...] umbin niĝ$_2$.ba šu bi$_2$.in.ti	*She took the gift with fingertips,*
86. [...] ⌜nibru⌝^{ki}.še$_3$ ĝiri$_3$ ba.an.dab$_5$	*He . . . directed his steps to Nibru,*
87. [...] x ^{d}en.lil$_2$.ra [ki] mu.un.su.ub	*. . . kissed the ground before Enlil,*

Although the examples are relatively few and difficult to differentiate, it does appear that those examples in which **šu** serves an entirely syntactic purpose (so as to reintroduce an agent into an achievement predicate that would normally exclude an agentive argument) can be distinguished by the fact that the verbs that they appear in conjunction with are

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either bear the nominalizing/resultative suffix, *-a, or—in one case at least—are based on an adjectival root. In the remaining cases, **šu** appears before a fientive (non-adjectival) root that does not bear the nominalizing/resultative suffix and, at the same time, seems to contribute to the lexical meaning of the compound verb. Only the latter should probably be thought of as true members of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class, while the former adopt a $BNBV_{inal}$ construction for syntactic reasons and should probably be spoken of as *derived* $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions.

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2.6 $BNBV_{inal}$ as a particle-verb construction

Up to now, I have concentrated on the semantic properties of the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction, particularly in terms of lexical aspect and certain interactions between lexical and grammatical aspect. Here in the penultimate section of this chapter, I describe the formal or distributional features that code the meanings suggested above. What morphosyntactic means, in other words, are used in Sumerian to code telicity and the phenomena related to it? I argue in the following that the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction is a particular kind of particle-verb construction (familiar from a variety of present-day European languages) and that the *bi-√ prefix is analogous to the particle in a particle verb construction and contributes telicity to the meaning of predicates in which it occurs. It has long been recognized that in English, for example, particles—prepositions that lack a nominal complement—are often used to control the telicity of verbs.

(83) He hammered it **Ø** for three hours / *in three hours.

(84) He hammered it **out** for three hours / in three hours.

In these examples, as is standard practice, a temporal adverb can be used to differentiate a telic event from an atelic one: in (83), an atelic verb can only occur with an unbounded temporal adverb, *for three hours*, whereas the telic verb in (84), which is followed by the particle *out*, can also occur with a bounded temporal adverb, *in three hours*. Since Sumerian is strictly verb-final, the possibility of a particle-based system for controlling the telicity of a verb seems out of reach. But recent work on the formation of verbal

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complexes (Kayne 1994; Koopman and Szabolcsi 2000; Julien 2002) has argued that verbal complexes are regularly derived through movement of phrases that appear to the right of the verb in languages like English into positions on the left of the verb in languages like Sumerian. This section argues that just such a phenomenon is at work in Sumerian.

In an SVO language like English, the syntax of particle-verb constructions is fairly clear: although the exact position of the adposition that serves as the particle varies, the crucial feature is that the adposition never takes a complement, which results in a "bare" adposition (hereafter referred to as a "particle").

(85) a. Amanda poured **out** the bottle of wine

b. Amanda poured the bottle of wine **out**

Although one might imagine that the preposition "out" in (85a) takes the noun phrase "the bottle of wine" as its complement to form a prepositional phrase "out (of) the bottle of wine," the variant form in (85b) shows that this is, in fact, not the case (leaving aside possible preposition complement relations at underlying levels of representation). The variant in (85b) has an ordinary noun phrase, "the bottle of wine," as the direct object of the main verb, "poured," and a particle at the end of the sentence, "out," without a noun phrase complement of any kind. The fact that the two sentences in (85) have more-or-less the same meaning indicates that—in all likelihood—the preposition in both sentences is to be interpreted as a particle that has more to do with controlling the telicity of the verb

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than indicating the location or adverbial case of the bottle of wine or its contents. The telicity of the construction probably arises from the fact that the particle forms what is known as a *small clause* along the same lines as the resultative secondary predicates discussed above.

(86) a. Mary drank [$_{\text{small clause}}$ the bottle [$_{\text{adjective}}$ dry]]

b. Mary poured [$_{\text{small clause}}$ the bottle [$_{\text{particle}}$ out]

The similarity between these two constructions is not surprising, particularly in light of the fact that both the adjective "dry" and the particle "out" are intransitive states and both refer to the defining property of the endpoint of the event that the predicate refers to. It should probably be noted as well that, in English at least, resultative secondary predicates ("Mary drank the bottle dry") and particle-verb constructions show complex interactions and co-occurrence restrictions with low applicative constructions. Den Dikken, for example, offers the following paradigm (1995, 173).

(87) a. **They sent [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ Bob [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ a package [$_{\text{Particle}}$ off]]].

b. **They fixed [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ John [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ a date [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up]]].

c. **They handed [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ the children [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ candies [$_{\text{Particle}}$ out]]].

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(88) a. I gave [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ John [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ his books [$_{\text{Particle}}$ back]]].

b. Hey, toss [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ me [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up]]], will you?

c. Would you saw [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ me [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ a piece [$_{\text{Particle}}$ off?]]]

Den Dikken (1995, 173-174) elaborates the matter in some detail, but the reason that the examples in (87) fail is presumably due to the details of the fine structure of phrasal movement in English and need not concern us here. My point in raising examples such as (88c) is that they also display a rather consist set of word-order variations in English.

(89) a. Hey, toss [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ to me]]], will you?

b. Hey, toss [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ to me]]], will you?

c. Hey, toss [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ me [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up]]], will you?

d. Hey, toss [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ me [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench]]], will you?

e. **Hey, toss [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ me [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench]]], will you?

What the series of examples in (89) demonstrate is that given an underlying word-order such as [Direct object [Particle [Indirect object]]] in (89a), the verb can "incorporate" either the particle as in (89b) or the indirect object as in (89c), but both can only be incorporated if they are in a particular order: (89d) is good, whereas (89e) is bad.

The parallels with the BNBV$_{\text{inal}}$ construction are manifold, but somewhat difficult to describe due to differences in morphosyntactic structure.

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(90) Hey, toss [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ me [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up]]], will you?

(91) gig.e igi bi_2.in.du_8

[$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ gig-e [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ igi [$_{\text{Particle}}$ bi [$_{\text{Verb}}$ n-du]]]]

Just as in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction, the transfer of possession model is paramount in the English example, due obviously to the necessary presence of a recipient or benefactee, which is incorporated into the verb. The particle ("up"), likewise, codes two distinct functions: the relational or orientational value ("up, out, in, back") that holds between the source (the addressee in [90]) and the goal ("me" in [90]) and the telicity of the verb through its modification of the direct object. The differences between (90) and (91) are also interesting, however, particularly in light of the fact that Sumerian and English differ in terms of ergative vs. accusative case-marking systems and basic word-order. Since Sumerian uses an inalienable body-part noun to code the relational/orientational value, the body-part noun remains in the absolutive case and uses two distinct forms of raised possessor construction (locative-terminative and ergative as inalienable possessor, both *-e) to indicate the nature of the relation between source and goal. At the same time, it seems to indicate the telicity or boundedness of the predicate through the conjunction of **igi** and the *bi-√ prefix. Ultimately these differences seem to result—quite directly—from the basic word-order of the respective languages in that the SVO language is capable of forming a particle-verb construction by stranding a bare adposition to the right of the verb, whereas in an SOV language like Sumerian, this is not possible and the

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inalienability in combination with distinct types of raised possessor construction are used to accomplish the same morphosyntactic function.

Den Dikken has noted that the element that corresponds to the particle in English particle-verb constructions seems to be represented by verbal affixes in other, more highly synthetic languages. He offers several examples in which an applicative use of an affix that attaches to the verb can be contrasted with a causative use of the same morpheme.

(92) Dutch applicative in ver- (Den Dikken 1995, 229)

a. Jan stuurde uitnodigingen voor het feest **aan** zijn vrienden.
Jan sent invitations for the party **to** his friends.

b. Jan **ver**stuurde zijn vrienden uitnodigingen voor het feest.
Jan **VER**sent his friends invitations for the party.

(93) Dutch causative in ver- (Den Dikken 1995, 229)

a. Jan maakte zijn positie **op** de arbeidsmarkt beter.
Jan made his position **on** the job market better.

b. Jan **ver**beterde zijn positie **op** de arbeidsmarkt.
Jan **VER**bettered his position **on** the job market.

Thus the (high) applicative in Dutch forms both an applicative construction in which the underlying prepositional phrase ("aan zijn vrienden" in [92a]) can be moved into direct

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object position if the applicative morpheme ("ver-") is affixed to the verb. If, however, there is a resultative secondary predicate ("beter" in [93a]), the adjective that formed the resultative can move to the position of main verb in combination with the applicative morpheme to form a kind of causative construction ("verbeterde" in [93b]). This is clearly reminiscent of the **bi$_2$.in.ḫul.le** construction dealt with above (with [93a] corresponding in certain respects to the **šu ḫul bi$_2$.in.du$_{11}$.ga** construction). The interesting thing about Dutch, however, is that the "applicative" morpheme alternates with independent particles as in the following examples.

(94) Dutch applicative in ver- and particle (Den Dikken 1995, 234)

a. Jan **ver**stuurde uitnodigingen voor het feest **aan** zijn vrienden.
   Jan **VER**sent invitations for the party **to** his friends

b. Jan stuurde uitnodigingen voor het feest **toe/op aan** zijn vrienden.
   Jan sent invitations for the party **out/up to** his friends

(95) Dutch applicative in ver- and particle + LOW APPLICATIVE (Den Dikken 1995, 234)

a. Jan **ver**stuurde zijn vrienden uitnodigingen voor het feest.
   Jan **VER**sent his friends invitations for the party

b. Jan stuurde zijn vrienden uitnodigingen voor het feest **toe/op**.
   Jan sent his friends invitations for the party **out/up**

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The construction in (94) parallels the English example in (90) quite closely, repeated as (96b) below.

(96) a. Jan stuurde [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ zijn vrienden [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ uitnodigingen ... [$_{\text{Particle}}$ toe/op]]].

b. Hey, toss [$_{\text{Indirect object}}$ me [$_{\text{Direct object}}$ that wrench [$_{\text{Particle}}$ up]]], will you?

Another set of examples cited by Den Dikken provide an additional example of the complex interactions between particle-verb constructions, applicatives and causatives in Indonesian.

(97) Indonesian applicative in -kan (Den Dikken 1995, 232)

a. ali membuka pintu **untuk** bapak.
Ali open the.door for father
Ali opened the door for father

b. ali membuka**kan** bapak pintu
Ali openKAN father the.door
Ali opened the door for father

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(98) Indonesian causative in -kan (Den Dikken 1995, 232)

a. ratna tidur

Ratna sleeps

Ratna is sleeping

b. Parto menidurkan ratna

Parto sleepKAN Ratna

Parto made Ratna fall asleep

In (97) and (98), a (high) applicative is used to change the benefactee from an oblique, adpositionally-marked case to a bare noun phrase that immediately follows the verb. But when the applicative morpheme co-occurs with the adpositional phrase rather than replacing it, the result is a particle-verb construction as in (99).

(99) Indonesian -kan as particle (Den Dikken 1995, 232)

a. parto menulis nama saya

Parto writes name my

Parto writes my name.

b. parto menulis**kan** nama saya di agendanya

Parto writesKAN name my in his.agenda

Parto writes my name **up** in his agenda.

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Den Dikken notes that Voskuil's translation of (99b) as "Parto writes my name **up** in his agenda" suggests that "the affix -kan corresponds to a PARTICLE in languages like Dutch or English" (Den Dikken 1995, 233 citing Voskuil 1990, 87).

The simplest way of describing $BNBV_{final}$ predicates as particle-verb constructions—particularly given Den Dikken's discussion of role of verbal affixes in forming particle-verb constructions in languages that do not exhibit prototypical particle-verb constructions—would be to interpret the *bi-√ prefix as a particle. But I think that the fact that *bi-√ prefix verbs regularly occur with either a locative or a BNBV construction, in which a locative-terminative argument is the raised possessor of the bare noun, suggests that the equivalent of the particle in such constructions is an actual postposition: either the locative postposition or the locative-terminative postposition that marks the raised possessor in a BNBV construction. The *bi-√ prefix simply indicates that the locative or locative-terminative phrase is to be interpreted along with a zero-marked noun as forming the equivalent of an existential "there" sentence (see section 3.4 for details). Taking **gig.e igi** $\mathbf{bi_2}$-√ as a paradigmatic example and adopting a conventionalized representation of it as [wheat-at eye there], the question is how does "at" function as a particle in a particle-verb construction in an SOV languages like Sumerian. Kayne has argued on the basis of the way in which hierarchically organized syntactic structure is linearized (see Kayne 1994 for explication) that the underlying order of this series of constituents is the opposite of the order in which they are found in the text-artifactual record. This would yield [there eye at wheat] as the underlying order of

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constituents, which happens to correspond to the sequence of constituents in an English existential sentence: "there is an eye on the wheat."

Koopman and Szabolcsi (2000) have argued on the basis of Kayne's theoretical program as well as distributional facts in Hungarian, Dutch and German that SOV complex verbs form through a process known as "rolling-up": the rightmost constituent moves to the left edge of the constituent to its left and forms a single constituent with it; the process is then repeated.

(100)	a.	bi-√ igi e [gig $_1$]	there eye at [wheat $_1$]
	b.	bi-√ igi [[gig $_1$] e $_2$]	there eye [[wheat $_1$] at $_2$]
	c.	bi-√ [[[gig $_1$] e $_2$] igi $_3$]	there [[[wheat $_1$] at $_2$] eye $_3$]
	d.	[[[[gig $_1$] e $_2$] igi $_3$] *bi-√ $_4$]	[[[[wheat $_1$] at $_2$] eye $_3$] there $_4$]

In (100), complex verb formation in its simplest form is applied to our paradigmatic example: **gig.e igi bi$_2$-√**. The underlying order appears in (100a), but in (100b), the rightmost constituent [gig $_1$] has moved to the left of the constituent to its left, forming a new compound: [[gig $_1$] e $_2$]. This compound then functions as a unit and moves to the left of [igi $_3$] to form a three-term complex: [[[gig $_1$] e $_2$] igi $_3$]. Lastly, the complex made up of three terms moves to the left of [bi-√ $_4$], yielding the attested form of the construction in (100d). The interesting thing, at least in my view, about such a derivational process with respect to BNBV$_{inal}$ predicates is that at the stage represented in (100c), *bi-√ [[[gig $_1$] e $_2$] igi $_3$], the purely relational, non-referential quality of [. . . igi $_3$], particularly in that it is

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juxtaposed to the locative-terminative postposition [[. . . e_2] igi $_3$], could easily act as a particle, an adposition that lacks a nominal complement, since [. . . igi $_3$] lacks many of the features that would typically be associated with a noun, but has several features that might be associated with an adposition.

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2.7 The link between the BNBV construction and the rise of ergativity

There are, in my view, two possible analyses of a BNBV construction: these two structures seem to correspond to the alienability of the absolutive noun that forms a component of the compound verb and they may also correspond to two distinct phases in the history of the development of ergativity in Sumerian. The older of these two structures, which corresponds to BNBV constructions in which the nominal component is inalienable, is analogous to an English existential sentence in which the post-copular noun is modified by a secondary/adjectival predicate.

(101) [$_{\exists}$ (en aratta^{ki}.ke$_4$) gig.e igi √du$_8$] √bi

There is [$_{\exists}$ *an eye (of the Lord of Aratta) opened up on the wheat*]

Within the structure outlined in (101), the ergative case-marked noun is the inalienable possessor of **igi** and is non-agentive, while the apparent main verb, √**du$_8$**, is actually an adjective modifying **igi** just as secondary predicates typically modify the direct object in secondary predicate environments. The actual main verb in such a construction is the verbal prefix *bi-√. As Pylkkänen predicted for low applicative morphemes, the low applicative takes three arguments: the lexical verb (√du$_8$), the direct object (igi) and the indirect object (gig.e).

In contrast, the second of the two structures, in which the nominal component of the compound verb is alienable, would have resulted from the grammaticalization of the possessive construction as a new ergative construction (Trask 1979; see below, chapter 5,

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for an extended discussion of the different pathways through which ergativity in Sumerian might have arisen).

(102) Lugalbanda II [1.8.2.2], l. 55a

amar.e ^{uzu}suš$_2$ bi$_2$.in.gu$_7$

(*lugal.banda$_3^{da}$.ke$_4$) [$_S$ amar.e uzu suš$_2$] bi gu$_7$

He (= Lugalbanda) had [$_S$ *the young one (amar) eat salt-meat*]

Here in (102), the verbal root, √**gu$_7$**, is no longer an argument of the verbal prefix *bi-√; instead, the tables have turned. √**gu$_7$** is the main verb and takes, in a rather informal sense, only two arguments: the causer (Lugalbanda), typically in an ergative case, and a complex made up of **amar.e**, **^{uzu}suš$_2$**, and the *bi-√ prefix as the second absolutive argument. In formal terms, the most important change is the movement of the *bi-√ prefix to preradical position from its originally postradical position. This undoubtedly reflects the rearrangement of dependency relations between the *bi-√ prefix and the lexical root. Since the head of the clause (the main or highest predicate, in other words) in a strictly verb-final language is almost invariably the final morpheme, it is fairly reasonable to argue that in the older, non-ergative structure in (101), the *bi-√ prefix occurred at the end of the clause. We might, therefore, represent the argument structures of the two diachronic phases as follows:

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(103) a. BI (du_8, igi, gig)

b. gu_7 (BI, $^{uzu}su\check{s}_2$, amar)

In the older of the two constructions, represented in (101) and (103a), the main verb was the *bi-√ prefix itself, acting as an existential verb along the lines of, say, a modal auxiliary in English; the primary difference was that the *bi-√ prefix and its fellow travelers presumably coded features such as quantification, definiteness and evidentiality, although these properties are quite difficult to recover from the later phases of the language are recorded in the excavated documentation. This resulted in an existentially quantified absolutive noun that was modified by an adjectival, secondary predicate in the form of √**du_8**. Note that the existential quantification coded by the *bi-√ prefix has scope over the entire clause on the basis of clause-final position. With the development of ergativity, however, the main verb is not longer the *bi-√ prefix, but rather a lexical verb such as √**gu_7**. Since √**gu_7** is the main verb, it appears at the end of the clause and the scope of the existential quantification introduced by the *bi-√ prefix is limited to the causee (amar.e) and the absolutive noun ($^{uzu}su\check{s}_2$). Crucially, the ergative agent/causer stands outside the scope of the existential quantification.

(104) a. [$_{\exists}$ (en aratta^{ki}.ke_4) gig.e igi √du_8] √bi

b. (*lugal.banda$_3$^{da}.ke_4) [$_{\exists}$ amar.e uzu $su\check{s}_2$] bi gu_7

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The change in word-order (the inversion of the *bi-√ prefix and **du$_8$/gu$_7$**) and the change in the scope of the existential quantification as represented in (104) would reasonably follow from the reinterpretation of *-e as an ergative postposition and the consequent "verbalization" of the adjectival and secondary predicate that originally modified the absolutive noun.

In my view, this is due to the fact that the ergative noun phrase is topical and, therefore, presupposed relative to the existentially quantified complex including the noun followed by the locative-terminative postposition, the bare noun and the *bi-√ prefix. In other words, the older structure in (104a) is *thetic* (a predication of an event such that the participants in the event are not differentiated from the event itself), whereas the later structure in (104b) is categorical (a predication where a "subject" is identified and a state of affairs of predicated of that particular participant in the event). The BNBV$_{inal}$ class is distinguished by the fact that the ergative case-marked noun and one component of the compound verb, namely the bare inalienable noun, are not referentially discrete and it is likely that this indiscretion prevented the conversion of the originally thetic predicate into a categorical one and preserved the original semantics of the construction. At some later point in the language, the particular configuration of the *bi-√ prefix and the lexical verb in (104a) was apparently brought into harmony with the other, non-BNBV$_{inal}$ predicates through an inversion of prefix and verbal root, but the semantics of the original construction remained intact (For additional discussion of the thetic/categorical opposition and its relation to head-internal relative clauses and verbs of perception, see below, section 3.5).

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3

Diagnosing presupposition in Sumerian

To review somewhat, having identified a distributional class, the $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates, on the basis of a relatively simple diagnostic in chapter 1 (including an identification of the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction as a low source applicative along with the "transfer of possession" model that underlies low applicative semantics), chapter 2 sought to identify the type of lexical aspect coded by a low source applicative such as the $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates. In the end, the $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates were tentatively classified as achievements, which also explained two seemingly unrelated properties: (a) the reduplication of *bi-√ prefix verbs (switching to a larger group of data due to the virtual non-existence of reduplicated $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates) which seem to function as adverbial clauses of cause or result (due to the point-like aspectual profile of achievement predicates and the consequent inability of another event to co-occur with the point of transition) and (b) the non-agentive character of the zero-marked, absolutive case-marked noun immediately preceding a *bi-√ prefix verb (including so-called "transitive" verbs in which the patient is not affected by the event that the verb refers to, e.g., "Mary reached the summit"). Two consequences of chapter 2, which were somewhat unexpected (though predicted by the theoretical literature to some degree) lead us to the subject matter of this chapter: the point-like

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aspectual profile of achievements as well as the use of the *bi-√ prefix to form constructions that are analogous to indefinite relative constructions in other languages suggest that one of the primary functions of the *bi-√ prefix is to indicate that the absolutive noun that immediately precedes the *bi-√ prefix is equivalent in a number of respects to an indefinite noun in languages that make use of an indefinite article, where the indefinite noun is quite often derived, in some fashion, from the number one.

The only substantive way of testing whether what I have previously referred to as a "bare indefinite" is in fact indefinite or not is to identify what is often termed a "definiteness effect." A morphosyntactic environment which exhibits a definiteness effect (at least of the most well-known type such as English existential "there" constructions: "There is a rat in the living room") will generally exclude definite nouns from that environment unless the noun is focus-affected. I argue that $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in the non-progressive/perfective aspect—the only grammatical aspectual category in which they regularly appear—offer an environment that exhibits a definiteness effect and that the zero-marked, absolutive noun that occurs in such environments must, therefore, be indefinite. I see the definiteness effect environment in question as defined by two essential features: the *bi-√ prefix codes a point-like achievement semantics, while the perfective (*ḫamṭu*) aspect ensures that there is only one such point-like event. In the progressive/imperfective aspect, however, the "oneness" of the predicate and hence its similarity to the indefinite article would break down. There is, however, one particular construction in which the restriction imposed by the definiteness effect weakens and the verb regularly appears in the progressive/imperfective aspect, namely the negative

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contrastive focus construction with the form *XP nam bi-√ (where XP refers to either a nominal or a postpositional phrase).

On the basis of contextual investigation of all the known exemplars from the Old Babylonian period (in chapter 4), I interpret the *XP nam bi-√ construction as a negative contrastive focus construction ("It was not IN THE STREET that I hit the car, [but rather IN THE DRIVEWAY]") and argue that the reason that the verbs in such constructions regularly appear in the progressive/imperfective is that the contrastive focus neutralizes the definiteness effect, allows a definite noun to occur in the construction, and forces the verb to appear in the progressive/imperfective so as to indicate that the noun is no longer indefinite. Since the indefinite interpretation of the BNBV construction (including alienable BNBV predicates) stems in part from the perfectivity of the verbal root, a progressive/imperfective verb presumably indicates that the absolutive noun is not indefinite (and by implication definite). Interestingly enough, the lone example of a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate in the *XP nam bi-√ construction exhibits a number of eccentricities that differentiate it from both non-compound *bi-√ prefix verbs and other compound *bi-√ prefix verbs, the most striking of which is the absence of the *marû*-stem suffix that is found on all other, non-$BNBV_{inal}$ examples of the construction.

The common theme that relates this chapter and the following one is presupposition. Indefinite nouns regularly lack presupposition in most contexts, but an indefinite noun is often used to introduce a new topic that is subsequently presupposed by subsequent discourse: in large measure, the meaning of any particular indefinite noun is a function of the relation that holds between presupposed and entailed propositions or parts thereof.

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Section 3.1 starts out with a brief definition of presupposition and juxtaposes it to entailment. The rest of the section notes the use of existential verb constructions to code indefiniteness in certain languages and argues that the same mechanism also operates in Sumerian. In the following section, section 3.2, a basic opposition is drawn between presupposition and focus, where the part of a sentence that is not under focus—namely the presupposition—remains true under negation in contrast to the focused constituent which is the only element that is negated. Section 3.3 looks at topicalized *bi-√ prefix verbs as represented by the form *mini-√: these are, I argue, to be interpreted as indefinite relative constructions that have been topicalized (and also made definite) through the addition of the third person animate possessive pronoun, *-ni. In other languages that make use of head-internal relative constructions, the head noun of the relative clause must be indefinite, but the clause itself can then be made definite as a unit; indefinite relatives in *bi-√ seem to conform to the pattern quite closely. Section 3.4 defines the definiteness effect in some detail and section 3.5 returns to the question of head-internal relative constructions in Sumerian. Recent work on head-internal relative constructions in Korean, Japanese and other typologically similar languages has suggested that head-internal relative constructions regularly constitute definiteness effect environments, so section 3.5 also considers whether the same holds true in Sumerian.

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3.1 Presupposition and assertion, topic and focus

Prior to delving into the correlation between topic, focus and presupposition, I take a moment here to review the basic meaning of the terms *presupposition* and *assertion* and also to establish some fairly broad correlations in their usage so as to orient the reader to subsequent discussion. In everyday use, the term *presupposition* is typically used to describe the part of an utterance that the speaker assumes his or her interlocutors would agree with without any argument (the following examples from Saeed 2003, 101):

(1) a. Her husband is a fool.

b. She has a husband.

(2) a. I don't regret leaving London.

b. I left London.

In each pair of examples, the assertion of the first sentence by the speaker presupposes the truth of the second sentence in each pair. In (1), the speaker and the interlocutor must mutually acknowledge that the referent of *she* has a husband—only when both speaker and interlocutor are in agreement about (1b), can the speaker go on to assert (1a). Likewise, it would be difficult for someone to regret doing something like leaving London as in (2a), if he or she had never left the city in the first place as in (2b). In languages in which topic and focus are explicitly marked, presupposition and assertion are, for the most part, mapped directly into topic and focus. The topic of a clause is quite

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regularly presupposed (and therefore usually definite), while the focus of a clause typically corresponds to the assertion.

As segments of text follow in sequence, subsequent clauses regularly presuppose certain elements of previous clauses, but at the same time, certain assertions require that other assertions that may or may not follow in sequence also be true—this is entailment (The following examples are taken from Saeed 2003, 98-99, ex. 4.52, 4.56, and 4.57.)

(3) a. The anarchist assassinated the emperor.

b. The emperor died.

(4) a. I bought a dog today.

b. I bought an animal today.

In (4), we have the simplest form of entailment, which involves a hyponym "dog" being replaced by a hypernym such as "animal." Since, at least from the logical point of view, all dogs are animals, the sentence in (4b) "includes" the sentence in (4a) and any assertion of (4a) necessarily "includes" an assertion of (4b). Although they are somewhat more complex, the same goes for verbs, hence the entailment that holds between (3a) and (3b). Since the verb "assassinate" includes death as one of its semantic components and the referent of the nominal argument that undergoes assassination in (3a) is the same one that experiences death in (3b), namely the emperor, any assertion of (3a) necessarily includes an assertion of (3b).

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The easiest way of differentiating presupposition and entailment is through the different responses of the two phenomena to negation. If the sentences in (3) are negated, we end up with the following.

(5) a. The anarchist did not assassinate the emperor.

b. The emperor did not die.

The tricky part is that the negative form of the sentence in (5a) does not entail the negative sentence in (5b) since it is entirely possible that, although the anarchist tried his or her best to end the emperor's life and failed, the emperor nonetheless died of gout or something like that. That is to say, the negation can apply to either the part of the assertion in (5a) that is equivalent to (5b), in which case (5b) would be true, or the negation can apply to the manner in which the emperor died, in which case (5b) would be false. If one asserts, however, that (5b) is true, then (5a) must also be true, since (5b) is an essential component of (5a).

Presupposition, however, works quite differently and if negation is introduced into one of the examples of presupposition dealt with above, the difference should be abundantly clear.

(6) a. Her husband is not a fool.

b. She does not have a husband.

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The sentence in (6a) does not have (6b) as its presupposition; instead, it has the original, non-negative version of (6b) as its presupposition, namely (1b): "She has a husband." Basically, a presupposition remains true even when the sentence in which it occurs is negated. Unlike the example of a negated entailment in (5b), however, the negation of the presupposition as in (6b) does not so much result in a negative sentence such as (6a) as the feeling that the assertion in (6a) no longer makes any sense in the first place; the negation of presuppositions has recently been discussed by Herburger (2000) under the heading of "backgrounded focal entailment" and we return to her discussion of the matter briefly in the following section (for a case-study in the use of negation to pick apart presupposition and entailment in an archaeologically recovered language like Sumerian, see Loprieno 1991).

If someone asserts that something is the case in a particular sentence, however, the part of the sentence that is being asserted will not, as a rule, be part of the presupposition: clearly one cannot presuppose and assert the same thing at the same time. In (1a), for example, the part of the sentence that the speaker is asserting is that someone is a fool, whereas the part of a sentence that is being presupposed is that there is someone who meets the criterion of being her husband. In English, this contrast is particularly evident in existential sentences with *there* in "subject" position as in (8) because the usual location of presuppositional elements is in the subject position, here occupied by "there."

(7) There is a rat in your soup.

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In the case of an existential sentence, the speaker does not include him- or herself in the utterance at all, since the claim is that the state of affairs exists quite independently of the person who is uttering the statement. In a certain sense, existential sentences are the inversion in pragmatic terms of so-called explicit primary performatives as in (8).

(8) I promise to bring the book to class tomorrow.

Although both (7) and (8) necessarily involve a speaker who is making an assertion of one kind or another, in (7), there is no element of the sentence that refers to the speaker and in fact there is no referential noun phrase in the nominative position before the verb. The presence of expletive *there* in the position in a sentence usually reserved for the person who takes responsibility for the truth of the state of affairs referred to by the rest of the sentence prevents any kind of responsibility or intention from being attributed to anyone (known as illocutionary force in some circles, abstracting away from culturally contingent notions such as intentionality, see Searle [1969] for the emic view and Rosaldo [1982] for the anthropological critique, cf. Duranti [1997, 231]). In precisely the opposite way, the first person pronoun in (8) results in a situation in which the speaker's intention is presupposed and the speaker is held responsible for the promise in question (see Austin 1975 [1962]; Silverstein 1993b, 46).

There are, furthermore, similarities between existential sentences, perception reports and (although not dealt with in this paper) reported speech in that they correspond to a segment of the implicational hierarchy for systems of evidentiality.

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(9) direct experience > visual > heard > inference > hearsay
existential sentence > perception reports > direct speech > indirect speech . . .

Thus the morphosyntactic form of expressions in English that are used to report perception in all its variety systematically exclude presupposition and regularly occur with indefinite perceived objects. At the same time, in a description of "languages without indefinite pronouns, Heine describes the use of existential sentence constructions to form indefinite pronouns in Tagalog and a Nilo-Saharan language named Lango (Heine 1997, 54-57, ex. 120, 130). Lipinski has also commented on definiteness in Nilotic (a branch of Nilo-Saharan) as follows:

> like Nilotic languages, Old and Middle Egyptian dispense, as a rule, with any equivalent of a definite or indefinite article, but an important feature of several Nilotic languages consists in showing definiteness by the use of verbal forms involving an internal vowel change, viz. the "qualitative" (indefinite) and the "applicative" (definite) (Lipinski 2001, 26)

Presumably a significant portion of the morphosyntactic complexity of Egyptian arises from the need, in the earlier phases of the language, to code (in)definiteness through syntactic means such as topic and focus, a situation that parallels that of Sumerian in a number of respects.

In terms of the language internal resources of Sumerian, clauses that report direct speech and/or direct perception are the best candidates if our goal is the identification of a morphosyntactic environment in which indefinite nouns regularly occur, and it just so happens that the verbal prefix that usually occurs with both verbs of direct speech and

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verbs of direct perception in Sumerian is the *bi-√ prefix. Much of the initial impetus for the investigation of the hypothesis proposed in this dissertation stems from this rather general observation. Note as well that, whereas English uses a verb of creation to form one type of light verb construction for verbs of speaking, namely "make," Sumerian actually uses the verb **du**$_{11}$, "to say" as an auxiliary verb in the formation of a variety of constructions including the light verb constructions mentioned above (section 2.5). It is likewise apparent that not only the *bi-√ prefix, but also other members of the set of deictic elements that include it (*-ni-, *-bi-, and *-ri-) migrated to the main verb and were grammaticalized as auxiliary verbs coding not only an expletive subject in either presentational or existential mode (and thereby, at least in the case of the distal forms, *-bi- and *-ri-, indefiniteness), but also the relative distance in time and/or space from the event referred to by the predicate (a kind of evidentiality). Woods argues for two distinct sets of deictics: what I will term set A (*-e, *-ne, *-be) and set B (*-e, *-še, *-re). Although Woods' model has much to recommend it, I would argue for a slight reconfiguration if only to capture the fact that set B clearly includes a case-marking component (the generally allative/dative cast of the members of set B) and seems to be used predominantly in the grammatical texts—for the most part to modify inalienable/orientational nouns such as **gu**$_2$ (see Woods 2001, 167, for an insightful discussion of the riverine system of deixis and its exclusive use of set B). If nothing else, the use of set B in a somewhat restricted distribution but quite systematically with **gu**$_2$ provides quite a bit of justification for distinguishing set B from the other deictics as a distinct series. Woods' reconstruction of set A, however, is in need of revision in my

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view. Although it is one of the central presuppositions of the Woods' hypothesis about Sumerian deixis, I find it untenable that Old Babylonian scribes would have glossed both *-e and *-ne with *annûm*, the Akkadian proximal demonstrative, *if they were perceived as part of the same deictic series.*[25] Given the fact that there appear to be at least two deictic series, the simplest hypothesis would be that *-e and *-ne each head a distinct series; since it is fairly clear that *-e is the proximal member of set B, I would argue that *-ne heads set A. If we further assume that *-be is a distal member of set A, the resulting table of deictics would be something like the following.

Set A	Set B	Deictic value
*-ne	*-e	PROXIMAL
*-be	*-še	DISTAL.VISIBLE
(*-re)	*-re	DISTAL.NON-VISIBLE

Woods (2001, 95-130) has shown that the VISIBLE/NON-VISIBLE opposition is valid in at least some cases, and, furthermore, that in the literary tradition *-re in conjunction with temporal nouns was typically used to refer to the mythic, a-historical time period typically associated with cosmogony and mythology. Woods has also shown that the visibility-driven system of set B can be mapped into person-driven system as represented in set A (Woods 2001, 146, 158, 168). I would argue, further, that the primary difference between set A and set B is that set A seems to be more closely associated with

[25] Even if *-e specifically referred to speech act participants to the exclusion of non-participants, as suggested by Woods, the absorptive character of deictics (Agha 1996, 647-648) would nearly ensure that, on at least some occasions, *-ne, which is "less proximal" in Woods' reconstruction would have been equated with *ullûm*, the distal member of the Akkadian deictic series. In other words, a reconstruction in which *-e is proximal to speaker, *-ne is proximal to addressee, and *-be is distal from both is not unreasonable, but we might expect to find *-ne occasionally equated to *ullûm* if that were the case.

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demonstrative reference, whereas the members of set B all code a locative or allative case of some kind. Although *-re is clearly a member of set B as evidenced by the OBGT paradigms, the parentheses around *-re in set A are meant to indicate that presence of *-re in set A is somewhat uncertain; nonetheless, some of the examples of *-re cited by Woods (2001, 118-123) are presumably members of set A rather than set B due to the fact that they are clearly demonstrative in use with little or no case-marking value and show no obvious connection to the riverine system of deixis or visual perception.[26]

Woods also cites several examples from the OBGT and MBGT (Woods 2001, 133-139) that are—as Woods acknowledges—contradictory as they exemplify two distinct paradigmatic series: set B (*-e, *-še, *-re) and what I will term set C (*-ne, *-še, *-re). Woods argues that set C represents an aberrant form of set B, but I think that a more parsimonious explanation can be found if we begin with the deictic series as outlined above. Given the widespread grammaticalization of the set A distal demonstrative, *-be, both as the default possessive pronoun in the possessive pronoun topicalization system and as the verbal prefix *bi-, its replacement by the corresponding member of set B should not come a much of a surprise. Woods himself has argued (2001, 168, 220) that the most likely site of grammaticalization within the deictic system is the element that serves as an anaphoric pronoun most readily, namely *-be, the distal member of set A. Once *-be had been grammaticalized as a component of the verbal prefix, its position

[26] I should emphasize that such a reconfiguration of the demonstrative series need not call in question the overall tenor of Woods' argument that matters of deixis play a central role in the grammar of Sumerian. Some form of obviation (see Aissen 1997), in which *-e may have functioned as a topic marker of some kind (and consequently as the marker of a proximal argument in an obviational system) presumably played a part in Sumerian grammar at some point in its history, but I would suspect that such an obviational system antedates even the development of case-marking in Sumerian, which I take as a fairly early development.

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within set A was simply replaced by the corresponding member of set B, yielding the attested form of set C. This seems to be demonstrated fairly well by the "aberrant" paradigms to be found in the OBGT materials cited by Woods (2001, 137). The early grammaticalization of *-be would also provide some explanation of the fact that *-be never exhibits the full or stressed form, **-ben, in the text-artifactual record (Woods 2001, 179).

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3.2 Focus and focal presupposition

Before turning to topic-marking constructions that involve the *bi-√ prefix, it is probably best to devote a few pages to focal presupposition. Just as negation plays a critical role in differentiating presupposition and entailment, it can also serve as a useful context for the elucidation of focus and focal presupposition. Take, for example, a relatively simple set of three variations on the same sentence in which the focal intonation (as indicated by capital letters) occurs on a different constituent in each variant.

(12) a. Mary PUNCHED the mayor on Wilshire Boulevard.

b. Mary punched THE MAYOR on Wilshire Boulevard.

c. Mary punched the mayor ON WILSHIRE BOULEVARD.

Each of these three intonational variants serve as the response to three distinct wh-questions.[27]

(13) a. What did Mary do to the mayor on Wilshire Boulevard?

b. Who did Mary punch on Wilshire Boulevard?

c. Where did Mary punch the mayor?

[27] The three intonational variants in (12) also have explicit syntactic variants that make use of the cleft ("It is the mayor that . . .") and pseudo-cleft ("What Mary did was . . .") constructions, but in the interest of brevity I have not gone into the matter here. See below in section 4.6 for a discussion of the difference between informational focus (typically coded through intonation) and identificational focus (usually coded by some kind of movement or morphosyntactic configuation).

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The same three variations under negation also yield an interesting result: it is only the part of the sentence that has focal intonation that is negated, the rest of the sentence remains in force. The import of the negation of a particular focal constituent is often best highlighted through the use of a subsequent contrastive sentence.

(14) a. Mary didn't PUNCH the mayor on Wilshire Boulevard; (she BIT him)

b. Mary didn't punch THE MAYOR on Wilshire Boulevard; (she punched THE GOVERNOR)

c. Mary didn't punch the mayor ON WILSHIRE BOULEVARD, (she punched him IN A CAB COMING FROM THE AIRPORT)

The point is that focal intonation dramatically changes not only the pragmatic appropriateness of a particular utterance, but also the truth conditions and hence the semantics of any particular assertion.

The traditional view holds that the part of a sentence that is not focused is presuppositional just as "her husband" is presuppositional in "her husband is a fool." This is basically correct in the vast majority of cases.

(15) a. Her husband is not A FOOL.

b. Mary didn't punch the mayor ON WILSHIRE BOULEVARD.

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In both (15a) and (15b), the focused part of the sentence is negated, but the presupposed part of the sentence is not: thus, even if (15a) and (15b) are true, someone in (15a) still has a husband, and Mary will still likely go to jail for assault in (15b). But specialists in semantics have actually expended quite a bit of energy attempting to differentiate focal presuppositions as in (15) from the logical presupposition involved in some of the examples at the beginning of the chapter such as (2), repeated below as (16).

(16) a. I don't regret leaving London.

b. I left London.

The sentence in (16b) would only be a focal presupposition if the focus structure in (16a) were as in (17a) below.

(17) a. I don't REGRET leaving London.

b. I don't regret LEAVING LONDON.

The example in (17a) carries the implication that there is some other emotion that the speaker feels toward his or her departure from London, which is not the case in (16a), where the somewhat artificial omission of focal intonation forces the reader to fall back on other interpretive principles such as the factive character of "regret" (Kiparsky and Kiparsky 1970). The contrastive focus in (17b) explicitly excludes (16b) as presupposition. Clearly focus introduces an orthogonal dimension to questions of

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presupposition, and presupposition in the logical sense differs in certain fundamental ways from focal presupposition. Herburger (2000, §§2.3-2.5) has argued, quite persuasively in my view, that focal presupposition is not, in fact, presupposition at all, but rather what she terms a "backgrounded focal entailment." Nonetheless, if only so as to preserve the title of this chapter, I use presupposition in its older somewhat less precise meaning in the balance of the chapter.

Of perhaps more importance for the investigation of Sumerian morphosyntax than subtleties of presupposition and entailment in focal sentences is the basic opposition between topic and focus. Although presupposition and assertion, as a pair of related concepts, bear a great deal of similarity to topic and focus, respectively, it is probably best to keep them separate as analytical terms, even if the correlation between them does provide a good deal of the scaffolding, linking together different parts of my investigation. Definitions of and theories concerning topic and focus are, as a rule, quite involved and not immediately applicable to Sumerian at the present state of our knowledge, but I would like to characterize these phenomena in a preliminary way. To oversimplify in the direction—I hope—of truth, three features can be used to differentiate topic and focus: (a) definiteness, (b) pronominalization and (c) sentence-initial/sentence-final position. Topics are regularly definite, are capable of being resumed by pronouns in the core of the sentence and can typically be found in sentence-initial position, whereas focused constituents can be either definite or indefinite, are not resumed by pronouns in the core of the sentence and are typically found as close as possible to the end of a

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sentence (taking into consideration other typological factors such as verb-final word order).

(18) a. Gudea, Cyl. A 5:4 [ETCSL 2.1.7] (Zólyomi 1993, 35)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ e_2.a ĝiš.ḫur.bi] im.ĝa$_2$.ĝa$_2$

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ As for the plan of the temple]$_i$, he was setting it$_i$ out.

b. Gilgamesh and the Netherworld [1.8.1.4], l. 179

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ ^{ĝiš}e.ke$_4$.ma.zu] ganzer.ta [$_{\text{Focus}}$ ĝa$_2$.e] ga mu.ra.ab.e$_{11}$.de$_3$

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ As for your ekema]$_i$, let [$_{\text{Focus}}$ me] retrieve it$_i$ for you from Ganzer,

In the topic construction in (18a), the topic appears in sentence-initial position and bears a possessive pronoun, here made possible through the use of an anticipatory genitive construction ("Of the house, its plan") and I have translated it accordingly using an "As for ..." topicalization and a resumptive pronoun (the coreferential elements in the translation share the subscript "i"). As noted above, the definiteness (and hence its suitability as topic) of the topical phrase **e_2.a ĝiš.ḫur.bi** is indicated by the possessive pronoun. The focus construction in (18b), however, is in answer to a wh-question, "who will retrieve my ekema from Ganzer," and as expected in the answer to the wh-question, the first person singular pronoun **ĝa$_2$.e**, occurs as far to the right as possible in the sentence and can be juxtaposed to the topical noun phrase on the extreme left edge of the sentence.

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My working hypothesis, which has been made more-or-less explicit from time to time in the chapters leading up to this point, has taken nouns bearing a possessive pronoun in sentence-initial position (alongside ergative case-marked nouns and independent pronouns) as topical noun phrases due to the fact that they satisfy all three of the features associated with topics: the possessive pronoun construction is necessarily definite, I have assumed that they are resumed by null pronouns in the core of the sentence and have translated accordingly although I know of no independent evidence for such resumptive pronominalization, and they regularly occur in sentence-initial position. The identification of focus constructions is somewhat more difficult since they regularly lack possessive pronouns (unless they are also followed by the copula, which is presumably introduced in focus precisely so as to allow for possessive pronouns and other modifications of what would otherwise be a bare noun). Clearly the absence of resumptive pronominalization is difficult to identify, but the fact that they regularly occur in the position immediately before the sentence-final verb presumably indicates that there is no subsequent position within the sentence in which a resumptive pronoun could occur.

The two following sections (as well as the entirety of chapter 4) speak to certain aspects of topic constructions and focus constructions respectively: section 3.3 offers a reinterpretation of verbs with the prefix *mini-√ as derived from *bi-√ prefix verbs that have undergone topicalization through the addition of the third person animate possessive pronoun, *-ni, as in the case of simple nouns above. This section also goes into the rather unusual structure of certain head-internal relative clauses in Sumerian that corresponds to

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similar structures in other languages and at the same time raises the issue of definiteness effects that preoccupy section 3.4.

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3.3 Topicalized and identificational *bi-√ prefix verbs in *mini-√

Before turning to the various issues surrounding definiteness effect environments and their relation to head-internal relatives clauses, this section represents a brief tangent so as to clarify both the difference between presupposition and focus (including the association between presupposition and topicalization) and an important point of Sumerian morphology: the derivation of verbs bearing the *mini-√ prefix from underlying *bi-√ verbs through the addition of a third person animate possessive pronoun, *-ni (the derivation of *mini-√ from *bi-ni-√ was first proposed by Postgate [1974, 21-22], see Attinger 1993, 273-275 and Rubio forthcoming, §3.9.6 for recent bibliography, but the interpretation of *-ni- as the possessive pronoun has not been suggested previously). On the basis of superficial formal as well as more substantial semantic similarities, I will assume for the time being that verbs of the form *mini-√ are definite versions of the indefinite relative construction dealt with in the previous chapter. Note, however, that the examples of the indefinite relative construction cited earlier regularly lacked pre-root pronominal agreement, *bi-Ø-√, whereas the topicalized form regularly includes it, *mini-**n**-√.

Several authors have argued against Postgate's derivation of *mini-√ from *bi-ni-√ on both formal/evidential grounds as well as semantic ones. Rubio has noted (personal communication, August 2004) that if *mini-√ were derived from *bi-ni-√, we might reasonably expect that in one or two cases the underlying form (sometimes known as a "morphographemic" orthography) might be attested in the text-artifactual record. All things being equal, such an evidential requirement would be entirely valid, but in the case

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of *mini-√ < *bi-ni-√, the situation is complicated by the fact that the prefix *bi-ni-√ is attested, but it is regularly and—in my view—correctly interpreted as an orthographic representation of **bi$_2$.i$_3$**-√ (= *bi-i-√), that is the *bi-√ prefix followed by a vocalic or glide preverbal pronominal agreement marker that is often associated with the directive case (Rubio forthcoming, §3.7.3; Karahashi forthcoming, 5 and 7; on the morphological form of the directive infix /y/, see Zólyomi 2000).[28] If **bi$_2$.i$_3$**-√ were the conventional orthography for a different verbal prefix, this would explain why the underlying form of *mini-√, namely *bi-ni-√, never surfaces in the text-artifactual record. The other objection that has been raised to Postgate's derivation is that the underlying form, namely *bi-ni-√, would include two morphemes that are each "locative" in meaning and that we should expect to be in complementary distribution (Rubio forthcoming, §3.9.6). But in my view, the *-ni- element is not "locative" in meaning and, therefore, shares no complementary distribution with the *bi-√ prefix. Besides, if *-ni- were "locative" in meaning, how is it possible that it can be replaced by *-ri- in the prefix *miri-√, when *-ri- is often associated with the second person dative infix, namely *-ra-: how, in other words, do a "locative" agreement marker, *-ni-, and a second person directive case marker, *-ri-, form a coherent paradigm (see my discussion of the directive case hypothesis in section 1.1 above). If, on the other hand, the *-ni- and *-ri- infixes originate as paradigmatic alternations in the deictic series *-ne, *-be, *-re, then it makes a good

[28] Although I agree with the growing consensus as to the morphological form of the "directive infix" as it is usually now called, the morphosyntactic interpretation of the morpheme remains, in my view, quite uncertain; my support of the Zólyomi's morphological analysis should not, therefore, be taken as agreement as to the morphosyntactic function of the morpheme.

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deal of sense that two members of that paradigm might well migrate to the verb in the same morphosyntactic position.

(19) The Exploits of Ninurta [1.6.2], ll. 348-352

348. ^{d}nin.urta dumu ^{d}en.lil$_2$.la$_2$.ke$_4$	*Ninurta, the son of Enlil, wanted to do*
gal.bi i$_3$.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$	*something big,*
349. **gu.ru.um na$_4$**	*As for the pile of stones that had been*
kur.ra mi.ni.in.ak	*accumulated in the mountains,*
350. dungu diri.ga.gin$_7$	*Since it (pile of stone) stretched across them*
a$_2$ bi$_2$.in.su$_3$.su$_3$.ud	*(mountains) like floating clouds,*
351. bad$_3$ maḫ.gin$_7$ kalam.ma	*Blocking the view of the land like a huge*
igi.ba bi$_2$.in.tab.⌜ba⌝	*wall,*
352. $^{g̃iš}$bala ki.šar$_2$.ra	*He is the one who installed a spigot (?) at*
mu.ni.in.g̃ar	*the horizon,*

This is a nice example of a topicalized *bi-√ verb. The underlying form of line 349 is probably something like *[gu.ru.um na$_4$ kur.ra bi$_2$.in.√ak].ni "his (= Ninurta's) pile of rocks which he caused to accumulate in the mountains," which is marked as topic through the use of the possessive pronoun topic-marking construction. The problem is that the third person animate possessive pronoun, *-ni, apparently cannot directly follow a finite verb, when it is functioning as an indefinite relative construction, therefore I would argue that the third person animate possessive pronoun incorporates into the verbal prefix: /bin/ + /ni/ > /bi ... n/ + /ni/ > /bi-ni-n/-√ (LoAp-3AnPoss-3AnimAgr-√). I should

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emphasize that in all likelihood this is not infixation, but rather underlying suffixation: [n-√]-bi_2 + -ni > [n-√]-bi_2-ni > bi_2-ni-[n-√] > mi.ni.in.√. Whether the same goes for forms like mu.ni.in.√ ([n-√]-mu + -ni > [n-√]-mu-ni > mu-ni-[n-√] > mu.ni.in.√) and ba.ni.in.√ ([n-√]-ba + -ni > [n-√]-ba-ni > ba-ni-[n-√] > ba.ni.in.√) must remain an open question, but I hope to extend my investigation of topicalized verb forms to these other verbal prefixes in future.

(20) A tigi to Enlil for Ur-Namma (Ur-Namma B) [2.4.1.2], ll. 2-5

2. en nam.nun gal.[la.ni ...]	*The lord who ... his great princeship,*
3. ^{d}nu.nam.nir an ki lugal.[bi ...]	*As for Nunamnir, the king of heaven and earth ...,*
4. **uĝ$_3$.ĝa$_2$ igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$** sipa zi ur.^{d}⌈namma⌉	*Looked around among the people—the good shepherd, Ur-Namma,*
5. kur gal ^{d}en.lil$_2$.le uĝ$_3$ šar$_2$.ra.ni.a im.ma.ni.in.pa$_3$.$^{?}$ [(x)]	*The Great Mountain, Enlil, chose him from among the multitude,*

The ETCSL translation in (20) attaches the first half of line 4 to the previous line as its main predicate, but given the conventions of line demarcation, in which a finite verb would generally end its line unless a sequence of short predicates followed (not the case here), it is unlikely that **uĝ$_3$.ĝa$_2$ igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$** is a finite main clause. Given its position at the beginning of a series of epithets, the most reasonable hypothesis is that it is a relative clause describing a characteristic of Ur-Namma, namely that he is "the one given prominence, lit. the one whose head was raised up over the people." This allows the first

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half of line 4 to be the first of a pair of epithets preceding the mention of Ur-Namma at the end of line 4, which also characterizes the relationship that holds between Enlil and Ur-Namma. The use of a topicalized indefinite relative as an epithet is not particularly surprising, but the same construction is also used to form relative clauses which cannot be characterized as epithets such as the following.

(21) Lugalbanda II [ETCSL 1.8.2.2], ll. 207-208

207. [mušen.e **an].ta igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$**	*As for the Bird, who was looking from*
erin$_2$.e igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru	*above, she saw the troops,*
208. [lugal].⌈ban$_3$⌉.da **ki.ta igi**	*As for Lugalbanda, who was looking from*
mi.ni.in.il$_2$ saḫar erin$_2$.e du$_8$.a	*below, he saw the troops enveloped*
igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru	*in dust,*

A literal interpretation of line 207, for example, would need to include the causative semantics of non-BNBV$_{inal}$ *bi-√ prefix verbs, yielding "The bird, whose eye was raised up, saw the troops." But since **igi** is an inalienable noun, we can reasonably infer that it was the bird who raised his own eyes and translate accordingly (note that the causative semantics of the non-BNBV$_{inal}$ predicate is preserved, however, indicating that there is an agent/causer of the action, which is not true of BNBV$_{inal}$ predicates—this corresponds to the fact that verbs of attempted perception such as "look" and "listen" tend to be agentive cross-linguistically, whereas verbs of achieved perception such as "see" and "hear" do not). Manuscript QQ (3 N-T 824), interestingly, offers a different form of the first verb in

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line 207: instead of **igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$ eren$_2$.e igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru**, QQ has **igi i$_3$.il$_2$ eren$_2$.na igi bi$_2$.ib.du$_8$**. This raises the possibility that in QQ the redactor interpreted the first half of the line as a finite verb, **i$_3$.il$_2$**, followed by a second finite verb, but a second verb that is no longer a BNBV$_{inal}$ construction due to the locative postposition that follows **eren$_2$** in manuscript QQ. Although I can do no more than speculate, one possibility is that a single ergative case-marked noun cannot function as an agent with respect to one predicate, **i$_3$.il$_2$**, and as an inalienable possessor with respect to another, **igi bi$_2$.ib.du$_8$**. This seems to be further supported by the fact that the majority version, which is a BNBV$_{inal}$ construction, agrees with the perceived object in number: **bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru** (< bi-n-dur-eš = LoAp-3AnimArg-see-Plur). Such an agreement pattern only seems to be available in the BNBV$_{inal}$ predicate, since the variant form of the line in manuscript QQ, **bi$_2$.ib.du$_8$** (< bi-b-dur = LoAp-3InanAgr-see) either agrees with some other argument or treats **erin$_2$** as a collective. The "collective" interpretation would seem to be favored by the presence of the locative postposition following **erin$_2$** in manuscript QQ. Two further examples that are similar in a number of respects occur in Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta, line 172 in (22) below, and the Exploits of Ninurta, line 349 in (23) below.

(22) Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta [1.8.2.3], ll. 170-174

170. ḫur.sağ 5(diš) ḫur.sağ 6(diš) ḫur.sağ 7(diš).e im.me.re.bala.bala	*He traversed five mountains, six mountains, seven mountains,*
171. [igi mu.un].⌜il$_2$⌝ aratta^{ki}.aš ba.te	*He lifted his eyes as he approached Aratta.*

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172. **[kisal] ⌜aratta⌝^{ki}.ka ĝiri$_3$ hul$_2$.la mi.ni.in.gub**	*As for the one who had been made to take the joyful path to the court of Aratta,*
173. nam.nir.ĝal$_2$ lugal.a.na mu.un.zu	*He made known the authority of his king,*
174. bur$_2$.ra.bi inim ša$_3$.ga.na bi$_2$.ib$_2$.be$_2$	*As for the solution (of the riddle), he recited the words he had memorized, lit. the words of his heart,*

As in the previous examples, there is a locative argument in the construction, namely **kisal aratta^{ki}.ka**, "in the halls of Aratta," but forms in which there is a locative or ablative argument such as this one seem to differ systematically from those in which a terminative postposition occurs in the same position such as in the following example from Lugalbanda.

(23) Lugalbanda II [1.8.2.2], ll. 345-351

345. ĝi$_6$.sa$_9$.a ^{ĝiš}banšur ku$_3$ ^{d}inanna.ke$_4$ nu.um.ma.te.a.aš	*At midnight, before they had brought the offering-table to pure Inanna,*
346. sig$_4$ kul.aba$_4$^{ki}.še$_3$ ĝiri$_3$ ḫul$_2$.la **mi.ni.in.gub**	*As for the one who made him take the joyful path to brick-built Kulaba,*
347. nin.a.ni ku$_3$ ^{d}inanna.ke$_4$	*As for his lady, holy Inanna,*
348. ša$_3$.da.ga.na mu.na.an.tuš	*She was seated*[29] *on her cushion,*

[29] The translation of the line so as to render Inanna relatively non-agentive is due to the use of **ku$_3$ ^{d}inanna.ke$_4$**, where the inclusion of the adjectival epithet seems to indicate that Inanna is in the locative-terminative rather than the ergative case.

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349. i_3.gur_2 ki.a mu.na.ab.za *He bowed and prostrated himself before her on the ground,*

Here, in the famous presentation scene from the end of Lugalbanda II, the reinterpretation of **mi.ni.in.gub** as a topicalized indefinite relative construction in combination with the causative semantics of non-$BNBV_{inal}$ *bi-√ prefix verbs would, if it were equivalent to the four previous examples, result in the translation of line 346 as an epithet characterizing Lugalbanda as causee ("The one made to take the joyful path to brick-built Kulaba"). But such an interpretation (though in conformity with the general tenor of previous interpretations) makes little since in context since both the line preceding 346 and the two lines that follow line 346 are a description of Inanna in which the entrance of Lugalbanda is, at least from a literary point of view, intrusive. There is, however, an important formal difference between this example and the four previous examples: whereas the location in the previous examples was in either the locative or the ablative case, the location in line 346 is in the terminative case: **sig_4 kul.aba$_4^{ki}$.$še_3$**. Since there is no obvious semantic difference between the locative construction in, for example, line 172 of (22) above and the terminative construction in line 346, I would guess that the opposition between locative and terminative is coding some other syntactic or semantic feature that has previously gone unnoticed.

On the basis of contextual coherence and narrative sequence, I would hypothesize that, whereas *mini-√ constructions that occur with a locative are causative relative clauses that characterize the *causee* in some fashion, *mini-√ constructions that occur with a terminative postposition characterize the *causer* or agent. This would allow line

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346 to function as a characterization of Inanna rather than Lugalbanda. At first such a reinterpretation may seem to disturb the narrative coherence of the passage, but in my view it improves it markedly: whereas previous interpretations place Lugalbanda's entrance in the middle of a series of lines otherwise devoted to increasingly circumscribed contextual descriptions of Inanna, in the reinterpretation offered here, lines 345 through 347 form a series of circumstantial clauses and epithets describing the goddess Inanna, culminating with the description of her sitting on her cushion in line 348. Line 349 then represents Lugalbanda's formal entrance into her presence.

There are several others examples in which a phrase in the terminative case occurs with a *mini-√ verb; the interpretation of these passages is quite difficult, but some of them would seem to allow for an analysis in which they can be characterized as relative clauses that refer to a *causer* rather than a *causee* as I suggest.

(24) The Death of Gilgamesh, segment F [1.8.1.3], ll. 180-183

(Kramer 1944; van Dijk 1967, 248-250; Wilcke 1970, 82-84; Klein 1990a, 64-65; Jacobson 1980, 19-20, 23; George 1999, 195-208; Cavigneaux and al-Rawi 2000a; Veldhuis 2001; George 2003, 14-17)

180. ⌜si⌝.si.ig dumu ^{d}utu.[ke$_4$]	*Sisig (a god of dreams), the son of Utu,*
181. **ki.bi ku$_3$.ku$_3$.ga u$_4$.še$_3$**	*the one who enlightens a place of*
mi.ni.in.⌜g̃ar⌝	*darkness,*

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182. nig_2.<gig> ak.a	*"What my evil magic of humanity brings will*
$nam.lu_2.ulu_3.ĝu_{10}$ $i.de_6$	*now be brought to you,*
$ma.ra.an.⌈tum_3⌉$	
183. nig_2 $gi.dur$ $ku_5.da.ĝu_{10}$	*What my cutting of the umbilical cord brings*
$i.de_6$ $ma.ra.an.⌈tum_3⌉$	*will now be brought to you,"*

My line numbering follows the reconstruction of Cavigneaux and Al-Rawi's new edition, which includes the Meturan texts (Cavigneaux and Al-Rawi 2000a, 16, N_1 v 4-6; 31, 179-183); the passage corresponds to ETCSL, segment F, lines 141-144. Except for line 181 (= ETCSL line 142), my translation conforms quite closely to that of Veldhuis (2001, 144). Lines 182 and 183 are quite difficult to understand and very little has been written about these two lines (Veldhuis 2001, 137), even in Cavigneaux and Al-Rawi's edition (2000a, 16, 20). But a comparison of the versions from Nippur and Meturan seems to shed some light on the matter. The most difficult part of line 182, for example, is the word **i.de$_6$** (with the variant **i.da**), but it seems that the line has been misunderstood by the scribes of Meturan (the sigla follow Cavigneaux and Al-Rawi 2000a, N = Nippur, M = Meturan).

N_1 v 17	nig_2 ⌈gig⌉ ak $nam.lu_2.ulu_3.ke_4$ ne.en de_6.a $ma.ra.du_{11}$
N_2 v 17	nig_2 ⌈gig⌉ ak $nam.lu_2.ulu_3^{lu}$.ka ne.en de_6.a $ma.ra.du_{11}$
M_2 iv	⌈nig_2⌉ <gig> ak.a $nam.lu_2.ulu_3.ĝu_{10}$ i.da $ma.ra.an.[tum_3]$
M_6 iii	nig_2 <gig> ⌈ak⌉.[a] x x x x ⌈$de_6^{?}$⌉ ma.ra [...]
M_1 iv	nig_2 <gig> ak.a $nam.⌈lu_2⌉.ulu_3.ĝu_{10}$ $i.de_6$ ma.ra [...]

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In the two exemplars from Nippur, we find the phrase **ne.en de$_6$.a**, which consists of what Woods has described as a "demonstrative adverb of manner" followed by a nominalized form of the verb √de$_6$ (Woods 2001, 67). On the basis of Woods' interpretation, the line should probably be translated as follows: "he (= Sisig) has told you that the bane of humanity is brought about in this way (i.e., by means of death)." The scribes at Meturan, however, arrived at the form **i.da/de$_6$** instead of **ne.en de$_6$.a**, presumably because they were unfamiliar with the use of demonstrative manner adverbs in Sumerian. I suspect that Meturan scribes may have reinterpreted a later orthographic form of **ne.en de$_6$.a** as an Akkadian gloss of some kind, *i-da* and *i-du* respectively. That is to say *i-du* and *i-da* may have been interpreted as first person forms of the verb *edû*, "to know," which may also explain the otherwise inexplicable presence of a first person possessive pronoun in the Sumerian of the witnesses from Meturan, when no such pronoun appears in the Nippur manuscripts.

(25) Enlil and Sud [1.2.2], ll. 145-148 (Heimerdinger 1979, 1-2; Civil 1983)

145. nam i.ri.tar.ra.g̃u$_{10}$ ḫe$_2$.em.ši.g̃al$_2$	*As for the fate I have determined for you,*
(*var.* nig̃$_2$ nu.kur$_2$.ru) sag̃ il$_2$.la	*it should be fulfilled (not be altered)!*
e$_2$.maḫ.še$_3$ g̃en.na	*Go to the Emah head held high,*
146. šu.ni im.ma.an.dab$_5$ **^{d}a.ru.ru eš$_3$**	*As for her hand, it was Aruru, the one who*
maḫ.še$_3$ mi.ni.in.kar	*led her to the Eshmah, who grabbed it,*
147. e$_2$.kur e$_2$ ^{d}en.lil$_2$.ke$_4$	*She brought her into the Ekur, the house of*
mu.un$^{!}$.ši.ib.ku$_4$ x [...]	*Enlil, and ...,*

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The curious word-order in line 146 of (25) presumably results from a secondary topicalization of **šu.ni im.ma.an.dab$_5$** based on an underlying word-order such as *^{d}a.ru.ru eš$_3$ maḫ.še$_3$ mi.ni.in.kar [šu.ni im.ma.an.dab$_5$] > **[šu.ni im.ma.an.dab$_5$] ^{d}a.ru.ru eš$_3$ maḫ.še$_3$ mi.ni.in.kar**. This change in word order probably reflects a contrast between two types of *mini-√ predicate: what I refer to below as topicalizing and identificational uses of the *mini-√ prefix. The topicalizing form corresponds to the underlying form *^{d}a.ru.ru eš$_3$ maḫ.še$_3$ mi.ni.in.kar [šu.ni im.ma.an.dab$_5$], "As for Aruru, the one who led her into the Eshmah, . . .," as opposed to the identificational use represented by line 146: "The one who grabbed her hand is Aruru, who led her to the Eshmah." Other interpretive possibilities certainly exist, but these depend on the interpretation of **im.ma.an.dab$_5$**, which is far from secure.

(26) Gilgamesh and the Netherworld [1.8.1.4], UET 6, 60, ll. 1-6

(George 1999, 190-191; Cavigneaux and Al-Rawi 2000b, 1-19; George 2003, 743, fn. 4, 769-770, 777)

1. [unug^{ki}] ⌈im.mi.gi$_4$.gi$_4$⌉.[ne]	*They returned to Uruk,*
2. ⌈iri⌉.bi im.mi.gi$_4$.gi$_4$.⌈ne⌉	*As for their city, they returned to it,*
3. ⌈ĝiš!⌉**šu.kar$_2$ a$_2$.kar$_2$.ra.ke$_4$**$^{pa.a.šu}$	*As for the one who had them girded with*
a$_2$.gid$_2$.[da] da.da.ra.še$_3$	*gear and equipment,*
mi.ni.in.⌈ku$_4$⌉	*axe and spear (= Gilgamesh),*
4. e$_2$.gal.la.na ḫul$_2$.⌈ḫul$_2$⌉.la	*As for those made to celebrate in his palace*
mi.ni.in.ĝar	*(= his soldiers),*

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5. ĝuruš ki.sikil unug^{ki}.ga saĝ.tuku ⌜bur.šum$_2$⌝.ma ⌜kul.[aba^{ki}]	*The young men and the young women of Uruk and the male and female elites of Kulaba,*
6. alan.bi igi mu.un.bar.bar.re.ne im.ma.ḫul$_2$.ḫul$_2$.la	*As for their statue, as they were staring at it, they rejoiced,*

Likewise, an interpretation of this passage in which the terminative *mini-√ construction in line 3 referred to the causer, namely Gilgamesh, while the locative *mini-√ construction in line 4 referred to a causee such as Gilgamesh's soldiers "made to rejoice" in Gilgamesh's palace, would yield a nice sequence of the various constituencies who participate in the celebration of the new statue: Gilgamesh himself, his soldiers, the young men and women, and the male and female elites.

(27) Winter and Summer [5.3.3], ll. 102-106

(Gragg 1973a, 57, 72; Vanstiphout 1997, 586)

102. u$_2$.kuš$_8$ en.[te.en.na x] ša$_3$ sug$_4$ šeg$_7$ saĝ.ĝa$_2$ x [...] e$_3$.a	*... brought forth in the early rain,*
103. lu.ub$_2^{sar}$ gal.gal AGA[?] gal.e ku$_5$.da TUN$_3$.LA$_2$[30] ga.raš^{sar} gid$_2$.da	*Large turnips, large ..., cut down with an axe(?), long leeks,*
104. en.te.en.e gu$_2$.un ĝar.ra.bi.še$_3$ ni$_2$.ba mi.ni.in.ĝar.ĝar	*Since Winter was the one who brought the tribute he had collected himself,*

[30] This line is relatively straightforward except for TUN$_3$.LA$_2$, which could be interpreted as a cutting device or, alternatively as a depression in the ground (= Akk. *mušpalu*).

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105. e_2 nam.ti.la e_2 ^{d}en.lil$_2$.la$_2$.še$_3$	*For the E'namtila, the house of Enlil,*
106. e_2.me.eš en.te.en.bi.da maš$_2$	*Summer and Winter set about organizing the*
kadra si ba.ni.in.sa$_2$.sa$_2$.eš	*animals and offerings,*

Here—I would argue—we see a distinct use of the *mini-√ construction that is probably not topicalizing, since there is no subsequent clause for which the *mini-√ clause can act as an argument. Lines 105 and 106 involve **en.te.en**, "Winter," but only as accompanied by **e$_2$.me.eš**, "Summer," so it is unlikely that the clause in line 104 acts as the subject of a plural verb in line 106, namely **si ba.ni.in.sa$_2$.sa$_2$.eš**. The reduplication of the verbal root, as suggested in the previous chapter, may serve as an indication that line 104 as a whole functions in an adjectival/adverbial capacity with respect to another clause, hence my use of the translation "since . . ." in line 104. Although the precise function of the *mini-√ prefix in line 104 and other cases like it remains unclear, in the following I classify such examples as "identificational" (like the example in [25] above) on the assumption that the primary function of such clauses is to introduce a property of topical noun such as **en.te.en** in line 104 without directly linking the descriptive clause itself to any nearby clause (as seems regularly the case with the topicalizing use of the *mini-√ prefix). In more formal or diagnostic terms, the characteristic feature of identificational *mini-√ predicates is that the line in which it occurs begins with a coreferential noun in the ergative case and that it cannot act as an argument of the following clause (in [25], the coreferential noun was implicit in the initial verb, **im.ma.ab.dab$_5$**).

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(28) A tigi to Enlil for Ur-Namma (Ur-Namma B) [2.4.1.2], ll. 20-22

(Castellino 1957; 1959, 106-118; Sjöberg 1961, ll. 51-70; Cavigneaux 1987, 49-51; Civil 1985, 27-37; Hurowitz 1992, 57-59; Klein 1989, 44-62)

20. **sipa ^{d}ur.^{d}namma.ke$_4$ e$_2$.kur maḫ**	*The shepherd, Ur-Namma, is the one who*
dur.an.ki.a.ka an.še$_3$	*made the lofty E-kur grow high in*
mi.ni.in.mu$_2$	*Dur-an-ki,*
21. u$_6$ di.bi.še$_3$ uĝ$_3$ šar$_2$.ra.ba	*He made it to be wondered at by the*
ši.im.ma.gub	*multitude of people,*
22. ka$_2$.maḫ ka$_2$.gal ka$_2$.silim.ma	*Of the Lofty Gate, the Great Gate, the Gate*
ḫur.saĝ galam.ma ka$_2$	*of Peace—of the Hursan-galama and*
še nu.ku$_5$.da	*the Grain Not Diverted Gate,*
23. su$_3$.ra$_2$.aĝ$_2$ ku$_3$ me.a sig$_7$.igi.ba	*He is the one who decorated their eyebrow-*
še.er.ka.an mu.ni.in.du$_{11}$	*shaped arches with Sudran-stones and refined silver,*

Here in (28), the use of the *mini-√ prefix is identificational as well. In terms of the semantics of causation, the example in (28) is among the clearest, since whatever the overall discursive structure of the passage, it is clear that Ur-Namma must be the causer rather than the causee of **mi.ni.in.mu$_2$**, hence "the one who made it grow" rather than "the one made to grow."

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(29) Lugalbanda I [1.8.2.1], l. 409-413 (Vanstiphout 2003, 126-127; Gadotti 2004)

409. u_4 ⌜ga⌝ LAM nig_2 $giri_{17}$.zal	*By day . . ., they promise, luxury,*
[im].ma.ab.$šum_2$.mu.ne	
410. ⌜$ĝi_6$⌝.u_3.na $muš_3$ za.gin_3	*At night they chant over the gleaming plain,*
im.⌜ši⌝.ib.$šir_3$.re.de_3.ne	
411. si.si.ig $sim^{mušen}$.$sim^{mušen}$ ^{d}utu.ka	*As for those who are brought in on the tail*
ur_2.ba šu mi.ni.in.te	*of the breezes, the swallows of Utu,*
412. e_2.e_2.a i.im.ku_4.ku_4.ne	*They enter house after house,*
413. e.sir_2.e.sir_2.ra	*Street after street they haunt,*
gu_2 mu.un.gid_2.gid_2.i.ne	

So, although it is not always possible to differentiate between them, there seem to be two distinct uses of the *mini-√ construction that have been mentioned up to this point, topicalizing and identificational. Although the topicalizing use is prototypical, the identificational use can be easily identified since it regularly occurs at the end of a textual passage. The following is a particularly good example of the phenomenon.

(30) Lament over Sumer and Ur [2.2.3], ll. 81-82.

81. u_4.ba an ba.dub_2 ki ba.sig_3 igi	*On that day, heaven rumbled, the earth*
u_4.da ba.lim	*shook, the storm did not sleep,*
82. an ba.$suḫ_3$.$suḫ_3$ gissu ba.an.la_2	*The heavens were confused, a shadow hung*
kur.ra ur_5 mi.ni.ib.$ša_4$	*over them, and the mountain was made*
	to roar,

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In (30), the final verb in a series of verbs that describe the storm appears in the form *mini-√. The lines following line 82 treat other figures such as the sun-god Utu and the storm does not recur in these lines, so the final verb in line 82 cannot be acting as a topicalized phrase for a following predicate. In my view, the use of *mini-√ in line 82 acts to demarcate a sequence of lines from an unrelated sequence to follow.

(31) Nippur Lament 103-104 (Vanstiphout 1985, 3; Tinney 1996, 104-105, 150, 207)

102. uru_2 ĝal_2.la.bi nu.ĝal_2.la	*As for their city, which once existed, it is*
mi.ni.in.ku_4.ra.am_3	*the one that became, lit., was made,*
	non-existent,
103. dim_2.ma.bi ĝiri_3	*As for their reason, it was what got lost,*
ib_2.ta.an.kur_2.ra.am_3	
104. umuš.bi in.suḫ$_3$.am_3 lil_2.e	*As for their intelligence, he confused it and*
bi_2.in.sag_3.ga.am_3	*made it haunted,*
105. u_2.bi a.bi ib_2.ta.an.kar.ra.am_3	*As for their food, as for their water, it was*
	what they were deprived of,
106. ga zu kaš zu.a u_4.bi	*As for their time of familiarity with milk*
mi.ni.ib.til.la.am_3	*and beer, it is what was brought to an*
	end,

In (31), we see the combination of a topicalized phrase, **uru_2 ĝal_2.la.bi**, and a corresponding, presumably "identificational," *mini-√ construction followed by the copula. The identificational character of the *mini-√ construction is fairly clear and

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similar to the previous examples of identificational *mini-√ constructions, except for the fact that the topical noun phrase in this case is not in the ergative case, but rather a possessive pronoun topicalization construction. At the same time, since the lexical meaning of the presupposed predicate **ĝal$_2$.la** is precisely the opposite of the focused predicate in **nu.ĝal$_2$.la**, the role of the copula as a contrastive focus marker is particularly clear (see below, section 5.6, for an extended discussion of identificational focus).

My suggestion that *mini-√ prefix verbs, and in particular verbs having the prefix *mini-b-√, act as textual demarcators along the lines of our own paragraph indentation is also supported, in part, by the overall distribution of *mini-b-√ prefix verbs in the Old Babylonian corpus. Unlike verbs of the form *mini-n-√, which occur in non-final positions relatively often, verbs of the form *mini-b-√ regularly occur at the end of their respective line with only a handful of exceptions, most of which occur in texts that I suspect were composed in the Isin-Larsa period (including, crucially, a large number of exceptions that occur in the laments). Although I hope to conduct an exhaustive comparison between verbs of the form *mini-n-√ as opposed to those of the form *mini-b-√ in future so as to further solidify the difference between topical and identificational uses of the *mini-√ prefix,[31] I have not attempted to do so for the time being. The most that can be said is that *mini-b-√ prefix verbs tend to occur in final position, whereas verbs of the form *mini-n-√ show no such restriction. Given such a distribution, one strong possibility that should be explored in future work is that the opposition between

[31] In morphological terms, the alternation is driven by difference of grammatical aspect, but the morphology itself does not explain the distributional differences between the two constructions.

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*-n- and *-b- in conjunction with the *bi-√ prefix is used to indicate "same" and "switch" reference respectively. The relatively few cases assembled here conform to such a model in that in the examples of topicalizing use with *mini-n-√, the "subject" of the relative will also typically be the subject of the main clause (hence "same"), whereas the examples with *-b- (not presented here in detail) tend to be identificational in use and to end a discursive unit, so that the subject of the following clause is different (hence "switch"). I do not attempt to investigate the matter further here.

There are also a couple of examples of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates that appear in *mini-√ constructions; both examples are of **igi-√du$_8$** "to see" and occur in related texts.

(32) Dumuzi's Dream [1.4.3], ll. 138-142

(Alster 1972, 68-69; forthcoming; Heimerdinger 1979, pl. 4, bottom right)

138. nin$_9$ ki šeš am$_3$.mu.un.pa$_3$.de$_3$.a	*The sister who reveals where her brother is,*
139. u$_4$ ul$^?$.la$_2$.ta a.ba.a	*Since the most ancient times who has seen*
igi mi.ni.in.du$_8$.a	*such a person,*
140. g̃a$_2$.nam.ma.an.ze$_2$.en ku.li.ni.ir	*Come! Let us go to his friend!*
ga.an.ši.re$_7$.en.de$_3$.en	
141. u$_4$ ne ku.li.ni.ir	*On the day that, to his friend,*
142. i$_7$ a.ba mu.un.na.ba.e.ne	*they offer a river's worth of water, he will*
šu am$_3$.ma.gid$_2$.de$_3$.en	*accept it,*

The textual witnesses to line 139 show a great deal of variation in the form of the verb without even so much as an arbitrary statistical edge for **mi.ni.in.du$_8$.a**.

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(33) Textual witnesses to Dumuzi's Dream, line 139

Synthetic text	u_4 $ul^?.la_2$.ta a.ba.a igi mi.ni.in.du_8.a
a = UET 6, 18 (Ur)	[...] ⌜igi⌝ mu.ni.in.du_8
e = UET 6, 187 (Ur)	[...] gim.mu.ni [...]
f = A 30256 (Nippur)	u_4.⌜ul.la_2⌝ [...]
i = UM 29-15-236+ (Nippur)	[...] $\tilde{G}A_2$ ba.ta mu.ni.in [...]
E' = 3N-T 908, 289 (Nippur)	[...].a mi.ni.in.du_8.a

In his original edition, Alster restores the beginning of the line on the basis of line 155 of Gilgamesh and Huwawa, version B [1.8.1.5.1] (corresponding to line 143 of Edzard's edition [1993, 33]); lines 154 and 155 read as follows: **gudu$_4$ dab$_5$.ba ḫi.li.še$_3$ gur.ra.am$_3$ / u$_4$ ul.li$_2$.a.ta a.ba.a igi im.mi.in.du$_8$**, "A captured gudu-priest restored to his wig! Who has ever seen such a thing?" The verbal form **igi im.mi.in.du$_8$** also appears in a passage from *The Death of Gilgamesh* in column 6, line 15a of Cavigneaux and Al-Rawi's edition (2000a, 17): **u$_4$.ul.li$_2$.a.ta [a].ba.a igi ⌜im.mi⌝.in.du$_8$.a**. Apparently the sequence **igi im.mi** was something of a tongue-twister: because of the prosody of the /iCi-iCi/ pattern as well as the alternation between /g/ and /b/ in Emesal and Emegir (in slightly different contexts), problems of dissimilation and resyllabification may have been in play. Note in particular the orthography of witness "e" of Dumuzi's Dream, where **igi** has been, at least in phonological terms, incorporated into the verb, **gim.mu.ni**. At the same time, the subtle morphosyntactic distinction between **a.ba.a igi im.mi.in.du$_8$** and **a.ba.a igi mi.ni.in.du$_8$** probably comes down to a difference between an indirect

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perception ("he saw that . . .") and an indefinite relative that has, subsequently, been made definite ("he is the one who saw . . ."). In line 139, if we can base ourselves on the opposition between direct, **bi$_2$.in.du$_{11}$**, and indirect speech, **im.mi.in.du$_{11}$**, we might expect a form such as **igi im.mi.in.du$_8$**. But the fact that the statement is a rhetorical question that expects a negative answer, may have led the copyists to draw an analogy with a negated verb of perception such as **igi nu mu.ni.du$_8$.am$_3$** (*Gilgamesh and the Netherworld* 302), which closely mirrors the form of the verb in several witnesses. All of these factors would seem to indicate that **igi mi.ni.in.du$_8$.a** is simply ungrammatical, the result of either phonological or grammatical misprision.

(34) Dumuzi and Geshtinana [1.4.1.1], lines 52-55 (Sladek 1974, 229, 234-235; Wilcke 1969b, 86)

52. šu.ĝar sa$_6$.ga nu.tuku.me.eš sa$_6$.ga ḫul nu.zu.me.eš	*Demons are never kind, they do not know good from evil,*
53. lu$_2$.u$_3$ e$_2$.nu ni$_2$.te.na zi.ni silim.ma[32] **a.ba.a igi mi.ni.in.du$_8$**	*Who has ever seen a man, without a family, all alone, escape with his life?*
54. ki ku.li.bi nu.um.ši.du$^{!}$.de$_3$.en ki mi$_2$.us$_2$.sa$_2$.bi nu.um.ši.du.de$_3$.en	*We shall go neither to the dwelling of his friend nor his in-laws,*

[32] The syntax of this line is quite interesting: the topic of the line, **zi.ni**, "his life," forms the final component of the anticipatory genitive construction **ni$_2$.te.na zi.ni**. The reflexive pronoun /niten/ then acts as a pivot for and is coreferential with the clause initial **lu$_2$.u$_3$**, which acts as the subject of the initial phrase, **lu$_2$.u$_3$ e$_2$ nu**, "a man without a house, lit. the man, to/for whom there is no house." The topical phrase, **zi.ni**, is the subject of **silim.ma**, "that it (= **zi.ni**) is well/whole," and the adjectival predicate followed by the complementizer *-a, **silim.ma**, then serves as the "complement" of **mi.ni.in.du$_8$**. If my suggestion as to the derivation of *mini-√ from *bi-ni-√ is true, it may even be possible to interpret mi.ni.in.du8 as the head of an anticipatory genitive: "Of a man without ..., who is his perceiver ([*igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$]-ni)," but the matter clearly requires further study.

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55. su_8.ba.ra ki ^{d}ğeštin.an.na.ka.$še_3$ ga.an.ši.re_7.en.de_3.en

Rather, for the shepherd, let us go to the dwelling of Geshtinana,

The interesting thing about these two examples is that they conform to the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction in that the experiencer appears in the ergative case as an inalienable possessor of a body-part noun, a.ba.a < /aba-e/, and there is not even a hint of the causative semantics that we might expect with a non-$BNBV_{inal}$ predicate, but the subtle differences between **bi_2.in.du_8**, **im.mi.in.du_8** and **mi.ni.in.du_8**, which all seem to come down to matters of quantification and definiteness are in need of further investigation (see the end of this chapter for one possible set of distinctions).

The obvious question is why the alternation between a locative postposition and the terminative position should have anything to with whether the relative form in *mini-√ refers to a causer or a causee. But recall the discussion of progressive/imperfective achievements in chapter 2. There I argued that progressive/imperfective achievements are unusual in that, whereas the non-progressive/perfective form is regularly non-agentive, the progressive/imperfective form has the possibility of expressing agentivity due to the "activity" inherent in any progressive/imperfective verb. There is, in other words, an association between activity predicates (as well as the activity component of accomplishments) and agentivity. If, as I argued at the beginning of the section, *mini-n-√ predicates are derived from the *bi-√ prefix indefinite relative construction, which is in turn limited to non-progressive/perfective aspect by the indefinite head noun that it serves as the relativization of, it should come as no surprise that the topicalized

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form of the indefinite relative in *mini-√, likewise, rarely if ever occurs in the progressive/imperfective aspect. But the opposition between the locative postposition, *-a, and the terminative postposition, *-še$_3$, seems to mirror the opposition between non-progressive/perfective aspect and progressive/imperfective aspect: whereas the locative, *-a, indicates location in or at (and thereby implicitly the completion of the movement or event), the terminative, *-še$_3$, indicates motion toward (and thereby the non-completion of the movement or event). So as to clarify the difference, the opposition between *-a and *-še$_3$ is perhaps best understood as an opposition between a "virtual perfective aspect," *-a, and a "virtual imperfective aspect," *-še$_3$: but only when all other avenues of marking the opposition between non-progressive/perfective and progressive/imperfective are neutralized as in the case of *mini -√ constructions does the aspectual opposition between virtual perfective and virtual imperfective aspect come into play.

Linguists working with a number of different languages have repeatedly noted that so-called head-internal relative clauses regularly take an indefinite noun as the head of such a relative clause (Williamson 1987 on Lakhota; Hale 1976 on the languages of Australia; Watanabe 1992 [cf. Nishigauchi forthcoming]; cf. Aldridge 2004 for a discussion of internally-headed relatives from the point-of-view of antisymmetry). In other traditions of grammatical investigation such as Assyriology and Egyptology, these are often spoken of as indefinite or appositional relative constructions (for an overview of previous interpretations of relativization in Sumerian, see Alster 2002) and are built up on the model of the Semitic construct state, where the initial, head noun must necessarily be unmarked for definiteness (for recent discussions of the Semitic construct state, see

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Shlonsky 2004). If one were to translate one of these internally-headed relatives into English, the result is a kind of apposition as in "Susan, a present had been given to her by her father," but such a sentence in English sounds odd, even if does highlight the fact that topicalization is often used to form such constructions: the referent of the relative construction being introduced as topical noun and the head-internal relative following as comment qualifying (in predicate-like fashion) the referent of the topicalized noun phrase.

(35) $[_{\text{Topic}}$ Susan$]_i$ $[_{\text{Focus}}$ a present had been given to her$_i$ by her father]

Constructions like this are well-known from head-marking languages (cf. Nichols 1986) and in topic-prominent languages such as Japanese and Korean, where a great deal of research into head-internal relatives has taken place.

One of the most interesting and surprising features of head-internal relative constructions (hereafter HIRC) is that there is a subtle and not entirely well-understood interaction between the head-internal relative itself, which is necessarily indefinite, and various markers of definiteness that can be attached "outside" the HIRC to indicate the definiteness of the entire relative clause. On the basis of Williamson (1987), Lyons (1999, 251) provides a nice example of the subtle dance of (in)definiteness in head-internal relatives from Lakhota (note that I have neglected the retroflex diacritics in the following example, see the referenced sources for the original transcription).

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(36) [[Joe wowapi wa owa] ki] wac'i

Joe book a wrote the want-1Sg

I want the book that Joe wrote

In (36), the indefinite determiner "wa" occurs inside the relative clause and indicates which noun is being relativized. The definite determiner "ki" then modifies the entire relative clause (although the determiner that modifies the entire clause can be either definite or indefinite). Readers who have some familiarity with Semitic languages will immediately recognize this as the pattern of (in)definiteness that underlies the genitive construction known as the construct state, where the head (possessed) noun cannot bear a definite determiner (hence definiteness is neutralized) and the definiteness of the entire construction is determined by either the presence or the absence of the article on the possessor. This allows one to draw a parallel between the Semitic construct state and the HIRC constructions in Akkadian (the following examples, after Huehnergard 2000, 188).

(37) a. [$_{DP}$ [$_{Topic}$ Ø] [$_{Focus}$ *bīt* *ēpuš-u*]] *imqut*

Ø house do.1Sg.Perf-Subord fall.3Sg.Perf

A/the house I built collapsed

b. [$_{DP}$ [$_{Topic}$ *bīt-um*] [$_{Focus}$ *ša* *ēpuš-u*]] *imqut*

house-Def Rel do.1Sg.Perf-Subord fall.3Sg.Perf

As for the house, namely the one I built, it collapsed,

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Although the omission of the nominal suffix *-um* and the relative pronoun *ša* is often taken as more-or-less arbitrary, the fact that *ša* can be replaced by indefinite pronouns such as *mamma(n)* "someone" and *mimma* "something" (Huehnergard 2000, 188) indicates that the construction in (37a) is not so much indefinite as neutralized with respect to definiteness, expressing neither definiteness nor indefiniteness. In (37b), however, the pattern of the two constructions comes into view: the suffix *-um*, as elsewhere in Akkadian, indicates that the noun that it modifies is a topic (this topichood was subsequently assimilated to nominative case, but such assimilation is a secondary phenomenon [the association of *-um* with topic and *-am* with focus undoubtedly served as the basis for a later assimilation to a nominative/accusative rection along the same lines as, for example, *-(n)un* and *-(l)ul* in Korean, cf. the contrast between **-e** and **-am$_3$** in Sumerian]). If *bītum* is taken as a topic, the rest of the relative clause in (37b) can then be interpreted as a HIRC, where the frozen relative marker, *ša* (at least in Old Babylonian), corresponds to a highly grammaticalized demonstrative indicating definiteness or specificity. The clause in (37a) can then be taken as a head-internal relative in which the noun that was topicalized in (37b) is incorporated into the relative and serves as the head of a relative that is unmarked for definiteness. The crucial difference between the two is topicalization: (37a) lacks a co-referent topic that the demonstrative *ša* would have resumed, while (37b) has such a topic available and uses the demonstrative *ša* as a resumptive pronominal. Although there are good reasons to recommend Deutscher's description of the history of relativization in Akkadian (2002), he fails to mention "head-internal relatives" anywhere in the paper (even in the section on typology) which

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indicates that the concept was unfamiliar to him. This may explain Deutscher's characterization of the Old Akkadian system of relativization as "dysfunctional" (often in conjunction with other pejoratives such as "maladaptive") on four separate occasions in the space of twenty pages (Deutscher 2002, 86, 92, 95, 102). But the "dysfunctional" aspects of the Old Akkadian system—such as agreement between the external, topicalized "head" and the true, clause-internal head in terms of gender, number *and case*—follows quite directly from the fact that the external "head" is topicalized and must, therefore, be resumed by a head within the relative clause that carries all of the same inflectional information as the topicalized, external "head" of the construction. This "full" resumption in conjunction with the restriction on definiteness marking on the head of the Akkadian relative both point toward some type of HIRC as the starting point for not only the Akkadian relative construction, but also the early construct state as represented in early Semitic and Egyptian. In fact, I would argue that the appositional, head-internal relative in Old Akkadian conforms quite closely to the Afroasiatic avatar of head-internal relative clause formation (on the specificity-driven system in Middle Egyptian, see Loprieno 1995, 158).

The same opposition between indefinite and definite HIRCs can, likewise, be seen in the opposition between *bi-√ prefix relatives and *mini-√ prefix relatives in Sumerian.

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(38) a. Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta 554 (see above, chapter 2, section 2.1)

en aratta^{ki}.ke$_4$ gig.e **igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$**

The Lord of Aratta saw the wheat, lit., there was a perception of wheat by the Lord of Aratta,

b. Dumuzi and Geshtinana 53 (example [26c] above)

lu$_2$.u$_3$ e$_2$.nu ni$_2$.te.na zi.ni silim.ma a.ba.a **igi mi.ni.in.du$_8$**

As for the life of a man who is without a home, that it (= his life) is safe, who is the one who has seen it?

Thus, just as (37a) and (37b) differed only in terms of the presence or absence of the relative marker *ša* and its consequences for topicalization of the head noun, the two examples in (38) are differentiated by the presence in (38b) of a third person animate possessive pronoun that was, presumably, affixed to the underlying infinitive root (*√-bi$_2$ + -ni [+ -n]), became part of the verbal prefix (*√-bi$_2$-ni [+ -n]), and moved along with it to preverbal position (*bi$_2$-ni-n-√ > *mini-n-√). The primary effect of the addition of the third person animate possessive pronoun is that the verb that it is affixed to becomes definite and can be topicalized. As such it parallels, in a number of respects, the Lakhota example noted below.

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(39) a. [[Joe wowapi **wa** owa] **ki**] wac'i

Joe book **Indef** wrote **Def** want-1Sg

I want the book that Joe wrote

b. [[... √ **bi**] **ni**] ...

Indef **Def**

The difficulty, however, lies in discovering how definiteness plays out in the grammar of Sumerian, particularly in terms of topic and focus.

The role of definiteness in the matter of *bi-√ and *mini-√ remains somewhat unclear, primarily because definiteness in Sumerian has not yet been differentiated from specificity and it seems to be very much tied up with the pragmatic opposition between topic and focus.[33] If the *mini-√ hypothesis proposed above is valid, then verbs of the form *mini-√ are formally identical to the possessive pronoun topicalization constructions mentioned earlier.

(40) a. ama.ni < ama + ni (3Poss)

As for his mother, she . . .

b. igi mi.ni.in.du_8 < igi √du_8-bi_2 + ni (3Poss) + n (AnimAgr)

As for the one who has seen . . ., he/she . . .

[33] The shades or ghosts mentioned in example (43) below, however, are specific indefinites, which suggests that definiteness rather than specificity is the criterion at work in Sumerian.

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If we are to pick apart the subtle differences between **bi$_2$.in.du$_8$**, **im.mi.in.du$_8$** and **mi.ni.in.du$_8$** (leaving aside the "negative" form in **mu.ni.in.du$_8$**), a more detailed understanding the definiteness effect and its interaction with focus constructions is clearly in order.

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3.4 The Definiteness Effect

Since the only way of proving that a bare noun, particularly a bare noun that acts as the head of a relative clause, is indefinite is through the identification of a definiteness effect, this section describes the prototypical case of a definiteness effect in English (the existential "there" sentence) and highlights several other related definiteness effects which occur in both English and, as I argue here, Sumerian.

The first extensive study of the phenomenon was by Milsark (1974), in which he begins with a series of sentences in English:

(41) a. There is a Santa Claus.

b. There might be a duck in the sink.

c. There has been a man shot by a maniac.

d. There were at least fifty people sick.

Milsark (1974; 1977) sought to characterize the noun that immediately follows the copula in (41a) through (41d) and argued that a number of distinct morphosyntactic and semantic restrictions apply to the noun in question as well as any deverbal modifiers such as "shot" in (41c). Milsark noted that definite nouns do not, as a rule, occur in this position (hence the name of the constraint), but that if the post-copular noun is affected by a co-occurring focus construction, then a definite noun could occur, but only in a rather particular interpretation known as a "pair-list" reading (see below for exemplification). Milsark also noted that what are known as individual-level predicates,

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which refer to permanent properties of the referent, are excluded as modifiers of the noun under the definiteness effect (see below, section 3.5, for a discussion of stage- and individual-level predicates, topicality and the opposition between adjectival and verbal small clauses in recent work by Basilico [2003]). Later authors have also identified definiteness effects in relational "have" sentences and, as noted above, head-internal relative clauses (see, among numerous other available references, in particular, Davidson 1967; Stowell 1981, 1983; Safir 1985; Reuland and Meulen 1987; Diesing 1992; Herburger 2000; Jäger 2001, *passim non vidi*; on the role of indefinites in certain kinds of complex verb formation, strongly resembling the Sumerian verbal complex, see Szabolcsi 1986; Koopman and Szabolcsi 2000: 32, 222, fn. 2).

Before turning to the exceptions to the definiteness effect, which are really the most interesting part about it, the precise definition of what an existential "there" sentence in English is, is in need of some clarification. The most important detail is that it must be kept separate from presentational "there" sentences.

(42) There is a post office next to the library.

In (42), we have a standard existential "there" sentence: note the indefinite article on the noun that immediately follows the copula. If the immediately post-copular noun is definite, "there" and the post-copular noun can alternate on either side of the "to be" verb without affecting the meaning much at all as in (43) below.

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(43) a. *There* is the post office next to the library.

b. The post office is *there* next to the library.

In both (43a) and (43b), the normal use for such sentences would be to ostend and refer to the post office with a pointing finger and emphatic stress on the word "there," hence the characterization of such sentences as presentational. Now, if one inverts "there" and the post-copular noun in a sentence like (42), the result is something like (44).

(44) A post office is there next to the library.

Once again the presentational rather than the existential reading is the only one available, so there really is something special about existential "there" sentences.

As noted above, the primary exception—an exception in certain respects at least—to the restriction on definite nouns in definiteness effect environments is that definite nouns can occur in definiteness effect restricted environments if they are affected by focus. When in focus, as for example in answer to a wh-question, the post-copular noun phrase in an existential sentence can be definite, but in such cases it assumes a rather special interpretation.

(45) Joe: "Who is going to drive me back home?"

Mary: "Well, there's [$_{\text{Focus}}$ my brother, or the guy standing on the corner]."

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Definite noun phrases such as "my brother" or "the guy standing on the corner" can only occur in definiteness effect environments as a list of alternatives, known as a pair-list reading. Even if only a single definite noun occurs, it is still interpreted as only one of several possible alternatives. The pair-list interpretation of definite nouns that occur in definiteness effect environments can be confirmed by looking at the behavior of what are known as strong quantifiers such as "each" and "every" in definiteness effect environments. McNally (1992 apud Chung and McCloskey 2002, 6) notes that strong quantifiers only appear in contexts affected by the definiteness effect when they quantify over semantic kinds as in the following example from Chung and McCloskey (2002, 6).

(46) There was every kind of ice cream in the fridge.

Here the quantifier "every" does not quantify over individuals, but rather over types as indicated by "every *kind* of . . . ."

Definiteness effects such as the one identified in English existential "there" sentences are fairly common in other languages and have been studied in considerable detail for years. Of the three major analytical traditions in the investigation of definiteness effects, identified by Chung and McCloskey as *the impersonal approach* (Milsark 1974; Chomsky 1981; Safir 1985; Chomsky 1986; Reuland and Meulen 1987, *passim non vidi*), *the locative approach* (Lyons 1967; 1968; Clark 1978; Kuno 1971; Freeze 1992), and *the pragmatics approach* (Lumsden 1988, Prince 1992; Abbot 1992; 1993; 1997; Ward and Birner 1995; 1997; Zucchi 1995, *passim non vidi*), I would like to

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turn to the locative approach as represented by Freeze (1992). Freeze begins by pointing out that the existential "there" sentence in English is somewhat exceptional; the most common pattern is one in which the basic structure consists of three parts: (i) a copula, which may or may not be of the **be.at'** type, (ii) a theme, typically in the unmarked or zero case, and (iii) a locative. The corresponding elements in Sumerian—at least with respect to $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates—are: (i) the *bi-√ prefix as existential predicate, (ii) the bare inalienable noun, and (iii) the locative-terminative case-marked noun.

Freeze then notes that these three components are commonly found in what are generally thought of as three distinct constructions: the predicate locative construction ("The book is on the bench"), the existential construction ("There is a book on the bench") and "have" constructions ("Lupe has a book") (1992, 553). In general, the "have" constructions pattern with the existential constructions and both can be differentiated from the predicate locative on the basis of what is known as "locative inversion" (The following example is from Hindi after Freeze 1992, 555; note that nasal diacritics are omitted, see Freeze for the original form).

(47)	a.	mai	hindustaan-mee	thaa
		I	India-in	Cop.Sg.Masc.Past
		THEME	LOCATIVE	VERB
		I was in India		

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b.	kamree-mee	aadmii	hai
	room-in	man	Cop.3Sg.Masc.Pres
	LOCATIVE	THEME	VERB

There is a man in the room

If the order THEME, LOCATIVE, VERB in (47a) is taken as the standard order, then the order of the elements in (47b) can be spoken of as "locative inversion" since the locative expression precedes the theme rather than following it as it did in (47a). Freeze then posits a basic complementarity between predicate locatives, which regularly include a definite theme, and existential/have sentences, which typically include an indefinite theme. Although Freeze fails to take into consideration the focus-affected, pair-list readings of definite nouns in existential sentences, the overall scheme seems to be fairly sound in typological terms and it conforms quite precisely to the basic dichotomy to be found with the *bi-√ prefix verbs. As noted in chapter 1, throughout the history of the *bi-√ prefix, there was always a basic dichotomy between an ordinary *bi-√ prefix construction in which an absolutive theme was followed by a locative that usually immediately preceded the verb and the construction dealt with in this study where a noun in the locative-terminative case is followed by a bare absolutive noun that immediately precedes the verb. The two examples from Hindi in (47), therefore, correspond quite closely to this basic opposition in the *bi-√ prefix construction in Sumerian; the primary difference is that in Hindi, two distinct lexical items serve as copula in the two constructions, whereas Sumerian uses a single existential/"have" preverb, the *bi-√

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prefix, and differentiates the various functions on the basis of definiteness, inalienability and animacy. Note as well that the opposition between (42) and (44) above, the existential and presentational "there" sentences in English, is also on the basis of locative inversion.

The conflation of "existential" and "have" predicates in the *bi-√ prefix in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions is interesting in that the transfer of possession model that underlies my earlier interpretation of the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction as a low source applicative seems to include both an existential "moment" and a possessive "moment." At the beginning of the event, the bare inalienable noun is said to exist at a particular location identified by the locative-terminative noun, while, at the end of the event, it is inalienably possessed by the noun in the ergative case—this corresponds to Freeze's "possessed theme" (Freeze 1992, 589).

In the Hindi examples provided by Freeze, three distinct forms stand out as typical exemplars: the predicate locative construction, the alienable "have" construction and the inalienable "have" construction, which correspond to the three following examples.

(48) a. mai hindustaan-mee thaa
I India-in Cop.Sg.Masc.Past
I was in India

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b. larkee-kee paas kuttaa hai

boy.Obl-Gen proximity dog Cop.3Sg.Pres

The boy has a dog, lit. by the boy is a dog

c. baccee-kee daat safeed hai

child.Obl-Gen teeth white Cop.3Pl

The child has white teeth, lit. the child's white teeth are

As I have argued previously, the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction seems, therefore, to consist of two, overlapping possessive constructions: an inalienably possessed theme **lugal.e igi** "the king's eye" and a theme **gig.e igi** "perception of wheat, lit. an eye to the wheat" with raised possessor, as if the two Hindi sentences in (48b) and (48c) could occur as a single clause. Freeze goes on to note (using the term "subject" in a rather special sense where it refers to either the possessor or the locative) that "[t]here is a tendency for [+ human] subjects to occur in expressions interpreted as 'have' constructions, while [– human] subjects are found in expressions interpreted as existentials" (Freeze 1992, 584). This is precisely the state of affairs in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction.

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3.5 Head-internal relatives revisited

Now that topic, focus, and the definiteness effect have been outlined in a preliminary way, I would like to return to my earlier discussion of head-internal relatives in Sumerian and Akkadian. When last we saw the Akkadian HIRC at the end of section 3.3, I had argued that *bītum* in the following example was topicalized and that it was then resumed by the demonstrative relative marker *ša*, which I take as the true head of the relative clause in this Akkadian example.

(49) [$_{DP}$ [$_{Topic}$ *bīt-um*] [$_{Focus}$*ša* *ēpuš-u*]] *imqut*

house-Def Rel do.1Sg.Perf-Subord fall.3Sg.Perf

As for the house, namely the one that I built, it collapsed

One of the most interesting features of HIRCs is the fact that they are definiteness effect environments. A skeptic might point out that the presence of the demonstrative/relative, *ša*, as the head of the relative clause, *ša ēpušu*, would seem to militate against it as a definiteness effect environment since demonstratives are necessarily definite and definite noun phrases are regularly excluded from such environments, but we should remember that definite nouns *can* occur in such environments when they are focused. The "topic + focus" model of the relative clause that I have sketched in (49) would regularly provide the head noun with focus as long as it is preceded by a coreferential topic. Unlike the sentence in (49), where the topicalized noun phrase, *bītum*, must be definite in order to be

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topicalized, the following example lacks both the topicalized, external "head" as well as the demonstrative/relative *ša*: the bare noun *bīt* has become the head of the HIRC.

(50) $[_{DP}\ [_{Topic}$ Ø$]\ [_{Focus}$ *bīt* *ēpuš-u*]] *imqut*

Ø house do.1Sg.Perf-Subord fall.3Sg.Perf

A/the house I built collapsed

Since there is no topicalized noun within the determiner phrase (DP) in (50), there is likewise no reason for a resumptive pronoun like *ša*; the internal head of the relative clause is *bīt* and in the absence of a topicalized noun, the expression need not be in focus.

In semantic terms, the HIRC works in Akkadian by setting up an existentially quantified noun ("There is an x such that . . .") and then identifying the existentially quantified noun (the internal head of the relative) with some other noun that is prominent in the discourse, typically a topic. Thus *bītum ša ēpušu* might be translated into English so as to capture the quantification involved as follows:

(51) As for the house (*bītum*), it is something that I made (*ša ēpušu).*

The reason for the use of the existential construction (and the consequent definiteness effect) is that in the absence of explicit quantization such as a cardinal number or plural morphology, an existentially quantified noun refers to a single entity. Such an entity can then be identified, or better equated, with another single entity. Since the head-internal

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relative may have to be equated with both definite and indefinite nouns, it needs to start out as the equivalent of a bare noun, unmarked for definiteness (or, for that matter, gender or number). In other words, the HIRC is a noun phrase in the narrow sense of the generative tradition rather than a determiner phrase.

The process of one-to-one identification where one entity is the HIRC (*ša ēpušu*) and the other is the topicalized noun (*bītum*) seems to be justified, at least to some degree, by restrictions on many-to-one possessive relations within the HIRC proper. Huehnergard notes three conditions (two that I deal with here) under which genitive constructions in *ša* must be used rather than the "construct state" genitive, or, in terms of my description of the Akkadian HIRC up to this point: certain many-to-one possessive relations require that the head noun be topicalized and resumed by *ša* inside the relative clause so that the HIRC can qualify each topical noun separately as in (52a) or that the possessors be included within the HIRC and coordinated, so that the topicalized noun can be equated with each coordinated HIRC independently (Huehnergard 2000, 363).

(52) a. when there is more than one governing noun:

mārum u mārtum [$_{\text{HIRC}}$ *ša šarrim*]

'the son and the daughter of the king, [lit., as for the son and the daughter, the one of the king CJ]'

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b. when there is more than one governed noun:

eqlum [$_{HIRC}$ [$_{HIRC}$ *ša dayyānim*] *u* [$_{HIRC}$ (*ša*) *aḫīšu*]]

'the field of the judge and his brother, [lit., as for the field, the one of the judge and (the one) of his brother CJ]'

(unless the governed nouns are seen as a unit by the writer: *bēl šamê u erṣetim*)

Thus, constructions in which the possessed noun and the possessor cannot be treated as a single entity are blocked within the HIRC and a periphrastic construction involving topicalization is forced in which either the multiple head nouns are topicalized (*mārum u mārtum*) and resumed by a single head-internal relative, the head of which of unmarked for number (*ša šarrīm*),[34] or the single entity is topicalized (*eqlum*) and resumed by two distinct, coordinated HIRCs. In both cases each HIRC refers to a single entity that can then be equated with one or more topics. Huehnergard's caveat to the rule in (52b) is the exception that proves the rule: where "the governed nouns are seen as a unit" (Huehnergard 2000, 363), the HIRC can be used since the cardinality and the definiteness of the possessed noun and the possessor is equivalent; the same goes for plurals that make use of the HIRC. The "topic-plus-focus" articulation of the HIRC that I describe here can, presumably, be assimilated to, for example, Basilico's description of topicalization in small clauses (2003) on the assumption that the marker of subordination *-u originated as a resultative suffix that formed an adjectival small clause (see below).

[34] In Old Akkadian, however, we find an older form of the construction in which the head of the HIRC, an inflected form of *ša*, agrees with the topical noun in terms of case, number and gender.

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Clearly, however, by the time Akkadian appears in the text-artifactual record, it has largely been assimilated to the familiar form of head-external relative clause that we find in English and other dependent-marking languages.

With the foregoing discussion of the head-internal relative in Akkadian still in mind, I return to the *mini-√ construction. If the *bi-√ prefix in its existential (NOUN-e $NOUN_{Bare}$ bi-√) configuration indicates that the bare noun that immediately precedes the *bi-√ prefix is an indefinite noun in a definiteness effect environment, then verbs of the form *mini-√ can be interpreted as a head-internal relative (bi-√) that has been made definite through the suffixation of the third person animate possessive pronoun, namely *-ni, so as to form a topicalized phrase. Note, therefore, the several differences between the Akkadian HIRC and the Sumerian one: (a) the Akkadian HIRC can occur with a distinct, topicalized noun that is coreferential with the head of the HIRC, but the Sumerian HIRC cannot; (b) if the Sumerian HIRC needs to be topicalized or made definite for some other reason, the HIRC itself is made definite through the addition of the third person animate possessive pronoun, *-ni. At a fairly rough level of granularity, this allows us to draw a parallel between the HIRC in Akkadian and Sumerian due to the fact that, in both cases, topicalization plays a central role in the formation of HIRCs that are definite.

(53) a. Ø *bīt ēpušu* // igi bi.in.du_8

b. (*bītum*) *ša ēpušu* // igi mi.ni.in.du_8

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The contrast in (53), therefore, is between the indefinite HIRC in (53a) and the definite form of the same construction in (53b): note, in particular, the parallel between *bīt* in (53a), *ša* in (53b) and **igi** in both examples in (53). While the similarities between the HIRC in Akkadian and Sumerian are intriguing, particularly in terms of the use of topicalization to code definiteness, it is the difference between the two constructions that I would like to turn to at this point.

Basilico (2003) has recently reemphasized the contrast between two basic types of small clause (hereafter SC): the adjectival SC and the verbal SC—the classic examples of a small clause include, for example, the post-copular position in an existential sentence ("there is [$_{SC}$ a dog in the street]"), the part of a direct perception verb that follows the verb of perception ("Mary saw [$_{SC}$ John leave the party]"), and secondary predicates such as those described in chapter 2 ("Rob painted [$_{SC}$ the house red]"). Basilico identifies a number of syntactic tests that differentiate the two types of SC, but I do not rehearse them here (the examples in [54] correspond to Basilico 2003, 4, ex. 8a and 7a respectively).

(54) a. The guard considers [$_{\text{Adjectival SC}}$ the prisoner intelligent]

b. The burglar saw [$_{\text{Verbal SC}}$ the prisoner escape]

The crucial difference seems to be that verbal SCs are *thetic*, whereas adjectival SCs are *categorical*—recall my brief discussion of the opposition in section 2.7 above. To reiterate somewhat, thetic statements can be thought of as predications that adopt a holistic representation of some state of affairs without singling out any particular

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participant in the event in question. Categorical statements are quite the opposite: they identify an individual and then attribute a property to that individual—note that the semantic content of the state of affairs described by a categorical statement can be the same as that described by a thetic statement, but the two statements will usually differ syntactically. In syntactic terms, at least according to Basilico's proposal, this amounts to the fact that in a categorical statement "the subject of an adjectival SC occupies a distinct topic position," whereas, the subject of a verbal SC in a thetic statement "does not form a topic" (Basilico 2003, 8). Clearly the use of topicalized nouns in conjunction with the Akkadian HIRC can be equated with the adjectival SC in contrast to the absence of topicalized nouns in the verbal SC found in the Sumerian HIRC.

Other factors such as the use of Sumerian HIRCs to form the complement of verbs of direct perception also favor interpreting it as a verbal SC. While topicality and/or definiteness can be difficult to evaluate in the text-artifactual record, the ability of a relative clause to act as the complement of a verb of direct perception should be readily identifiable. Min-Joo Kim, for example, has noted the nearly identical form of HIRCs and direct perception complements [DPCs] in Korean (M. Kim 2003, 2):

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(55)	John-un	[[totwuk-i	tomangka]-nun	kes]-ul	cap-ess-ta
	PN-Top	thief-Nom	run.away-Rel.Imprf	KES-Acc	catch-Past-Decl
	John caught a/the thief running away				

(56)	John-un	[[totwuk-i	tomangka]-nun	kes]-ul	po-ess-ta
	PN-Top	thief-Nom	run.away-Rel.Imprf	KES-Acc	see-Past-Decl
	John saw the event of a/the thief running away				

In (55), the HIRC consists of [[totwuk-i tomangka]-nun kes], "a/the thief running away," and corresponds precisely with the direct perception complement in (56). Kim notes that these two constructions, the HIRC and the DPC, can be differentiated from other, similar constructions such as propositional attitude verbs like "know" or "believe" on the basis of syntactic tests in Korean. The contrast between HIRC + DPC and propositional attitude verbs seems to be represented in Sumerian by the opposition between $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates and non-$BNBV_{inal}$ predicates; if so, these oppositions can be tabulated as follows (neither of the two examples of **bi$_2$.in.zu** that I am aware of [Letter of Shulgi to Aradmu about Apillasha (3.1.02), line 30, and Proverbs Collection 7 [6.1.07], section C, line 21] is a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate):

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	Thetic	Categorical
Basilico	Verbal SC	Adjectival SC
Kim	HIRC + DPC	Propositional attitude verbs
	$BNBV_{inal}$	non-$BNBV_{inal}$

The Akkadian HIRC, in which a distinct, topical noun phrase is followed by a relative clause that bears a resultative suffix in *-u seems to correspond to a second type of relative clause in Sumerian, namely those relatives formed through the suffixation of the nominalizing/resultative suffix, *-a, to a verbal root. This type of Sumerian relative clause, which is generally thought of as a head-external relative in accord with the conventional interpretation of the Akkadian relative clause, also allows for a distinct, coreferential noun; it is, in other words, appositional like the Akkadian HIRC. In the case of Sumerian, however, the coreferential noun is not topicalized and occurs in the zero-marked absolutive/nominative case. This second type of HIRC in Sumerian (or head-external, if the Akkadian relative ultimately proves to be head-external instead of head-internal), need not concern us further here. Although the *-a suffix and the second type of HIRC in Sumerian in which it appears are beyond the scope of this dissertation, the association between bare complements and *bi-√ type HIRCs, on the one hand, and the relative formed through the suffixation of *-a, on the other, is certainly in need of further investigation, particularly in light of possible connections with the opposition between direct and indirect speech/perception, definiteness and different types of complementation in Sumerian.

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These distinctions can also provide a model for a possible interpretation of closely related verbal forms such as **igi bi_2.in.du_8**, **igi im.mi.in.du_8**, and **igi mi.ni.in.du_8**: **igi bi_2.in.du_8** would represent a basic, thetic statement, neutralized with respect to definiteness (". . . is one who . . ."); **igi mi.ni.in.du_8** would be a definite/topicalized version of the thetic statement represented by **igi bi_2.in.du_8** ("the one who . . ."); while **igi im.mi.in.du_8** would correspond to the kind of categorical statement typically associated with propositional attitude verbs and indirect speech. I hope to investigate these contrasts in greater detail in future work.

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4

Focus-affected constituents in the *XP nam bi-√ construction

At the end of the last chapter, I argued that one of the characteristic features of *mini-√ prefix verbs is that the introduction of the third person animate possessive pronoun makes the construction definite and the definiteness of the construction allows it to serve as a topic. Topics are regularly definite, since they are necessarily presuppositional. But in this chapter I attempt to isolate a rather different form of presupposition, the presupposition in a sentence in which a particular constituent is in focus. The focused constituent in such a construction constitutes the assertion within the clause, whereas the rest of the sentence is its presupposition (section 4.1 offers a brief review of focus and presupposition and isolates the basic oppositions within Sumerian through the use of robust diagnostic situations such as wh-questions, which regularly elicit responses structured on the basis of informational focus, and examples of explicit contrastive focus).

This chapter looks at a particular construction of the form *XP nam bi-√ (where XP stands for a constituent of any phrasal type) and argues that it is to be interpreted as a negative contrastive focus construction ("it is not THE DOG that ate your cereal, but rather THE BIRD that did so"). The unusual thing about this construction is the "but

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rather THE BIRD that did so" counterpart to the negative contrastive focus is left unstated and only drawn as an implication from the context. Given the contextual nature of such an unstated contrast, obviously the first course of investigation is to look in detail at the contexts in which the construction occurs and confirm that this interpretation of the construction "fits"—this is the objective of sections 4.2, 4.3 and 4.4, the centerpiece of the chapter, which correspond to three subsets within the overall class of *XP nam bi-√ constructions: section 4.2 covers examples of the construction that do not involve compound verbs; section 4.3 deals with the compound verb subset, excluding $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates; section 4.4 looks at $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in the *XP nam bi-√ construction. The use of the "It is not A . . ., but rather B" translational equivalency is, however, somewhat artificial in that the positive contrast never appears in the context, so, in section 4.5, my hypothesis about of the *XP nam bi-√ construction is refined somewhat on the basis of Herburger's work on double negation in Spanish (2000). In the final section of the chapter, section 4.6, I turn to the opposition between what Kiss (1998) has called informational and identificational focus and argue that the use of the copula to mark the focused constituent (whether as the ordinary copular construction *XP-am or the copula that forms a component of the *XP nam [< *XP nu/na-am] constituent) is limited to instances of contrastive/identificational focus.

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4.1 Focus in Sumerian

Since focus constructions are important in that they can act as a heuristic tool in reconstructing the pragmatics (and the syntax for that matter) of archaeologically recovered languages, I would like to turn to some basic examples of focus in Sumerian. One might imagine that two contexts would be promising: (a) the answer given to a content- or wh-question (known as informational focus in some circles), and (b) contexts in which there is an explicit contrast between one referent and another (known as identificational or contrastive focus).

(1) Gilgamesh and the Netherworld [1.8.1.4], ll. 174-179 (George 2003, 898-905)

174. ^{giš}ellag.g̃u$_{10}$ kur.še$_3$ mu.da.šub	*(Gilgamesh:) As for my ellag, it has fallen*
a.ba.a ma.ra.ab.e$_{11}$.de$_3$	*into the netherworld, who will descend*
	on my behalf?
175. ^{giš}e.ke$_4$.ma.g̃u$_{10}$ ganzer.še$_3$	*As for my ekema, it has fallen into Ganzer,*
mu.da.šub **a.ba.a** ma.ra.ab.e$_{11}$.de$_3$	*who will descend on my behalf?*
177. lugal.g̃u$_{10}$ er$_2$ e.ne ba.še$_8$.še$_8$	*(Enkidu:) My king, you are weeping,*
178. u$_4$.da ^{giš}ellag.zu kur.ta **g̃a$_2$.e**	*At daybreak, as for your ellag, let me*
ga mu.ra.ab.e$_{11}$.de$_3$	*retrieve it from the netherworld for you,*
179. ^{giš}e.ke$_4$.ma.zu ganzer.ta **g̃a$_2$.e**	*As for your ekema, let me retrieve it from*
ga mu.ra.ab.e$_{11}$.de$_3$	*Ganzer for you,*

In (1), in response to Gilgamesh's question, Enkidu answers and the noun phrase that specifically answers that wh-question is **g̃a$_2$.e** "I" with the rest of the sentence merely

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repeating the presupposition of the wh-question. The only evidence that **ĝa$_2$.e** is in focus is that it immediately precedes the verb rather than appearing in its usual position at the beginning of the clause. In (2), interestingly enough, a haruspex is having a conversation with a cow:

(2) Enmerkar and Ensuḫgirana [1.8.2.4], ll. 175-177

(The haruspex asks:)

175. ab$_2$ i$_3$.zu **a.ba.a** i$_3$.gu$_7$.e ga.zu	*Cow, as for your butter, who will eat it?*
a.ba.a i$_3$.na$_8$.na$_8$	*As for your milk, who will drink it?*

(The cow responds:)

176. i$_3$.ĝu$_{10}$ i$_3$.gu$_7$.e ^{d}**nisaba.ke$_4$**	*As for my butter, it will be eaten by Nisaba,*
177. [ga].ĝu$_{10}$ i$_3$.na$_8$.na$_8$ ^{d}**nisaba.ke$_4$**	*As for my milk, it will be drunk by Nisaba,*

The example in (2) is particularly interesting in that the response to the wh-question actually follows the verbal predicate, a nearly unique phenomenon in Sumerian grammar. But as in example (2), the phrase in focus occurs as close as possible to the end of the clause. In example (3), the contrastive use is particularly clear.

(3) The Tale of Gudam, segment C [1.3.4], ll. 10-11

10. i$_3$.gu$_7$.a.zu i$_3$.gu$_7$.a.zu	*As for what you have eaten, as for what you have eaten,*
11. ninda nu.e.gu$_7$ **uzu.zu.um** i$_3$.gu$_7$	*It was not bread that you have eaten, it was your flesh that you have eaten!*

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The copula **-am$_3$** undergoes vowel harmony in (3); the underlying form is **uzu.zu.am$_3$**. Still, it occurs immediately before the verb as in the previous examples. Thus it is presumably reasonable, bearing in mind parallels from a number of verb-final languages, to postulate a focus position immediately before the verb. If this is the case, then we may want to interpret the **i$_3$.na$_8$.na$_8$** in example (2) as a type of *nomen agentis* and argue that the syntactic form of (2) consists of an extended nominal as represented in (4).

(4) [$_{\text{Topic}}$ ga.g̃u$_{10}$ [$_{\text{Focus}}$ i$_3$.na$_8$.na$_8$ ^{d}nisaba.ke$_4$ [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ am$_3$]

Bearing these examples of focus constructions in Sumerian in mind, I would like, at this point, to turn to examples of focus-affected *bi-√ prefix verbs in the hope of clarifying the particular way in which the *bi-√ prefix forms a definiteness effect environment. But in order to resolve some of these issues, the focused and presupposed parts of any particular clause need to be clearly differentiated.

Since the use of the copula, *-am, to mark contrastive focus is the clearest morphosyntactic indicator of a focused constituent in Sumerian, it must obviously serve as the primary diagnostic of any focus construction. But since focus can apply to constituents of any size, we are in need of some means of delimiting the parts of a clause that are not in focus as well. Take, for example, the following passage from *Gilgamesh and the Netherworld.*

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(5) Gilgamesh and the Netherworld, Version A [1.8.1.4], ll. 254-277

254a. lu_2 dumu.ni 1.am_3 igi bi_2.du_8.am_3	*(Gilgamesh:) Did you see a man who had one son?*
254b. igi bi_2.du_8.am_3	*(Enkidu:) I saw such a man,*
254c. a.na.gin_7 an.ak	*(Gilgamesh:) How does he fare?*
255. $^{\tilde{g}i\check{s}}$gag e_2.$\tilde{g}ar_8$.a.na ab.du_3.a gig.ga i.i	*(Enkidu:) He weeps bitterly at the wooden peg which was driven into his wall,*
256a. lu_2 dumu.ni 2.am_3 igi bi_2.du_8.am_3	*(Gilgamesh:) Did you see a man who had two sons?*
256b. igi bi_2.du_8.am_3	*(Enkidu:) I saw such a man.*
256c. a.na.gin_7 an.ak	*(Gilgamesh:) How does he fare?*
257. sig_4 2.a al.tuš ninda al.gu_7.e	*(Enkidu:) He sits on a couple of bricks, eating bread,*

This is certainly an interesting passage from a number of perspectives—note that the question and the answer in (254a) and (254b) as well as (256a) and (256b) are each, at least in orthographic terms, identical in form—but the frequent use of the copula in such a passage prevents any clear demarcation of focus and presupposition in the passage. In the following section, I turn to a particular morphosyntactic environment, namely the *XP nam bi-√ construction, so as to demarcate focus and presupposition with some precision. The relevance of this particular construction is that, in this environment, the focused constituent regularly occurs in the middle of two well-demarcated, presuppositional constituents: the possessive pronoun topic-marking construction to its

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left and the *bi-√ prefix verb to its right. The fact that each of these components can be identified and distinguished makes this construction particularly useful in evaluating matters of focus and presupposition.

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4.2 Focus-affected *bi-√ prefix constructions

In the Sumerian literary materials from the Old Babylonian schools, there are a dozen or so examples of a verb in the progressive/imperfective (*marû*) aspect bearing the verbal prefix *nam-bi_2-√. These verbal forms have conventionally been assimilated to a modal system in which the prefix *na- in conjunction with a perfective (*ḫamṭu*) verbal form indicates positive assertion, while co-occurrence with an progressive/imperfective (*marû*) verbal form indicates prohibition. I would like to propose a somewhat different interpretation of the forms in which *nam- immediately precedes the *bi-√ prefix: namely, that *nam- is a conventionalized orthography for a sequence made up of either the modal particle *na- or the simple negation *nu- followed by the copula as represented in (6).

(6) nam-bi_2-√ ⇨ nam bi_2-√ (< *na/nu-am_3 bi_2-√)

That is, given conventional principles of scope under negation, that it represents a negation of the focused constituent in an otherwise positive assertion of the content of the presupposition, namely whatever topic is in play as well as the semantic content of the *bi-√ verbal form. The special feature of this construction as opposed to other constructions in which a focus constituent is differentiated from other presupposed constituents is that, in most of the following cases, explicit morphosyntactic evidence of one kind or another separates the focused material from the presupposed material: the constituents to the left of the focused phrase are demarcated by either the possessive

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pronoun topicalization system or the equative postposition, *-gin$_7$, while the presupposed material to the right of the focused constituent consists of a *bi-√ prefix verb.

Before turning to the particular examples of this distributional class, it needs to be carefully differentiated from a distinct class that bears a superficial resemblance to it, namely predicates of the form *XP nam.mi-√. Whereas the *XP nam bi-√ construction is always written in the Old Babylonian period with the graphemes NAM and NE, yielding the sequence *nam bi$_2$-√, the members of the *XP nam.mi-√ class, in which there is no copula to the right of *na-/*nu-, are typically written with the graphemes NAM and MI, yielding *nam.mi-√. Of the 95 examples of *XP nam.mi-√ and the 25 examples of *XP nam bi-√ in the composite texts made available through ETCSL, only one simple verbal root or compound verb occurs in both constructions: √**ḫu.luḫ**. The decisive piece of evidence in favor of differentiating the two constructions, however, is that fact that *XP nam bi-√ regularly occurs with a *marû* root, whereas *XP nam.mi-√ never occurs with a *marû* root. If some degree of variation were present, it might provide some evidence in favor of arguing that the two forms exist in a paradigmatic opposition, but strict differentiation of the two classes and the nature of the two orthographies would seem to suggest that they are fundamentally different. Given the usual orthographic conventions for cuneiform, I would suggest that *nam.mi-√ represents the morpheme *na- prefixed to a verbal prefix of the form *bi-√, whereas the difference between the final consonant of /nam/ and the initial consonant of /bi/ presumably indicates that no prefixation is present in the *XP nam bi-√ construction.

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In the first of my examples of focus-affected *bi-√ verbs, example (7), Gilgamesh has been put to sleep by Huwawa, a creature that he and Enkidu meet in the Cedar Forest and Enkidu is attempting to revive Gilgamesh.

(7) Gilgamesh and Huwawa, version A [1.8.1.5], ll. 81-84

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *ama ugu.bi* [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **tilla$_2$ iri^{ki}.za.ka.še$_3$ nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.sar.re]]]

As for their mothers, **it is not TO THE MARKETPLACE OF YOUR CITY** that they should be running, (but rather TO THE SONS OF YOUR CITY)

81. ^{d}bil$_4$.ga.mes en.še$_3$ i$_3$.nu$_2$.de$_3$.en	*Gilgamesh, how long will you sleep for?*
82. dumu iri^{ki}.za mu.un.de$_3$.re$_7$.eš.am$_3$	*As for your city's sons, they came with you,*
83. ur$_2$ ḫur.saĝ.ĝa$_2$.ka nam ba.e.de$_3$.gub.bu.ne	*They should not be waiting at the foot of the hills,*
84. ama ugu.bi tilla$_2$ iri^{ki}.za.ka.še$_3$ nam bi$_2$.ib.sar.re	*As for their mothers, it is not to the marketplace of your city that they should be hurrying,*

(8) Enmerkar and the lord of Aratta [1.8.2.3], ll. 116 and 118 (cf. 188 and 190)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *iri.bi*] [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ mušen.gin$_7$ [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **gud$_3$ us$_2$.sa.bi.a nam**] bi$_2$.ib.dal.en]

As for their city (= the inhabitants), **it is not FROM THE NEST ATTACHED TO IT** (with Aratta as metaphorical tree) that I want them to fly like birds, (on the contrary, the inhabitants can stay)

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[$_{Topic}$ *ganba ĝal$_2$.la*] [$_{Presupposition}$ iri gul.gul.lu.gin$_7$ [$_{Focus}$ **saḫar nam**] bi$_2$.ib.ḫa.za.en]]]

As for what is in the marketplace, **it is not THE DUST** that I want to take possession of, as if (I were) someone who destroys cities, (but rather the precious objects)

115. iri.bi ir$_7$.saĝ^{mušen}.gin$_7$ ĝiš.bi.ta na.an.na.ra.ab.dal.en	*As for their city (= the inhabitants), it is not from their tree that I want them fly like a wild dove,*
116. mušen.gin$_7$ gud$_3$ us$_2$.sa.bi.a nam bi$_2$.ib.dal.en	*It is not from the nest attached to it that I want them to fly like a bird,*
117. ganba ĝal$_2$.la.gin$_7$ na.an.si.ig.en	*It is rather* (-gin$_7$) *what is in the market that I want to load up,*
118. iri gul.gul.lu.gin$_7$ saḫar nam bi$_2$.ib.ḫa.za.en	*It is not the dust that I want to take possession of, as if (I were) someone who destroys cities,*
119. aratta^{ki} a$_2$.dam ^{d}en.ki.ke$_4$ nam ba.an.ku$_5$	*Aratta, a settlement cursed by Enki,*
120. ⌈ki bi$_2$⌉.in.gul.la.gin$_7$ ki nam ga bi$_2$.ib.gul.en	*Is it not such as place, a place in ruins, that I should want to undermine,*

In (8), we find two examples of the construction in lines 116 and 118, separated by the *na- modal prefix plus perfective verb of assertion in line 117. The alternation between negative contrastive focus constructions and positive assertion in line 117 serves to

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indicate that Enmerkar seeks neither the inhabitants of the city themselves, nor the destruction of the city, but rather simply the material wealth accumulated in Aratta. The entire passage is built up around the grapheme NAM which occurs in the *XP nam bi-√ construction, the compound verb **nam-√ku$_5$** "to curse," and an *XP nam bi-√ construction in which the cohortative prefix, *ga-, also occurs.[35] Note as well that, although not a single progressive/imperfective (*marû*) verbal root occurs in the entire passage, the temporal reference is to the future, so I have translated the modal forms as if they were imperfective so as to capture the temporal reference as well as its presumably modal associations. The only exception is the verb in line 117, which I interpret as equivalent to *na- plus perfective, yielding the assertive rather than prohibitive meaning in that line. Although one might be tempted to justify the differential treatment on the basis of the syllable closing grapheme in line 117, since one would have expected the orthographic sequence **si.ge.en** rather than **si.ig.en** had the root been in the progressive/imperfective (*marû*) aspect, the best evidence for the differential interpretation of line 117 as opposed to the other *bi-√ prefix lines is the variation in the pronominal agreement in the *bi-√ prefix verbs. Whereas the verb in line 117 shows *-n-, the *bi-√ prefix verbs elsewhere in the passage—lines 116, 118 and 120 as well as 115, which should probably be assimilated to the *bi-√ prefix verbs in this passage—have *-b- as the preverbal pronominal agreement marker.

[35] There is a great deal of confusion of **ga.nam** and **nam.ga** evident in the text artifactual record, so the proper interpretation of line 120 remains uncertain.

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(9) A praise poem of Shulgi (Shulgi E) [2.4.2.05], l. 58 (Ludwig 1990, 44-45)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *en$_3$.du.ĝu$_{10}$ …*] [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **ki.šu.ke$_4$ lu$_2$ nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib$_2$.da$_{13}$.da$_{13}$.a]]

As for the songs about me …, it is not (only) THE PEOPLE ASSIGNED TO DO SO who should sing them, (but rather they should be sung on every important occasion)

53. en$_3$.du.ĝu$_{10}$ a.da.ab ḫe$_2$.em tigi ma.al.ga.tum ḫe$_2$.em	*As for the songs about me, whether adab, whether they are tigi or malgatum,*
54. šir$_3$.gid$_2$.da ar$_2$ nam.lugal.la	*Whether shirgida or praises of kingship,*
55. šumun.ša$_4$ kun.ĝar bal.bal.e ḫe$_2$.em	*Whether shumunsha, kunnar or balbale,*
56. gi.gid$_2$ za.am.za.am ḫe$_2$.em	*Whether gigid or zamzam,*
57. ĝeštu$_2$.ge nu.dib.be$_2$ ka.ta nu.šub.bu.de$_3$	*That they never pass out of memory and never lapse from people's mouths,*
58. ki šu.ke$_4$ lu$_2$ nam bi$_2$.ib$_2$.da$_{13}$.da$_{13}$.a	*It is not (only) the people in the cultic centers who should perform them,*
59. e$_2$.kur za.gin$_3$.na muš nam ba.an.tum$_2$.mu	*They should sung without end in the shining E-kur!*
60. ^{d}en.lil$_2$.ra eš$_3$ u$_4$ sakar.ra.ka.na ḫe$_2$.na.du$_{12}$	*so that they are played for Enlil in his Shrine of the New Moon!*
61. eš$_3$.eš$_3$ kaš gi.rin a.gin$_7$ su$_3$.su$_3$.u$_3$.da.bi	*(and) at the Esh'esh festival, where the girin-beer is endless like water,*

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62. ^{d}en.lil$_2$ ^{d}nin.lil$_2$.da tuš.a.ra — *May they be performed repeatedly before*

ḫe$_2$.en.ne.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$ — *Enlil as he sits with Ninlil,*

Example (9) and example (10) below are particularly interesting in that the case of the focal constituent in each example is quite different: the focal constituent in (9) is in the absolutive case with a raised inanimate possessor, **ki.šu.ke$_4$ lu$_2$**, whereas the focal constituent in (10), namely **su iri.na.ke$_4$**, is in the locative-terminative case coding the experiencer of the predicate **bi$_2$.ib.du$_{10}$.ge**. Elsewhere, in other examples of this construction, the focal constituent occurs in the terminative case as in (7), **tilla$_2$ iri^{ki}.za.ka.še$_3$**, and the locative case as in (8), **gud$_3$ us$_2$.sa.bi.a**. The variety of postpositional phrases seen in the focal position in the *XP nam bi-√ construction is indicative of the fact that it is a pragmatic phenomenon that we are dealing with here. Note, however, that there are no cases in which an ergative noun occurs in focus; this is probably due to the fact that ergative nouns are usually topical and their presence in a focus position would be somewhat surprising.

(10) A praise poem of Shulgi (Shulgi E) [2.4.2.05], l. 83

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ en$_3$.du.g̃u$_{10}$ [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **su iri.na.ke$_4$ nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.du$_{10}$.ge]]]

As for my hymns, **it will not be THE PEOPLE OF HIS OWN CITY** who will enjoy them, (but rather THE PEOPLE OF MY CITY)

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74. tukum.bi en_3.du.$\tilde{g}u_{10}$	*But if, as for my hymns,*
75. mu.⌜$\tilde{g}u_{10}$⌝ [x] ⌜ba⌝.ta.$\tilde{g}a_2$.ar mu.ni la ba.ru.gu?	*... removes my name and fails to ... his name,*
. . . .	
81. ni$\tilde{g}_2$.$erim_2$ maškim.$še_3$ ḫe.en_6.$šum_2$	*Let him be given enmity as his companion,*
82. a_2.sag_3 nam.$uš_2$ dugud $\tilde{g}al_2$.la.gin_7	*May an asag demon, as causer of plague,*
83. su iri.na.ke_4 nam bi_2.ib.du_{10}.ge	*It is not the people of his own city who will enjoy them,*
84. gug.kal bar.$še_3$ mu še.$\tilde{g}ar$.ra.ka igi kalam.ma.ka na.ni.sa_6	*Because of famine in the midst of hungry years, he will not find favor in the countenance of the land,*

(11) A praise poem of Shulgi (Shulgi E) [2.4.2.05], l. 117

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *lu_2 en_3.du.$\tilde{g}u_{10}$ ...*] [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **ki.lugal.gub ki dadag.ga nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi_2.gub.be_2]]

As for my hymn-singer, it is not IN THE PLACE OF THE KING, IN THE SPOTLIGHT that he should stand, (but rather at the king's side)

111. lu_2 en_3.du.$\tilde{g}u_{10}$.a šu i_3.[...]	*The man who ..... my hymns,*
. . . .	
115. bad_3 iri.na.ka na.am_3.⌜bi_2?⌝.[x x]	*May he no longer ... within the walls of the city.*
116. a sa.ga nam.lugal.la.na na.⌜an?⌝.[x x]	*May the criminal offspring of his kingship not...*

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117. ki lugal gub ki dadag.ga nam bi$_2$.gub.[be$_2$]	*It is not in the place of the king, the shining place that he should stand,*
118. ub.šu unken.na.ta bar.še$_3$ ḫe$_2$.[...]	*May he ... from the Ubshu'unkena,*

(12) A hymn to Inanna for Ur-Ninurta (Ur-Ninurta A) [2.5.6.1], l. 85 (Sjöberg 1977, 192, 194)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *x x ⌈bara$_2$⌉mi$_2$ zi.de$_3$.eš du$_{11}$.ga.ĝu$_{10}$*] [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **muš$_3$ nam** [$_{\text{Presuppposition}}$ bi$_2$.ga.ga.an]]

As for the dais which I care for, it is WITHOUT END that you shall sit on it, (rather than a normal reign)

83. ur$_2$ ku$_3$ nam.ti.la SI.A.ĝu$_{10}$ u$_4$.zu su$_3$.su$_3$.de$_3$	*As for my holy, life-giving embrace, to prolong your days (by means of it),*
84. šul ^{d}en.lil$_2$.le e$_2$.kur.ta a$_2$.bi mu.un.da.an.ag$_2$	*Young Man Enlil has commanded me from the Ekur,*
85. x x ⌈bara$_2$⌉ mi$_2$ zi.de$_3$.eš du$_{11}$.ga.ĝu$_{10}$ muš$_3$ nam bi$_2$.ga.ga.an	*As for the dais which I care for, it is without end that you shall sit on it,*
86. ^{d}nanna an ku$_3$.ga pa e$_3$.a ka.na.ag$_2$.e u$_6$ di.gin$_7$	*Like when Nanna, admired by the land (= its inhabitants), appears in clear sky,*
87. $^{[d]}$⌈ur⌉.^{d}nin.urta.ĝu$_{10}$ kur.kur.re ḫi.li ḫu.mu.u$_8$.ši.ak.e	*As for my Ur-Ninurta, may every land rejoice over you,*

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(13) The Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], ll. 15 and 18

(Alster 1974, 34-35, 79-80; Alster 1990; Alster forthcoming)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *gana*$_2$ [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **kaskal.[la] nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib$_2$.ĝa$_2$.ĝa$_2$]] nam.silig gu$_2$ ĝa$_2$.am$_3$

As for (your) fields, **it is not BY THE ROAD** that you should put them, it is only attention they will yield,

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *e*$_2$ [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **sila dağal nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.la$_2$.e]]] KEŠ$_2$.da ĝal$_2$.la.am$_3$

As for (your) house, **it is not ONE ON A WIDE STREET** that you should buy, it will always have someone singing (as the walk),

15. gana$_2$ kaskal.[la] nam bi$_2$.ib$_2$.ĝa$_2$.ĝa$_2$nam.silig gu$_2$ ĝa$_2$.am$_3$	*As for fields, near the road is not where you should put them, (you will) gather only attention, (not barley),*
16. a.ša$_3$ ka.ĝiri$_3$.ka nam ba.e.ur$_{11}$.ru zi bulug.ga.am$_3$	*You should not plough a field at the entrance of a pathway, it is the uprooting of boundary stakes,*
17. gana$_2$.zu.am$_3$ pu$_2$ na.an.ni.du$_3$.e.en uĝ$_3$.e ša.ri.ib.ḫul.ḫul	*You should not build a well in your field, people will damage it,*
18. e$_2$ sila dağal nam bi$_2$.ib.la$_2$.e keš$_2$.da ĝal$_2$.la.am$_3$	*As for a house, next to a public square is not where to buy one, there are always groups (of people) there,*

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Alster (1974, 34-35) reconstructs line 17 as **gan$_2$ ⌜ša$_3$⌝ [...] pu$_2$ na.an.du$_3$.un a.e ša.re.eb.ḫul.ḫul**, which treats the water, **a**, from the well as deleterious agent rather than people (UN > un, ug̃$_3$) who might assemble there. Alster's suggestion that **keš$_2$.da** is to be translated as "taboo," while valid in other contexts (Alster 1974, 79-80), does not seem to make much sense here, so I have taken it as a headless relative (people) 'tied up/together' meaning small groups of people. Such an interpretation also fits the overall theme of the passage that human traffic in various forms is harmful to one's property.

(14) The Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], l. 22 (Alster 1974, 34-35, 81)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ (*za.e*) [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **ki du$_{14}$.da.ka nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.du.x.de$_3$]]]

As for you, **it is not NEAR A QUARREL** that you should walk, (but rather AWAY FROM ONE)

22. **ki du$_{14}$.da.ka nam** bi$_2$.du.x.de$_3$	*It is not near a quarrel that you should walk,*
23. du$_{14}$.de$_3$ lu$_2$.ki.inim.ma nam ba.e.ku$_4$.ku$_4$	*Don't let the quarrel make you a witness,*
24. du$_{14}$.de$_3$ ni$_2$.zu nam ⌜ba⌝.[...]	*Don't let yourself be ... in a quarrel,*
25. du$_{14}$ ⌜nam.ak⌝.de$_3$.en x [...]	*You should not cause a quarrel, ...*

(15) The Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], l. 54-59 (Alster 1974, 36-38, 88)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *gi.sig.ga* $^{\tilde{g}i\check{s}}$*kiri$_6$.ka* [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **da.ga nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.du$_8$.e.en]]]

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54. sun_7.na.da e_2 na.an.da.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$.⌈an⌉ *You should not establish a home with an arrogant man,*

55. gi_4.in.še$_3$ du.de$_3$ ši.me.ši.ib.šub.šub *He will make your life that of a slave girl,*

56. ki.tuš lu_2.ka na.ab.ta.bala.e.de$_3$ *You'll not be able to pass by anyone's place,*

57. ši.du.un ši.du.un ši.me.ši.ib$_2$.be$_2$.e.ne *"Restore it! Restore it!" they will tell you,*

58. gi.sig.ga $^{g̃iš}$kiri$_6$.ka da.ga nam bi$_2$.du$_8$.e.en *Inside the garden's reed fence, you should not hold a social gathering,*

59. su.ga.ab su.ga.ab ši.me.ši.ib$_2$.be$_2$.ne *"Restore it! Restore it!" they will tell you,*

Line 58 corresponds to line 63 in Alster's edition (1974, 38). The context of line 58 is particularly difficult: the meaning of the preceding lines, for example, is entirely up for grabs. The translation above is close to that of ETCSL, but Alster translates it quite differently: "(55) When you go to the slave girl, she will throw it back to you, (56) "Do not transgress people's dwelling places (Alster 1974, 37). The proper interpretation of line 58 is equally unclear.

(16) The Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], ll. 245-249 (Alster 1974, 82-83; Cooper 1983, 248)

[$_{Topic}$ (dumu.g̃u$_{10}$)] [$_{Presupposition}$ $^{g̃iš}$mi.si.IŠ.a [$_{Focus}$ **lag nam**] bi$_2$.šub.be$_2$.en]

My son, it is not A CLOD that you should throw into the strongbox, (but rather GOLD that you should throw in it),

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245. ^{d}ezina$_2$.ra	*You should not ... grain, its ..... are*
na.an.keš$_2$.keš$_2$.re.de$_3$.en	*numerous,*
^{ĝiš}a$_2$.bi i$_3$.šar$_2$	
246. kir$_{11}$.e aš$_2$ nam.en dumu.munus	*You should not abuse a female lamb,*
in.u$_3$.tu.un	*lest you give birth to a daughter,*
247. ^{ĝiš}**mi.si.IŠ.a lag nam**	*It is not a clod that you should throw into*
bi$_2$.šub.be$_2$.en	*the strongbox, if you want to beget a*
dumu.nitaḫ in.u$_3$.tu.un	*son,*
248. dam nam.mu.un.kar.re.en	*You should not abduct a wife, you should*
gu$_3$ KA na.an.ĝa$_2$.ĝa$_2$	*not make her cry (?),*
249. ki dam kar.re nam.silig	*The place where the wife was abducted ...*
gum.ĝa$_2$.am$_3$ [...]	

(17) The Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], l. 256

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *dumu.ĝu$_{10}$*]

[$_{\text{Focus}}$ **inim ama.za inim diĝir.za.ka.še$_3$ nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.dib$_2$.be$_2$.en]]

My son, **it is not THE WORDS OF YOUR MOTHER AND YOUR GOD** that you should transgress, (but rather THE WORDS OF STRANGERS that you should pass by [and ignore]),

254. emeda.ga.la$_2$ ama$_5$.a.ke$_4$	*The wet-nurses in the women's quarters*
lugal.bi.ir nam	*determine the fate of their lord,*
ši.im.mi.ib.tar.re	

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255. ama.zu.ur$_2$ inim diri nam
ba.na.ab.be$_2$.en ḫul
ša.ba.ra.gig.ga.am$_3$
You should not tell your mother exaggerations, that causes hatred against you,

256. **inim ama.za inim diĝir.za.ka.še$_3$ nam** bi$_2$.ib.dib$_2$.be$_2$.en
It is not the words of your mother and your god that you should transgress,

257. ama ^{d}utu.⌜am$_3$⌝ lu$_2$ mu.un.u$_3$.tu
The mother, like Utu, gives birth to the man,

258. ab.ba diĝir.ra.⌜am$_3$⌝ [x]
mu.un.dadag.ge
The father, like a god, makes him bright,

(18) Letter from Ibbi-Suen to Puzur-Shulgi about Ishbi-Erra [3.1.20], Version A 33

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *šu.ni*] [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **iri^{ki}.a nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.sa$_2$.sa$_2$]]

As for his activities, **it is not IN THE CITY** that you should oppose them, (but rather IN THE COUNTRYSIDE),

29. i$_3$.ne.eš$_2$ inim du$_{10}$.ga gi$_4$.gi$_4$.de$_3$
Now, that good words are restored,

30. lul duḫ.duḫ.u$_3$.da
ḫe$_2$.ni.ib.tum$_2$.tum$_2$.mu
and falsehoods are cleared up, lit., loosened, you are to bring it about,

31. uĝ$_3$.ba buru$_{14}$.ba ḫe$_2$.ak.e.de$_3$
You are to let him (= Ishbi-Erra) participate in the harvest among the people,

32. za.e na.an.gur.ru ugu.ĝu$_{10}$.še$_3$
nam.ma.ši.du.un
You yourself should not contest this, and do not come back to me!

33. šu.ni iri^{ki}.a nam bi$_2$.ib.sa$_2$.sa$_2$
As for his hand, it is not (your) city that it will capture,

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34. lu_2 $ma_2.ri_2^{ki}.ke_4$ ĝalga ur.re nam.en na.an.na.ak.e — *This man from Mari, with dog-like understanding, should not rule!*

(19) Proverb Collection 1.40, line 53

[Topic *ninda.ni*] [Focus **lu_2 nam** [Presupposition $bi_2.in.šu_2.šu_2$]]

As for his bread, **no one should COVER IT UP**, (but rather EXPOSE IT TO VIEW)

52. ninda.ni $niĝ_2.u_2.zug_4$ $ḫe_2.a$ — *As for his bread, even if it is rotten,*

53. **lu_2 nam** $bi_2.in.šu_2.šu_2$ — *No one should cover it up,*

(20) Lipit-Ishtar A (Karahashi forthcoming, 8; Römer 1965, 29-38)

[Topic *kalag.ga me.en* [Focus **$niĝ_2$ nam** [Presupposition $bi_2.i.e_3$]]

As for me, the one of strength, it is **not ONE THING** that I made come forth, (but rather EVERYTHING),

93. $niĝ_2.gi.na.ĝu_{10}.uš$ a.na mu.da.šub — *What of my truthful things can be thrown away?*

94. nun ^{d}li.pi_2.it.$eš_4.tar_2$ me.en $uĝ_3.e$ si $bi_2.sa_2$ — *I, prince Lipit-Eshtar, keep the people on a straight path.*

95. si $sa_2.ĝu_{10}.uš$ a.na $ĝa_2.la$ im.mi.dag — *As regards my integrity: in what respect have I ever been idle?*

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96. kalag.ga me.en **nig$_2$ nam** *I am a strong one, it is not just one thing I*

pa bi$_2$.i.e$_3$ *have made appear,*

(21) Proverb Collection 17.b2, ll. 8-10

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ (*za.e*) [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **lu$_2$ nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.til.e]]

As for you, It is **not A MAN** who brings about your end, (but rather THE GODS),

8. ⌜pirig̃⌝.gin$_7$ ne he$_2$.gub *May you establish yourself like a lion,*

9. x.zu ^{giš}kiri$_6$ a ḫe$_2$.eb$^{?}$.gub . . .

10. lu$_2$ nam bi$_2$.ib.til.e *It is not a man who brings about your end,*

Overall, the foregoing examples demonstrate the relatively wide applicability of the construction in different syntactic conditions, but a concentration of the exemplars in the epic and wisdom literatures, both of which derive from the Ur III period at the latest—an early version of Shuruppak's Instructions, for example, dates to the ED IIIa period—may suggest that the use of the construction was already archaic and poorly understood prior to the Ur III period. The absence of exemplars from texts composed in the Old Babylonian period would suggest that the Old Babylonian scholars no longer had productive use of the construction.

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(22) The Young Scribe and his Father, ll. 114-117, manuscript Z

(Sjöberg 1973, 112, 117-118, 128; Karahashi 2000, 87)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *nam* ^{d}*en.lil$_2$.la$_2$*] [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **lu$_2$.u$_{18}$.lu.a nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.tar.re]]

As for the fate (assigned) by Enlil, **it is not AMONG THE PEOPLE** that it is decided, (but rather AMONG THE GODS),

114. ĝiš gid$_2$ ad.da.ĝu$_{10}$.še$_3$	*You didn't say, "I want to listen to the ... for*
eštu$_2$ ga.ĝar nu.ub.be$_2$	*my father,"*
115. **nam ^{d}en.lil$_2$.la$_2$ lu$_2$.u$_{18}$.lu.a**	*It is not among humanity that the fate of*
nam bi$_2$.ib.tar.re	*Enlil is determined,*
116. dumu kiĝ$_2$.gi$_4$.a ad.da.na.ka	*That a son should follow in the occupation*
ib$_2$.us$_2$.e	*of his father,*
117. a.ra$_2$ na.me.ka ka.tar	*Haven't you heard these precious statements*
du$_{11}$.du$_{11}$ ĝiš li.bi$_2$.in.tuku.am$_3$	*made innumerable times?*

Sjöberg notes that his version of this manuscript is based on a handcopy by Kaneva, but I have not yet been unable to locate the publication: the foregoing transliteration is based on Sjöberg's composite text in conjunction with his list of variants. This manuscript essentially changes the mood from interrogative to indicative, so, for example, in line 117, what is a question in the majority text becomes an assertion in this manuscript, "you have heard . . . innumerable times!" The meaning of the passage is still quite uncertain and I have taken the absence of an explicit agreement marker before the verbal root in

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combination with the copula following the verb as an indication that line 117 is a question (for a similar construction, see the series of **igi bi_2.du_8.am_3** ["did you see . . . ?"] predicates at the end of *Gilgamesh and the Netherworld*). The final verb in line 115 also shows a great deal of formal variation: **nam.bi tar.ra** (K and EE), **nam bi_2.ib.tar.re** (Z), **nam.bi in.tar.re** (AA), **nam.bi in.tar.ra.am_3** (FF), **nam.bi tar.re** (II), **nam bi_2 [...]** (JJ). It seems fairly clear that the variation revolves around the sequence /nam bi tar/ and one interpretation, **nam bi_2.ib.tar.re** (Z), belongs to a grammatical class dealt with in this chapter, namely the *XP nam bi-√ distributional class. Otherwise, the differences between manuscript Z and the majority text are more difficult to evaluate: ĝiš gid.da ad.da.**ĝu_{10}**.še_3 instead of ĝiš gid_2.da ad.da.**ĝa_2**.še_3; nu.ub.be_2 instead of nu.ub.be_2.**en**; and ib_2.us_2.**e** instead of **i_3**.ib_2.us_2.

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4.3 Focus-affected compound verb constructions (excluding $BNBV_{inal}$)

The interpretation of the four following examples is particularly difficult due to the fact that they are compound verbs with relatively opaque compositionality.

(23) Lugalbanda [1.8.2.2], ll. 213-217

[$_{Topic}$ *gu_3 i.ri.de_2.a nam mu.ni.ib.be_2.en*

[$_{Presupposition}$ šeš.zu.ne.er [$_{Focus}$ **pa nam**] bi_2.ib.e_3.en]

As for what I have told you, the fate I have fixed for you, **you should not MAKE IT KNOWN** to your brothers, (but rather you should TAKE CARE OF THEM [cf. **a_2-√e_3** "to take care of"], lit. it is not THE BRANCH that you should cause to go forth [so as to inform] your brothers, but rather THE ARM that you should cause to go forth.

213. gu_3 i.ri.de_2.a nam i.ri.tar.ra	*As for what I told you, your fate I ordained,*
214. ku.li.zu.ne.er nam mu.ni.ib.be_2.en	*It is not your friends whom you should tell,*
215. šeš.zu.ne.er pa nam bi_2.ib.e_3.en	*It is not to your brothers that you should make it known,*
216. sa_6.ga ḫul $ša_3$.ga ĝal$_2$.la ur_5 ḫe$_2$.na.nam.ma	*Fair fortune may conceal foul, isn't it true?*
217. ĝa$_2$.e gud_3.ĝu_{10}.še$_3$ ḫe$_2$.me.en za.e erin$_2$.zu ḫe$_2$.me.en	*Leave me to my nest, you should be with your troops,"*

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Though the translation I offer in (23) is, in my view, roughly correct, a rather subtle pun may also be at work in the passage: if the contrast in (23) is in fact between **pa**-√$\mathbf{e}_3$ "to appear" and $\mathbf{a}_2$-√$\mathbf{e}_3$ "to take care of," then a literal translation, taking the bird imagery into consideration might be something like "it is not YOUR WINGS, **pa**, that you should show your brothers, but rather YOUR ARMS, $\mathbf{a}_2$. In itself the contrast is rather innocuous, but since **pa** "wing" and $\mathbf{a}_2$ "arm" as body-part nouns are emblematic of the contrast between bird and man and by extension, in the language of the epic, the contrast between the divine realm of the bird-man and that of an ordinary mortal, what Anzu seems to be telling Lugalbanda is that the time of his rite of passage is over (cf. Michalowski 1980b) and that it is time to return to human company.

(24) The Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], ll. 9-12

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *na.ri.ga.g̃u$_{10}$*] [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **šu nam** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.bar.re]]

As for my instructions, **you should not LOSE TRACK of them**, (but rather follow them closely [cf. igi-√bar "to keep an eye on something"], lit. **it is not THE HAND** that you should open [so as to release], but rather THE EYE that you should (keep) open [so as to keep an eye on something])

9. dumu.g̃u$_{10}$ na ga.ri na ri.g̃u$_{10}$	*My son, let me instruct you, remember my*
he$_2$.dab$_5$	*advice,*
10. zi.u$_4$.su$_3$.ra$_2$ inim ga.ra.ab.⌜du$_{11}$⌝	*Zi'usudra, let me speak a word to you, you*
g̃izzal ḫe$_2$.em.ši.ak	*should pay attention!*

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11. na ri.ga.ĝu$_{10}$ **šu nam** bi$_2$.bar.re	*As for my instructions, you should not lose track of them,*
12. inim du$_{11}$.ga.ĝu$_{10}$ na.ab.ta.bala.e.de$_3$	*As for my words, you should not turn away from them,*

This passage is repeated more-or-less verbatim in lines 84-87 and lines 149-152. ETCSL omits **šu** from line 151 (equivalent to line 156 in Alster's edition [1974, 42]), but all four of the exemplars that preserve the relevant part of the line in Alster's edition include the **šu** (Alster 1974, 62).

(25) Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], ll. 32-34 (Karahashi 2000, 82)

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *dumu.ĝu$_{10}$*] [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ daggan.na lu$_2$ dam tuku.da [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **dur$_2$ nam**] bi$_2$.ĝa$_2$.ĝa$_2$]
My son, **you should not SIT DOWN** in a chamber with a married woman, (but rather you should REMAIN STANDING)

32. nitaḫ niĝir.si na.an.ak ni$_2$.zu na.an x x	*You should not make a young man best man ...,*
33. ki.sikil dam tuku.⌜da⌝ e.⌜ne⌝ nam.mu.un.ne$^?$.e inim sig.ga ⌜mah⌝.[am$_3$]	*You should not play around with a young married woman, (her) weak words will be weighty,*
34. dumu.[ĝu$_{10}$] daggan.na lu$_2$ dam ⌜tuku.da⌝ dur$_2$ nam ⌜bi$_2$⌝.e.ĝa$_2$.ĝa$_2$	*My son, in a chamber with a married woman, lit. married person, you should not sit down,*

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(26) The Instructions of Shuruppak [5.6.1], ll. 29-31 (Alster 1974, 36-37, 83;

[$_{\text{Topic}}$ *ni$_2$.zu*] [$_{\text{Focus}}$ **tun$_3$.am$_3^{\text{nam}}$** [$_{\text{Presupposition}}$ bi$_2$.ib.bar.ʳre¹.e]]

As for fearsomeness, **it is not AN AXE** that you should hold on to, (but rather A TRUE EYE (igi zi(d) [cf. igi zi √bar]),

29. e$_2$ na.a.an.ni.buru$_3$.e.en	*You should not break into a house, you*
mi.si.IŠ.ra al nam.me	*should not wish for the money chest,*
30. ni$_2$.zu ʳpirig̃ na.nam¹ ul.dab$_5$ sag̃	*As for your fearsomeness, it is that of a lion,*
na.nam	*but once caught, it is that of a slave,*
31. dumu.g̃u$_{10}$ sa gaz nam.mu.u$_3$.ak.e	*My son, you should not commit robbery—as*
ni$_2$.zu **tun$_3$.am$_3^{\text{nam}}$**	*for fearsomeness, it is not an axe that*
bi$_2$.ib.bar.ʳre¹.e	*hold,*

Line 31 in the ETCSL version, which I adopt as conventional, is equivalent to lines 35-36 in Alster's edition (1974, 36-37). In his commentary (1974, 83), Alster takes **ni$_2$.zu** as a phonetic writing of **ni$_2$.zuḫ** "thief," but translates it in his edition as 'yourself'. I also take the NAM in line 31 as a gloss on **tun$_3$.am$_3^{\text{nam}}$** so as to clarify that it is /tun-nam/ rather than /tun-am/: the orthography is interesting in that if the author had wanted to indicate a simple copula, the expected orthography would have been **tun$_3$.na.am$_3$**. Note, therefore, that, apparently, one of the reasons for the highly conventionalized orthography of NAM for *na-/*nu-am might be that, if the underlying form is *na-am, a syllabic orthography would have been systematically confused with the third person animate possessive pronoun followed by the copula *XP-ni-am > XP-**na.am$_3$**—the occurrence of NAM

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following a word that ends in /n/ in this case represents a similar problem for the orthographic system. At the same time, given the conventionalized orthography of NAM in the negative contrastive focus constructions dealt with in this section, it could just as well be taken as a kind of semantic, or more precisely, a morphosyntactic determinative, indicating the particular morphological segmentation of the sequence in question. The contrast in this example is somewhat unclear to me, but I suspect that it is with *igi zi √bar "to look at something/one with a clear/just eye."

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4.4 Focus-affected $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates

At present, I know of just one example of a focus-affected $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate in line 410 of the Ur Lament. Due to the fact that there is only a single example of the construction, that it is formally anomalous in various ways and that it appears in a composition that was, in all likelihood, composed in the Isin-Larsa period, I cannot exclude that possibility that the postulation of a focus-affected $BNBV_{inal}$ class in the *XP nam bi-√ construction is mistaken. Nonetheless, if the single example is valid to some degree, it is a very interesting example and the following analysis proceeds on the assumption that it represents some stage of Sumerian linguistic reality. The line numbers used here are consistent with ETCSL's numbering, but Römer's new edition numbers my line 410 as line 408.

(27) Ur Lament [2.2.2], ll. 407-410

(Kramer 1940; Jacobsen 1987, 473; Römer 2004, 82 and 166)

[$_{Topic}$ *uĝ$_3$ saĝ gi$_6$.zu*] [$_{Presupposition}$ [$_{Focus}$ **igi.<<zu>>$^?$ nam**] bi$_2$.ib.du$_8$]

As for your black-headed people, **it is not YOU WHO SEE** them (after the storm has cleared, but rather THEY WHO SEE you, the moon-god, Nanna, in a night sky free of storms)

407. u$_4$.de$_3$ u$_4$ kalam.ma	*The storm that causes the light of the land to*
u$_2$.gu bi$_2$.ib.de$_2$.a.re	*disappear,*

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408. u_4 ḫul gig du_{11}.ga ^{d}en.lil_2.la_2.ta	*The evil storm that sweeps through, ordered*
im.mi.in.zal.la.re	*in hate by Enlil,*
409. a.a ^{d}nanna u_4.bi uru_2.zu.ta	*Father Nanna, may that storm swoop down*
ki nam ba.$\tilde{g}a_2$.$\tilde{g}a_2$	*no more on your city,*
410. $u\tilde{g}_3$ $sa\tilde{g}$ gi_6.zu igi.<<zu>>$^{?}$	*As for your black-headed people, it is not*
nam bi_2.ib.du_8[36]	*you who see them,*

The reconstruction of line 410 used here is in conformity with ETCSL's presentation, but the evidence in the text-artifactual record is quite slim. Römer's score transliteration, which I have altered in some typographic details, reads as follows (Römer 2004, 82):

(28) Ur Lament [2.2.2], l. 410 (l. 408 in Römer 2004, 82)

A V 408	$u\tilde{g}_3$ $sa\tilde{g}$ gi_6.zu igi$^{?}$.zu$^{??}$ nam bi_2.ib.du_8
CC	OMITS
HH 19	⌜$u\tilde{g}_3$⌝* $sa\tilde{g}$ gi_6.ga.zu igi.bi nam* bi_2.ib.du_8
R_4 IV 14	[...] ⌜ib⌝$^{!?}$.du_8
Da rev. II 9	[...] igi.zu nam ⌜bi_2.ib$^{!?}$.du_8⌝
C VI 3	[...] ⌜bi_2⌝.ib_2.du_8
S 2	[...] ⌜gi_6⌝.zu ⌜igi⌝ [...]

[36] The pronominal agreement marker *-b- in **bi_2.ib.du_8**, like the sequence of similar forms in example (8), seems to indicate future/modal reference, see the discussion following example (8).

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Römer notes the "conspicuous alternation" between **igi.zu** (A V 408; Da, rev. II 9) and **igi.bi** (HH19)," and goes on to contrast Jacobsen's interpretation of the line on the basis of **√du$_8$** as a simple verb with Falkenstein's suggestion that it is a compound verb **igi-√du$_8$**, but offers little insight into the matter (2004, 166). I suspect that the relatively unusual syntactic form of the line has resulted in the two versions, which, interestingly enough, present two different perspectives on the perception of Nanna. Since the possessive pronoun presumably refers to the perceiver rather than the one who is perceived, the version with **igi.zu** could be translated "as for your black-headed people, it is not YOU WHO CAN SEE them, (but rather THEY WHO CAN SEE you)." The alternative in manuscript HH has only **igi.bi**, but there is also an additional locative postposition inserted into the topicalized phrase, ⌜u$\tilde{g}_3$⌝ sa$\tilde{g}$.gi$_6$.**ga**.zu, in order to form an anticipatory genitive within the topicalized phrase (with *-bi as the topic-marking possessor rather than *-zu). This makes the black-headed people of Nanna the possessor of **igi** and the perceiver of whatever is to be seen: "As for your black-headed people, it is not THEY WHO SAW ... (?)." This interpretation seems, however, to collapse under its own weight.

I would submit that the original form is not preserved in any of the extant witnesses: namely, **u$\tilde{g}_3$ sa$\tilde{g}$.gi$_6$.zu igi nam bi$_2$.ib$_2$.du$_8$**, "As for your black-headed people, it is not THE STORM that they saw, (but rather YOU, NANNA, THE MOON GOD, whom they saw in the clear, storm-free sky)." The confusion seems to arise from the fact that the perceived object, namely **u$_4$ ... re**, was originally in the underlying form of the line: ***u$\tilde{g}_3$ sa$\tilde{g}$ gi$_6$.zu u$_4$...re igi nam bi$_2$.ib$_2$.du$_8$**. But I looks like it has been moved out of line 410

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and made the subject of a lengthy "appellation poem" (Michalowski 1996, 146), each line of which is followed by the demonstrative *-re. Woods, as part of a larger effort to make sense of deixis in Sumerian, has collected 42 examples of similar uses of *-re as a demonstrative, 18 of which occur in the very same passage from the Ur Lament. Nearly every line in the series of appellations that precede line 410 in description of the storm ends with the demonstrative *-re (Woods 2001, 119-123). Woods has argued, quite persuasively in my view, that the *-re demonstrative is the distal, non-visible member of a ternary set of demonstratives (Woods 2001, 167 and 171):

*-e	PROXIMAL
*-še	DISTAL, VISIBLE
*-re	DISTAL, NON-VISIBLE

Although I find Woods' interpretation of *-re quite appealing, many of his proposed semantic/pragmatic features (from disjoint ontic realms [Woods 2001, 157-148] to an iconic model of its discourse functions that maps the distal feature of the demonstrative to the "end [or] final position [in] a relative clause [Woods 2001, 116]) can safely be disregarded. As the examples that Woods has assembled make clear, the pragmatics of the demonstrative follow quite directly from its semantic features: the demonstrative *-re marks nominals (including relative clauses) that refer to an entity that is *no longer visible* at the point in time when the verb of perception takes place. Woods indicates this in some

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of his translations through the use of "once" and in others the addition of "used to" or past tense on the main verb in the translation.

(29) Lament for Sumer and Ur 338

(Michalowski 1989, 56-57, 98; Woods 2001, 120, ex. 133)

ne.mur dugud.gin$_7$ i$_3$.ra.a.re i.bi$_2$.bi ba.gul

As for the fire that used to burn like a heavy coal, its smoke is now extinguished,

(30) Nippur Lament 38-39

(Woods 2001, 120, ex. 135)

^{kuš}šem$_5$ ^{kuš}a.la$_2$ mu.un.du$_{12}$.a.re i.lu gig.ga.a a.na.še$_3$ u$_4$ mi.ni.ib$_2$.zal

As for those who used to play the shem and ala drums, why do they pass the day in bitter lament?

These examples as well as the vast majority of the other examples occur—as we might have expected for a syntactic construction that refers to entities that no longer exist—in laments. I am even tempted to say that the frequent occurrence of *-re and the semantics associated with it could probably be used as a criterion for the identification of laments and elegies as generic categories. Interestingly enough, this example may represent an exception to my earlier statement that the composers of OB texts no longer understood the *XP nam bi-√ construction, but this is the only lament in which I have identified the construction.

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It is interesting that the construction differs from the other examples of the *XP nam bi-√ construction in a couple of ways: not only is the inalienable noun modified by a possessive suffix that is not followed by any subsequent case-marking postposition, which is not the case with any other examples, but the verb itself is not in the progressive/imperfective (*marû*) aspect even though it refers to a future event. It may be that the syntax of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates was simply different from the other examples, but it is also entirely possible that the composers were attempting to use two different morphosyntactic/rhetorical devices so as to achieve the trope at work in the passage: the use of *-re to indicate something *no longer visible* and the use of the *XP nam bi-√ construction to code *negative contrastive focus*. Although the artistry is quite advanced in my opinion, the grammaticality of the passage—if we can judge on the basis of comparison to other *XP nam bi-√ constructions—is either marginal or no longer familiar to its tradents and consequently, the manuscripts exhibit a great deal of variation and orthographic uncertainty.

Now, to return to the passage from the Ur Lament, (27) above, the real poetic beauty of the passage lies in its juxtaposition of the terrifying darkness of the storm and the calm, tranquil darkness of a clear, moonlit night. In the sections that lead up to lines 388-414, a litany of destruction is attributed to the storm, but in the passage itself, the lines leading up to line 410 draw a contrast between the storm (u_4) and the light of the land (u_4 kalam.ma), namely the moon-god Nanna. This opposition is epitomized by line 407.

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(31) Ur Lament, l. 407

u_4.de$_3$ u_4 kalam.ma u_2.gu bi$_2$.ib.de$_2$.a.re

The storm that causes the light of the land to disappear,

The storm (u_4) can, therefore, be thought of as an utter darkness, whereas the light of the land (as made clear by lines 409-410) is to be equated with Nanna, the moon-god. The series of lines that end in *-re all seem to refer to the storm and the use of the demonstrative *-re indicates the hope of those singing the lament that the storm will *no longer be visible* in future. Clearly this use of *-re inverts the standard trope in which the entities destroyed by the storm bear the *-re demonstrative. The inversion reaches its culmination in line 410 and my reconstruction of the line without any possessive pronoun on **igi** completes the contrast between the no longer visible storm and—as a direct consequence of the disappearance of the storm—the visibility of Nanna, the moon-god, in a clear, nighttime sky: **uĝ$_3$ saĝ.gi$_6$.zu u$_4$...re igi nam bi$_2$.ib$_2$.du$_8$** "As for your black-headed people, it is not THE STORM (u_4) that they will see, (but rather YOU, NANNA, THE MOON-GOD, that they will see)." Hence the addition of the second person possessive pronoun to **igi** to form **igi.zu** in some of the witnesses is apparently an attempt to indicate the meaning of the passage in a more direct fashion than the use of the contrast implicit in the negative contrastive focus construction.

Although this phenomenon can be thought of as a form of evidentiality (Chafe and Nichols 1986), the contexts in which *-re occurs point to a more specific "problem," if you will, that the use of *-re solves: there is a fundamental difference between verbs such

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as "to look at," which need not specify an object of perception and are regularly agentive, and verbs such as "to see," which must occur with a perceived object and are regularly non-agentive. Whereas a statement like "Mary is looking at nothing" can be interpreted to mean that Mary is looking at an entity that happens to be empty space, when "to look at" is replaced by "to see," this is no longer the case. But the use of the demonstrative *-re seems to allow for the direct perception of an entity that is *no longer visible* even when it occurs with the verb that means "to see" in Sumerian.

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4.5 Seeing something that is no longer there: The demonstrative *-re and visual perception

The somewhat unusual characterization of contrastive focus in Sumerian in the foregoing pages has a number of features to recommend it, notably the degree to which it makes sense of otherwise recalcitrant textual passages. But the major flaw it embodies is that in no case—not even one—is the positive contrastive alternative to the negated focal phrase present in the text-artifactual record. In light of such a seemingly problematic empirical gap, I would like to offer a redescription of the phenomena in the previous section that captures the contrastive force of the construction without necessarily positing a distinct, positive contrastive sentence that is regularly deleted under relevance. At the same time, the alternative proposed in this section—based on Herburger's analysis of double negation in Spanish—also helps us to make sense of the **igi nam bi_2.ib_2.du_8** construction in the previous section. I should emphasize that the interpretation of the *XP nam bi-√ construction in this section is not necessarily incommensurable with that of the previous section: given the different levels at which a particular grammatical construction can be evaluated (morphological, semantic, pragmatic, generic), the previous section can be thought of as an investigation of the construction in pragmatic or generic terms, whereas this section looks more directly at its morphosyntactic and semantic details.

As part of a quite involved argument on the nature of focal presupposition that need not detain us here, Herburger reviews certain interesting double negative constructions in Spanish (Herburger 2000, 23-26). The following examples provide a useful starting point (Herburger 2000, 24, ex. 19 and 20).

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(32) María se fué con nada

Maria left with nothing

"Maria left with nothing"

(33) María no se fué con nada

Maria Neg left with nothing

a. "Maria didn't leave with anything (simple negation)"

b. "Maria didn't leave with nothing, i.e., she left with something (double negation)"

Whereas the example in (32) with its negative indefinite pronoun in the prepositional phrase *con nada* "with nothing" has only one interpretation: "that Maria left, but that she did not take anything with her," the sentence in (33) has two diametrically opposed interpretations. The interpretation in (33a) is basically equivalent to the meaning of the sentence in (32), where *nada* "nothing" is what is known as a negative polarity item (NPI) such as "any" in English. Hence the proper translation of (32) and (33a) in English would be the two following sentences.

(34) a. Maria left with nothing.

b. Maria didn't leave with anything.

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In English, the NPI allows the negative particle to move to the main verb, while being interpreted as negating "thing" rather than "left": hence "Maria didn't leave with anything" still entails that Maria actually left due to the presence of the NPI. The double negative interpretation in (33b), however, does not interpret *nada* "nothing" as a NPI, but rather as an independent referential term. In other words, according to the interpretation in (33b), *nada* refers to an entity that can be described as "nothing, thin air, empty space" and only after *nada*'s act of reference is the sentence as a whole negated. This double negation then leads the addressee or reader to draw the opposite implication: if she did not leave with nothing at all, then she must have left with something. Note that regardless of which interpretation of (33) that we choose, the fact that Maria left is presupposed and is not affected by the negation.

Herburger then goes on to verbs of visual perception in Spanish and contrasts two versions of the following sentence:

(35) Spanish (Herburger 2000, 25, ex. 22)

El pobre Juan se ha melto loco. Se pasa los días *mirando a nada* / ***viendo nada*

Poor Juan has gone insane. He spends his days *looking at nothing* / ***seeing nothing.*

As Herburger writes, "[i]t is possible to look and to look at nothing (even if a sane person might not spend his days doing that). It is not possible, though, to see and to see nothing" (Herburger 2000, 25). Herburger is arguing that as long as *nada* is part of a prepositional phrase rather than an argument of the verb, it can have narrow scope (the negation only

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applying to *nada* as in [32b]) and "refer" in some sense to nothingness. The difference between *mirando a* "to look at" and *viendo* "to see" also exists in Sumerian, thus in the two following examples, which have already been presented earlier in the study, **igi-√il$_2$** "to look at" does not require a perceived object, but **igi-√du$_8$** "to see" does, even when it is negated.

(36) Lugalbanda II (Wilcke 1969a, 110-111, 184)

207. [mušen.e an].ta igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$	*As for the Bird, who was looking from*
erin$_2$.e igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru	*above, she saw the troops,*
208. [lugal].⌈banda$_3$⌉^{da} ki.ta	*As for Lugalbanda, who was looking from*
igi mi.ni.in.il$_2$ saḫar erin$_2$.e	*below, he saw the troops*
du$_8$.a igi bi$_2$.in.du$_8$.ru	*enveloped in dust,*

(37) Gilgamesh and the Netherworld, ll. 300-303

(Karahashi 2000, 121, ex. 25; Shaffer 1963, 95, 119)

300. niĝar$_x$(NIGIN$_3$)^{ĝar} tur.tur.ĝu$_{10}$	*(Gilgamesh:) As for my little newborns,*
ni$_2$.ba nu.zu igi bi$_2$.du$_8$.am$_3$	*who never knew themselves, did*
igi bi$_2$.du$_8$.am$_3$ a.na.gin$_7$ an.ak	*you see them? (Enkidu:) I saw them.*
	(Gilgamesh:) What happened to them?
301. ^{ĝiš}banšur ku$_3$.sig$_{17}$ ku$_3$.babbar	*(Enkidu:) They play on a table of gold and*
lal$_3$ i$_3$.nun.ta e.ne im.di.e.ne	*silver, (laden with) honey and ghee,*

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302. lu_2 izi.la_2 igi bi_2.du_8.am_3	*(Gilgamesh:) Did you see a man who'd*
igi nu mu.ni.du_8.am_3	*burned? (Enkidu:) I didn't see one.*
(var. mu.de_3.du_8.am_3)	
303. gidim.a.ni nu.$ĝal_2$ i.bi_2.ni	*As for his ghost, it is not there. As for his*
an.na ba.e.e_{11}	*smoke, it went up into the sky,*

In (36), neither of the two occurrences of **igi mi.ni.in.il_2** take a perceived object as an argument: **igi** refers to the eye of the beholder rather than that which is perceived and if a target of the "looking at" does occur, it is never followed by the locative-terminative postposition *-e: in the set of attestations collected by Karahashi (2000, 125-126), the object being "looked at" is followed by the dative (*-ra), the locative (*-a) or the terminative (*-$še_3$). The main verb in each line, **igi bi_2.ib_2.du_8.ru**, does occur with the perceived object in the locative-terminative case and agrees with it in number, *-eš, as well. In (37), the point of interest is the contrast between Enkidu's report of successful perception in line 300 and the report of unsuccessful perception in line 302, **igi nu mu.ni.du_8.am_3**. This type of alternation apparently provided the impetus for a number of forerunners to the directive case hypothesis (Poebel 1933; Falkenstein 1978, 188; Gragg 1973a, 72), so that, for instance, just a few lines after arguing for a distinctively "locative" interpretation of *-ni-, Gragg cautions that "[t]his position which we have taken should not however be allowed to obscure the close relationship that exists between - n i -, i m – m i -, (and also b í -)" (Gragg 1973a, 72). In my view, the differences in form result from the need for a direct object with a verb meaning "to see" even when the verb

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is negated. The phrase **igi nu mu.ni.du$_8$**, "I didn't see anyone (like that)," therefore, corresponds to an NPI in English in certain respects, but I do not go into the matter further here.

The question, or rather the textual passage, looming in the background of this entire discussion is the **igi nam bi$_2$.ib.du$_8$** construction in line 410 of the Ur Lament, example (27) above, which I repeat below.

(38) Ur Lament [2.2.2], ll. 407-410

407. u$_4$.de$_3$ u$_4$ kalam.ma	*The storm that causes the light of the land to*
u$_2$.gu bi$_2$.ib.de$_2$.a.re	*disappear,*
408. u$_4$ hul gig du$_{11}$.ga ^{d}en.lil$_2$.la$_2$.ta	*The storm that sweeps through, ordered in*
im.mi.in.zal.la.re	*hate by Enlil,*
409. a.a ^{d}nanna u$_4$.bi uru$_2$.zu.ta	*Father Nanna, may that storm swoop down*
ki nam ba.g̃a$_2$.g̃a$_2$	*no more on your city,*
410. ug̃$_3$ sag̃ gi$_6$.zu igi.<<zu>>$^{?}$	*As for your black-headed people, it is not*
nam bi$_2$.ib.du$_8$	*the storm that they will see,*

In (38), the verbal prefix *bi-√ indicates that there should be a raised possessor of **igi** as the perceived object and as I have argued above, the raised possessor that we are looking for is represented by the series of epithets and appellations applied to the storm (u$_4$) in lines 392, 395-398, 402-408, each of which ends with the distal, non-visible demonstrative *-re.

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The double negation implicit in the juxtaposition of the *negative* contrastive focus particle, *nam, and the non-visible demonstrative, *-re, i.e., that which is *no longer* visible, complicates matters. I understand the basic underlying form of the line to be the following:

(39) **u_4...re igi $bi_2.ib_2.du_8$

They see/saw the storm that is/was no longer there.

Regardless of variation in tense or other factors, the English translation is problematic. If, however, the negative contrastive focus particle, *nam, is introduced into (39), and the new formulation translated in line with the non-$BNBV_{inal}$ examples in sections 4.2 and 4.3, the result might be something like this:

(40) *u_4...re igi nam $bi_2.ib_2.du_8$

It is not the storm (u_4) that is/was no longer visible that they saw, (but rather the light of the land (u_4 kalam.ma) that is/was visible = Nanna)

The contrast, therefore, consists of two parts: the contrast between that which is not visible and that which is visible and the contrast between the storm (u_4) and the light of the land (u_4 kalam.ma = Nanna). If the parallel with the double negative construction in Spanish holds, then each of the two possible interpretations of the double negative construction in Spanish corresponds to half of the translation in (40): the interpretation in

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(33a), "Maria didn't leave with anything," corresponds to "it is *not* the storm that is *no longer* there (that they see)," whereas the interpretation in (33b), "Maria didn't leave with nothing, i.e., she left with something," corresponds to "it is the light (of the land) (that they see)."

In all of the examples of the *XP nam bi-√ construction including the example from line 410 of the Ur Lament, the main verb occurs to the right of the copula and is presupposed, while the constituent immediately to the left of the copula is negated under contrastive focus. Here, however, in the example from line 410 of the Ur Lament, the extensional meaning of the two contrastive interpretations, namely "it is not the storm (u_4) that is no longer there (that they see)" and "it is the light of the land (u_4 kalam.ma) (that they see)," is the same. Due to the peculiar nature of verbs of direct perception such as **igi-√du$_8$** and the context at issue, the act of "not seeing the storm" is equivalent to the act of "seeing Nanna in the clear evening sky." Recall the discussion of the thetic character of direct perception complements [DPCs] and the similarities between DPCs and HIRCs outlined in section 3.5. If DPCs are thetic, it should not be possible, under ordinary circumstances, to distinguish two entities in a thetic statement and bring them into contrast. But here in line 410 of the Ur Lament, we find a rather unordinary situation in which two contrastive intensions are equivalent in extensional terms, thereby allowing contrastive focus and the thetic semantics of a DPC to coexist in a single construction.

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4.6 Contrastive/identificational focus and the thetic/categorical opposition

Given the fact that the example in the previous section is unique among *XP nam bi-√ constructions in a number of respects, it obviously cannot serve as a model for interpreting the other exemplars, but it does at least raise the issue of the thetic/categorical opposition and its relation to contrastive focus. Since all of the examples of the *XP nam bi-√ construction necessarily represent examples of contrastive focus, I turn initially to a further explication of contrastive focus, followed by a discussion of the interactions between contrastive focus and the thetic/categorical opposition.

Kiss (1998) argues that there are two basic types of focus: identificational focus and informational focus. Identificational focus, which I have generally termed contrastive focus above, can be distinguished from informational focus on the basis of both morphosyntactic and semantic criteria. The semantic criteria have been outlined in some detail above, but in terms of morphosyntax, identificational focus regularly moves the focused constituent to the left periphery or puts it into some other distinctive syntactic configuration such as the copular construction in Sumerian. In the two pairs of examples that follow, from Greek (41) and Finnish (42) respectively, constituents under identificational focus appear in bold, while items bearing informational focus are in capitals (Kiss 1998, 246, ex. 2 and 3).

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(41) a. **ston** **petro** dhanisan to vivlio

to.the Petro lent.3Pl the.Acc book

It was **to Petro** that they lent the book

b. dhanisann to vivlio STON PETRO

lent.3Pl the.Acc book to.the Petro

They lent the book TO PETRO

(42) a. **annalle** mikko antoi kukkia

Anna.Adess Mikko gave flowers

It was **to Anna** that Mikko gave flowers

b. mikko antoi kukkia ANNALLE

Mikko gave flowers Anna.Adess

Mikko gave flowers TO ANNA

In each pair of sentences, the first member, (41a) and (42a), is an example of identificational focus as evidenced by the fact that the focused constituent has moved to clause-initial position, whereas the examples of informational focus, in (41b) and (42b), show no such movement, merely distinctive intonation. The English glosses in (41) and (42) are, in this regard, instructive as well: identificational focus in English is indicated

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through the use of the cleft sentence, whereas a constituent that bears informational focus remains *in situ* and has a distinctive intonation.

The difference between identificational and informational focus in Sumerian (as briefly noted in relation to examples (1) and (3) in section 4.2 above) is that identificational focus regularly makes use of the copula, whereas informational focus does not make special use of the copula.

(43) The Tale of Gudam [1.3.4], ll. 10-11

10. i_3.gu_7.a.zu i_3.gu_7.a.zu	*As for what you have eaten, as for what you have eaten,*
11. ninda nu.e.gu_7 **uzu.zu.um** i_3.gu_7	*It was not bread that you have eaten, it was* ***your flesh*** *that you have eaten!*

(44) Gilgamesh and the Netherworld [1.8.1.4], ll. 175 and 179

175. ^{ĝiš}e.ke_4.ma.$ĝu_{10}$ ganzer.$še_3$	*As for my ekema, it has fallen into Ganzer,*
mu.da.šub **a.ba.a** ma.ra.ab.e_{11}.de_3	*who will descend on my behalf?*
...	
179. ^{ĝiš}e.ke_4.ma.zu ganzer.ta **ĝa_2.e**	*As for your ekema, I shall retrieve it from*
ga mu.ra.ab.e_{11}.de_3	*Ganzer for you,*

In (43), it seems clear that **uzu.zu.um** (< *uzu.zu.am_3) contrasts with **ninda**, since **ninda** is followed by the negative form of the same verb that follows **uzu.zu.um**. Although both

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ninda and **uzu.zu** appear in the same line in (43), the first half of the line, in which **ninda** occurs with a negative form of the verb is a simple statement of fact; the second half of the line, however, draws a contrast with the first half of the line and it is **uzu.zu.um** in contrastive focus that bears the copula. In (44), however, **ĝa$_2$.e** "I" under informational focus is not contrastive and is not followed by the copula. Although both types of focused phrase appear immediately before the verb, it seems that they can be distinguished on the basis of the presence or absence of the copula. If my analysis of **nam** as derived from *na/nu-am is valid, then the *XP nam bi-√ construction would represent a particular kind of identificational focus construction, namely what I have previously described as a negative contrastive focus construction.

Kiss describes two semantic features so as to characterize identificational focus: ± exhaustive and ± contrastive and describes the semantics of identificational focus as follows (Kiss 1998, 245):

> An identificational focus represents a subset of the set of contextually or situationally given elements for which the predicate phrase can potentially hold; it is identified as the exhaustive subset of this set for which the predicate phrase actually holds.

The import of this definition is that thetic statements and contrastive focus should be incompatible: since contrastive focus typically identifies an individual or group of entities and predicates something of them in contrast to some other entity or entities, it would seem to call for reference to individuals—so as to draw the contrast—and, consequently, categorical rather than thetic predication. Since I have not investigated alienable BNBV predicates or *bi-√ prefix verbs that do not form compound verbs, I can do little more

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than offer a tentative suggestion. But if the *bi-√ prefix refers to a single, bounded event (as might be suggested by my discussion of the particle-verb constructions in 2.6), the formation of the *marû* stem may well indicate a plurality of possible events. I do not mean to suggest that the *marû* of a *bi-√ prefix verb is equivalent in some way to *ḫamṭu* reduplication as a sign of absolutive/nominative plurality, nor that it is iterative in the usual sense. When I speak of a plurality of possible events, what I have in mind is the pair-list reading of a focus-affected phrase in a definiteness effect environment. Recall example (45) from section 3.4, repeated below:

(45) Joe: "Who is going to drive me back home?"

Mary: "Well, there's [$_{\text{Focus}}$ my brother, or the guy standing on the corner]."

In (45), when the definiteness effect environment (to the left of the copula in an existential sentence) is focus-affected, as in answer to a wh-question for example, any phrase that occurs in that environment—even if there is only one—is interpreted as one member of a list of possibilities. I would suggest that the *marû* form of the verb in *XP nam bi-√ constructions is due to the pair-list reading of the focused constituent to its left. In other words, under contrastive focus (as in the *XP nam bi-√ construction) a bare noun to the left of the verb can no longer be interpreted as an indefinite noun that only contributes to the specification of the meaning of the verb ("Restrict" in the opposition described by Chung and Ladusaw 2004); instead, the introduction of the copula that acts as a contrastive focus marker converts the bare noun into a specific, referential noun

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("Specify" in Chung and Ladusaw's opposition), and, at the same time, the change to a *marû* verbal root invokes a pair-list reading of the bare noun that is now referentially specific.

Such a scenario has several things that recommend it: (a) it fits nicely with the contrastive focus construction (for non-$BNBV_{inal}$ predicates) in that a noun needs to be individualized and made referential if is it is to serve as a point of contrast for some other entity; (b) the non-occurrence of the *marû* form of the verb in the one example of a $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate in the *XP nam bi-√ construction makes a certain amount of sense in that, unlike all of the other examples of the *XP nam bi-√ construction, the example from line 410 of the Ur Lament refers to what is, from an extensional point of view, a single state of affairs rather than two entities that are mutually exclusive; and (c) the nominal component of a compound verb is treated as, alternatively, non-referential ("Restrict") or referential ("Specify") depending on the morphosyntactic environment in which it occurs. If the predicate in question is a non-$BNBV_{inal}$ predicate, the bare noun is presumably non-referential with a *ḫamṭu* *bi-√ prefix verb, but in the complex morphosyntactic environment of the *XP nam bi-√ construction, it becomes referentially specific and acquires a pair-list reading. In terms of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates, however, the semantic interpretation of the bare noun is much more highly constrained: the non-referential character of the bare inalienable noun clearly makes the transfer of possession model advocated above possible, and in all likelihood, it also contributes to the thetic character of verbs of perception. But the restriction on $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates in the *XP nam bi-√ construction are equally clear: there is only a single, questionable example of the

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construction in a nearly unique context in spite of the fact that **igi-√du$_8$** occurs quite frequently in the text-artifactual record.

The inability of $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates to form the *XP nam bi-√ construction more readily seems, therefore, to follow from the highly thetic character of verbs of perception and experience and the transfer of possession model that underlies these constructions in Sumerian. This line of argument also allows for a harmonization of the general findings of Sumerologists who have investigated the matter (particularly Karahashi's discussion of non-referentiality and the set of devices that introduce referential specificity (Karahashi 2000, 42-45) and a number of different research traditions in formal semantics that draw a distinction between events or portions thereof (stage-level / thetic / "Restrict") and individuals (individual-level / categorical / "Specify").[37]

[37] The named contrasts are, for our purposes, best associated with Carlson 1977, Basilico 2003, and Chung and Ladusaw 2004, respectively.

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5

Possession, animacy and the rise of ergativity in Sumerian

In the final chapter, I attempt to draw together a few strands of the discussion up to now, primarily in terms of the diachronic dimension of some of the foregoing proposals. In section 5.1, I look at the tendency for inalienable constructions to be older—in terms of the diachronic changes that are constantly taking place in a grammar—than constructions involving alienable nouns and what this might tell us about the history of the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction. In section 5.2, I evaluate several different proposals to explain the development of ergativity in general and, in particular, the split of what I will term the old locative postposition *-e into two distinct postpositions in the text-artifactual record: the locative-terminative postposition and the ergative postposition. Section 5.3 offers a brief conclusion and highlights several prospects for future research.

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5.1 Inalienability and the historicity of the case-marking schemata

Since inalienability is the distinctive quality of the $BNBV_{inal}$ lexical class and the morphosyntactic environment that defines it as a lexical class, not to mention the fact that a number of morphosyntactic and semantic distinctions seem to be based on whether or not the nominal component of a *bi-√ prefix compound verb is inalienable, the typological literature on inalienability may be of some help in elucidating the diachronic background to the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction in Sumerian. It seems fairly clear—at least according to Nichols' survey of inalienable possession in North America (1988)—that the type of inalienability represented by the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction is among the most common ways of marking inalienability. Nichols describes a similar case as follows:

> ... languages of the Caddoan and Iroquoian families systematically deprive kin terms of the possibility of displaying an alienability opposition, in that those nouns obligatorily take clausal rather than phrasal possession: one says, roughly, 'she is mother to me' rather than 'my mother'. Since the verb is the head of the clause and hence dominates *mother*, these constructions amount to placement of the pronominal marker of possession not on the head of the phrase but even higher, on the head of the clause. The same can be said of constructions involving body-part terms, known variously as the *ethical dative*, possessor ascension, etc. (Nichols 1988, 577-578).

Although "possessor raising," which is the same thing as what Nichols calls "possessor ascension" and describes in the foregoing paragraph, has been previously documented in Sumerian (Zólyomi 1999, 231-237), I would submit that the kind of possessor raising described by Zólyomi as an argument for the directive case hypothesis is better

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understood as a single component of a broader and older possessor raising regime in which the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction plays a crucial role. Zólyomi notes, for example, that the *bi-√ prefix "agrees" with a nominal phrase of the form *NP-a after the possessor raising has taken place (Zólyomi 1999, 236), but this is just the familiar statement of locative "agreement" and makes no clear connection between the existence of possessor raising and the contribution of the *bi-√ prefix to either the possessor raising itself or the semantics of the predicate.

I would argue, however, that the low source applicative hypothesis proposed in chapter 1 explains both the presence of possessor raising (including *NP-a bi-√ environments as well as BNBV environments) and the distinctive causer/experiencer semantics of the construction as a whole. Zólyomi's causative analysis of alienable BNBV predicates can be subsumed, in other words, as one component of a broader (low source) applicative hypothesis alongside the experiential semantics of the $BNBV_{inal}$ class: the *bi-√ prefix in conjunction with a bare inalienable noun acts as a low source applicative morpheme, while in the presence of an alienable noun, it becomes causative in function. The same pattern is also found in the examples of applicative/causative alternation at the end of section 2.6. More importantly, it brings ongoing work on the morphosyntax of Sumerian in line with descriptions of the same phenomena in other languages.

Nichols does not describe a particular historical scenario for the type of clausal possessive pattern that seems to be manifest in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction, but what she describes as "Pattern 6" is very close to the clausal pattern seen in Sumerian.

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> In languages with Pattern 6, whose 'inalienable' possession involves no marking while 'alienable' possession is dependent-marked, the lack of marking for the inalienable type is due to one of two historical factors: either the fixation of inalienable constructions antedates the rise of case in the language, or the possessor loses its case marker due to its incorporation into the head in a form of compounding (Nichols 1988, 579).

Since the second of the two scenarios described by Nichols is clearly not the case in Sumerian, I take the first of the two descriptions ("the fixation of inalienable constructions antedates the rise of case in the language") as a plausible scenario for Sumerian. This would suggest that the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction is a kind of historical artifact embedded in the grammar of Sumerian and that it may well provide a window into the earlier history of the language. In particular, the nominative/dative, or alternatively, the absolutive/oblique case marking system found in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction ([$_{absolutive/nominative}$ ergative possessor + bare inalienable noun] vs. [$_{dative/oblique}$ object of perception]) corresponds quite closely to the "normalform" conjugation discussed by Silverstein as the point of departure for the development of case-marking schemata in other ergative languages (Silverstein 1976, 161; cf. Silverstein 1993a). This raises the strong possibility that the different types of *bi-√ prefix constructions ($BNBV_{inal}$, alienable BNBV, *NP-a bi-√, etc.) can actually be thought of as morphosyntactic primitives registering distinct combinations of particular case-marking relations (or thematic structure) and inherent lexical content such as distinctions based on inalienability and animacy. The following section describes two successive (and

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increasingly specific) models of the rise of ergativity in Sumerian and attempts to determine what, if any, correlations hold between particular models of the development of ergativity and features such as inherent lexical content and/or possession.

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5.2 Possession and the development of ergativity

Theorists have long posited relations of one kind or another between ergative case-marking and possession. One of the most insightful comments actually occurs in the midst of a debate between Silverstein and Hale on the nature of ergative case-marking systems: Hale had reasserted an ergativity-as-obligatory-passivization model that harmonized in some respects with the aspirations of early generative theory (Hale 1970) and Silverstein responded with one of the most important papers ever written about ergativity (Silverstein 1976). As part of an argument to the effect that the early generativists did not have a theory that could encompass the attested data, Silverstein describes the ergative "type" as follows:

> . . . possessors and ergators (or apparent agents) are frequently identified at the surface at least (Eskimo [including the West Greenlandic examples (70), (71), and (72) in section 1.8, CJ], Chinook, Tsotsil, Quiche); non-ergators (or apparent patients) are incorporated into verb-complexes in the same way, whether they are in transitive or in intransitive structures (Iroquoian, Tsimshian, Wichita); mediopassives and reflexives are identical in syntax and sometimes in form (Dyirbal, Chinook, Bandjalang); the 'antipassive' forms an 'active intransitive'—in Sapir's (1922: 150-151, 153-154) felicitous phrase—with the underlying agent of the transitive in nominative case (Chinook, Aleut), or it forms a nominative-dative schema for inflectional purposes (Dyirbal, Georgian). (Silverstein 1976, 115)

Thus the relation between possession and ergative case-marking seems to have been—at least in descriptive terms—quite clear. But Silverstein is hesitant to address the

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diachronic origins (as opposed to the typological variation) of ergativity, since it was precisely the question of origins that had given rise—a century before—to the obligatory-passive hypothesis as well as it corollary to the effect that all languages "start out" as nominative/accusative languages and change into ergative languages under certain circumstances.

Several years later, Trask (1979) would attempt to split the difference in historical terms, arguing that the typological framework proposed by Silverstein can actually come into being in historical terms in at least two different ways: Type A ergativity develops from an obligatory passivization, whereas Type B ergativity results from the grammaticalization of a possessive construction. Trask describes Type B ergativity, which bears a certain resemblance to the situation in Sumerian, as follows:

> Now in a language lacking a verb 'have', possessive predications are commonly made by putting the possessor into an oblique case, most often the dative, locative, or genitive—carrying an overt mark. And re-interpretation of such a possessor as an agent would automatically bring about ergative case-marking. Thus a sentence of the general form *To me / Of me / At me (is) a window broken*, on being re-interpreted to mean 'I have broken a window', would yield a typical Type B pattern, with the agent overtly marked, the patient unmarked, the verb agreeing with the patient in number and gender but not in person, the verb not agreeing with the agent at all, and the whole thing confined to the perfect (Trask 1979, 398).

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Trask's work is early in the rather extensive literature on ergativity (see Dixon 1994 for a general treatment), but it does capture a basic distinction between ergative cases that derive from the agentive adjunct of a passive verb and ergative cases that derive from other, possessive postpositions, while the agent of the verb in question is either impersonal or unexpressed. At a fairly rough level of description, Trask's type B ergativity explains the development of ergativity in Sumerian in that, as discussed in chapter 1, one of the characteristic features of low source applicative constructions is that they make use of possessor raising in the form of clausal possessive constructions in which the possessor bears a dative or locative case and is also an argument of the verb. Clearly such a configuration is very close to the one described by Trask and would be ripe for grammaticalization as a ergative case.

While Trask's model is descriptively adequate to a certain degree, a more precise and detailed explanation can be formulated on the basis of Garrett's discussion of the development of ergative case-marking in Hittite (Garrett 1990). Like Trask, Garrett has also argued that there are at least two primary ways in which ergative case-marking develops in diachronic terms. Whereas Trask differentiated between obligatory passivization (Type A) and the grammaticalization of adpositionally-marked possessors (Type B), Garrett juxtaposes cases in which tense/aspect oppositions in conjunction with passivization have yielded ergative case-marking (= Trask's Type A), and cases in which noun phrase animacy contrasts (known as "inherent lexical content of noun phrases," in Silverstein's work) interacts with instrumental case-marking patterns in impersonal causative constructions to produce ergative case-marking, a pattern that I will term "Type

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C" ergativity. Whether Type C ergativity actually corresponds to Type B ergativity to some degree is actually an interesting question in light of Pylkkänen's low source applicative hypothesis: since a low source applicative is equivalent in certain semantic respects to an ablative postposition and necessarily involves a possessive relation, there might be the possibility of an encompassing theory, but I will not attempt to come up with such a theory here (for Garrett's argument *against* relating the Hittite possessive adjective and the ablative endings, see Garrett 1990, 272-273).

Coghill and Deutscher (2002) have recently proposed that ergativity arises in Sumerian through a Type A process in which demoted agents, i.e., agentive adjuncts, were marked by the locative-terminative postposition in passive clauses and that the locative-terminative postposition was subsequently reinterpreted as an ergative postposition. They then go on to argue that the "inverse"[38] character of the pronominal agreement markers on the verb in the perfective aspect derives from a reinterpretation of the locative-terminative as an ergative case-marking postposition. But there are several problematic components of their proposal that I would like to clarify, and, once the problematic items are identified, I would like to propose an alternative account that relies on the Type C grammaticalization process outlined above. The most serious problem with Coghill and Deutscher's proposal is their interpretation of the locative-terminative postposition as regularly corresponding to a demoted agent. As Coghill and Deutscher freely admit (2002, 282-283), the use of the locative-terminative postposition to refer to a (demoted) agent is only attested in causative constructions in which the noun phrase

[38] Note that Coghill and Deutscher are using "inverse" in a descriptive way that has no connection to what is known as better known inverse case-marking, see Van Valin and LaPolla 1997, 288-289, 373-376.

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bearing the locative-terminative is the causee, a morphosyntactic environment that is much more reminiscent of both Garrett's Type C ergativity and Zólyomi's reconstruction of the history of four-participant verbs (Zólyomi 1999, 244-251) than the Type A process that Coghill and Deutscher propose. There are no attestations of the locative-terminative postposition marking a demoted agent anywhere else in the language (leaving open, for the moment, the interpretation of the **mes.an.ne$_2$.pa$_3$.da** construction below) and the most common uses of the locative-terminative postposition are (a) as the indicator of a goal in certain morphosyntactic environments and (b) as marker of demoted *patient* in certain compound verb constructions. In Michalowski's recent study of "Enmebaragesi" (Michalowski 2003), he identifies a construction that can be exemplified in contrast with the **mes.an.ne$_2$.pa$_3$.da** construction as follows (both examples are personal names).

(73) ME.bara$_2$.ge$_4$.e.si

išib-Ø	barag-e	si-Ø
priest-Nom/Abs	dias-LocTerm	fill-ActivePrt

"the priest who fills the dias"

(74) mes.an.ne$_2$.pa$_3$.da

mes	an-e	pad-a
youth	An-LocTerm	call-PerfPrt

"the youth called by An"

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Here in the realm of participial constructions and nominalized verbs, we do find the kind of system of demoted agents that Coghill and Deutscher imagine. In (73), the locative-terminative marks either the original goal argument (the most likely interpretation), or represents the demoted patient within an antipassive rection (Michalowski 2003, 200; cf. Johnson 2000 and Rubio forthcoming, §3.13.2), whereas in (74), the locative-terminative marks what might be termed a demoted agent. The contrast in meaning between the locative-terminative in (73) and (74) seems to be determined by whether the participle at the end of each phrase is active, as in (73), or passive (and perfective), as in (74): this type of tense/aspect split, in which a locative adpositional phrase acts as agentive adjunct with a transitive perfective participle would correspond precisely to the examples of a tense/aspect split from Middle Indic and Iranian as presented by Garrett (1990, 263-264) except for the fact that there appears to be no evidence that these perfective/passive participial constructions were ever reanalyzed as active finite verbs in Sumerian (one of the primary requirements for a subsequent reinterpretation of the agentive adjunct as ergative). The opposition between (73) and (74), in other words, would have provided an ideal environment for the type of tense/aspect-driven split ergativity envisioned by Coghill and Deutscher, but there is no evidence that such a grammaticalization ever took place.

Within a Type C model of the development of ergativity as outlined by Garrett for Hittite, there are three necessary components of the morphosyntactic environment in which ergativity arises: (a) a transitive verb, (b) a null (or impersonal) agent, and (c) an

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inanimate noun in an ablative/instrumental case. Garrett describes the morphosyntactic environment as well as its justification as a locus of change as follows:

> According to this scheme, instrumental NPs in null-subject transitive clauses . . . are reanalyzed diachronically as subjects. Such a reanalysis is permitted because of the functional overlap between instrument and agent in clauses with transitive predicates: cf. e.g. *John opened the door with the key* and *the key opened the door*, or *John extinguished the fire with water* and *water extinguished the fire*. A similar reanalysis cannot occur in clauses with intransitive predicates because thematic instruments are rare or absent altogether in the subject position of intransitive clauses. (Garrett 1990, 265)

I would argue that that [+locus] component of the ablative/instrumental case that Garrett's model calls for is coded by the old locative postposition, *-e, whereas the directionality of the *ablative*/instrumental case is coded by the low source applicative, *bi-.

Given these constraints, it may be useful at this point to imagine two templates for such an environment that differ only in terms of the (in)alienability of the bare noun.

(75) $NOUN_{animate}$-e (GOAL) $NOUN_{inanimate}$-e (SOURCE) **$NOUN_{inalienable}$** bi-√

(76) $NOUN_{animate}$-e (GOAL) $NOUN_{inanimate}$-e (SOURCE) **$NOUN_{alienable}$** bi-√

In the old system, in which both perceived object (SOURCE) and perceiver (GOAL) appeared in the same old locative case, *-e, the transfer of possession model was fairly

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straightforward: the perception began at one location and ended up at another location—both locations appearing in the same case, *-e. Since the two locations were indicated, as locations, by the same postpositional morphology, namely *-e, the thematic roles of the two locations must have been assigned by some other component of the clause. This is where the *bi-, *ba-, *ni-, *na- system would have stepped in: the *bi- and *ba- prefixes may have identified the topical (or, in an obviational system [see Aissen 1997 for a recent overview], the proximal) locative noun as a source, whereas the *ni- and *na- prefixes identified the topical or proximal locative noun as a goal. Such a scenario would also explain the fact that in later phases of the language *ba- indicated movement away from speaker (if the proximal locative noun—proximal to speaker that is—is a source, then the corresponding goal will necessarily represent movement away from speaker), whereas the derived form *imma-√ indicates motion toward speaker. As predicted by Nichols' diachronic model (see above), the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction seems to be the only part of the grammar in which the full system is preserved: the proximal locative, **gig.e** in the paradigmatic example, is identified as the source of the perception, while the non-proximal locative, **en aratta^{ki}.ke$_4$**, by implication, must be the goal of the perception. I would imagine that the *bi-, *ba-, *ni-, *na- system was formed through grammaticalization of the set A deictics as low applicative heads, which originated as auxiliary verbs in clause final position.

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*bi-	SOURCE, INDEFINITE	("There is a ... in ...")
*ba-	SOURCE, DEFINITE	("The ... is there")
*ni-	GOAL, INDEFINITE	("Here is a ... for ...)
*na-	GOAL, DEFINITE	("The ... is here")

But, for whatever reason, the transfer of possession model began to break down and, as a result, the two templates sketched out above, (75) and (76), began to diverge.

The $BNBV_{inal}$ predicate in (75) presumably maintained the possessive relation between $NOUN_{animate}$-e (GOAL) and the $NOUN_{inalienable}$ due to the requirement that an inalienable noun must have a possessor. So the possessive meaning of the old locative (GOAL) postposition in clauses such as (75) was presumably fairly stable due to its inalienability. The template in (76), however, is another story entirely: with the dissolution of the transfer of possession model in those cases in which the bare alienable noun was indefinite (as in the alienable BNBV construction in [76]), the low source applicative that had previously functioned as an applicative morpheme became causative and the two locative arguments of the applicative were reinterpreted as participants in a causative construction. The old locative goal argument was reinterpreted as causer (presumably due to the semantic overlap between possessors and ergators), while the old locative source argument was reinterpreted as causee due to the similarity between the privative and adversely affected semantics of the source argument ($BNBV_{inal}$) and the characterization of a causee as the coerced or controlled participant in some situation, or alternatively the association between a source or ablative thematic relation and

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instrumentality. In other words, the semantics associated with the source argument bearing the old locative postposition, *-e, split into two subfields on the basis of the inalienability of the noun: the source argument in $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates was associated with deprivation and adversity, whereas the source argument in alienable BNBV predicates was identified as coerced and/or instrumental.

Once the split between causative *bi-√ and applicative *bi-√ constructions (on the basis of the (in)alienability of the bare noun in the construction) had taken place, the subsequent reshuffling of functions assigned to the old locative postposition set the stage for the Type C grammaticalization suggested by Garrett. In a causative construction with null or impersonal causer and a causee in the equivalent of an ablative/instrumental case (due to the co-occurrence of the old locative postposition, *-e, and the low source applicative, *bi-), the resulting configuration would look something like the following.

(77) $Ø_{animate.causer}$ $NP_{inanimate}$-e_{causee} $NP_{alienable}$ bi-Ø-√

Since the inanimate causee is very similar to the animate causer in that they both share the same morphological form with old locative postposition and nearly the same function, the reinterpretation of the postposition that marks the causee as an ergative case-marking on the basis of these similarities is in conformity with the Type C model described by Garrett and it also incorporates certain components of the Coghill/Deutscher hypothesis. Thus, any noun bearing the old locative postposition in a transitive clause with an alienable noun would—via two distinct grammaticalization pathways—have been

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reinterpreted as an ergative postposition. At the same time, the low transitivity and coreferentiality of possessor/ergator and bare noun in $BNBV_{inal}$ constructions would have blocked the development of ergativity in $BNBV_{inal}$ clauses. The three possible functions of the old locative postposition can, therefore, be represented as follows:

Form	Environment	Function
$*NP_{animate/inanimate}$-e	$BNBV_{alienable}$	ergative
$*NP_{inanimate}$-e	$BNBV_{inal}$	ablative
$*NP_{animate}$-e	$BNBV_{inal}$	possessor/allative

But a second component of the Coghill/Deutscher hypothesis also seems to play a role in the formation of the Sumerian preverbal agreement system.

One of the most interesting components of the Coghill/Deutscher hypothesis is their suggestion that the preverbal pronominal markers of ergative case in *ḫamṭu* clauses originate from the *bi- and *ni- verbal prefixes in verbs in which the original preverbal pronominal element is absent. The suggestion that verbs of the form ...n-√gu_7 might derive from an underlying form such as ...ni-Ø-√gu_7 was first proposed by Krecher (1979) and subsequently adopted by a number of authors (see references in Coghill and Deutscher 2002, 285, fn. 52). Coghill and Deutscher argue that the form that has undergone vowel syncope was subsequently reanalyzed as an ergative agreement marker, but their argument actually makes much more sense in a Type C model of the development of ergativity, particularly if we assume the null or impersonal agent of the

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causative environment described by Garrett would have been represented by a zero element in the immediately preverbal slot. If this scenario is valid, then we have to acknowledge the possibility that two, homophonous systems of preverbal "agreement" may either coexist within the Sumerian of the text-artifactual record, or at least in one of the historical phases that immediately precedes the attested documentation. If so, then we should expect that $BNBV_{inal}$ predicates would preserve the older system of pronominal agreement—whatever that might be (for my suggestion that it was a switch-reference system, see the discussion following example [31] in section 3.3). At the same time, causative alienable BNBV predicates would exhibit a distinct system of agreement involving some form of agreement with the causee. Since this is not, however, a study of the alienable BNBV class of predicates, I do not go into the matter further here, but it should be emphasized that such a historical scenario would lead us to expect that the preverbal pronominal agreement markers may well function quite differently depending on the lexical class of the main verb and the morphosyntactic environment in which they occur.

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5.3 Conclusions and prospects

Of the many hypotheses, proposals and suggestions included in this dissertation, two strike me as particularly important: (a) the interpretation of the *bi-√ verbal prefix in the $BNBV_{inal}$ construction as a (low source) applicative in that it incorporates and extends previous work on the directive case hypothesis in a model that allows for typological comparison, and (b) the opposition between topic-marking using the possessive pronoun topic-marking construction (*NP-bi) and the role of focus in the *XP nam bi-√ construction. The further extension of recent work on applicative typology and interpretation (particularly within the Distributed Morphology framework) to some of the other recalcitrant verbal prefixes in Sumerian as well as an investigation of the quantificational properties of the different verbal prefixes would, in my view, be quite fruitful and I hope to continue with the investigation of the some of the other classes of the *bi-√ prefix and other related prefixes in future. But it is the second of the two conclusions, namely the opposition between topic and focus in Sumerian, that deserves further attention and research by all those who work on Sumerian morphosyntax and the literature that it encodes.

The most productive avenue to substantive progress in our understanding of Sumerian morphosyntax is undoubtedly further investigation of topic and focus in. In particular, the connections between possession, definiteness and topicalization, which I have attempted to elucidate in this study, are in need of a great deal of additional research, particularly if such research manages to identify further connections between these features and certain components of the verbal prefix. At the same time, additional

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work on bare nouns, indefiniteness and head-internal relativization will undoubtedly shed light on Sumerian forms that have resisted coherent interpretation for decades. Thus the prospects for an advance in our understanding of Sumerian morphosyntax and consequently the language itself are auspicious and I hope to be able to continue working on these problems in future.

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